A SURVIVAL HANDBOOK

After the Algorithm

A Practical Handbook for Work, Money and Meaning in the Age of AI

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Important note. This book offers general information and practical guidance. It is not legal, financial, tax, immigration or medical advice. Laws, benefits and programmes differ by country, region and over time; always check the rules where you live and, for decisions with serious consequences, speak to a qualified professional or an official agency.

About the stories. The short stories in this book are illustrative composites, written to show common situations. They are not accounts of real, identifiable people.

About resources. Organisations, websites and programmes mentioned were believed accurate at the time of writing, but they change. Verify details before relying on them. No organisation listed has endorsed this book.

If you are in crisis or thinking about harming yourself, please contact your local emergency number or a crisis line now. In the US call or text 988; in the UK and Ireland call Samaritans on 116 123; elsewhere, find a line at findahelpline.com.

Illustrations created with AI image generation for this edition.

For everyone who did good work
and was told it was no longer needed —
and for the people who helped them begin again.

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START HERE

Lost Your Job This Week? Read This First

A short, calm guide you can read in one sitting. It covers the ten things that matter most in the next seven days, the mistakes to avoid, and where to turn next in this book.

If you have just lost your job, you may feel numb, angry, scared, or all three at once. That is normal. You do not need to fix your whole life this week. You only need to protect yourself, gather a few facts, and take the next small step.

This section is short on purpose. Read it now, do what you can, and leave the rest of the book for when your head is clearer.

First, Breathe

Before you open your laptop, sit for one minute. Breathe in slowly for four counts, hold for four, and breathe out for six. Do this five times. It sounds too simple to matter, but a calmer body makes better decisions.

Then remind yourself of three true things. Losing a job is an event, not a verdict on your worth. Many people are going through this right now as work changes around AI. And you have more options than it feels like today.

You do not need a five-year plan this week. You need a safe week.

KEY IDEA

The goal of the first seven days is not to find a new job. It is to **stabilise**: protect your money, your rights, your health and your options. Job hunting goes better once that ground is steady.

The Next 7 Days: Your Ten Priorities

Work through these in roughly this order. If you only manage half of them this week, that is still real progress.

YOUR FIRST-WEEK CHECKLIST

- [ ] **Get everything in writing.** Ask for your termination letter, your final pay date, and details of any severance, notice pay, or unused holiday pay.
- [ ] **Save your records.** Before your work accounts close, save personal copies of payslips, contracts, performance reviews and contact details you are allowed to keep. Do not take confidential company data.
- [ ] **Apply for unemployment support.** Do it within days, not weeks. Many programs pay from the date you apply, not the date you lost your job. Search for your local service (for example, your state unemployment office in the US, Jobcentre Plus in the UK, Employment Insurance in Canada, or Centrelink in Australia).
- [ ] **Sort out health coverage.** Find out exactly when your work-linked health cover ends, if you have it, and what your options are. Write the date down.
- [ ] **Count your runway.** Add up your cash and expected payouts, then divide by your essential monthly costs. That number of months is your runway. A simple version is in Appendix B.
- [ ] **Pause flexible spending.** Cancel or pause subscriptions and non-essentials for now. You can restart them later.
- [ ] **Call lenders early.** If a mortgage, rent, loan or card payment will be hard, contact the lender before you miss it and ask about hardship options.
- [ ] **Tell the people closest to you.** A partner, a family member, a close friend. You do not have to carry this alone.
- [ ] **Line up references.** Ask two or three former colleagues or managers if they would be willing to speak for you, while your work is still fresh in their minds.
- [ ] **Make a simple daily rhythm.** Get up at a normal time, move your body, eat real meals, and set a limit on how long you spend on job sites and news each day.

TIP

Keep one notebook or one document called “Job Change” for everything: dates, phone calls, reference numbers, names of people you spoke to. When you are stressed, memory is unreliable. Paper is not.

What Not to Do This Week

Shock pushes people toward fast, permanent decisions. Most of the expensive mistakes after a layoff happen in the first few weeks. Here are the big ones to avoid.

DON’T

- Sign a severance or settlement agreement on the spot, especially if it asks you to give up legal rights.
- Cash out retirement savings in a panic. Penalties and taxes can take a large bite, and that money is hard to rebuild.
- Pay for “guaranteed job” schemes, expensive courses sold under time pressure, or “get rich with AI” programs.
- Post angry messages about your employer online.
- Shut yourself away and stop talking to people.

DO INSTEAD

- Ask how long you have to review it. Get advice from an employment adviser, union rep, or lawyer if the stakes are high.
- Use cash, benefits and severance first. Talk to a qualified adviser before touching long-term savings.
- Use free public services and free learning first (see Appendix C).
- Write the angry message in a private journal, then delete it.
- Send one message a day to someone you trust, even if it is just “rough week, can we talk?”

WATCH OUT

Scammers target people who have just lost their jobs. Be wary of anyone who offers a job without an interview, asks you to pay for training or equipment up front, wants your bank details early, or pressures you to decide today. Real employers do not charge you to work for them. Chapter 14 covers this in detail.

A STORY

Marisol, 46, was told on a Tuesday that her customer support team was being replaced by an automated system. She was handed an agreement and asked to sign by Friday. Instead of signing, she asked for two weeks to review it, and got one. A free session with an employment adviser showed her that the notice pay was below what her contract promised. She raised it politely in writing, and the offer was corrected. One calm week saved her a month's pay.

If You Are Struggling to Cope

Job loss can hit as hard as a bereavement. If you feel hopeless, cannot sleep or eat for days, or have thoughts of harming yourself, please reach out now. In the US and Canada you can call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland you can call Samaritans on 116 123. In Australia you can call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In an emergency, call your local emergency number. More options are listed in Appendix C.

Where to Go Next in This Book

When you are ready for more, these chapters pick up exactly where this page leaves off.

If you need...	Read
A full plan for the first month, including severance, benefits and references	Chapter 2
Help with money, debts and protecting savings	Chapter 3
Support with stress, shame, sleep and talking to family	Chapter 4

If you need...	Read
To understand why this is happening, and that it is not your fault	Chapter 1
To spot fake job offers and recruitment scams	Chapter 14
A week-by-week plan for the next three months	Appendix A
Printable worksheets and message scripts	Appendix B
Phone numbers and websites for help in your country	Appendix C

REMEMBER

- This week is about stabilising, not solving everything.
- Get facts in writing, apply for support quickly, and know your runway.
- Don’t sign, cash out, or pay for anything under pressure.
- Stay connected to at least one person you trust.

Your next step: Pick the first unchecked item on the checklist above and do it today. Then put this book down and do something kind for yourself.

INTRODUCTION

How to Use This Book

Who this book is for, what it believes, how it is organised, and how to find the parts you need most right now.

This is a handbook, not a lecture. It was written for people whose working lives have been shaken by artificial intelligence, or who can feel the ground starting to move. You might have been laid off last week. You might still have a job but watch your tasks being handed to software one by one. Either way, this book is meant to sit on your desk, get scribbled in, and be useful on bad days as well as good ones.

You do not need to read it cover to cover. You do not need to be good with technology. You only need to be willing to take one small, practical step at a time.

Who This Book Is For

This book is for anyone whose work is being changed by AI and automation. That includes customer support agents, writers, translators, designers, junior developers, administrators, analysts, bookkeepers, and many others in roles that once felt secure. It also includes people in jobs that have not changed much yet, but who are worried they will.

It is for people at every stage. Some readers are 22 and wondering whether the career they trained for still exists. Some are 58 and wondering whether anyone will hire them again. Some are parents, carers, immigrants, or people managing a health condition while also managing a job search. Chapter 21 speaks directly to many of these situations.

And it is for readers all over the world. Rules about benefits, severance, health care and employment rights vary a great deal between countries. Where it matters, the book gives examples from several places and points you toward your local equivalent.

The Honest Premise

This book rests on three beliefs. They shape every chapter.

1. **Work is changing fast.** AI tools are now widespread, and many companies are using them to do routine tasks that people used to do. Hiring has become more crowded and more automated. Pretending otherwise would not help you.
2. **It is not your fault.** If your role was cut or reshaped, that was a business decision made in a period of rapid change. It does not mean you were lazy, slow, or not good enough. Shame is a common reaction, but it is not an accurate one.
3. **There is a way forward.** Not a guaranteed one, and not always an easy one, but a real one. People adapt to big shifts in work, and they do it best with clear information, a plan, and support from others.

You will not find hype in these pages. Nobody can promise that a single course, tool, or trick will rescue your career. You also will not find doom. Large forecasts, such as the World Economic Forum's *Future of Jobs Report 2025*, expect many jobs to be displaced but even more to be created by 2030. The hard part is that the new jobs are not always in the same places, or asking for the same skills, as the old ones. This book is about getting you across that gap.

Honest about the difficulty. Practical about the next step. Hopeful about where you can get to.

How the Six Parts Fit Together

The book follows the path most people take through a career shock: first you steady yourself, then you understand what is going on, then you choose a direction, and then you act. The last part is about building a life that can handle the next change too.

Part	What it helps you do	Chapters
I. Steady the Ground	Get through the shock: understand what is happening, handle the first month, protect your money and look after your mind and body.	1–4
II. Understand the New Landscape	See how AI is reshaping work, which human skills keep their value, and how to become confident using AI tools yourself.	5–7
III. Find Your Direction	Take stock of your skills, compare realistic paths, and learn new skills efficiently without wasting money.	8–10
IV. Winning in a Crowded Job Market	Search smarter, network without feeling fake, show proof of your abilities, and handle interviews, offers and scams.	11–14
V. Create Your Own Opportunities	Explore freelancing, small business, multiple income streams and opportunities in your local community.	15–18
VI. Meaning, Resilience and the Long Game	Rebuild identity and purpose, lean on relationships, handle special situations, and future-proof your working life.	19–22

At the back you will find four appendices. Appendix A is a 90-day comeback plan that turns the whole book into weekly actions. Appendix B collects the most useful worksheets and message scripts in one place. Appendix C is a directory of services and resources by country. Appendix D is a plain-English glossary of terms you will meet along the way.

Three Ways to Read This Book

Start with the route that matches where you are today. You can always switch later.

Route 1: You are in crisis

You have just lost your job, or you are about to. Money is tight and your mind is racing.

CRISIS ROUTE

- [ ] Read the Quick Start at the front of the book first.
- [ ] Then read Chapter 2 (the first 30 days) and Chapter 3 (money triage).
- [ ] Read Chapter 4 (mind and body) whenever you feel overwhelmed.
- [ ] Begin the 90-Day Comeback Plan in Appendix A, Phase 1.
- [ ] Keep Appendix C open for phone numbers and services.
- [ ] Leave the rest of the book until your runway is clear.

Route 2: You are planning a change

The immediate shock has passed, or you have chosen to move on. You want to figure out what is next and go after it properly.

PLANNING ROUTE

- [ ] Read Chapter 1 for the big picture, then Part II (Chapters 5–7).
- [ ] Work through Part III (Chapters 8–10) slowly, with a pen.
- [ ] Choose either Part IV (job search) or Part V (creating your own work), or both.
- [ ] Use Appendix A, Phases 2 and 3, as your weekly structure.

Route 3: You are still employed but worried

You have a job, but you can see AI changing your field. You want to get ahead of it while you still have a salary and time.

PREPARE-EARLY ROUTE

- [ ] Read Chapter 5 and use it to assess how exposed your own role is.
- [ ] Read Chapters 6 and 7 and start building AI fluency at work.
- [ ] Build your runway now using Chapter 3, before you need it.
- [ ] Start your skills inventory (Chapter 8) and your network map (Chapter 12).
- [ ] Finish with Chapter 22 and set up an annual career review.

KEY IDEA

The best time to prepare for a career change is while you are still employed. If you are on Route 3, every small step you take now buys you calm and choice later.

How to Use the Worksheets

Most chapters include worksheets, checklists, scripts and reflection prompts. They are the most important part of the book. Reading about a skills inventory is useful. Actually writing one is what changes your next interview.

Here is how to get the most from them:

- **Write in the book**, or print the pages. If you are reading on a screen, copy the worksheet into a notebook or a document.
- **Be rough, not perfect.** A messy, honest answer is worth more than a polished, empty one. You can always revise.
- **Date your answers.** Coming back in a month and seeing how far you have moved is a real boost on hard days.
- **Use Appendix B for repeats.** The worksheets you will use again and again, like the runway calculator and job-search tracker, are collected there for easy copying.
- **Adapt the scripts.** Message templates use [brackets] for the parts you fill in. Change the wording until it sounds like you.

TIP

You can use an AI assistant to help you think through a worksheet: talk through your answers, ask it to spot patterns, or have it suggest questions you missed. Just keep the final words your own, and avoid pasting in private details you would not want stored. Chapter 7 explains how to do this safely.

A Note on the Stories

Throughout the book you will find short boxes labelled "A story." These are illustrative composites. They are built from common experiences to show how an idea works in a real life, but they are not interviews with real people, and the names are invented. They are there to help you picture yourself taking a step, not to promise that your path will look the same.

A STORY

Tomás, 34, a translator in Spain, picked up this kind of book the week his biggest client switched to machine translation. He skipped straight to the money chapter, then the worksheets. He only read the chapters about meaning and identity months later, once he had a new contract. "I read it in the wrong order," he joked, "which turned out to be the right order for me."

A Note on Checking Local Rules

This book gives general information, not legal, financial, tax or medical advice. Rules on unemployment benefits, severance, notice periods, health coverage, retirement accounts, self-employment and taxes differ from country to country, and often between states, provinces or regions. They also change.

When the book mentions a program or a rule, treat it as a starting point. Check the details with your local government service, a qualified adviser, a union, or a free advice service such as those listed in Appendix C. For big decisions, like signing a settlement or withdrawing retirement savings, a short conversation with a professional can save you a great deal.

WATCH OUT

Websites, phone numbers and program names change over time. Before you rely on any resource in this book, confirm it on the organisation's official site.

Which route are you on today, and what is the one thing you most want this book to help you with?

REMEMBER

- This is a handbook: dip in, write in it, and use the parts you need.
- Work is changing fast, it is not your fault, and there is a way forward.
- Pick a route: crisis, planning a change, or preparing early.
- The worksheets matter most. Rough answers are fine.
- Always check local rules and confirm resources before relying on them.

Your next step: Choose your route above, then turn to the first chapter on that route and read just its opening section today.

PART I

Steady the Ground

Before you can plan a new future, you need solid footing. This part is about the first weeks: understanding what is really happening, protecting your money, handling the paperwork, and looking after the person doing all of this — you.

1 · You Are Not Obsolete
2 · The First 30 Days After Losing Your Job
3 · Money Triage: Building Your Runway
4 · Mind and Body: Handling the Shock

CHAPTER 1

You Are Not Obsolete

A clear, honest look at what AI is really changing about work, what it still can't do, and why your experience still counts. Read this first so the rest of the book stands on solid ground.

If you picked up this book, something has probably shaken you. Maybe you lost your job. Maybe you watched a team get cut, or saw a tool do in seconds what used to take you a day. Maybe you just have a tight, quiet feeling in your chest every time someone says "AI."

That feeling makes sense. Big changes are happening, and they are happening fast. But the story you may be telling yourself, "I'm finished, I'm being replaced, there is no place for me," is not the full story. It is not even the most likely one.

This chapter gives you a clearer picture. Not a cheerful one, and not a scary one. A useful one. When you understand what is actually going on, you can stop fighting fog and start making moves.

What is actually happening

By late 2026, AI tools are part of daily work in many industries. Chat assistants draft emails and reports. AI agents can carry out multi-step tasks on a computer. Coding agents write and fix software. Image and video tools produce marketing material in minutes.

Companies have used these tools to automate a lot of routine thinking work. The areas hit hardest so far include customer support, junior coding, content writing, translation, data entry and back-office processing, and some kinds of analysis. If you worked in one of these areas, you are not imagining it. The ground really did move under you.

At the same time, hiring has become more crowded. Many applications are first screened by software. Candidates use AI to write cover letters and résumés, so employers get far more applications than before. That makes searching feel like shouting into a storm. It is harder, and it is not your fault.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> Two things are true at once. AI is genuinely changing work, and some jobs are shrinking fast. And people are still needed, in large numbers, for work that machines do poorly or that people simply prefer a human to do. Your job now is to find where those two truths meet for you.

The big numbers, in context

You will see a lot of numbers in the news. Many are guesses dressed up as facts. One widely cited source is the World Economic Forum's *Future of Jobs Report 2025*. It projected that by 2030, roughly 170 million jobs would be created worldwide and about 92 million would be displaced. That is a net gain, on paper.

But a net gain on a global chart does not help you pay rent next month. The jobs being created are often in different places, different fields, and need different skills than the ones being lost. The gap between "a job disappeared here" and "a job appeared there" is where real people struggle. This book is about crossing that gap.

WATCH OUT

Be wary of anyone who tells you with total confidence what will happen. That includes people saying "AI will take every job" and people saying "nothing will really change." Nobody knows exactly. Make plans that work across several possible futures, not just one.

Tasks, not jobs: the most useful way to think

Here is the single most helpful shift in thinking you can make: **AI automates tasks, not whole people.** Every job is a bundle of tasks. Some tasks are routine and predictable. Others need judgment, trust, physical skill, or a relationship.

Take a customer support role. It might include answering common questions, looking up order details, calming an angry customer, spotting a pattern of complaints, explaining a problem to the product team, and training new staff. AI can now handle many of the common questions and lookups. It is much weaker at calming someone who is truly upset, noticing that a complaint is a sign of a bigger problem, or earning the trust of a team.

When the routine tasks get automated, a few things can happen to a job:

- **It shrinks.** Fewer people are needed because much of the work is done by software.
- **It shifts.** The job stays, but its focus moves to the harder, human parts.
- **It splits.** The routine part vanishes and a new, more skilled role forms around the rest.
- **It grows.** The work gets cheaper and faster, so demand rises and more people are hired.

Which of these happens depends on the industry, the company and the region. It is rarely the same everywhere. That means your past job title tells you less about your future than the specific tasks you are good at.

Task type	How exposed to AI?	Examples
Routine information work	High	Data entry, standard reports, first-draft writing, simple translation, form processing
Pattern-based analysis	Medium to high	Summarising documents, basic financial checks, first-pass code, sorting applications
Judgment under uncertainty	Lower	Deciding what to do when the rules don't fit, weighing trade-offs, setting priorities
Trust and relationships	Lower	Caring for patients, selling to long-term clients, managing a team, mediating conflict
Physical, hands-on work in messy settings	Low (for now)	Electrical repair, plumbing, nursing, cooking, installing equipment, home care
Accountability	Low	Signing off, taking legal or professional responsibility, being the person who answers for a result

Chapter 5 goes much deeper into how to judge the AI exposure of any role. For now, keep this frame in mind: you are not a job title. You are a set of skills and tasks, and many of them carry forward.

This has happened before (and it was still hard)

Big shifts in technology are not new. Looking back can help, as long as we are honest about what history actually shows.

When farming became mechanised, the share of people working on farms dropped sharply over generations in many countries. Factory work grew, then later shrank as machines and global trade changed manufacturing. Typing pools and switchboard operators largely disappeared as computers and automatic phone systems spread. Bank cash machines took over simple withdrawals, yet banks kept employing people, with the work shifting toward advice, sales and service.

In each case, overall employment eventually recovered and new kinds of work appeared, many that nobody could have predicted. Few people in 1980 imagined jobs like app developer, social media manager or data scientist.

But history also shows a harder truth. The transition was often painful for the specific people caught in it. Some found new work quickly. Others took years, or ended up in lower-paid roles. Whole towns struggled. The long-run average looked fine; many individual lives did not.

> *The economy as a whole tends to adapt. Your job is to make sure you adapt with it, not get left on the wrong side of the average.*

What made the difference for people who came through well? The same few things show up again and again: they moved early rather than waiting, they built on skills they already had, they leaned on other people, and they kept trying small steps even when the big picture was unclear. This book is built around exactly those habits.

What is different this time

It would be dishonest to say this shift is just like the others. A few things really are new:

- **Speed.** AI tools have improved and spread in a few years, not a few decades. There is less time to adjust.
- **Who is affected.** Earlier waves mostly hit physical and manual work. This one reaches into office jobs, creative work and professional services, which many people assumed were safe.
- **Breadth.** One tool can affect many fields at once, from law to marketing to software.

These differences are real. They are also why acting early and deliberately matters so much. You do not have to predict the future perfectly. You just have to keep moving toward work where people are still clearly needed.

What AI can and cannot do (as of late 2026)

Fear grows in the dark. Let's turn on the lights. Here is a plain look at the strengths and limits of today's AI tools. These change over time, so treat this as a snapshot, not a final verdict.

AI IS OFTEN GOOD AT

- Producing fast first drafts of text, code, images and summaries
- Answering common questions with well-known answers
- Sorting, tagging and extracting information from large amounts of data
- Translating everyday language
- Following clear, repeatable steps on a computer
- Working at huge volume, any time of day

AI STILL STRUGGLES WITH

- Being reliably accurate; it can state wrong things confidently
- Understanding context it hasn't been told: office politics, a client's history, local culture
- Taking responsibility; someone still has to sign off and answer for the result
- Building trust and long-term relationships
- Physical work in unpredictable places, like homes, hospitals and building sites
- Knowing what is worth doing in the first place

Notice the pattern. AI is strong at producing output. It is much weaker at knowing whether that output is right, deciding what matters, and being trusted by other humans. Those are the gaps where people remain essential, and Chapter 6 explores how to build your strengths there.

TIP

Spend 20 minutes trying a free AI assistant on a task from your old job. Ask it to draft something you used to write, or to solve a problem you used to solve. Notice where it does well and, more importantly, where you can see its mistakes. That gap is your expertise. Chapter 7 gives you a full 30-day plan for getting comfortable with these tools.

Why it feels so personal

Losing work to a machine can feel different from losing work to a budget cut. It can feel like a judgment: "What I did wasn't valuable. A computer could do it." That stings in a deep place.

Here is a more accurate way to see it. Companies automate tasks because those tasks became cheap to automate, not because the people doing them were bad. Being replaced on a routine task is a statement about the cost of software, not about your worth, intelligence or effort.

It may also feel personal because work is tied to identity. Many of us answer "What do you do?" with our job title. When the title goes, it can feel like part of us went with it. That is a real loss, and Chapter 4 helps you work through it.

A STORY

This is an illustrative composite, not a real person. Mariana, 44, spent eleven years as a translator in Lisbon, mostly on business documents. When her agency switched to AI translation with human review, her hours dropped by more than half. At first she felt humiliated. "A program does my job now," she told a friend. After a few weeks, she listed what clients had actually thanked her for over the years. It wasn't the routine documents. It was catching a phrase that would have offended a partner in Brazil, explaining why a contract clause meant something different in Portuguese law, and calming a nervous client before a negotiation. She began pitching herself as a cross-cultural communication consultant for small firms entering Portuguese-speaking markets. It took months, and it wasn't easy. But she was building on what she had, not starting from zero.

Common thoughts, and a more accurate version

The thought	A more accurate version
"I'm obsolete."	Some of my tasks were automated. Many of my skills still matter in other settings.
"I should have seen this coming."	Very few people predicted the speed of this change, including experts and companies.
"I'm too old to learn this."	Adults learn new tools all the time, especially when it's tied to real goals. Experience helps you learn faster.

The thought	A more accurate version
“Everyone else is doing fine.”	Many people are quietly struggling. You see their highlights, not their worry.
“There’s no point trying.”	Hiring is harder, not impossible. Targeted, steady effort works far better than random effort.

What is the harshest thing you have been telling yourself about your situation? Write it down. Then write a version that is just as honest, but fairer.

A realistic outlook

So what should you actually expect? Here is an honest, middle-of-the-road view.

- **The next few months may be hard.** Searching takes longer than it used to for many people, and money may be tight. Plan for that rather than hoping it won’t happen. Chapters 2 and 3 help you prepare.
- **Your next role may look different.** It may be an adjacent role, a hybrid of old and new skills, or work in a field you hadn’t considered. Different is not the same as worse.
- **Growth areas are real.** Care work, health, skilled trades, the energy transition, infrastructure, education, hospitality and AI-adjacent roles are all areas where demand is expected to stay strong or grow. Chapter 5 covers these in detail.
- **Using AI well is becoming a basic skill.** Like using email or a spreadsheet, it is increasingly expected. The good news: the basics can be learned in weeks.
- **People who adapt early tend to do better.** You don’t need a perfect plan. You need to start.

KEY IDEA

Hope is not the same as optimism. Optimism says things will turn out fine. Hope says, "There are things I can do that make a better outcome more likely." This book is built on hope.

Three possible futures, one plan

Since nobody knows exactly how fast AI will change your field, it helps to think about a few scenarios and choose actions that make sense in all of them.

If change is...	What it might look like	Moves that help
Slower than feared	Your field adjusts gradually; many roles shift rather than vanish	Learn AI tools, strengthen human skills, network actively
Steady and uneven	Some roles shrink, new hybrid roles appear, demand moves between sectors	Same as above, plus test an adjacent path or two
Faster than expected	Your old role largely disappears in your area	Same as above, plus build runway, consider retraining or a growth sector

Look closely at the last column. The moves overlap. Learning the tools, building on human strengths, staying connected to people, protecting your money and testing new directions are wise in every scenario. You don't have to bet on one future. You can prepare for all of them at once.

Your personal starting point

Before moving on, take stock. You don't need answers yet; Part III of this book will help you build them. You just need an honest snapshot of where you are today.

WORKSHEET 1.1 — YOUR TASKS, SORTED

Task I did in my last job	Routine or human-heavy?	Could AI help me do it better?	Where else is this useful?

Task I did in my last job	Routine or human-heavy?	Could AI help me do it better?	Where else is this useful?

List at least eight tasks. Include the small, invisible ones: “I was the person everyone asked when the system broke,” or “I trained every new hire.” These often turn out to be your most valuable skills.

GROUND YOURSELF: A QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] I can name at least three tasks I did that needed human judgment or trust
- [ ] I understand that losing routine tasks to AI is about cost, not my worth
- [ ] I have tried an AI tool at least once on a work-related task
- [ ] I know which chapter to read next based on my most urgent need
- [ ] I have told at least one person how I’m really feeling
- [ ] I have stopped (or limited) doom-scrolling AI news for now

How to use this news without drowning in it

When you are anxious about AI, it is tempting to read everything about it. Headlines swing between “AI will change everything tomorrow” and “AI is overhyped.” Reading all of it rarely makes you calmer or better informed. It mostly keeps you on edge.

DO THIS NOW

1. Pick one or two reliable sources for news about work and AI, such as a respected newspaper or your industry's trade publication.
2. Set a limit: for example, 15 minutes, once a day, not before bed.
3. Mute or unfollow accounts that leave you feeling panicked without giving you anything you can act on.
4. When you read something worrying, ask: "Is there one thing I can do about this?" If yes, write it down. If no, let it go for today.

Chapter 22 returns to this, with a longer-term system for staying informed without doom-scrolling.

Where to go from here

This book is designed so you can jump to what you need. If you just lost your job, go straight to Chapter 2 for the first 30 days. If money is the loudest worry, Chapter 3 helps you build a runway. If you are struggling emotionally, Chapter 4 is there for you, and it is not a sign of weakness to start there.

When you are steadier, Part II helps you understand the new landscape, Part III helps you choose a direction, and Part IV helps you win in a crowded job market. Take it one step at a time.

If a friend were in your exact situation, what would you want them to know about their value? Write it to yourself.

REMEMBER

- AI automates tasks, not whole people. Your skills are bigger than your last job title.
- Big technology shifts have happened before. Economies adapt, but individuals need a plan to come through well.
- This shift is faster and reaches more office and creative work than earlier ones. That's why acting early matters.
- AI is strong at output, weak at accuracy, judgment, trust, accountability and hands-on work in messy places.
- Losing routine work to software reflects the cost of software, not your worth.
- Choose moves that help in every possible future: learn the tools, build human strengths, protect your money, stay connected.

Your next step: Fill in Worksheet 1.1 with at least eight tasks from your last job, and circle the three that needed the most human judgment.

CHAPTER 2

The First 30 Days After Losing Your Job

A calm, step-by-step plan for the first month: what to do in the first 72 hours, how to handle severance and paperwork, how to protect your income and health coverage, and how to shape your days so you keep moving.

The first days after a layoff can feel like being dropped into cold water. Your mind races, your stomach turns, and everything seems urgent at once. It is hard to know what actually matters.

This chapter is your map. Not everything needs doing today. A few things are truly time-sensitive, and missing them can cost you money or coverage. Most other things can wait a week. Knowing the difference is a huge relief.

Go slowly. Read the 72-hour checklist first. Then come back to the rest of the chapter when you have a bit more breathing room.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> In the first month, your main jobs are to **protect** (money, health coverage, legal rights), **stabilise** (sleep, routine, support), and **prepare** (references, records, a simple plan). The full job search can start once these are in place. Rushing into frantic applications in week one rarely helps.

The first 72 hours

You do not need to make big decisions in the first three days. You need to secure a few things before they slip away, and then let yourself breathe.

THE 72-HOUR CHECKLIST

- [ ] Do not sign any severance or separation agreement yet. Ask how long you have to review it.
- [ ] Save copies of everything you received: termination letter, severance offer, benefits information, final pay details.
- [ ] Write down exactly what you were told, by whom, and when, while it's fresh.
- [ ] Download personal records you are allowed to keep: your own pay slips, tax forms, performance reviews, and any praise emails sent to you. Do not take confidential company data.
- [ ] Save the contact details (personal email or phone) of colleagues and managers you want to stay in touch with.
- [ ] Find out your last day of pay, and when and how you will receive final pay, unused holiday pay and any severance.
- [ ] Find out exactly when your work health coverage ends (if you have it through work).
- [ ] Look up how to apply for unemployment or jobseeker benefits where you live, and note any deadlines.
- [ ] Check your bank balance and list any bills due in the next 30 days.
- [ ] Tell at least one person you trust what happened.
- [ ] Eat a proper meal, drink water, and try to get to bed at a normal time.

WATCH OUT

Be careful with company devices and accounts. Many employers cut access immediately, and copying company files can create legal trouble. Only keep things that are clearly yours, such as your own pay records. If you're unsure, ask HR in writing what you are allowed to keep.

TIP

Create one folder, on paper or on your computer, called “Job transition.” Put every letter, form, receipt and note in it. You will need these documents for benefits applications, tax returns and possibly legal advice. Future you will be very grateful.

Severance and paperwork

Severance (also called a redundancy payment or a separation package in some countries) is money or benefits your employer offers when your job ends. Some of it may be required by law. Some may be offered in exchange for you signing an agreement, often one where you give up the right to sue the company.

The single most important rule: **you usually have more time and more room to ask questions than it first appears.** Companies often present a package as final. Sometimes it is. Sometimes small parts can change if you ask politely.

What to look for in a severance agreement

Item	What to check
Payment amount	How it’s calculated, whether it’s a lump sum or paid over time, and when it arrives
Notice period / pay in lieu	Whether you are paid for a notice period you won’t work
Unused holiday or vacation	Whether it’s paid out (in many places this is required)
Health coverage	When it ends and whether the company will help pay for continued coverage
Bonus, commission, equity	What happens to earned bonuses, unpaid commission, and stock options or shares
Release of claims	What legal rights you give up by signing
Non-compete / non-solicit	Any limits on where you can work next or who you can contact

Item	What to check
Reference and announcement	What the company will say about your departure, and to whom
Deadline	How long you have to sign and whether you can change your mind afterward

Rules differ a lot by country. A few examples, so you know what kind of protections may exist:

- **United States:** Workers aged 40 and over who are asked to give up age discrimination claims generally must be given at least 21 days to consider the agreement (45 days in a group layoff) and 7 days to change their mind after signing.
- **United Kingdom:** A settlement agreement is generally only binding if you have received independent legal advice on it, and employers often contribute toward the cost of that advice. Statutory redundancy pay may apply if you have at least two years' service.
- **Canada, EU countries and Australia:** Minimum notice periods or redundancy pay often apply, set by law or by collective agreements, and sometimes by your contract on top.

These are general examples. Check your local rules with an employment lawyer, a union, a legal aid service or your government's labour agency. Many offer free or low-cost first consultations.

SCRIPT: ASKING ABOUT SEVERANCE TERMS

Hi [HR contact name],

Thank you for meeting with me on [date]. I want to make sure I understand everything before I sign anything, so I have a few questions:

1. What is the deadline to sign the agreement, and is there any flexibility on that date?
2. Can you confirm how the severance amount was calculated, and when it will be paid?
3. Will my unused holiday/vacation days be paid out?
4. When exactly does my health coverage end, and is there any support for continuing it?
5. What happens to my [bonus / commission / equity] for this year?
6. What will the company confirm if a future employer contacts you for a reference?

I'd also like to ask whether there is any room to [extend health coverage support / increase the payment / adjust the non-compete], given [my X years of service / my role in project Y / the short notice].

Thank you for your help. I'd appreciate a reply in writing.

Best regards,
[Your name]

TIP

Ask for things that cost the company little but help you a lot: a longer period of health coverage support, a positive agreed reference, outplacement or career coaching, keeping your laptop, or a later end date. These are often easier to win than more cash.

Other paperwork to gather

PAPERWORK CHECKLIST

- [ ] Termination or redundancy letter stating the reason (often needed for benefits)
- [ ] Your employment contract and any updates
- [ ] Recent pay slips and your final pay slip
- [ ] Tax documents for the year so far
- [ ] Official employment record if your country uses one (for example, a Record of Employment in Canada or a P45 in the UK)
- [ ] Retirement or pension plan details and your account numbers
- [ ] Health and other insurance details, including end dates
- [ ] Your performance reviews and any written praise you're allowed to keep

Unemployment and jobseeker benefits

Many people delay applying for benefits because of pride, confusion or hope that they will find work quickly. Please don't wait. These programmes exist for exactly this moment. In many places, you or your employer paid into them while you were working.

Benefits vary widely. Here are some examples of what to look for:

Where	Common programmes (examples)	Where to start
United States	Unemployment insurance, run by each state	Your state's labour or workforce agency website
United Kingdom	New Style Jobseeker's Allowance, Universal Credit	The government's official website (GOV.UK)
Canada	Employment Insurance (EI)	Service Canada
Australia	JobSeeker Payment	Services Australia
EU countries	National unemployment insurance schemes	Your national public employment service

WATCH OUT

Deadlines can be strict. In some countries, applying late can reduce or cancel your benefits, and some require you to register as a jobseeker very soon after you learn your job is ending, even before your last day. Look this up in your first 72 hours. Also note that severance and holiday pay can affect when benefits start, so read the rules or ask.

1. **Find the official site.** Use your government's official website only. Avoid paid "help" services that charge for free applications.
2. **Gather documents.** ID, bank details, employer details, dates of employment, and the reason your job ended.
3. **Apply as early as allowed.** Even if you think you might not qualify, apply and let them decide.
4. **Note your obligations.** Many programmes require you to log job search activity, attend appointments or report earnings. Put these in your calendar.
5. **Keep records.** Save confirmation numbers, screenshots and letters in your transition folder.
6. **Ask about extra support.** Many public employment services offer free training, career coaching or retraining funds. Ask what's available (see Chapter 10).

Health coverage

If your health coverage came through your job, losing it can be one of the most frightening parts of a layoff. If you live in a country with a public health system, your basic coverage likely continues, but you may lose private extras such as dental, vision or faster specialist access.

If you are in the United States

- **COBRA** usually lets you keep your employer's plan for a period (often up to 18 months), but you typically pay the full cost yourself, which can be expen-

sive. You generally have 60 days to decide, and coverage can be applied back to your end date.

- **The ACA Marketplace** (HealthCare.gov or your state's exchange): losing job-based coverage usually gives you a 60-day special enrollment window. With lower income, you may qualify for subsidies that make plans much cheaper than COBRA.
- **Medicaid:** depending on your state and income, you or your children may qualify.
- **A partner's plan:** losing your coverage usually lets you join a spouse's or partner's workplace plan outside the normal enrollment period.

Elsewhere

In the UK, Canada, Australia and most EU countries, public health care continues regardless of your job. Check whether any private insurance from work can be continued on an individual basis, and whether you have any prescriptions, dental work or appointments you should book before work coverage ends.

DO THIS NOW

1. Write down the exact date your current coverage ends.
2. List any upcoming medical needs: prescriptions, treatments, appointments.
3. Compare at least two options for continued coverage, including cost.
4. Put the decision deadline in your calendar with a reminder one week before.

References: lock them in early

The people who know your work best are easiest to reach right now. In six months, your old manager may have moved on, too. Securing references in the first few weeks is one of the smartest things you can do.

REFERENCE CHECKLIST

- [ ] Identify three to five people who can speak to your work (managers, senior colleagues, clients)
- [ ] Get their personal email or phone, not just work contacts
- [ ] Ask if they are willing to be a reference
- [ ] Ask for a short written recommendation or a public endorsement on a professional networking site while your work is fresh in their mind
- [ ] Find out what your company's official reference policy is (some only confirm dates and job title)
- [ ] Send each reference a short summary of your key achievements to make it easy for them

SCRIPT: ASKING A FORMER MANAGER TO BE A REFERENCE

Hi [Name],

As you know, my role was part of the recent changes at [Company]. I really valued working with you, especially on [project or result].

Would you be willing to act as a reference for me as I look for my next role? If it helps, I can send you a short list of what we achieved together so it's easy to recall the details.

And if you have five minutes, a short written recommendation would mean a lot to me. No pressure at all if now isn't a good time.

Thank you, and I hope we stay in touch.
[Your name]
[Personal email] | [Phone]

Telling people

Deciding who to tell, and how, can feel awkward. You may feel embarrassed, or worried people will treat you differently. But keeping it secret is lonely and slows your search, because so many jobs are found through people you know (Chapter 12 covers this in depth).

You don't need to tell everyone at once. Think in circles:

1. **Inner circle:** partner, close family, a close friend. Tell them early and honestly. Chapter 4 includes a script for these conversations.
2. **Trusted professional contacts:** former colleagues and mentors. Tell them within the first couple of weeks.
3. **Wider network:** a short, positive public post when you're ready, often after the first week or two.

Your short explanation

Prepare one or two sentences you can say calmly. Practise it out loud a few times. A layoff, especially one linked to automation, is common right now and nothing to hide.

SCRIPT: YOUR SHORT EXPLANATION

"My role at [Company] was cut as part of a restructuring, as they moved more of [type of work] to automated tools. I'm taking this as a chance to move toward [direction, if known / work where I can use my skills in X]. If you hear of anything in that area, I'd love to know."

SCRIPT: A SHORT PUBLIC POST

After [X] years at [Company], my role ended this month as part of a restructuring. I'm proud of what I contributed, including [one concrete achievement].

I'm now looking for roles in [field or role type], where I can bring my experience in [two or three skills]. If you know of opportunities or people I should talk to, I'd be grateful for an introduction.

Thank you to the colleagues who made the work so rewarding.

WATCH OUT

Don't criticise your former employer in public, however you feel. Future employers read these posts. Vent privately to people you trust instead. Also, once you post publicly, expect a rise in job scam messages. Chapter 14 explains how to spot them.

Structuring your days

Without work, days can blur. You might sleep late, scroll for hours, and then feel guilty at night. Or you might do the opposite, spending 12 frantic hours a day sending applications until you burn out. Neither helps.

A simple structure brings back a sense of control. Think of your search as a part-time job with clear hours, not a 24/7 emergency.

> *Treat your search like a job you show up for, not an emergency you never leave.*

A healthy daily shape

- **Start at a regular time.** Get up, get dressed, and begin roughly when you used to start work.
- **Do the hardest task first.** Outreach messages or tailored applications in the morning, when your energy is highest.
- **Mix in learning.** An hour of skill-building gives you a sense of progress even on quiet days.
- **Move your body and go outside.** Every day, even a short walk.
- **Have a stopping time.** End your search work at a set hour. Evenings are for rest and people.

WORKSHEET 2.1 — WEEKLY ROUTINE TEMPLATE

Day	Morning (focus work)	Afternoon (learning, admin)	Rest & connection
Monday			
Tuesday			
Wednesday			
Thursday			
Friday			
Saturday			

Day	Morning (focus work)	Afternoon (learning, admin)	Rest & connection
Sunday			

Example entries: “Monday morning: send four outreach messages.” “Tuesday afternoon: one hour on an AI fluency lesson (Chapter 7).” “Wednesday evening: dinner with my sister.” Keep at least one day a week mostly free from job search work.

> **A STORY**
>
> *This is an illustrative composite, not a real person. Dev, 29, a junior developer in Toronto, was laid off when his company adopted coding agents. For the first week he applied to 40 jobs a day and slept four hours a night. He heard nothing back and felt worse every day. A friend suggested he try a schedule: mornings for a few targeted applications and messages to people at those companies, afternoons for building a small project, and gym at 5 p.m. His number of applications dropped, but his replies went up, and he slept again. It didn’t solve everything, but it made the search something he could keep doing.*

Your 30-day plan at a glance

Week	Focus	Key actions
Week 1	Protect	72-hour checklist, review severance, apply for benefits, sort health coverage, tell inner circle
Week 2	Stabilise	Money triage (Chapter 3), set up your weekly routine, lock in references, tell professional contacts
Week 3	Reflect	Skills inventory (Chapter 8), explore paths (Chapter 9), start AI fluency plan (Chapter 7)
Week 4	Prepare	Update CV/résumé (Chapter 11), map your network (Chapter 12), pick a first direction to test

This is a guide, not a race. If week one takes two weeks because you need rest, that’s fine. The order matters more than the speed.

What not to do in the first month

TRY TO AVOID

- Signing a severance agreement on the spot
- Cashing out retirement savings in a panic (see Chapter 3)
- Paying for an expensive course before you know your direction
- Accepting the first offer out of fear without checking it
- Mass-applying to hundreds of jobs with the same CV
- Hiding what happened from the people closest to you

INSTEAD

- Ask for time and get advice
- Build a runway plan first
- Use free resources while you explore
- Compare it with your plan and your runway
- Send fewer, targeted applications
- Let a few trusted people help carry the load

What is the one thing about this month that worries you most? What is one small step you could take this week to make it a little less scary?

What do you want your days to feel like this month? Describe a good, realistic day.

REMEMBER

- In the first 72 hours, protect your rights, records, income and health coverage. Big decisions can wait.
- Don't sign severance agreements immediately. Ask questions, get advice, and ask for low-cost extras.
- Apply for unemployment or jobseeker benefits early. Deadlines can be strict.
- Know exactly when your health coverage ends and compare your options before the deadline.
- Lock in references in the first few weeks while your work is fresh in people's minds.
- Tell people in circles, with a short, calm explanation. Your network is one of your best resources.
- Give your days a shape: focused mornings, learning, movement, a stopping time, and rest.

Your next step: Work through the 72-hour checklist today, starting with the items that have deadlines: severance, benefits and health coverage.

CHAPTER 3

Money Triage: Building Your Runway

How to work out how long your money can last, stretch it further, talk to lenders before you fall behind, bridge the gap with honest side income, and steer clear of the debt traps and "get rich with AI" scams that target people in exactly your position.

Money worry is loud. It wakes you at 3 a.m. and follows you through the day. It can make it hard to think about anything else, including the job search that would fix the problem.

The way to quiet that noise is not to avoid the numbers. It is to look at them clearly, once, and make a plan. Most people find that facing the real figures, even when they're tough, is less frightening than the vague dread of not knowing.

This chapter walks you through "money triage": like a nurse in an emergency room, you deal with the most urgent things first. You'll calculate your runway, cut where it counts, protect what matters most, and avoid the mistakes that make a hard period much worse.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> Your **runway** is how many months you can cover your essential costs before you run out of money. The longer your runway, the more choice you have: you can hold out for a better-fit job, retrain, or test a new path instead of grabbing the first thing out of fear. Every month you add to your runway is a month of freedom.

This chapter offers general guidance, not personal financial advice. For decisions about debt, taxes or retirement accounts, talk to a qualified, independent adviser or a free non-profit money advice service where you live.

Step 1: Know what you have

Start by listing every source of money you can count on in the coming months. Be realistic. Only include money you are confident will arrive.

WORKSHEET 3.1 — MONEY YOU HAVE AND MONEY COMING IN

Source	Amount	When it arrives
Checking / current account		Now
Savings (easy to access)		Now
Final pay and holiday pay		
Severance / redundancy pay (after tax)		
Unemployment / jobseeker benefits (monthly)		
Partner's or household income (monthly)		
Expected tax refund		
Side income you are confident about (monthly)		
Other		

TIP

Severance may be taxed differently from normal pay, and in some places it can delay when benefits start. Ask your employer what will be deducted, and check the benefit rules. Use the amount you'll actually receive, not the headline figure.

Step 2: Sort your spending

Next, look at what you spend in a typical month. Pull up the last two or three months of bank and card statements. It's tedious, but it's the most useful hour you'll spend this week. Sort each expense into one of three groups:

- **Essential:** things you must pay to stay safe, housed, healthy and able to work. Housing, utilities, basic food, essential transport, insurance, minimum debt payments, medicine, childcare you need.

- **Flexible:** things you need, but where the amount can shrink. Groceries beyond basics, phone plan, internet speed, transport choices.
- **Optional:** things you can pause for now. Subscriptions, eating out, takeaway, new clothes, hobbies that cost money, gifts beyond token amounts.

WORKSHEET 3.2 — MONTHLY SPENDING, SORTED

Expense	Current monthly cost	Essential / flexible / optional	New target
Rent / mortgage			
Utilities (energy, water)			
Groceries			
Transport			
Phone and internet			
Health coverage and medicine			
Insurance (home, car, life)			
Minimum debt payments			
Childcare / dependants			
Subscriptions			
Eating out and takeaway			
Everything else			

Step 3: Calculate your runway

Now for the key number. You're going to work it out two ways: what your runway looks like if nothing changes, and what it looks like with your new, leaner budget.

1. **Add up your available money.** Total of savings, final pay and severance from Worksheet 3.1 (the one-off amounts). Call this *A*.

2. **Add up your regular monthly income.** Benefits, partner income, reliable side income. Call this *B*.
3. **Add up your monthly spending.** Use your new target column from Worksheet 3.2. Call this *C*.
4. **Find your monthly gap.** Subtract income from spending: *C* − *B*. This is how much you lose each month.
5. **Divide.** Runway in months = *A* ÷ *(C* − *B)*. If your income covers your spending, your runway is open-ended for now.

WORKSHEET 3.3 — RUNWAY CALCULATOR

Line	Current spending	Lean budget
A. Available money (one-off)		
B. Regular monthly income		
C. Monthly spending		
D. Monthly gap (C − B)		
E. Runway in months (A ÷ D)		
F. Date money runs out		
G. “Decision date” (2 months before F)		

Here’s an example. Suppose you have 9,000 in savings and severance (in whatever currency you use). Your benefits and a partner’s contribution bring in 1,400 a month. Your current spending is 3,200 a month, but your lean budget is 2,600.

- Current: gap is 3,200 − 1,400 = 1,800. Runway = 9,000 ÷ 1,800 = 5 months.
- Lean: gap is 2,600 − 1,400 = 1,200. Runway = 9,000 ÷ 1,200 = 7.5 months.

Trimming 600 a month bought two and a half extra months. That’s the power of this exercise.

KEY IDEA

Set a **decision date** about two months before your money would run out. If you haven't found work by then, that's when you switch to plan B: a bridge job, a bigger change in housing costs, or more side income. Deciding this now, calmly, means you won't have to decide it later in a panic.

Step 4: Stretch your runway

Small cuts add up, but the biggest wins usually come from a few large costs. Focus there first.

The big levers

- **Housing:** ask about hardship options on your mortgage (see below), consider a lodger or flatmate if it's safe and practical, or negotiate with your landlord before you fall behind.
- **Transport:** could you sell a second car, switch to public transport, or pause a car loan through a hardship programme?
- **Insurance:** shop around or adjust cover, but don't drop health or essential insurance without understanding the risk.
- **Debt payments:** ask lenders for lower payments, paused payments, or a lower interest rate.

The quick wins

SPENDING CUTS TO CHECK THIS WEEK

- [ ] Cancel or pause every subscription you won't miss (streaming, apps, memberships, software)
- [ ] Call your phone and internet providers and ask for a cheaper plan or a loyalty discount
- [ ] Plan a week of meals and shop with a list
- [ ] Check if you qualify for social tariffs on energy, water, phone or internet (offered in several countries for people on low income or benefits)
- [ ] Ask about discounts for unemployed people: public transport, gyms, museums, libraries, courses
- [ ] Use your local library for books, internet, printing and often free courses
- [ ] Pause automatic savings or investment transfers if you need the cash flow (you can restart later)
- [ ] Delay large purchases unless they're essential

WATCH OUT

Don't cut things that protect your future earning power or health. Keep your phone and internet working, since you need them to job hunt. Keep up with medicine. And don't skimp so hard on food that it hurts your energy and mood. Lean is good; harmful is not.

Step 5: Talk to lenders early

This is the step most people avoid, and the one that often helps most. Many lenders, landlords, mortgage providers and utility companies have hardship programmes for people who lose their income. The catch: they are much more flexible **before** you miss payments than after.

Hardship options can include:

- A short pause in payments (sometimes called forbearance or a payment holiday)

- Lower payments for a few months
- Lower interest rates or waived fees
- Extending the length of a loan to reduce monthly payments
- For student loans in some countries, income-based repayment plans that can drop very low when your income falls

Each of these has trade-offs. Interest may still build up, and some options can affect your credit. Ask exactly how each option works before you agree.

SCRIPT: CALLING A LENDER FOR HARDSHIP OPTIONS

"Hello, my name is [Name], and my account number is [number]. I'm calling because I recently lost my job, and I want to stay on track with my payments. I haven't missed a payment yet, and I'd like to keep it that way.

Can you tell me what hardship or payment assistance options you offer? For example, could I reduce my payments or pause them for a few months?"

When they describe options, ask:

"Will interest continue to build during that time?
Will this be reported to credit agencies, and how?
What happens at the end of the hardship period? Will I need to make up the missed amount at once?
Are there any fees?
Can you send me the details in writing?"

Before ending the call: "Thank you. Can I have your name and a reference number for this call?"

TIP

Keep a simple call log: date, company, name of person, what was agreed, reference number. If something goes wrong later, this record protects you. Ask for every agreement to be confirmed by email or letter.

Which bills come first?

If you can't pay everything, prioritise the bills where falling behind has the most serious consequences. These are often called **priority debts**:

1. Housing (rent or mortgage)
2. Energy and water
3. Taxes owed to the government
4. Court-ordered payments, such as child support or fines
5. Car loan, if you need the car to get work
6. Essential insurance

Credit cards, personal loans and buy-now-pay-later plans matter too, but the consequences of falling behind are usually less immediate. Talk to them, but pay the priority bills first. A free, non-profit debt advice service can help you work out the right order for your situation. Most countries have them; search for "free debt advice" plus your country, and look for a registered charity or government-backed service.

Step 6: Use the help that exists

On top of unemployment benefits (see Chapter 2), many places have extra support for people on low or reduced income. People often don't claim these because they don't know they exist.

SUPPORT TO LOOK INTO

- [ ] Housing or rent assistance programmes
- [ ] Food assistance programmes and food banks
- [ ] Help with energy or heating bills
- [ ] Reduced-cost or free health care, prescriptions or dental care
- [ ] Child benefits or tax credits that increase when income drops
- [ ] Free school meals for children
- [ ] Council tax or local tax reductions
- [ ] Retraining grants or funds through your public employment service (see Chapter 10)
- [ ] Hardship funds from unions, professional bodies or former employers

Many countries have free online benefits calculators run by government or charities. Ten minutes with one can reveal support you didn't know about. If you feel uncomfortable accepting help, remember that this is what these programmes are for. Using them now helps you get back on your feet faster.

Step 7: Bridge income, without losing focus

A little income can stretch your runway a lot. Earning even a few hundred a month can add months of time. But bridge work should support your search, not swallow it. Aim for something flexible, with limited hours, that doesn't drain all your energy.

Type of bridge income	Pros	Watch for
Part-time or temporary work (retail, hospitality, warehouse, delivery)	Reliable pay, gets you out of the house, real people	Can be tiring; check impact on benefits
Contract or freelance work in your field	Keeps your skills fresh, adds to your CV	Irregular pay; contracts and tax (see Chapter 15)
Tutoring, teaching or coaching	Uses your expertise, flexible hours	Needs a few clients to be worthwhile
Local services (pet care, cleaning, odd jobs, helping small businesses)	Fast to start, local demand	Insurance, safety, local rules
Selling things you no longer need	Quick cash, clears space	One-off, not ongoing

WATCH OUT

Most benefit programmes require you to report any earnings, and earnings can reduce your payments. Failing to report can lead to having to pay money back or penalties. Check the rules and report honestly. Also set aside some money for tax on self-employed income.

A STORY

This is an illustrative composite, not a real person. Sandra, 52, a bookkeeper in Manchester, lost her job when her firm moved to automated accounting software. Her runway came out at four months, which terrified her. She cut her budget by switching energy and phone plans, pausing two subscriptions, and taking in a lodger for her spare room. She also picked up two small local businesses that needed help checking and fixing their automated books. That brought her runway to nine months. "The extra time changed how I searched," she said. "I stopped panicking and started choosing."

Step 8: Avoid predatory debt

When money is tight, some lenders see an opportunity. High-cost credit can turn a temporary gap into a long-term trap. Be especially careful with:

- **Payday loans** and short-term cash loans, which can carry extremely high costs.
- **Car title or logbook loans**, where you can lose your car.
- **Rent-to-own** deals, which often cost far more than buying outright.
- **Buy-now-pay-later** plans used for everyday spending, which can pile up quickly across several apps.
- **Debt "consolidation" or "settlement" companies** that charge large upfront fees or tell you to stop paying your creditors.

RED FLAGS

- "Guaranteed approval, no credit check"
- Pressure to sign today
- Fees you must pay before getting the loan
- Unclear total cost or interest rate
- Lender contacted you first, out of the blue

SAFER ALTERNATIVES

- Hardship programmes from your existing lenders
- Credit unions or community lenders
- Government or charity emergency funds
- Free non-profit debt advice
- Short, written agreements with family, if appropriate

Step 9: Spot "get rich with AI" scams

People who've lost jobs to AI are a prime target for a new wave of scams that promise to make you rich *using* AI. You'll see ads, videos and messages promising passive income from AI-written books, automated online stores, AI trading bots, or "done-for-you" AI businesses. A few honest people do build small businesses with AI (Chapter 16 shows realistic ways). But many of these offers exist mainly to sell you courses, software or "coaching" at high prices.

SCAM WARNING SIGNS

- [ ] Promises of large, fast or "passive" income with little effort
- [ ] Screenshots of earnings or luxury lifestyle as proof
- [ ] Countdown timers and "only 3 spots left" pressure
- [ ] You must pay upfront for a course, software, starter kit or "membership"
- [ ] Income mainly comes from recruiting other people
- [ ] AI trading bots or crypto schemes promising guaranteed returns
- [ ] Requests to pay in cryptocurrency, gift cards or by wire transfer
- [ ] Vague answers when you ask exactly how the money is made

DO THIS NOW

Before paying for any income opportunity, ask three questions:

1. Who exactly pays money, and for what? (If the answer is "people who join," walk away.)
2. Can I find independent reviews and complaints by searching the company name plus "scam" or "complaints"?
3. Would I still do this if I waited a week to decide? (Real opportunities don't vanish in 24 hours.)

Fake job offers are another common trap, especially once you post that you're looking for work. Chapter 14 covers recruitment scams in detail.

Step 10: Protect your retirement savings

When things get scary, a retirement or pension pot can look like a lifeline. Sometimes using it is truly necessary. But cashing it out early is often one of the most expensive choices you can make, and it's hard to undo.

- **Taxes and penalties.** In many countries, early withdrawals are taxed as income, and some add penalties. For example, in the US, withdrawals from a 401(k) or IRA before age 59½ generally face income tax plus a 10% additional tax, with some exceptions.
- **Lost growth.** Money withdrawn now can't keep growing for your future.
- **Restrictions.** In some countries, such as the UK, most pension money can't be accessed until a minimum age anyway. Anyone offering to "unlock" it early may be running a scam.

Better first moves

1. **Leave it where it is, or move it carefully.** When you leave a job, you can often leave the pension with the old employer's plan or transfer it to another plan. Avoid cashing it out by accident when you change jobs.
2. **Use other options first.** Benefits, budget cuts, hardship programmes and bridge income usually come before retirement money.
3. **If you must use it,** take only what you need, understand the tax cost first, and get advice from a qualified, independent adviser or a free government pension guidance service.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Be very suspicious of anyone who calls, texts or messages you offering a "free pension review," a way to access your pension early, or a special investment for your retirement money. Pension scams are common and can wipe out a lifetime of savings.

Talking about money at home

If you share finances with a partner or family, include them in this triage. Money stress grows when it's kept secret. Sit down together with the worksheets, share the real runway number, and agree on the cuts as a team. Chapter

4 includes guidance on telling family, and Chapter 20 covers longer-term family conversations.

What feelings come up when you look at your runway number? What would make you feel 10% safer this month?

Which three spending cuts would hurt least? Which one thing are you not willing to cut, and why does it matter to you?

REMEMBER

- Your runway is the number of months your money covers essentials. Calculate it today, both at current spending and on a lean budget.
- Set a decision date about two months before your money runs out, so you can change course calmly.
- Focus cuts on the big costs first: housing, transport, debt payments, insurance.
- Call lenders before you miss payments. Hardship options are easier to get early. Get everything in writing.
- Pay priority bills first and use free, non-profit debt advice.
- Claim the support that exists, and use modest bridge income to extend your runway, reporting earnings honestly.
- Avoid payday loans, upfront-fee "opportunities" and "get rich with AI" schemes.
- Treat retirement savings as a last resort, and get independent advice before touching them.

Your next step: Pull up your last two months of statements and fill in Worksheets 3.2 and 3.3. Write your runway number and your decision date somewhere you'll see them.

CHAPTER 4

Mind and Body: Handling the Shock

Losing work hits your mind and body, not just your bank account. This chapter helps you understand what you're feeling, care for yourself through it, talk to the people close to you, and know when and where to get more help.

You might be surprised by how much this hurts. People who lose a job often describe feeling numb, angry, ashamed, scared, relieved, or all of these in a single afternoon. Some can't sleep. Some can't get out of bed. Some feel fine for a week and then fall apart.

All of this is normal. Losing a job is one of the more stressful things that can happen in adult life. It touches your money, your routine, your relationships, your sense of who you are, and your picture of the future, all at once.

This chapter is not about "staying positive." It's about getting through this period with your health, your relationships and your sense of self intact. A steady mind and a rested body are also your best tools for finding what comes next.

IF YOU ARE IN CRISIS RIGHT NOW

If you are thinking about ending your life or harming yourself, please reach out now. **If you are in immediate danger, call your local emergency number** (for example 911 in the US and Canada, 999 or 112 in the UK, 112 across the EU, 000 in Australia). In the **US**, call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline); 988 also works in **Canada**. In the **UK and Ireland**, call **Samaritans** free on **116 123**. In **Australia**, call **Lifeline** on **13 11 14**. In other countries, visit **findahelpline.com** to find free, confidential support near you. You don't have to be in a certain kind of crisis to call. Feeling overwhelmed is enough.

Why job loss hurts so much

Work gives us more than money. Often without noticing, we get a lot of things from it:

- **Structure:** a reason to get up, a shape to the day and week.
- **Identity:** an answer to "What do you do?"
- **Belonging:** colleagues, in-jokes, a team.
- **Purpose:** the feeling of being useful and needed.
- **Security:** a sense of being safe about the future.
- **Status:** respect from others, and from ourselves.

When the job goes, all of these can go at once. That's why it can feel so much bigger than "I need to find another job." You are not overreacting. You are reacting to a real, many-sided loss.

When AI is part of the reason, there can be an extra sting. It can feel like your skills were judged worthless, or like the future has no room for you. Chapter 1 explains why that isn't the full truth: automation reflects the cost of software, not your value. But knowing that in your head and feeling it in your gut are two different things. Give the feeling time.

Grief and identity loss

It may help to call what you're going through by its real name: grief. You can grieve a job, a career, a workplace, a team or a planned future, just as you can grieve other losses. Grief doesn't move in neat stages. It comes in waves.

Common feelings include:

- Shock or numbness ("This can't be happening.")
- Anger at the company, at technology, at the unfairness of it
- Bargaining and replaying ("If only I'd...")
- Sadness, emptiness, a heavy tiredness
- Fear about money and the future
- Moments of relief, especially if the job was stressful, followed by guilt for feeling relieved
- Gradual acceptance and curiosity about what's next

You might move through several of these in one day and come back to them weeks later. That isn't going backwards. It's how grief works.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> You are more than your job title. Your skills, values, relationships, humour, care for others, curiosity and character all came with you when you left. The job was one place you used them. There will be others.

Rebuilding your sense of self

If your identity was tightly tied to your work, it can help to deliberately remind yourself of the rest of who you are. Chapter 19 goes deeper into this, but you can start now.

Finish this sentence five different ways, without mentioning any job title: "I am someone who..."

What did you love about your old work? What will you not miss? Be honest about both.

Shame: the quiet weight

Many people feel shame after losing a job, even when the layoff had nothing to do with their performance. Shame says, "Something is wrong with me." It makes you want to hide, avoid friends and skip the very conversations that could help.

Shame grows in secrecy and shrinks when it's spoken out loud to someone safe. That's one of the most important reasons to tell people what happened.

SHAME SAYS

- "I failed."
- "People will think less of me."
- "I should be able to handle this alone."
- "I'm a burden."
- "I have to look fine."

A KINDER, TRUER REPLY

- "A role I had was cut. That's different from me failing."
- "People who care about me will want to help."
- "Asking for support is how most people get through this."
- "I have helped others before. It's okay to receive help now."
- "I can be honest about having a hard time."

TIP

Try talking to yourself the way you'd talk to a good friend in the same situation. If you wouldn't say "You're useless" to them, don't say it to yourself. This isn't about pretending. It's about being fair.

Anxiety and the racing mind

Worry about money and the future is natural, and some of it is useful. It pushes you to act. But when worry runs all day and all night, it drains your energy and makes clear thinking harder.

Signs that anxiety is taking over include a racing heart, tight chest, shallow breathing, trouble falling asleep, constant checking of your email or bank account, irritability, and going over the same worries again and again without getting anywhere.

Tools that help in the moment

1. **Slow your breathing.** Breathe in gently through your nose for a count of four, then out through your mouth for a count of six. Repeat for two minutes. A longer out-breath helps calm your body.

2. **Ground yourself.** Name five things you can see, four you can touch, three you can hear, two you can smell, and one you can taste. This pulls your mind back to the present.
3. **Move.** A brisk ten-minute walk can take the edge off a wave of panic.
4. **Write it down.** Get the worries out of your head onto paper. Seeing them listed often makes them feel smaller and more manageable.
5. **Sort the worry.** Ask: "Can I do anything about this today?" If yes, pick one small action. If no, put it on a "later" list.

Schedule your worry

It sounds odd, but it works for many people. Set aside 15 minutes a day as "worry time," perhaps late afternoon. When worries pop up at other times, jot them down and tell yourself, "I'll think about this at worry time." Then, at the set time, go through the list and decide on any actions. Outside that window, gently steer your attention back to what you're doing.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Constant AI news, layoff headlines and social media comparisons can feed anxiety without giving you anything useful to act on. Set limits on news and scrolling, especially in the evening. Chapter 1 has a simple plan for this.

Routines that hold you up

When the structure of work disappears, building your own becomes one of the most protective things you can do for your mental health. You don't need a perfect schedule. You need a few anchors that happen most days.

DAILY ANCHORS

- [ ] Wake up at roughly the same time each day
- [ ] Get dressed, even if you're staying home
- [ ] Spend some time outside, ideally in daylight in the morning
- [ ] Do at least one focused task you can finish (one application, one message, one lesson)
- [ ] Move your body for at least 20–30 minutes
- [ ] Have at least one real conversation with another person
- [ ] Eat regular meals
- [ ] Stop job-search work at a set time
- [ ] Do one thing just because you enjoy it

Chapter 2 includes a weekly routine template (Worksheet 2.1) you can use alongside these anchors.

Sleep, movement and food

Stress and the body are deeply connected. When you look after your body, your mind becomes steadier, and you think more clearly. These basics can feel too simple to matter. They matter a lot.

Sleep

Most adults need around seven to nine hours of sleep. Stress often disrupts it. These habits can help:

- Keep consistent sleep and wake times, even at weekends.
- Put screens away 30–60 minutes before bed, especially job sites, news and bank apps.
- Keep your bedroom cool, dark and quiet if you can.
- Cut down on caffeine after early afternoon, and go easy on alcohol, which tends to worsen sleep.
- If you can't sleep after about 20 minutes, get up, do something calm in low light, and go back when you feel sleepy.

- Keep a notebook by your bed for 3 a.m. worries. Write them down, then let them wait until morning.

Movement

Physical activity is one of the best-supported ways to ease stress and lift mood. The World Health Organization recommends that adults aim for at least 150 minutes of moderate activity a week. That's about 30 minutes, five days a week. Walking counts. So does cycling, dancing, gardening, swimming or playing with your kids.

If that feels like too much right now, start with ten minutes. Any movement is better than none.

Food and drink

When stressed, many people either stop eating properly or eat for comfort. Try to keep regular meals with some vegetables, protein and water, even on a tight budget. Be honest with yourself about alcohol and other substances. If you notice you're relying on them to get through the day, that's an important signal to talk to someone.

Check in with yourself

It's easy to lose track of how you're really doing. A quick weekly check-in helps you notice patterns, catch a slide early and see progress you might otherwise miss.

WORKSHEET 4.1 — WEEKLY FEELINGS AND ENERGY CHECK-IN

Area	This week (1 = very low, 5 = good)	What helped	What drained me
Mood overall			
Energy			
Sleep			
Anxiety (5 = calm)			
Hope about the future			

Area	This week (1 = very low, 5 = good)	What helped	What drained me
Connection with people			
Physical activity			
Sense of progress			

Do this at the same time each week, for example on Sunday evening. Look at the "what helped" column and do more of those things next week. If your scores stay low for two weeks or more, or are getting worse, that's a sign to reach out for more support (see below).

Talking to family

Telling the people closest to you can feel like one of the hardest parts. You might worry about letting them down, scaring them, or changing how they see you. But most partners and family members would much rather know. Keeping it hidden usually adds strain, and they often sense something is wrong anyway.

Tips for the conversation

- **Choose a calm time.** Not in the middle of a rush, an argument or late at night.
- **Be honest and specific.** Share what happened and what you know so far, including the money picture.
- **Share a plan, even a small one.** "Here's what I'm doing this week" is reassuring.
- **Say what you need.** People want to help but often don't know how.
- **Leave room for their feelings.** They may be worried or upset too. That's okay.

SCRIPT: TELLING YOUR PARTNER OR FAMILY

"I need to talk to you about something important. Today [or: last week] I found out my job at [Company] is ending. They're cutting [my team / roles like mine] as they bring in more automated tools. It's not about my performance, but it's still a big shock, and I'm feeling [scared / angry / numb].

Here's what I know so far: my last day is [date], and I'll get [severance / final pay] of about [amount]. I'm going to apply for [benefits] this week and work out a budget so we know how long our savings will last.

What would really help me right now is [listening without trying to fix it / help looking over the budget / not asking about job applications every day / just some patience if I'm quiet]. How are you feeling hearing this?"

Talking to children

Children notice changes in mood and routine, even when they don't understand why. Silence can make them imagine something worse. Keep it simple, honest and suited to their age.

SCRIPT: TELLING A CHILD

Younger children: "My job ended, so I'm going to be looking for a new one. That means I might be home more for a while. We might be careful about spending money, but you're safe, and we're going to be okay. You can ask me anything."

Older children and teens: "The company I worked for is using more automated tools, and my job was one of the ones that got cut. It wasn't because I did anything wrong. We're going to make some changes to our spending for a while, and I'm working on finding new work. I'll keep you in the loop. How do you feel about it?"

TIP

Reassure children that this isn't their fault and isn't their job to fix. Keep their routines as normal as you can. If an older child offers to help, give them a small, real way to do so, such as helping plan cheaper meals. It can ease their worry. Chapter 20 has more on family conversations over the longer term.

A STORY

This is an illustrative composite, not a real person. Kwame, 38, a customer service team lead in Melbourne, didn't tell his wife about his redundancy for nine days. He left the house each morning and sat in the library. "I felt like I'd failed the family," he said later. When he finally told her, she was hurt, but mostly by the secrecy, not the job loss. They sat down with the budget together that night. "It was the first night I slept properly since it happened," he said. "I'd been carrying it alone for no reason."

Staying connected beyond home

Loneliness is a real risk after job loss, especially if your social life was built around work. Connection protects your mood and often leads to opportunities, too.

- Reach out to one or two former colleagues for coffee or a call. They may be going through the same thing.
- Join a job-seekers' group, either local (libraries and employment centres often run them) or online.
- Volunteer a few hours a week. It adds structure, purpose and new contacts (see Chapter 19).
- Keep up with hobbies, sports or faith communities that matter to you.

You don't have to feel ready to reach out. Reaching out is often what helps you feel ready.

When to get professional help

Many people get through job loss with the support of friends and family. But sometimes stress turns into something heavier, like depression or an anxiety disorder, and professional help can make a big difference. Seeking help is a sign of good judgment, not weakness.

SIGNS IT'S TIME TO TALK TO A PROFESSIONAL

- [ ] You feel down, hopeless or empty most days for two weeks or more
- [ ] You've lost interest in things you usually enjoy
- [ ] Your sleep or appetite has changed a lot
- [ ] You struggle to get through basic daily tasks
- [ ] You feel constant, intense worry or have panic attacks
- [ ] You're using alcohol, drugs or gambling to cope
- [ ] You're withdrawing from everyone
- [ ] You're having thoughts that life isn't worth living, or of harming yourself

If the last item applies to you, please use the crisis contacts at the start and end of this chapter right away.

Where to find help (including low-cost options)

- **Your doctor or general practitioner:** often the best first step. They can assess you, discuss treatment and refer you to services.
- **Public mental health services:** many countries offer free or low-cost talking therapy. In England, for example, NHS Talking Therapies accepts self-referrals.
- **Employee Assistance Programmes (EAPs):** some employers let you keep using their free counselling service for a period after you leave. Check your exit paperwork or ask HR.
- **Community and charity services:** many offer free or sliding-scale counselling.
- **University training clinics:** often provide lower-cost therapy with supervised trainees.
- **Peer support groups:** for job loss, depression, anxiety or addiction.

SCRIPT: ASKING YOUR DOCTOR FOR HELP

"I recently lost my job, and I've been struggling more than I expected. For the past [number] weeks, I've been [having trouble sleeping / feeling hopeless / having panic attacks / unable to get going]. It's affecting [my daily life / my relationships / my job search]. I'd like to talk about what support or treatment might help, including any free or low-cost options."

TIP

AI chat assistants can be useful for organising your thoughts or learning about coping techniques. But they are not a replacement for a trained professional or a crisis line, and they can get things wrong. If you're in real distress, talk to a human.

Crisis support

If you ever feel that you can't go on, or you are thinking about suicide or self-harm, please reach out immediately. These services are free, confidential and staffed by trained people who want to help. You don't need a reason that seems "serious enough."

Where you are	Who to contact	How
Immediate danger, anywhere	Local emergency services	Call your local emergency number (e.g. 911, 999, 112, 000)
United States	988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline	Call or text 988
Canada	9-8-8 Suicide Crisis Helpline	Call or text 988
United Kingdom and Ireland	Samaritans	Call 116 123 (free, any time)
Australia	Lifeline	Call 13 11 14
Other countries	Find A Helpline	Visit findahelpline.com to find a local service

DO THIS NOW

1. Save the crisis number for your country in your phone, even if you don't think you'll need it.
2. Write down the names and numbers of two people you could call on a bad day.
3. Tell one of them: "If I ever call and say I'm having a hard time, please take it seriously."

If you're worried about someone else, ask them directly and kindly how they're doing, listen without judging, and help them connect with one of these services. Asking someone if they're thinking about suicide does not put the idea in their head. It can open the door to help.

Small acts of self-respect

Finally, remember that coping isn't only about solving problems. It's also about treating yourself with basic care while you work through them. Give yourself credit for small things: you made the call, you went for the walk, you sent the message, you got through a hard day. Progress during a crisis is often quiet.

What has helped you get through hard times in the past? Which of those things could you use now?

Name three people you could lean on this month. What could you ask each of them for?

REMEMBER

- Job loss is a real loss of structure, identity, belonging and security. Strong feelings are normal and often come in waves.
- You are more than your job title. Your skills and character came with you.
- Shame shrinks when you share it with someone safe. Tell the people close to you.
- Calm anxiety with slow breathing, grounding, movement, writing it down and scheduled worry time.
- Daily anchors (waking time, daylight, movement, connection, a stopping time) protect your mental health.
- Sleep, movement and regular meals are powerful, not trivial.
- Get professional help if low mood or anxiety lasts two weeks or more, or if daily life becomes hard.
- In crisis: call local emergency services if in danger; 988 (US and Canada); Samaritans 116 123 (UK and Ireland); Lifeline 13 11 14 (Australia); finda-helpline.com elsewhere.

Your next step: Save your country's crisis number in your phone, then fill in Worksheet 4.1 to see honestly how you're doing this week.

PART II

Understand the New Landscape

Fear grows in the dark. Here we switch on the lights: which kinds of work AI is changing, which it is not, where demand is growing, and how to make AI a tool in your hands rather than a force acting on you.

5 · How AI Is Reshaping Work
6 · The Human Advantage: Skills That Compound
7 · Becoming AI-Fluent

CHAPTER 5

How AI Is Reshaping Work

A clear map of what is changing: which kinds of tasks AI handles well, which sectors are shrinking or growing, and a simple method to judge the AI exposure of any role before you put your time and money into it.

If you have lost a job to automation, or watched your team shrink while the software got smarter, you probably have one big question: where is it safe to go next? The honest answer is that no job is fully safe and very few are fully doomed. What changes is the mix of tasks inside each job, and how much of that mix a machine can now do.

This chapter gives you a way to see that mix clearly. You will not need to predict the future. You will learn to read the present well, which is far more useful when you have bills to pay and decisions to make this month.

We will look at work in four layers: tasks, jobs, sectors and forces. Then you will use two worksheets to judge any role you are thinking about, including the one you just left.

Jobs are bundles of tasks

In Chapter 1 we introduced the idea that AI replaces tasks, not whole jobs. It is worth going deeper, because this one idea changes how you plan your career.

Think of any job as a bundle. A customer support agent answers routine questions, calms angry people, spots patterns in complaints, handles odd cases nobody has seen before, and works with other teams to fix root problems. A bookkeeper enters transactions, reconciles accounts, chases missing receipts, explains numbers to a worried business owner, and notices when something looks wrong.

AI is very good at some parts of those bundles and weak at others. When a company automates the strong parts, one of three things tends to happen:

- **The job shrinks.** Fewer people are needed, because the remaining human tasks take less total time. This is what has happened to many support, data entry and junior content roles.
- **The job changes shape.** The same number of people do different work. They spend less time on drafts and more time on review, judgment and client contact.
- **The job grows.** Cheaper output leads to more demand. When something becomes faster and cheaper to make, people often want more of it, and someone still has to direct, check and deliver it.

Which of these happens depends less on the technology itself and more on the business, the customers, the rules and the cost of mistakes. That is why two people with the same job title can have very different experiences.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> Do not ask "Will AI take this job?" Ask "Which tasks in this job can AI do well, and what is left for a person to do?" The second question has a useful answer. The first one usually does not.

Exposure by task type

Researchers and companies use the word *exposure* to describe how much of a task current AI could perform or speed up. High exposure does not mean the task disappears tomorrow. It means it is a likely target, so the people who do it should expect pressure on pay, headcount or job design.

The table below is a practical guide, not a scientific ranking. It is based on what AI tools can broadly do as of late 2026. Use it to sort the tasks in your own work.

Task type	Exposure	Why
Data entry, copying information between systems, form filling	Very high	Rules are clear, input is digital, and mistakes are easy to catch automatically.

Task type	Exposure	Why
Answering routine, repeated questions (FAQs, order status, password help)	Very high	Chat assistants handle common questions at scale, around the clock, at low cost.
First drafts of standard text (product descriptions, basic reports, routine emails)	High	Language models write fluent drafts in seconds. The human role moves to editing and approval.
Translation of general, low-risk content	High	Machine translation is good for everyday material. Legal, medical, literary and sensitive work still needs skilled people.
Summarising documents, meetings and research	High	A core strength of current tools, though summaries can miss nuance or include errors.
Routine coding (boilerplate, simple fixes, tests)	High	Coding agents write and fix standard code quickly. Design, review and system understanding matter more.
Standard analysis (spreadsheets, dashboards, basic forecasts)	Medium to high	AI can run the numbers. Choosing the right question and explaining what it means is still human work.
Scheduling, coordination, inbox triage	Medium to high	AI agents are improving fast here, but real-world exceptions and politics slow them down.
Complex judgment with high stakes (diagnosis, legal strategy, credit decisions)	Medium	AI assists, but rules, liability and trust keep a qualified person responsible.
Building trust, persuading, negotiating, comforting	Low to medium	People want a human they can hold accountable and feel understood by.
Physical work in changing environments (repairs, care, construction, cooking)	Low	Robots are advancing, but messy real-world settings remain hard and expensive to automate.
Leading people, managing change, handling ambiguity	Low	These depend on relationships, context and responsibility that do not transfer to software.

Notice the pattern. Exposure is highest where work is **digital, repetitive, rule-based and low-stakes**. It is lowest where work is **physical, relational, high-stakes or unpredictable**. Most jobs sit somewhere in between, with a mix of both.

WATCH OUT

Low exposure is not the same as good pay or good conditions. Some low-exposure jobs, such as many care roles, are badly paid and physically tiring. High exposure is not the same as no future either. Judge a role on exposure *and* on pay, working conditions, demand and your own fit. We will combine these in Worksheet 5.2.

Automation versus augmentation

There are two broad ways a company can use AI. *Automation* means the machine does the task instead of a person. *Augmentation* means the machine helps a person do the task better or faster. The same tool can be used either way. What decides it is mostly the employer's choices and the nature of the work.

SIGNS OF AUTOMATION

- The goal is to cut cost per transaction.
- Output quality only needs to be "good enough".
- Errors are cheap and easy to fix later.
- Customers rarely see or care who did the work.
- The company talks about head-count reduction.

SIGNS OF AUGMENTATION

- The goal is better quality, speed or new services.
- Mistakes are costly, public or legally risky.
- Clients pay for expertise and a relationship.
- A licensed or accountable person must sign off.
- The company talks about "doing more with the same team".

In practice, many workplaces do both at once. They automate the simplest work and augment the rest. That is why entry-level and routine roles have often been hit first, while experienced staff are asked to use AI to take on more. It is

also why the ladder into many professions feels broken right now: the bottom rungs were made of tasks that are easy to automate.

If you are early in your career, this is not your fault, and it is not permanent. Chapter 13 shows how to build proof of skill when the usual entry jobs are scarce, and Chapter 21 has a section written for new graduates.

The same tool can replace a worker or make one more valuable. Your job is to find the places where it does the second.

Why change is slower and messier than headlines suggest

News stories often suggest that once AI *can* do something, it immediately *does* it everywhere. Real life is slower. Several forces act as brakes, and knowing them helps you judge how much time a role really has.

- **Cost and effort to switch.** Companies have old systems, contracts and processes. Changing them takes money, time and staff training.
- **Reliability.** AI tools still make confident mistakes. Where errors hurt people or cost money, businesses add human checks or go slowly.
- **Rules and liability.** Health, finance, law, transport and public services are regulated. In many places, including the European Union under its AI Act, high-risk uses face extra requirements.
- **Customer trust.** Many people still prefer a human for important matters, and some businesses compete by offering one.
- **Unions and agreements.** In some countries and industries, collective agreements shape how fast and how fairly automation happens.
- **Physical reality.** Software spreads quickly. Robots, buildings and supply chains do not.

None of this means you can relax. It means that “exposed” roles often change over years, not weeks, and that the details of a specific employer matter a great deal.

Sectors under pressure and sectors growing

Big picture first. The World Economic Forum's *Future of Jobs Report 2025* projected that between 2025 and 2030 roughly 170 million jobs would be created worldwide and about 92 million displaced, a net gain overall. That is a global average across many causes, not only AI. It does not help much if your own job is among the displaced ones, and it says nothing about whether the new jobs are near you or pay as well. But it is a reminder that work is moving, not simply vanishing.

The table below is qualitative and deliberately cautious. Patterns differ a lot by country, region, and even city. A growing field in one place may be saturated in another. Use this as a starting list of places to research, not as a forecast.

Area	General direction	What is driving it
Customer support and call centres	Under pressure	Chat and voice assistants handle routine contacts. Complex, sensitive and high-value cases still need people.
Routine office and back-office work (data entry, admin processing)	Under pressure	Document processing and AI agents reduce manual handling.
General content writing, basic translation, stock design	Under pressure	Cheap generated text and images. Specialist, brand-critical and regulated work holds up better.
Junior software and testing roles	Mixed, pressure at entry level	Coding agents speed up routine work. Demand for people who can design, review and secure systems continues.
Health and care (nursing, aged care, therapy, home support)	Growing	Ageing populations in many countries. Hands-on, trust-based work that is hard to automate.
Skilled trades (electrical, plumbing, HVAC, carpentry, welding)	Growing in many places	Retirements, housing needs and building upgrades. Shortages are widely reported in several countries.

Area	General direction	What is driving it
Energy transition (solar, heat pumps, grid, retrofits, EV infrastructure)	Growing	Public policy and investment, though it varies with government priorities.
Infrastructure and construction (roads, data centres, utilities)	Growing in many places	Public spending and the physical build-out that AI itself needs.
AI-adjacent roles (data quality, AI operations, evaluation, governance, training staff to use tools)	Growing	Every organisation adopting AI needs people to set it up, check it and manage risk.
Education and training	Mixed to growing	Strong need for teachers, trainers and coaches, especially for adults reskilling. Some content creation is automated.
Hospitality, experiences, events, tourism	Steady to growing	People pay for in-person experiences. Sensitive to economic cycles.
Sales, account management, relationship roles	Mixed	Prospecting and admin are automated. Trusted advisers who close complex deals remain valuable.

TIP

Check your own country's data. Many governments publish lists of shortage occupations or labour market outlooks. Examples include the US Bureau of Labor Statistics Occupational Outlook Handbook, the UK's shortage occupation and skills reports, Canada's Job Bank outlooks, Australia's Occupation Shortage List from Jobs and Skills Australia, and the EU's EURES labour shortage reports. Search "[your country] occupation outlook" or "[your country] skills shortage list".

A closer look at AI-adjacent work

When people hear "AI jobs", they imagine machine learning engineers with advanced degrees. Those roles exist, but they are a small slice. Much of the growing work around AI needs domain knowledge plus comfort with tools, not a computer science degree. Examples include:

- **AI operations and workflow roles:** setting up and maintaining AI tools inside a team, such as a support department or a finance office.
- **Quality and evaluation:** checking AI outputs for accuracy, bias and tone, often in a specific field like medicine, law or customer service.
- **Data preparation:** cleaning, labelling and organising the information that AI systems rely on.
- **Governance, risk and compliance:** making sure AI use follows laws, privacy rules and company policy.
- **Training and change management:** teaching staff how to use new tools well, and helping teams adjust.
- **Subject-matter experts:** people who know a field deeply and guide or review how AI is used in it.

If you spent years in a field that is now being automated, you may be unusually well placed for these roles. You know what good work looks like, where mistakes hide, and what customers actually need. Chapter 7 shows how to build and prove the AI fluency that makes this transition possible.

> A STORY
>
> *Marisol, 46, worked for eleven years in a bank's customer support team in Spain. When the bank introduced an AI assistant, her team was cut by more than half. She was upset, then curious. During her notice period she volunteered to review the assistant's answers and flag mistakes, because she knew exactly which questions confused customers. That work became a new role: she now helps maintain the assistant's knowledge base and trains staff on escalations. Her pay is similar. Her job looks nothing like it did. (This is an illustrative composite, not a real person.)*

How to assess any role's AI exposure

You can apply the ideas in this chapter to any job: the one you lost, the one you are applying for, or the one you are thinking of retraining for. The method takes about an hour per role. It is worth doing before you spend months or money on a new direction.

1. **Collect real job descriptions.** Find five to ten current job ads for the role in your area. Use recent ones, since descriptions are changing fast. Note what tasks and tools they mention.
2. **List the tasks.** Write down eight to twelve tasks people in this role actually do. Add tasks you know from experience or from talking to people who do the job. Ads often leave out the human parts.
3. **Estimate time share.** Next to each task, guess what share of a typical week it takes. Rough numbers are fine.
4. **Rate each task's exposure.** Use the table earlier in this chapter. High, medium or low. Ask: is it digital, repetitive, rule-based and low-stakes?
5. **Test it yourself.** For two or three of the high-exposure tasks, try doing them with a free AI assistant. How close does it get? This is a quick reality check and good practice for Chapter 7.
6. **Talk to someone in the role.** Ask one or two people how AI is changing their work. Chapter 12 has scripts for these conversations.
7. **Score the role.** Add up the share of time in high-exposure tasks. Then complete Worksheet 5.2 to weigh exposure against pay, demand and fit.

WORKSHEET 5.1 — TASK EXPOSURE BREAKDOWN FOR A ROLE

Task in this role	Share of week (%)	Exposure (High / Med / Low)	What a human still adds

Task in this role	Share of week (%)	Exposure (High / Med / Low)	What a human still adds
Total share in High-exposure tasks			

A rough guide for reading your total: if more than about half the week is in high-exposure tasks, expect the role to shrink or change a lot in the next few years. If it is under a quarter, the role is likely to be more stable, though it may still change. Between those, look closely at the employer and the sector.

WORKSHEET 5.2 — WEIGHING A ROLE: EXPOSURE, DEMAND AND FIT

Question	Score 1 (poor) to 5 (strong)	Evidence or notes
Low AI exposure (5 = mostly low-exposure tasks)		
Local demand (number of current openings near you or remote)		
Pay compared with your minimum needs (see Chapter 3)		
Working conditions (hours, physical demands, stability)		
Time and cost to qualify		
Fit with your existing skills (see Chapter 8)		
Fit with your energy, values and constraints		
Room to grow (a ladder above the entry level)		
Augmentation potential (can AI make you better at it?)		
Total (out of 45)		

DO THIS NOW

Pick the job you most recently held, even if it is gone. Fill in Worksheet 5.1 for it. Then circle the tasks you did that were *low* exposure. Those are often your most portable strengths, and they will feed directly into Chapter 6 and your skills inventory in Chapter 8.

Reading the signals in job ads and companies

You can learn a lot about how an employer uses AI before you ever speak to them. Look for these signals when you research roles:

ENCOURAGING SIGNALS

- The ad asks for people who can "use AI tools to improve" work, not just do the task.
- The role includes client contact, review, decisions or training others.
- The company describes growth, new services or expanding teams.
- There is a clear path from this role to more senior ones.
- Current staff talk about learning new tools, not fearing them.

CAUTION SIGNALS

- The role is described mainly by volume: tickets per hour, words per day.
- The company recently announced automation-driven layoffs in the same team.
- The job is a short contract to "train" or "clean up after" a system.
- Pay is falling for the same title in your area.
- The only tasks listed are ones in the high-exposure rows of the table above.

A caution signal does not mean "never take this job". A short contract can be a useful bridge while you build toward something steadier. Just go in with your eyes open, keep your search going, and keep building skills from the low-exposure side of the table.

> **TIP**
>
> In an interview, it is fair to ask: “How is the team using AI tools today, and how do you see this role changing over the next two years?” The answer tells you a lot, and asking shows that you think ahead. Chapter 14 covers more questions about AI in interviews.

Your own exposure, honestly

It can hurt to look at a table and see your old job in the “under pressure” rows. You may have been very good at it. You may have loved it. Being good at a task that machines now do cheaply is not a personal failure. It is a change in the price of that task, and it happened to you, not because of you.

The useful move now is to separate two things: the tasks that are losing value, and the knowledge, judgment and relationships you built while doing them. The first may be fading. The second usually is not. A translator knows culture and nuance. A support agent knows how customers think and where products fail. A junior developer knows how to break a problem into steps. These carry forward.

Looking at your last job, which tasks would you be relieved to hand to a machine, and which would you be sad to lose? What does that tell you about the work you want next?

Which growing area in this chapter surprised you, or seemed more possible for you than you expected? What is one small way you could learn more about it this week?

BEFORE YOU COMMIT TO A NEW DIRECTION

- [ ] I have read at least five current job ads for the role.
- [ ] I have completed Worksheet 5.1 and know roughly what share of the role is high-exposure.
- [ ] I have tried at least two of its tasks with an AI tool to see how well it performs.
- [ ] I have spoken to at least one person who does the job now.
- [ ] I have checked my country's official occupation outlook or shortage list.
- [ ] I have scored the role on Worksheet 5.2, including pay and working conditions.
- [ ] I know how long and how much it would cost to qualify.

REMEMBER

- Jobs are bundles of tasks. AI changes the bundle more often than it erases the job.
- Exposure is highest for digital, repetitive, rule-based, low-stakes tasks, and lowest for physical, relational, high-stakes and unpredictable ones.
- The same tool can automate or augment. Look for roles and employers that use it to make people more valuable.
- Change is real but uneven, and usually slower than headlines suggest. Country, sector and employer all matter.
- Growing areas include care, health, skilled trades, energy, infrastructure, education, experiences and AI-adjacent roles, but check your local data.
- Assess any role by its tasks, then weigh exposure against pay, demand, conditions and fit.

Your next step: Fill in Worksheet 5.1 for your last job, then pick one role you are curious about and find five current job ads for it.

CHAPTER 6

The Human Advantage: Skills That Compound

The skills that grow more valuable as AI spreads, how to recognise the ones you already have, and how to combine them into a skill stack that is hard to replace.

When a machine can write a decent email, summarise a report or draft code in seconds, it is natural to wonder what is left for you. Quite a lot, as it turns out. But the skills that matter most are often the ones nobody wrote on your job description, and the ones you may never have thought of as skills at all.

This chapter is about those skills. We will call them the *human advantage*: abilities that AI does not replace well and that often become more valuable when AI does the routine work around them. Many of them compound. The more you

use them, the stronger they get, and the more they connect with your other abilities.

You will finish this chapter with two things: a clear list of your own human-advantage skills, with evidence, and a first draft of your personal skill stack.

Why some skills compound

A skill compounds when each year of practice makes the next year of practice more valuable. Typing speed does not compound much. Judgment does. So do trust, relationships and deep knowledge of a field. They build on themselves, and they combine with each other in ways that are unique to you.

AI tends to make cheap the things that are easy to describe, check and repeat. As those things get cheaper, the scarce things around them become more valuable. If anyone can produce a first draft, the person who knows which draft is right, and can stand behind it, becomes more important. If anyone can generate a report, the person a client trusts to explain it becomes harder to replace.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> When AI makes some work cheap, the work around it often becomes more valuable: deciding what to do, checking that it is right, taking responsibility, and earning the trust of the people affected. Aim your learning at those surrounding skills.

Eight human advantages

Below are eight broad skill areas that hold up well in the age of AI. You do not need all of them. Most people have strengths in two or three. For each, you will see what it looks like in practice, why AI does not replace it easily, and how to strengthen it.

1. Judgment

Judgment is choosing well when the answer is not obvious. It means knowing which question to ask, which option fits this situation, and when the usual rule should not apply. A nurse who notices that a patient “just seems off”, a manager

who knows a deadline will slip before the spreadsheet shows it, and a tradesperson who spots that a quick fix will cause problems later are all using judgment.

AI can offer options and information. It cannot know your client, your community, or the unwritten history of a situation unless someone tells it. And it does not carry the consequences. **To strengthen it:** keep a simple decision journal. Write down important decisions, your reasoning and what you expected. Review them a few months later. You will learn more about your own judgment than any course can teach.

2. Trust

People hire, buy from and follow people they trust. Trust is built from reliability, honesty and care over time. It is one of the slowest assets to build and one of the most valuable. In a world flooded with generated content and fake profiles, a real person with a real track record stands out more, not less.

To strengthen it: do what you say, when you say. Tell people early when something is going wrong. Give credit freely. Keep small promises. These sound simple, and they are, but they add up to a reputation that follows you from job to job.

3. Accountability

Someone has to sign off. Someone has to be responsible when things go wrong. Organisations, regulators and customers want a named person who will answer for a decision. That is why AI often ends up assisting a professional rather than replacing them in high-stakes work.

To strengthen it: volunteer to own outcomes, not just tasks. Say “I will make sure this gets done” and then follow through. In interviews, tell stories where you took responsibility, including for mistakes you fixed.

4. Relationships

Relationships cover listening, empathy, persuasion, conflict resolution and the long-term network of people who know you. AI can draft a polite message. It cannot sit with an upset customer, read the room in a tense meeting, or be the person someone calls because they know you will help.

To strengthen it: practise curious listening. In conversations, ask one more question than feels natural, and summarise back what you heard. Keep in touch with people when you do not need anything. Chapter 12 turns this into a practical networking system.

5. Physical skill and presence

Fixing a boiler, lifting a patient safely, cooking for a crowd, installing solar panels, cutting hair, coaching a child to swim: these combine knowledge with hands, eyes and timing in changing environments. Robots are improving, but real-world physical work remains difficult and costly to automate, especially in homes and other unpredictable places.

To strengthen it: physical skills are learned by doing, usually with feedback from someone more experienced. Apprenticeships, short practical courses and supervised volunteering are often the fastest route. See Chapter 10 for how to find them.

6. Taste

Taste is the ability to tell good from merely acceptable. It is knowing which of ten generated logos actually fits the brand, which paragraph sounds like your organisation, which product feature customers will love. When AI can produce endless options, the person who can choose well becomes the bottleneck, and that person is worth paying.

To strengthen it: study excellent work in your field and ask why it works. Compare versions side by side. Explain your choices out loud. Taste grows through deliberate attention, not just exposure.

7. Teaching and explaining

Being able to make a complex thing simple, and to help another person actually learn it, is valuable everywhere. Organisations adopting AI need people to train staff. Clients need someone to explain what a result means. Communities need mentors. AI can supply information, but people often learn best from a person who understands their situation and believes in them.

To strengthen it: explain something you know to a friend, write a short guide, or volunteer to run a workshop. Watch where people get confused and adjust. Teaching also deepens your own understanding.

8. Managing ambiguity

Many real problems arrive messy. Goals are unclear, information is incomplete and people disagree. Someone has to make sense of it, choose a direction, and adjust as things change. AI works best with clear instructions. People who can create clarity out of confusion make AI more useful and are hard to replace.

To strengthen it: when you face a messy problem, practise writing a one-paragraph summary: what we know, what we do not know, what we will try first, and how we will know if it is working. That habit is the core of managing ambiguity.

If anyone can produce a first draft, the person who knows which draft is right becomes the one who matters.

WATCH OUT

"Soft skills" can sound vague on a CV. Writing "excellent communicator" or "strong judgment" proves nothing. Every human-advantage skill needs evidence: a story, a result, a number or a person who will vouch for you. The worksheet below helps you collect that evidence.

Find your human-advantage skills

You probably already use several of these skills, but you may not notice them because they feel normal to you. A useful clue: think about what people come to you for. What do colleagues ask you to look at, sort out or explain? What do friends call you about?

WORKSHEET 6.1 — YOUR HUMAN-ADVANTAGE INVENTORY

Skill area	Rate yourself 1–5	One real example (what happened, what you did)	Result or who could vouch
Judgment			
Trust			
Accountability			

Skill area	Rate yourself 1–5	One real example (what happened, what you did)	Result or who could vouch
Relationships			
Physical skill and presence			
Taste			
Teaching and explaining			
Managing ambiguity			

DO THIS NOW

Send a short message to two or three people who know your work well and ask them a simple question. Their answers often reveal strengths you overlook. Add what they say to Worksheet 6.1.

SCRIPT: ASKING PEOPLE WHAT YOU ARE GOOD AT

Hi [Name], I hope you are well. I am taking some time to think about my next career step, and I would value your honest view.

When you worked with me, what did you find yourself relying on me for? Is there a situation where you thought I handled something especially well?

Even one or two sentences would really help. Thank you, [Your name]

Think of a time at work, or outside it, when you felt fully capable and useful. What were you doing? Which of the eight skill areas were you using?

Combining domains: the T-shape and skill stacking

Single skills are easier to replace than combinations. A good writer competes with millions of writers and now with AI. A good writer who also understands pension regulations, speaks Portuguese and knows how small charities work competes with very few people. That is the logic of combining domains.

The T-shaped person

A T-shaped person has one area of real depth (the vertical bar of the T) and a broad base of working knowledge across related areas (the horizontal bar). The depth makes you credible. The breadth lets you work with others, see connections and adapt when your main area changes.

AI is very good at broad, shallow knowledge. That means breadth alone is less rare than it used to be. But depth combined with breadth, and with the human skills above, is still a strong position. Your depth is where your judgment and taste live. Your breadth is how you connect it to new problems.

Skill stacking

Skill stacking means putting together two, three or four skills that are each reasonably good, in a combination that is unusual and useful. You do not need to be the best in the world at any one of them. You need a combination that solves a real problem for real people.

A strong stack usually has three layers:

- **A domain:** a field you understand from the inside (healthcare, logistics, retail, local government, construction, hospitality).
- **A human advantage:** one or two of the eight skills above, such as teaching or relationships.
- **A tool or method layer:** AI fluency, data skills, a licence, project management, a language, a trade qualification.

Starting point	Stack	Where it could lead
Customer support agent	Product knowledge + calming upset people + AI tool setup	Support operations, AI assistant trainer, escalations lead, customer success

Starting point	Stack	Where it could lead
Translator	Two languages + cultural nuance + reviewing AI translation for quality	Localisation lead, legal or medical translation reviewer, community liaison
Junior developer	Coding basics + a specific industry + explaining technical ideas simply	Implementation specialist, technical trainer, solutions consultant
Retail manager	Running a team + stock and cash control + local relationships	Small business operations, franchise support, hospitality management
Office administrator	Organisation + knowing how offices work + AI workflow automation	Operations coordinator, freelance systems setup for small firms
Content writer	Clear writing + a regulated field (finance, health) + editorial judgment	Compliance content editor, subject-specialist writer, communications lead
Warehouse worker	Logistics knowledge + safety awareness + forklift or electrical certification	Shift supervisor, maintenance technician, safety officer
Teacher	Teaching + curriculum design + AI tools for learning	Corporate trainer, learning designer, adult reskilling coach
Graphic designer	Visual taste + brand strategy + directing AI image tools	Creative director for small brands, brand consultant
Carer or nursing assistant	Hands-on care + patience + a further health qualification	Nurse, care coordinator, home care business owner

Notice that most of these stacks reuse what the person already has. You rarely need to start from zero. Usually you need to add one layer, often a modest one, and then learn to describe the combination clearly.

A STORY

Kwame, 38, wrote marketing copy for an agency in Canada until AI tools cut the agency's writing team. He had spent four years writing for a client in agriculture equipment and had picked up a surprising amount about farming. He took a short course on writing for regulated industries, used AI tools daily to speed up drafts, and pitched himself to equipment dealers as someone who could produce clear safety and product guides. He now works part-time for one dealer and freelances for two others. His writing alone was not enough. Writing plus farm knowledge plus speed was. (This is an illustrative composite, not a real person.)

Build your first skill stack

Use the worksheet below to sketch two or three possible stacks. Do not worry about getting it perfect. You will refine this in Chapter 8, when you do a full skills inventory, and in Chapter 9, when you choose a path.

WORKSHEET 6.2 — SKILL STACK BUILDER

Layer	Stack option A	Stack option B	Stack option C
Domain I know from the inside			
Human advantage skill(s)			
Tool or method I have			
One layer I could add in 3–6 months			
Who would pay for this combination?			
What problem does it solve for them?			
One-sentence description of me			

TIP

A good one-sentence description follows this shape: "I help [type of person or organisation] with [problem] using [your combination]." For example: "I help small clinics set up and check AI scheduling tools, using ten years of front-desk experience." If you can say it clearly, others can repeat it and refer you.

Practising the human advantages every week

These skills grow through use. You do not need a job to practise them. Here is a simple weekly rhythm you can follow during your search, alongside the structure from Chapter 2.

1. **One judgment rep.** Write down one decision you made this week, why, and what you expect to happen. Review old entries monthly.
2. **One relationship rep.** Have one real conversation where you mostly listen. Follow up with something useful for the other person.
3. **One teaching rep.** Explain something you know, in person, in a short post or in a written guide. Notice what was hard to explain.
4. **One taste rep.** Compare two pieces of work in your field, or two AI outputs, and write down which is better and why.
5. **One ambiguity rep.** Take a messy problem, yours or a friend's, and write the four-line summary: what we know, what we do not know, first step, how we will know.

These take only an hour or two in total, and they give you fresh stories for interviews. Instead of saying "I have good judgment", you can say, "Last month I helped a local food bank decide how to reorganise volunteers. Here is what I recommended and what happened." That is much stronger.

Showing your human advantage to employers

Employers are hungry for these skills but often struggle to see them on paper. Make them visible by turning each skill into a short, specific story. Chapter 14 covers the STAR method in detail. For now, aim for this pattern: the situation, what you did, and what changed.

WEAK

- "Strong communication skills."
- "Reliable team player."
- "Good at solving problems."
- "Experienced with customers."

STRONG

- "Trained 14 new staff on our returns process, cutting their ramp-up time from three weeks to two."
- "Covered three roles during a staff shortage, keeping every client deadline for six months."
- "Spotted a billing error pattern that had been missed for a year and fixed the root cause."
- "Kept our largest account through a service failure by calling them personally each day until it was fixed."

YOUR HUMAN ADVANTAGE, READY TO USE

- [ ] I have rated myself on all eight skill areas in Worksheet 6.1.
- [ ] I have at least one real example for my top three skills.
- [ ] I have asked two or three people what they rely on me for.
- [ ] I have sketched at least two skill stacks in Worksheet 6.2.
- [ ] I have written a one-sentence description of my strongest stack.
- [ ] I have chosen one layer I could add in the next three to six months.
- [ ] I have started the weekly practice routine.

Which stack in Worksheet 6.2 gives you the most energy when you imagine doing it every week? What is the smallest test you could run to see if anyone would pay for it?

REMEMBER

- As AI makes routine work cheap, the work around it, such as deciding, checking, owning and connecting, becomes more valuable.
- Eight human advantages hold up well: judgment, trust, accountability, relationships, physical skill, taste, teaching and managing ambiguity.
- These skills compound with practice and you can build them without a job.
- Combinations are harder to replace than single skills. Aim for a stack of domain, human advantage and tool layer.
- You rarely start from zero. Usually you add one layer and describe the combination clearly.
- Every soft skill needs hard evidence: a story, a result or a person who will vouch for you.

Your next step: Send the "what are you relying on me for" message to two people today, and fill in your top three rows of Worksheet 6.1.

CHAPTER 7

Becoming AI-Fluent

A practical 30-day plan to go from uncertain to confident with AI tools: how to ask for what you need, how to check what you get, how to protect your privacy, and how to show employers you can use AI well.

It can feel strange, even painful, to learn the very tools that may have cost you your job. You might feel angry at them, or worried you are too late. Both reactions are understandable. But AI fluency has quickly become a basic workplace skill, a bit like using email or a spreadsheet once did. Learning it puts some power back in your hands.

The good news is that being AI-fluent does not mean becoming a programmer or an engineer. It means knowing what these tools are good and bad at, asking them clearly, checking their work, and using them safely. Most people can get there in about a month of short daily practice.

This chapter gives you that month, step by step, along with ready-to-use prompts for your job search, your learning and any small business you might start.

What AI fluency actually means

AI fluency is not about knowing every tool. Tools change too fast for that. It is a set of habits that work across tools:

- **Knowing when to use AI** and when not to.
- **Asking well:** giving clear context, a clear task and a clear format.
- **Working in rounds:** refining the output through follow-up requests instead of accepting the first answer.
- **Checking:** verifying facts, numbers and claims before you rely on them.
- **Protecting privacy:** knowing what you must never paste into a tool.
- **Owning the result:** treating AI output as a draft that you are responsible for.

> KEY IDEA
>
> Treat an AI assistant like a fast, well-read helper who has never met you, knows nothing about your situation, and sometimes makes things up with total confidence. Give it context, check its work, and keep the final say.

Choosing your tools

You only need one general-purpose AI assistant to start. Well-established options include ChatGPT, Claude, Google's Gemini and Microsoft Copilot. All of them offer free tiers that are good enough for everything in this chapter. Paid plans add more usage, newer models and extra features, but you do not need them to become fluent.

Tools, features, names and prices change very fast, often every few months. Do not worry about picking the "best" one. Pick one, learn the habits, and you will find it easy to switch later. Many people end up using two: one main assistant and one for a second opinion.

You may also meet AI built into tools you already use, such as email, word processors, spreadsheets, design apps and search engines. The same habits apply.

> **TIP**
>
> If you do not have a computer at home, most assistants have phone apps. Public libraries in many countries also offer free computers and, increasingly, free help sessions for learning digital and AI skills. Ask at your local library or job centre.

Prompting basics

A prompt is simply what you type to the AI. Better prompts get much better results. You do not need special tricks. You need the same things a capable human helper would need.

The four parts of a good prompt

1. **Context.** Who you are, what situation you are in, who the result is for. "I am a former warehouse supervisor applying for operations roles in Manchester."
2. **Task.** Exactly what you want. "Suggest five ways to describe my experience leading a team of 12 on night shifts."
3. **Format.** How you want it. "As bullet points, each under 25 words, starting with an action verb."
4. **Constraints.** What to avoid or include. "Do not invent numbers. Use plain British English. Ask me questions if something is missing."

Work in rounds

The first answer is rarely the best. Treat it as a starting point. Useful follow-ups include:

- "Make it shorter and less formal."
- "That is too generic. Here is more detail about me: [details]. Try again."
- "Give me three different versions so I can compare."
- "What questions would you need answered to do this better?"

- “What are the weaknesses in what you just wrote?”

WEAK PROMPT

- “Write my CV.”
- “Tell me about nursing.”
- “Make a business plan.”

STRONGER PROMPT

- “Here is my current CV and a job ad. Suggest which three bullet points to rewrite to match the ad, without inventing anything.”
- “I am 44, worked in retail for 20 years, and live in Ontario. Explain the main routes into nursing, how long each takes, and what I should check locally.”
- “I want to start a weekend dog-walking service in my town. List the ten questions I should answer before I spend any money.”

WATCH OUT

AI tools can produce text that sounds certain but is wrong. This is often called a “hallucination”. They can invent facts, statistics, quotes, laws, course names, company details and even sources that do not exist. Never submit or publish AI output that you have not checked. You are responsible for anything you send.

How to check AI output

Checking is the single most important part of AI fluency, and the part employers care about most. Anyone can get an AI to produce something. The valuable person is the one who can tell whether it is right.

THE OUTPUT CHECK

- [ ] **Facts:** Can I confirm each key fact from a reliable source, such as an official website, the original document or a trusted publication?
- [ ] **Numbers:** Do the figures add up? Did it invent any statistics? Can I find where each number came from?
- [ ] **Sources:** If it cites a source, does that source actually exist and say what is claimed?
- [ ] **Dates:** Is the information current? Tools can be out of date about recent events, prices and rules.
- [ ] **Local fit:** Does this apply in my country, state or province? Rules on benefits, tax, licences and employment vary a lot.
- [ ] **Truth about me:** Has it added skills, achievements or experience I do not have?
- [ ] **Tone:** Does it sound like me, or like a generic machine? Would a real person say this?
- [ ] **Harm:** Could this mislead, offend or hurt anyone if it were wrong?

Some quick verification techniques:

- **Ask for sources, then check them yourself.** Click the links or search for the titles.
- **Ask a second tool** the same question and compare answers. Disagreements point to areas you need to check.
- **Ask the AI to critique itself:** "List anything in your answer that might be wrong or uncertain."
- **Go to the primary source** for anything important: the government website for benefits, the regulator for licences, the employer's own site for company details.
- **For legal, financial or medical matters,** use AI to prepare questions, then confirm with a qualified professional or an official service.

Privacy and ethics: the rules to live by

When you type something into an AI tool, it is usually sent to the company that runs it. Depending on the tool and your settings, it may be stored, reviewed or used to improve the service. Read the privacy settings of the tool you choose, and switch off any options to use your data for training if you prefer. Even then, follow these rules.

NEVER PASTE

- Confidential employer or client information: internal documents, customer lists, financial results, code, contracts, strategy.
- Personal ID numbers: social security, national insurance, tax file, passport or driver's licence numbers.
- Bank, card or account numbers, passwords, PINs or security codes.
- Medical records or health details about other people.
- Other people's personal details without their permission.

SAFE HABITS

- Replace names with roles: "my former manager", "Client A".
- Remove addresses, phone numbers and account details from CVs or letters before pasting.
- Describe a situation in general terms instead of pasting the real document.
- Follow your employer's AI policy at any job. If there is none, ask before using AI on work material.
- Use only the tools your employer has approved for work data.

Ethical use

- **Be honest about what is yours.** AI can help you write and think, but do not claim skills, experience or work you do not have.
- **Follow the rules of the situation.** Some tests, assessments and applications forbid AI help. Respect that. Being caught breaking such rules can end your candidacy.
- **Do not use AI to deceive.** No fake reviews, fake references or impersonating real people.
- **Respect creators.** Be careful about using AI to copy someone else's style, brand or work for commercial purposes.

- **Keep humans in the loop** for decisions that affect other people.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Scammers use AI too. Expect very polished fake job offers, fake recruiter messages and convincing voice or video imitations. Be wary of anyone who asks for money, ID documents or banking details early in a hiring process. Chapter 14 covers recruitment scams in detail, and Chapter 3 covers "get rich with AI" schemes.

Your 30-day AI fluency plan

This plan takes 20 to 40 minutes a day. It is built around your real life, so every practice session also moves your job search or your plans forward. If you miss a day, simply pick up where you left off. Five days a week is fine.

Days	Focus	What to do
Week 1 — Get comfortable		
1	Set up	Choose one assistant and create a free account. Check its privacy settings. Ask it: "Explain what you are good and bad at, in plain language."
2	Everyday questions	Use it for three ordinary tasks: plan a cheap week of meals, explain a confusing letter (with personal details removed), draft a polite reply to a message.
3	The four-part prompt	Write the same request twice: once vaguely, once with context, task, format and constraints. Compare the results.
4	Working in rounds	Take one output and improve it with at least five follow-up prompts. Notice how much better it gets.
5	Catch a mistake	Ask about something you know very well (your old job, your town, a hobby). Find at least one error or weak point.
6–7	Rest and reflect	Write down three things AI did well and three it did badly for you this week.
Week 2 — Use it for your job search		

Days	Focus	What to do
8	Understand a role	Use the role research prompt below for one job you are considering. Check its claims against real job ads.
9	CV bullet points	Rewrite three CV bullets with the CV prompt. Check every word is true.
10	Match a job ad	Compare your CV with one real job ad. Ask which skills are missing or under-described.
11	Cover letter draft	Draft one cover letter, then rewrite at least a third of it in your own words.
12	Interview practice	Run a mock interview with the AI for 15 minutes. Ask for feedback on your answers.
13–14	Rest and reflect	Update your job tracker (see Chapter 11). Note which prompts saved you the most time.
Week 3 — Use it to learn		
15	Learning plan	Ask for a four-week learning plan on a skill from your Worksheet 6.2 stack, using free resources. Check the resources exist.
16	Explain it simply	Have it explain a difficult concept at three levels: to a child, to a beginner, to a professional.
17	Quiz yourself	Ask it to quiz you on what you learned, one question at a time, and to correct you.
18	Summarise and verify	Summarise a long public article or report. Then read the original and check what the summary missed.
19	Second opinion	Ask a second assistant the same learning question. Compare the two answers.
20–21	Rest and reflect	Write a short note on what you learned and how you checked it.
Week 4 — Build something you can show		
22	Pick a project	Choose a small, real problem: a volunteer group's schedule, a friend's shop menu, a guide for your old team's common questions.

Days	Focus	What to do
23	Data and spreadsheets	Use AI to help build or clean a simple spreadsheet, budget or tracker. Check every formula.
24	Write and design	Create a one-page guide, flyer or checklist for your project with AI help.
25	Try another kind of tool	Experiment with one other AI feature: image generation, voice, or AI built into your email or documents.
26	Small automation	Ask the AI to help you set up a simple time-saver, such as an email template, a checklist or a repeating workflow.
27	Document it	Write a short case study: the problem, how you used AI, how you checked it, the result. (See Chapter 13.)
28	Update your CV	Add your AI fluency using the examples later in this chapter.
29	Practise the story	Rehearse a 60-second answer to “How do you use AI in your work?”
30	Review	Complete Worksheet 7.1. Choose which habits to keep using daily.

DO THIS NOW

Put Day 1 in your calendar for tomorrow, at the same time you do your other job search work. Set a timer for 30 minutes. That is all you need to start.

Prompts you can use today

Copy these and fill in the brackets. Remove any personal details you would not want stored. Always check the output.

For your job search

PROMPT: RESEARCH A ROLE

I am considering a career move into [role] in [city/country]. My background is [short summary, e.g. 8 years in retail management].

Please explain: what people in this role do day to day, which tasks are most likely to be affected by AI, what qualifications are usually needed in [country], and three questions I should ask someone who does this job. Mark anything you are unsure about, and remind me what I should verify locally.

PROMPT: IMPROVE CV BULLET POINTS

Here are three bullet points from my CV: [paste bullets, with names of employers and clients removed if confidential].

Rewrite each one to start with a strong action verb and show a result. Use only the facts I have given. If a result or number would help but I have not provided one, ask me for it instead of inventing it. Keep each bullet under 25 words.

PROMPT: COMPARE YOUR CV TO A JOB AD

Here is a job ad: [paste ad]. Here is my CV with personal contact details removed: [paste CV].

List the five most important requirements in the ad. For each, tell me whether my CV shows clear evidence, weak evidence or none. Suggest how I could show it better, using only experience that is genuinely mine.

PROMPT: MOCK INTERVIEW

Act as an interviewer for a [role] position at a [type of organisation]. Ask me one question at a time, mixing standard, behavioural and AI-related questions. Wait for my answer each time.

After each answer, give me brief feedback: what was strong, what was missing, and how to make it more specific. After six questions, give an overall summary.

For learning

PROMPT: BUILD A LEARNING PLAN

I want to learn [skill] to a level where I could [specific goal, e.g. apply for junior bookkeeping roles]. I have [hours] hours a week and a budget of [amount, or "nothing"].

Create a four-week plan with weekly goals, practice tasks and free or low-cost resources. For each resource, name the provider so I can check it exists. Include a way to test myself at the end of each week.

PROMPT: TUTOR ME

Teach me [topic] step by step. Start by asking me two questions to find out what I already know. Then explain one idea at a time, with an everyday example, and check my understanding with a short question before moving on. If I get something wrong, explain it a different way.

For a small business or freelance idea

PROMPT: TEST A BUSINESS IDEA

I am thinking of starting [business idea] in [town/region]. My relevant experience is [summary]. My budget to start is about [amount].

Help me think critically. List the main risks, the questions I need to answer before spending money, who my likely customers are, and three cheap ways to test demand in the next two weeks. Be honest if the idea has serious weaknesses.

PROMPT: DRAFT CUSTOMER MESSAGES

I run a small [type of business]. Write a friendly, short message to [customers / a local shop owner / past clients] explaining [offer or update]. Tone: warm, plain, no hype. Give me two versions: one for email and one for a text message under 300 characters.

TIP

Keep a "prompt notebook": a simple document where you save prompts that worked well. Over a month, you will build a personal toolkit that saves you hours each week and shows employers exactly how you work.

A STORY

Ingrid, 57, was a records administrator for a local council in Norway until her department was restructured. She had barely used AI and felt sure she was too old to start. She followed a month-long plan like this one, mostly on her phone. In week four she used an AI assistant to help her volunteer choir build a simple rehearsal schedule and membership spreadsheet, and she wrote a one-page summary of how she did it and how she checked it. In her next interview, for an office coordinator role, that one page started the best conversation of the day. (This is an illustrative composite, not a real person.)

Showing AI fluency to employers

Many job ads now ask for "familiarity with AI tools" or "experience using generative AI". Many more expect it without saying so. Employers are not usually looking for technical depth. They want evidence that you can use AI to work faster *and* that you have the judgment to check it and use it safely.

On your CV

Avoid empty lines like "Proficient in AI". Instead, show a task, a tool type, a result and a sign of judgment. Name tools if the ad does, but focus on what you did with them.

WEAK

- "Skilled in ChatGPT."
- "AI enthusiast."
- "Familiar with generative AI."

STRONG

- "Used AI assistants to draft weekly client reports, cutting preparation time by about half while fact-checking every figure before sending."
- "Built a volunteer scheduling spreadsheet for a 40-member community group with AI help; reduced missed shifts."
- "Created a 20-question support FAQ using AI drafting and my own product knowledge; reviewed all answers for accuracy."

Add a short line to your skills section too, for software screening systems (see Chapter 11). For example: "AI tools: general assistants (e.g. ChatGPT, Claude, Copilot) for drafting, research and analysis; output verification; data privacy practices."

In interviews

Expect questions like "How do you use AI in your work?" or "What are the risks of using AI for this job?" A strong answer shows three things: you use it for real tasks, you check it, and you know its limits.

SCRIPT: ANSWERING "HOW DO YOU USE AI IN YOUR WORK?"

"I use AI assistants mostly for [two or three tasks, e.g. first drafts, summarising long documents and planning]. For example, recently I [specific example and result].

I always treat the output as a draft. I check facts and numbers against the original sources, and I make sure the tone fits the audience. I am also careful about privacy: I never put confidential or personal information into a tool unless it is one the organisation has approved for that.

I find it saves me time on the routine parts, which lets me spend more time on [the human part of the job, e.g. talking to customers or solving the unusual problems]."

SCRIPT: ANSWERING "WHAT ARE THE RISKS OF AI IN THIS ROLE?"

"The main risks I would watch for are confident mistakes, out-of-date information, and privacy. In a role like this, a wrong figure or a leaked customer detail could cause real harm.

So I would want to know the team's policy on which tools are approved, and I would build checking into the workflow rather than leaving it to the end. I see AI as a way to speed up the routine parts, with a person still responsible for the result."

WORKSHEET 7.1 — YOUR AI FLUENCY REVIEW AFTER 30 DAYS

Question	Your answer
Which tool(s) did I use most?	
Three tasks where AI saved me real time	
Three tasks where AI was unhelpful or wrong	
One mistake I caught, and how I caught it	
My best prompt (saved in my prompt notebook)	
The project I can show an employer	
My new CV line about AI fluency	

Question	Your answer
My 60-second interview answer, in brief	
My personal privacy rules	
One AI skill I want to learn next	

How did your feelings about AI change over the month? Where do you now feel more in control, and where do you still feel uneasy?

Anyone can get an AI to produce something. The valuable person is the one who can tell whether it is right.

REMEMBER

- AI fluency is a set of habits, not technical expertise: ask clearly, work in rounds, check everything, protect privacy and own the result.
- Start with one well-established assistant on a free tier. Tools change fast, but the habits transfer.
- Good prompts include context, task, format and constraints.
- Checking output is the most valuable part of the skill. Verify facts, numbers, sources and local rules.
- Never paste confidential employer data, personal ID numbers, financial details or other people's private information.
- Show employers specific tasks, results and your checking process, not vague claims.

Your next step: Choose one assistant, check its privacy settings, and complete Day 1 of the 30-day plan today.

PART III

Find Your Direction

You have more to work with than you think. Take stock of your skills, energy and values, compare realistic paths, and learn new things quickly and cheaply — testing before you bet big.

8 · Your Skills Inventory
9 · Choosing Your Path
10 · Reskilling Smart

CHAPTER 8

Your Skills Inventory

Before you choose a direction, you need an honest map of what you bring. This chapter walks you through five short audits (skills, achievements, energy, values and constraints) that turn a vague sense of "I don't know what I'm good at anymore" into a clear, usable picture.

When a job ends, especially when it ends because software can now do part of it, it is easy to feel that your skills have been wiped out along with the role. That feeling is understandable. It is also almost always wrong. A job title is a label on a bundle of tasks, and most of the tasks in your bundle were never about the part a machine took over.

This chapter is about unbundling. You will take apart your working life, piece by piece, and look at what is actually there. Some of it you will want to keep. Some of it you will gladly leave behind. Some of it you have probably never named before, because it felt too ordinary to count.

Set aside two or three sessions of about an hour each. You do not need to finish in one sitting, and you should not try to. Memory works better in short bursts, and new examples will surface between sessions. Keep a notebook or a document open for the whole week so you can catch them.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> You are not looking for one "passion" or one perfect job. You are gathering raw material. The next chapter (Choosing Your Path) uses everything you collect here to compare real options side by side. The more honest and specific you are now, the better those choices will be.

Why an inventory matters more in the age of AI

In Chapter 5 you saw that AI changes work task by task, not job by job. In Chapter 6 you saw which human abilities tend to grow in value: judgment, trust, relationships, physical skill, taste and handling messy situations. An inventory is where those big ideas become personal. It answers a practical question: which of your tasks were routine and easy to automate, and which were the hard, human parts that people relied on you for?

There is a second reason. Hiring is crowded right now, and many applications are screened by software before a person reads them. Vague claims like "strong communicator" or "team player" do not survive that process. Specific evidence does. The achievements bank you build in this chapter becomes the raw material for your CV, your interview stories and your networking conversations later in the book (see Chapters 11 to 14).

Third, an inventory protects you from making a big decision for the wrong reasons. People in shock often grab the first path that looks safe, or the one a friend took, or the one an advert promises. Knowing your energy, values and limits makes it much harder for anyone to sell you a direction that does not fit.

Step 1: Break your jobs into tasks

Start with what you actually did, not what your job description said. Pick your most recent role, or the role you are most likely to build on. Then list every task you did in a typical week, a typical month and a typical year. Include the small,

invisible things: calming an upset customer, fixing the shared spreadsheet nobody else understood, training the new person, noticing a mistake before it went out.

Next to each task, make a quick judgment. Was this mostly routine and repeatable (the same steps each time)? Or did it need judgment, relationships, physical presence or creativity? You are not grading yourself. You are sorting the work so you can see where the durable value sits.

WORKSHEET 8.1 — TASK BREAKDOWN OF YOUR LAST ROLE

Task I did	How often (daily / weekly / monthly)	Routine or judgment-heavy?	Could AI do most of it today? (Y / Partly / N)

When you finish, circle the tasks marked “judgment-heavy” and “N” or “Partly”. Those are usually the core of your transferable value. If almost everything you did was routine, that is useful information too. It tells you where to invest in new skills (Chapter 10), and it does not mean you lack ability. It often means your employer never gave you room to use it.

TIP

If your memory is foggy, look at old calendars, sent emails, project folders, performance reviews and messages to colleagues. Your calendar from a single busy month can remind you of a dozen tasks you had forgotten. If you no longer have access to work systems, ask a former colleague: "What did people come to me for?"

Step 2: The transferable skills audit

Tasks are specific to a job. Skills travel. A transferable skill is something you can do in one setting that is valuable in a different one. Running a busy reception desk, for example, builds triage, calm under pressure, scheduling and handling difficult people. Those skills matter in healthcare administration, event management, property management, customer success and dozens of other fields.

Use the categories below as prompts. For each category, write down the specific skills you have used, rate your confidence from 1 (beginner) to 5 (people come to you for this), and note one piece of evidence. Evidence can be a task, a result, a compliment, a qualification or simply something you have done many times.

Category	Example skills to jog your memory
People and relationships	Building trust, calming conflict, coaching, caring for others, customer service, reading a room
Communication	Explaining complex things simply, writing clearly, presenting, listening, negotiating, persuading
Organising and operations	Planning, scheduling, running processes, keeping records, managing stock, coordinating many moving parts
Numbers and analysis	Budgeting, spotting patterns, using spreadsheets, checking accuracy, forecasting, research
Technical and tools	Software you know well, machinery, systems, AI tools, troubleshooting, setting things up for others
Physical and hands-on	Repairing, building, driving, cooking, operating equipment, fine motor work, stamina

Category	Example skills to jog your memory
Creative	Designing, writing, visual taste, coming up with ideas, improving how things look or feel
Leadership and judgment	Making decisions with incomplete information, taking responsibility, prioritising, leading a team
Domain knowledge	What you know about an industry, its rules, customers, jargon and problems

WORKSHEET 8.2 — TRANSFERABLE SKILLS AUDIT

Category	My specific skills	Confidence (1–5)	One piece of evidence
People and relationships			
Communication			
Organising and operations			
Numbers and analysis			
Technical and tools			
Physical and hands-on			
Creative			
Leadership and judgment			
Domain knowledge			
Skills from outside paid work			

Do not skip the skills from outside paid work

Many people leave out some of their strongest abilities because they were not paid for them. Caring for a sick parent teaches you to coordinate doctors, manage medication schedules, handle paperwork and stay steady in a crisis. Running a youth sports team teaches scheduling, conflict resolution and moti-

vating people. Managing a household budget on a tight income is real financial skill. Organising a community event, moderating an online group, fixing cars on weekends and teaching yourself a language all count.

Employers will not always value these as highly as paid experience, and that is unfair. But naming them helps you in two ways. It shows you patterns in what you are drawn to, and it gives you true, concrete examples to use when you have little paid experience in a new field.

Spot your "domain plus" combinations

Look across your audit for combinations. Chapter 6 described the power of skill stacking: someone who knows logistics and can also use data tools, or a former nurse who understands software, or a retail manager who speaks two languages. One skill alone may be common. Two or three together, in a specific domain, can be rare and valuable. Write down your two or three strongest combinations at the bottom of the worksheet.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Two common traps: underrating yourself ("anyone could do that") and rating yourself by your worst day. If colleagues regularly asked you for help with something, give it at least a 4. If you did something every week for years without disasters, it is a real skill, even if it felt easy to you. Things that feel easy to you are often your biggest strengths.

Step 3: Build an achievements bank

Skills tell people what you can do. Achievements prove it. An achievements bank is a running list of specific things you did and what happened as a result. It is the single most useful document you can create in a job search, because you will draw on it again and again: for CV bullet points, cover letters, interview answers, networking messages and pricing conversations if you freelance.

Use a simple three-part format called Situation, Action, Result (SAR):

1. **Situation.** The problem, challenge or context in one or two sentences. What was going on, and why did it matter?

2 **Action.** What you personally did. Use "I", not "we". Be specific about the steps, tools and decisions.

3 **Result.** What changed because of you. Use numbers where you can: time saved, money saved or earned, errors reduced, customers kept, people trained. If you have no numbers, describe the outcome and who benefited.

A worked example

Situation: Our team's monthly supplier invoices were often paid late, which led to late fees and strained relationships with two key suppliers.
Action: I mapped the approval process, found that invoices sat waiting for a manager who travelled often, and proposed a backup approver plus a shared tracker with reminders. I trained three colleagues to use it.
Result: Within two months, late payments dropped from about one in five invoices to almost none, and we stopped paying late fees. One supplier later offered us better terms.

Notice what this example shows: problem-solving, process design, persuasion and training. None of those skills depended on the specific software or job title. That is why achievements travel so well into new fields.

Memory joggers

If you are stuck, work through these questions. Each one tends to unlock a story.

- When did you fix something that was broken, slow or confusing?
- When did you save money, time or a relationship?
- When did a customer, patient, student or colleague thank you, and why?
- When did you step in during a crisis or when someone was absent?
- What did you teach someone, and what could they do afterwards?
- What are you proud of that nobody noticed?
- When did you learn something new quickly because you had to?
- When did you disagree with a plan and turn out to be right, or handle being wrong well?

WORKSHEET 8.3 — ACHIEVEMENTS BANK (AIM FOR 10 TO 15 ENTRIES OVER TIME)

Situation	Action (what I did)	Result (with numbers if possible)	Skills it shows

TIP

An AI assistant can be a good interviewer here (see Chapter 7). Try asking it: "Interview me about my last job, one question at a time, to help me find specific achievements. Push me for numbers and for what I personally did." Then write the final SAR entries yourself, check every claim is true, and leave out confidential details such as client names, internal figures or anything covered by an agreement with your former employer.

KEY IDEA

Estimates are fine if they are honest. "Reduced processing time from roughly two days to half a day" is better than nothing. If you are not sure of a number, say "about" or describe the scale. Never invent figures. If an interviewer asks how you measured it, you should be able to explain.

Step 4: The energy audit

Here is a truth that career advice often skips: being good at something is not the same as wanting to do it all day. Many people are skilled at tasks that slowly drain them. If you build your next chapter around those tasks, you may end up

competent and miserable, which tends to show up as burnout a year or two later.

An energy audit looks at how activities make you feel, not just how well you do them. Think back over the last year or two of work and life. Which activities left you tired but satisfied, or even buzzing? Which left you flat, anxious or dreading the next day? Both kinds of tiredness are real, but they are different.

WORKSHEET 8.4 — ENERGY AUDIT

Activity or type of task	Energises (+) or drains (−)?	How good am I at it? (1–5)	Why I think it affects me this way

Reading your energy audit

Sort your answers into four groups. This is one of the most useful views in the whole inventory.

GOOD AT IT AND IT ENERGISES ME

- Your sweet spot. Build your next role around as much of this as possible.
- These are often the tasks people praise you for without you noticing.

NOT GOOD YET, BUT IT ENERGISES ME

- Growth areas. Worth investing learning time here (Chapter 10).
- Energy makes practice easier, so progress is often faster than you expect.

GOOD AT IT, BUT IT DRAINS ME

- Useful to keep in your back pocket, especially for short-term income.
- Try not to make it the centre of your long-term plan.

NOT GOOD AT IT AND IT DRAINS ME

- Avoid, delegate, or use tools (including AI) to handle it.
- Be wary of paths where this is a large share of the work.

Look for patterns underneath the activities. Maybe every energising task involves helping one person at a time, or solving a puzzle, or working with your hands, or seeing a finished result. Maybe every draining task involves constant interruptions, unclear goals or conflict without resolution. Those patterns matter more than any single task because they will show up in any job you take.

Think of a day at work (or outside it) when time flew and you went home feeling good. What were you doing, who were you with, and what made it work?

WATCH OUT

Right after a job loss, almost everything can feel draining. That is the shock talking, not a permanent fact about you (see Chapter 4). If your energy audit comes out flat, think back to a period when you felt more like yourself, even if it was years ago, and audit that time instead.

Step 5: Rank your values

Values are what you need from work for it to feel worth it. They are the reason two people can take the same job and one thrives while the other quits within months. When your work clashes with a core value, no amount of skill makes up for it.

Below is a list of common work values. Read through it quickly and mark every value that feels important. Then narrow it down to your top seven, and finally rank those seven in order. Ranking is uncomfortable, and that is the point: real choices involve trade-offs, and you need to know which values win when they collide.

Common work values	(continued)	(continued)
Financial security	High income	Stability and predictability
Flexibility of hours	Working from home	Working with people in person
Helping others directly	Making a difference at scale	Independence and autonomy
Creativity	Learning and growth	Mastery and craft
Recognition and status	Leadership and influence	Belonging to a team
Variety	Physical activity	Calm, low-stress environment
Challenge and excitement	Ethics and integrity of the employer	Time for family and life outside work
Being close to home or community	Fairness and respect	Building something of my own

WORKSHEET 8.5 — MY TOP VALUES, RANKED

Rank	Value	What it looks like in practice for me	A past job that met or clashed with it
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			

The third column is important. "Flexibility" means different things to different people. For one person it means picking up a child at 3 p.m. every day. For another it means taking three months off each year. The more concretely you describe each value, the easier it is to test whether a path actually delivers it.

Values can also shift with your circumstances. Right now, financial security might rightly sit at the top, even if creativity or independence usually matter more to you. That is not selling out. It is sequencing. You can note "for now" next to a value and plan to revisit your ranking once your runway is stronger (see Chapter 3).

A job that pays well but clashes with your top value is not a safe choice. It is a delayed problem.

Step 6: Name your constraints honestly

Constraints are the real-world limits on what you can do in the next year or two. Ignoring them is how people end up in a training course they cannot finish, or a business they cannot fund, or a job two hours away that falls apart after three months. Naming them is not giving up. It is planning.

Work through the five areas below. For each, write down your situation as it is today, and then mark whether the constraint is **hard** (truly fixed for now) or **soft** (could change with effort, help or time).

Money

How many months of runway do you have (from your work in Chapter 3)? What is the minimum monthly income you need to cover essentials? Can you afford a period of lower pay while you train or build something? Can you pay for any courses, tools or equipment? Your answer here strongly shapes which paths in Chapter 9 are realistic now and which need a bridge first.

Time

How many hours a week can you truly give to learning, job searching or building something new? Be honest about caring duties, a bridge job, health and rest. Ten focused hours a week, sustained for three months, beats forty hours a week that collapses after two.

Location

Are you able or willing to move? How far can you travel each day? Do you have reliable transport and internet? Some growing fields, such as skilled trades and care, need you on site. Others can be remote but face global competition. Your local job market matters a lot (see Chapter 18).

Health and physical capacity

Do you have any health conditions, disabilities or physical limits that affect the kind of work you can do or the hours you can sustain? Many paths can be adapted, and in many countries employers have legal duties to make reasonable adjustments. But it is better to plan around your real capacity than to hope it will not matter (see Chapter 21).

Family and relationships

Who depends on you, and who can support you? Does a partner's job tie you to a place? Are there childcare or eldercare responsibilities? Have you talked with the people affected about what changes they could accept, such as a temporary pay cut or a move (see Chapter 20)?

WORKSHEET 8.6 — MY CONSTRAINTS

Area	My situation today	Hard or soft?	What could loosen it (if soft)
Money: runway and minimum income			
Money: budget for training or tools			
Time: hours per week available			
Location: willingness to move or commute			
Health and physical capacity			
Family and caring duties			
Legal or practical (visa, licence, criminal record, driving)			
Other			

TIP

Many constraints that look hard are actually soft. A lack of training money might be solved by a free government-funded course or a library subscription (Chapter 10). A location limit might be solved by a hybrid role. Lack of time might ease once a bridge income is in place. Before you rule out a path, ask: "What would have to be true for this constraint to change?"

Ask other people what they see

Self-assessment has blind spots. We tend to overlook our strengths because they feel normal, and we tend to remember our failures more clearly than our wins. Other people can see what you cannot. Asking three to five people for honest feedback is one of the fastest ways to sharpen your inventory.

Choose a mix: a former manager, a peer, someone you helped or trained, and a friend or family member who knows you well outside work. Keep the request short and easy to answer. Most people are glad to help, especially when you make it simple.

SCRIPT: ASKING FOR STRENGTHS FEEDBACK

Hi [Name],

As you may know, my role at [Company] ended recently, and I'm taking some time to think carefully about what to do next. I'd really value your perspective, since you've seen me work up close.

Would you be willing to answer three quick questions? A few sentences each is perfect:

1. What did you see me do especially well?
2. When would you come to me for help, or recommend me to someone else?
3. Is there a kind of work you could imagine me doing that I might not have considered?

No pressure at all, and if a quick call is easier than writing, I'm happy to do that instead. Thank you, [Your name]

When replies come in, look for repeated words or themes. If three people independently mention that you explain things clearly or stay calm when others panic, believe them. Add those strengths to your skills audit, and add any examples they mention to your achievements bank.

A STORY

This is an illustrative composite. Priya, 46, spent eleven years writing product descriptions and marketing emails for an online retailer in Leeds. When most of that writing moved to AI tools, her role was cut, and she was sure she had "nothing left to offer". Her task breakdown told a different story: a large share of her week had gone into checking supplier facts, handling complaints about wrong product information and training new staff on the house style. Her energy audit showed she loved the training and the fact-checking and was tired of writing to volume. Three former colleagues all said the same thing: "You were the person who made sure things were right." Her inventory pointed her toward content quality, compliance and training roles, which she had never considered. She did not have an answer yet, but she had a direction to test.

Bring it together: your one-page snapshot

You now have a lot of material. The final step is to boil it down to a single page you can keep next to you while you work through Chapter 9. This snapshot will act as a filter. Any path you consider should use some of your strengths, deliver your top values, fit your energy and work within your hard constraints.

WORKSHEET 8.7 — MY DIRECTION SNAPSHOT

Area	My summary (keep it short)
My 5 strongest transferable skills	
My 2–3 best skill combinations	
My 3 best achievement stories (one line each)	
Work that energises me (patterns)	
Work that drains me (patterns)	
My top 3 values (for now)	
My hard constraints	
Skills I want to grow	
What others say I am good at	
Early ideas or directions that keep coming up	

SKILLS INVENTORY CHECKLIST

- [ ] I broke my last role into specific tasks and sorted routine from judgment-heavy work.
- [ ] I completed the transferable skills audit, including skills from outside paid work.
- [ ] I wrote at least five achievements in Situation, Action, Result format.
- [ ] I completed the energy audit and noticed the patterns.
- [ ] I ranked my top seven values and described what each means in practice.
- [ ] I listed my constraints and marked each as hard or soft.
- [ ] I asked at least three people for strengths feedback.
- [ ] I filled in my one-page direction snapshot.

DO THIS NOW

Do not wait until the inventory feels perfect. It never will. Instead:

1. Set a timer for 30 minutes and write three entries in your achievements bank.
2. Send the strengths feedback script to two people today.
3. Put a recurring 15-minute reminder in your calendar each week to add new achievements and update your snapshot. You will keep finding new material for months.

Treat this inventory as a living document. As you try small experiments in the next chapter, learn new skills in Chapter 10 and talk to people in Chapter 12, you will discover new strengths and adjust your values and constraints. That is not a sign you did it wrong. It is the inventory doing its job.

Looking at everything you wrote in this chapter, what surprised you most about yourself?

REMEMBER

- Your job title was a bundle of tasks. Most of your value lives in the tasks a machine did not take over.
- Transferable skills travel across fields. Name them by category and back each one with evidence.
- An achievements bank in Situation, Action, Result format is the most re-usable tool in your whole search.
- Being good at something is not the same as wanting to do it. Build toward work that energises you.
- Ranked values and honest constraints protect you from choosing a path for the wrong reasons.
- Other people can see strengths you overlook. Ask them.

Your next step: Write your first three achievement stories in the Situation, Action, Result format before the end of today.

CHAPTER 9

Choosing Your Path

There are six broad paths forward after AI reshapes your work. This chapter lays each one out honestly, gives you a weighted decision matrix to compare your options, and shows you how to run small, cheap experiments before you make a big bet.

Choosing a new direction can feel like standing at a crossroads in fog. Every path looks risky, and everyone you ask seems to have a different opinion. It is tempting either to freeze or to leap at whatever looks safest this week. Neither tends to end well.

There is a better way. You do not need to see the whole road before you start. You need to see the next stretch clearly, compare a few options fairly, and test them in small ways before you commit your savings, your time or your identity. That is what this chapter helps you do.

Have your one-page direction snapshot from Chapter 8 next to you. You will use it throughout. If you have not done it yet, you can still read on, but come back to it before you fill in the decision matrix.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> Most good career changes are not one big decision. They are a series of small, reversible steps, each one giving you better information than the last. Your goal right now is not to pick your forever path. It is to pick two or three promising options and find out more about them as cheaply as possible.

The six paths at a glance

Almost every direction people take after job disruption fits into one of six broad paths. They are not exclusive. Many people combine two, such as a part-time adjacent role while building a freelance practice, or move from one to another

over a few years. The table below gives you a quick overview before we look at each in detail.

Path	In one line	Typical time to income	Upfront cost
1. Adjacent pivot	Similar skills, different role or industry	Weeks to a few months	Low
2. Reskill into a growth field	Learn a new set of skills for a field that is hiring	Several months to two years	Low to high
3. Trades, care and hands-on work	Physical, local, in-person work that is hard to automate	Weeks (entry) to years (fully qualified)	Low to medium
4. Freelance or consulting	Sell your existing expertise directly to clients	Weeks to several months	Low
5. Small business	Build a product or service business of your own	Months to years	Medium to high
6. Portfolio career	Combine several income streams	Weeks (first stream) to a year (stable mix)	Low to medium

These time ranges are rough. They vary a lot by country, field, your starting point and the local job market. Use them to compare paths with each other, not as promises.

Path 1: The adjacent pivot

An adjacent pivot means keeping most of your skills and moving one step sideways: into a different role in the same industry, or the same kind of role in a different industry. A customer support lead might move into customer success, onboarding or support operations. A translator might move into localisation project management or quality review of AI translations. A junior developer might move into quality assurance, technical support engineering or a developer role in a less automated industry.

Who it suits: People with solid experience, a strong achievements bank and a need for income relatively soon. It also suits people who mostly liked their field but whose specific role shrank.

PROS

- Fastest route back to a steady income for many people.
- Your experience and network still count.
- Pay is often closer to what you had before.
- Low cost and low risk.

CONS

- If the whole field is shrinking, you may face the same pressure again.
- Can feel like “more of the same” if you were unhappy.
- Competition from other people making the same move.

Time to income: Often weeks to a few months, depending on the job market.

First steps: Use your task breakdown from Chapter 8 to find the judgment-heavy parts of your old role. Search job postings for roles that emphasise those parts. Pick three target job titles, read twenty postings, and talk to two people currently doing each role (see Chapter 12). Check each role’s AI exposure using the approach in Chapter 5, so you pivot toward durability rather than into the next role to be automated.

Path 2: Reskill into a growth field

This path means learning a substantially new set of skills to enter a field with stronger demand. Chapter 5 covered fields that are growing in many countries, including healthcare, the energy transition, infrastructure, education, cybersecurity and AI-adjacent roles such as data work, AI operations and quality evaluation. The key is that the new field is hiring, and that your learning leads to something employers recognise.

Who it suits: People with some runway or access to funded training, a genuine interest in the new field, and the time to study. It also suits people whose old field is clearly shrinking.

PROS

- Moves you toward long-term demand.
- Can lead to better pay and stability over time.
- Often a fresh start that restores energy and confidence.
- Many free or funded training options exist (Chapter 10).

CONS

- Takes time, and you may start at a junior level and lower pay.
- Risk of training for a field that does not hire you locally.
- Expensive courses with weak results are common.
- Learning while job-hunting and worrying about money is hard.

Time to income: Several months for shorter certificates; one to two years or more for licensed or degree-level fields.

First steps: Check real local demand: look at job boards in your area, not national headlines. Find out which credentials employers actually ask for. Combine your old skills with the new ones where you can (a former accountant moving into data analysis for finance teams has an edge). Then try a free introductory course for two to four weeks before paying for anything.

Path 3: Trades, care and hands-on work

Skilled trades (electrician, plumber, HVAC technician, welder, solar and heat-pump installer), care work (nursing assistant, home care, disability support, childcare), and other hands-on roles (paramedic, physiotherapy assistant, chef, technician) share something important: they require physical presence, dexterity and human judgment in unpredictable real-world settings. These are hard to automate, and many countries report shortages in them.

Who it suits: People who enjoy working with their hands or directly with people, who want visible results, and who are willing to work on site. Age is less of a barrier than many assume; plenty of people enter trades and care in their 40s and 50s.

PROS

- Strong demand in many places, and lower exposure to AI.
- Paid apprenticeships let you earn while you learn.
- Skilled trades can lead to self-employment and good income.
- Work that is clearly useful and often deeply meaningful.

CONS

- Physically demanding; consider your health honestly.
- Care work is often poorly paid relative to its value.
- Full qualification in some trades takes years.
- Less location flexibility; you work where the work is.

Time to income: Entry-level care and helper roles can start in weeks. Apprenticeships pay from the start, though at a lower rate. Full licensing usually takes several years.

First steps: Spend a day shadowing someone in the trade or role. Contact local colleges and apprenticeship services (see Chapter 10). Ask about pre-apprenticeship or taster programmes, which let you try the work before committing. Check the physical demands against your health constraints from Worksheet 8.6.

Path 4: Freelance or consulting

Freelancing means selling your skills directly to clients, project by project. Consulting is similar but usually focuses on advice and expertise rather than doing the work. Many people have more marketable expertise than they realise, especially deep knowledge of an industry, a process or a type of customer. AI tools can also help a single freelancer deliver more than before (Chapter 15 covers this in depth).

Who it suits: People with clear, specialised expertise, an existing network, comfort with uncertainty and the self-discipline to find their own work.

PROS

- Can start quickly with almost no upfront cost.
- Independence and control over clients and hours.
- Your former employer or its competitors may become clients.
- Good as a bridge while you pursue other paths.

CONS

- Income is uneven, especially in the first year.
- You must sell, invoice, chase payments and handle taxes.
- No employer benefits such as paid leave or a pension contribution.
- Crowded in fields where AI has cut prices, such as basic writing or translation.

Time to income: First paid project can come in weeks if you have a network; a stable income often takes six to twelve months.

First steps: Write down one specific problem you can solve for one specific type of client. Tell ten people in your network that you are available for that work. Aim for one small paid project before you build a website or print business cards.

Path 5: Start a small business

A small business sells a product or service under your own name or brand, and usually aims to grow beyond just your own hours. It might be a local service (cleaning, repairs, tutoring, catering), an online shop, a specialised agency or a niche software product. Chapter 16 covers how AI tools can now act as part of your team for marketing, admin and customer service.

Who it suits: People with a real problem they understand well, some savings or funding, a tolerance for risk, and a household that can handle uneven income for a while.

PROS

- Highest potential for independence and long-term upside.
- You build an asset, not just a job.
- Can create work for others in your community.
- AI tools have lowered some start-up costs.

CONS

- Highest risk; many new businesses do not last.
- Often slow to produce reliable income.
- Can drain savings if not tested carefully first.
- Long hours and stress, especially early on.

Time to income: Some service businesses make sales in weeks. Replacing a full salary usually takes much longer, often a year or more.

First steps: Do not start by spending money. Start by talking to potential customers and getting them to pay for a simple version of what you plan to offer. Read Chapter 16 on validation before you sign a lease, buy stock or quit a bridge job.

WATCH OUT

Be very careful with redundancy pay, severance and retirement savings when starting a business. Never withdraw retirement funds early to fund an untested idea without first speaking to a qualified financial adviser; in many countries the penalties and tax costs are severe (see Chapter 3). Also be wary of anyone selling a "done-for-you AI business" or franchise that promises easy income. Test before you invest.

Path 6: The portfolio career

A portfolio career combines several income streams instead of one full-time job. For example: three days a week in a part-time role, one day of freelance work, and some evening tutoring. Or a seasonal job plus a small online business plus occasional consulting. Chapter 17 explores how to manage this well.

Who it suits: People who like variety, want to reduce their dependence on a single employer, or need flexibility around caring duties or health. It also suits people who cannot yet find a single job that pays enough.

PROS

- Spreads risk: losing one stream does not mean losing everything.
- Lets you test several paths at once.
- Variety can be energising.
- Can combine stability (a part-time role) with upside (freelance).

CONS

- Juggling schedules and admin takes effort.
- Benefits and pension contributions may be patchy.
- Taxes and bookkeeping get more complicated.
- Hard to explain to some traditional employers.

Time to income: Your first stream can start quickly. A stable, balanced mix often takes six months to a year to build.

First steps: Identify one anchor stream that covers a good share of your essential costs. Then add one more stream at a time, rather than five at once.

A STORY

This is an illustrative composite. Marcus, 52, had worked for nineteen years in insurance claims processing in Ohio. When his department adopted an AI claims system, his job was cut. His inventory showed he was good at explaining complicated rules to stressed people and loved working with his hands on his house at weekends. He shortlisted three options: an adjacent pivot into claims quality review, a reskill into home energy assessment, and a portfolio mix of part-time claims work and handyman jobs. Instead of choosing straight away, he shadowed an energy assessor for a day, did a free online introduction to building science, and took two small paid repair jobs from neighbours. The experiments showed him he loved the assessment work, and that his claims experience gave him an edge in explaining reports to homeowners. He started the assessor training while working part-time in claims review to keep income coming in.

Shortlist before you score

Before you compare options, narrow them down. Go back to your direction snapshot (Worksheet 8.7) and filter. First, cross out any specific option that breaks a hard constraint. If you cannot relocate and the role only exists two

hundred miles away, it is out for now. If you need income within two months and a path needs a year of unpaid study, it either needs a bridge or it waits.

Then, for each remaining option, ask three questions. Does it use at least some of my strongest skills? Does it deliver at least two of my top three values? Does it involve mostly work that energises me? Aim for a shortlist of two to four specific options. “Healthcare” is too broad; “medical coding in a hospital” or “healthcare administration in my city” is specific enough to research and test.

> **TIP**
>
> If you cannot think of options, use an AI assistant as a brainstorming partner. Paste in your (anonymised) direction snapshot and ask: “Suggest ten specific roles or paths that fit these skills, values and constraints. For each, explain why it fits and how exposed it is to AI.” Treat the output as a list of ideas to check, not as advice. Verify every suggestion against real job postings and conversations with real people.

The weighted decision matrix

A decision matrix helps you compare options fairly, using criteria that matter to you rather than whichever option you thought about most recently. It does not make the decision for you. It makes your reasoning visible, so you can see where your gut and your analysis agree, and where they do not.

1. **Choose your criteria.** Pick five to eight factors that matter. Good starting points: income potential, speed to income, fit with my strengths, fit with my top values, energy, AI resilience, upfront cost, local demand and fit with my family situation.
2. **Weight each criterion.** Give each a weight from 1 (nice to have) to 5 (essential). Your weights should reflect your values ranking and constraints from Chapter 8. If money is tight, speed to income might be a 5.
3. **Score each option.** For each option, score each criterion from 1 (poor) to 5 (excellent). Base scores on what you know, and mark any you are guessing with a question mark. For cost and risk, a high score means low cost or low risk, so that higher is always better.

4 **Multiply and add.** Multiply each score by its weight, then add up the totals for each option.

5 **Check your reaction.** Look at the winner. Do you feel relief or disappointment? Either feeling is useful information.

A worked example

Here is how Marcus, from the story above, might have filled in his matrix. Each cell shows score × weight = weighted score.

Criterion (weight)	Claims quality review	Energy assessor	Portfolio mix
Speed to income (5)	4 × 5 = 20	2 × 5 = 10	4 × 5 = 20
Income potential (4)	3 × 4 = 12	4 × 4 = 16	3 × 4 = 12
Fit with strengths (4)	4 × 4 = 16	4 × 4 = 16	4 × 4 = 16
Energy (4)	2 × 4 = 8	5 × 4 = 20	4 × 4 = 16
AI resilience (3)	2 × 3 = 6	4 × 3 = 12	3 × 3 = 9
Upfront cost (3)	5 × 3 = 15	3 × 3 = 9	4 × 3 = 12
Total	**77**	**83**	**85**

The scores were close, which is common. What mattered was the pattern: the energy assessor path scored best on energy, income and resilience but worst on speed. That told Marcus he did not have to choose. He could combine a fast-income option with the long-term one. Close scores are often a sign that a combination or a sequence is the real answer.

WORKSHEET 9.1 — MY WEIGHTED DECISION MATRIX (WRITE SCORE × WEIGHT IN EACH CELL)

Criterion (weight 1–5)	Option A:	Option B:	Option C:
Speed to income ( )			
Income potential ( )			
Fit with my strengths ( )			

Criterion (weight 1–5)	Option A:	Option B:	Option C:
Fit with my top values ( )			
Energy ( )			
AI resilience ( )			
Upfront cost and risk ( )			
Local demand ( )			
Fit with family and health ( )			
My own criterion: ( )			
Total			

KEY IDEA

The question marks in your matrix are the most valuable part. Each one marks something you do not yet know, such as whether you would enjoy the daily work, whether local employers are hiring, or what the training really costs. Those unknowns are exactly what your experiments should test.

When you saw which option scored highest, what was your honest first reaction? What does that tell you?

Small experiments before big bets

Here is the most important idea in this chapter. Before you commit serious money or months of your life to a path, run small, cheap experiments to test your assumptions. An experiment is anything that lets you experience a slice of the real work, or test real demand, for a small cost in time and money.

Experiments protect you from two expensive mistakes: committing to a path that looks good on paper but feels wrong in practice, and dismissing a path that you would actually love. They also give you stories, contacts and evidence that help you get hired later. Someone who says "I spent a day shadowing a nurse and volunteered at a hospice for a month" is far more convincing than someone who says "I think I would like healthcare."

Experiment	Typical cost	Time	What it tells you
Informational conversation	Free	30 minutes	What the job is really like, how people got in, what employers want
Job shadowing	Free or travel costs	Half a day to a few days	Whether you would enjoy the daily reality, the pace and the environment
Short or free course	Free to low	1–4 weeks	Whether you enjoy the subject and can learn it at a reasonable pace
Paid micro-project	Free (you get paid)	A few hours to a week	Whether people will pay for the work, and what it is like to deliver it
Volunteering	Free	A few hours a week for a month	Whether the setting and people suit you; builds references and contacts
Temporary or part-time role	Paid	Weeks to months	The fullest test of a field while earning money
Tiny business test	Low	1–4 weeks	Whether real customers will pay for a simple version of your idea

How to design a good experiment

1. **Name your biggest unknown.** Pick the question mark that would most change your decision. For example: "Would I actually enjoy working with elderly clients every day?" or "Will small businesses pay for my bookkeeping help?"
2. **Choose the smallest test.** Find the cheapest, fastest way to get real information about that unknown. A day of shadowing beats a year-long course for testing whether you like the work.

3. **Decide what success looks like in advance.** Write it down before you start. “If I still feel interested after a full day, and I can picture doing it for years, that is a yes.” Or: “If two of the ten businesses I contact agree to a paid trial, that is a yes.”

4. **Set a deadline.** Most experiments should take less than a month. Open-ended exploration easily drifts.

5. **Reflect and decide.** Afterwards, write down what you learned and what you will do next: continue, adjust or drop this option.

WORKSHEET 9.2 — EXPERIMENT PLAN

Option I am testing	My biggest unknown	The experiment and deadline	Success looks like...

WORKSHEET 9.3 — EXPERIMENT RESULTS

Experiment	What I learned	How I felt doing it	Decision: continue, adjust or drop

Asking to shadow someone

Shadowing feels like a big ask, but many people are happy to help, especially if you are clear, flexible and respectful of their time. Start with your own network, then local employers, professional associations and colleges. Some workplaces, such as hospitals and building sites, have safety or privacy rules, so be ready for a "no" or for a more limited visit.

SCRIPT: ASKING TO SHADOW SOMEONE FOR A DAY

Hi [Name],

[Mutual contact] suggested I get in touch. I spent [number] years working in [field], and I'm now seriously exploring a move into [new field]. Before I commit to training, I want to see what the work is really like day to day.

Would you be open to me shadowing you for a few hours, or for a day, sometime in the next month? I'm happy to fit around your schedule, stay out of the way, and follow any rules about privacy or safety. If that's not possible, even a 20-minute phone call would be a huge help.

Thank you for considering it. [Your name] [Phone number]

Getting a paid micro-project

A paid micro-project is a small, clearly defined piece of work you do for a real client for a modest fee. It is the best test of freelance, consulting or business paths, because it answers the most important question: will someone pay for this? Offer something small and specific, such as "I will clean up and organise your customer spreadsheet" or "I will review your website copy and send you ten specific improvements," with a fixed price and a short deadline. Your existing network is the best place to start.

WATCH OUT

An experiment should be cheap. If a "taster" requires you to pay a large deposit, sign a long contract, buy a starter kit, or recruit other people, it is not an experiment. It may be a sales funnel or a scam. Real shadowing, volunteering and introductory courses are free or low cost.

When to make the bigger bet

At some point, experiments need to turn into commitment. Training takes months, and job searches need focus. A helpful way to think about this is the difference between two kinds of decisions. Some decisions are like a two-way door: if you walk through and do not like it, you can walk back. Others are like a one-way door: hard or expensive to undo.

TWO-WAY DOORS (MOVE FAST)

- Taking a free course
- Shadowing or volunteering
- Applying for jobs in a new field
- Taking a short-term contract
- Telling people you are open to freelance work

ONE-WAY DOORS (SLOW DOWN)

- Paying for an expensive course or taking a loan
- Withdrawing retirement savings
- Signing a business lease or buying a franchise
- Moving to a new city
- Turning down a solid job offer

Move quickly through two-way doors. For one-way doors, wait until your experiments give you real evidence, talk it over with the people affected, and where money is involved, get qualified advice.

READY TO COMMIT? CHECK BEFORE A BIG BET

- [ ] I have done at least one real experiment on this path.
- [ ] I have spoken to at least three people doing this work now.
- [ ] I have checked local demand using real job postings or customer conversations.
- [ ] I know the full cost in money and time, including lost income.
- [ ] I have a bridge plan for income while I make the move.
- [ ] I have talked it through with the people it affects.
- [ ] I know what I will do if it does not work out (my Plan B).

Plan A, Plan B and a bridge

Before committing, write down three things. Your **Plan A** is the path you are moving toward. Your **Plan B** is what you will do if Plan A takes much longer or does not work. Your **bridge** is how you will cover your essential costs in the meantime: part-time work, freelance projects, a temporary job or benefits. Having a Plan B is not a lack of commitment. It is what lets you commit to Plan A without panic.

WORKSHEET 9.4 — MY PLAN ON ONE PAGE

Element	My answer
Plan A (specific path)	
Why I chose it (evidence from experiments)	
Bridge income while I get there	
Plan B if Plan A stalls	
The signal that tells me to switch to Plan B	
Date I will review this plan	

When you feel stuck

Decision paralysis is common after a job loss. Your brain is tired, the stakes feel huge, and too many options can be as hard as too few. If you are stuck, try these:

- **Shrink the decision.** You are not choosing a career. You are choosing your next experiment.
- **Set a deadline.** Give yourself two weeks to choose a Plan A for the next three months, then stop deliberating.
- **Talk it through out loud.** Explain your options to a friend, a mentor or a career adviser. Hearing yourself often reveals what you already think.
- **Remember that not choosing is also a choice.** Waiting has costs too, especially for your runway.
- **Get help.** Many public employment services, unions and libraries offer free career guidance. In the UK, for example, the National Careers Service offers

free advice; in the US, American Job Centers do something similar. Check what exists where you live.

You do not need to know where you will end up. You only need to know what you will test next.

DO THIS NOW

1. Write down your shortlist of two to four specific options.
2. Fill in Worksheet 9.1, marking any guesses with a question mark.
3. Choose the one unknown that matters most, and plan one experiment to test it in the next two weeks.
4. Send one message today: to ask for a shadowing day, an informational chat or a small paid project.

REMEMBER

- There are six broad paths: adjacent pivot, reskilling into a growth field, trades and care, freelancing, small business and a portfolio career. Many people combine two.
- Filter options by your hard constraints first, then by strengths, values and energy.
- A weighted decision matrix makes your reasoning visible. Close scores often point to a combination or sequence.
- Test before you invest. Shadowing, short courses, paid micro-projects and volunteering are cheap ways to learn a lot.
- Move fast through reversible decisions. Slow down for the ones that are hard to undo.
- Always have a Plan A, a Plan B and a bridge.

Your next step: Pick one option from your shortlist and send one message today asking to shadow someone or have a 20-minute chat about their work.

CHAPTER 10

Reskilling Smart

Learning new skills as an adult, under pressure, is very doable if you learn the right way and spend your money carefully. This chapter shows you how adults learn fast, where to find free and low-cost training, which credentials actually matter, how to spot a bad course, and how to build and fund a 12-week learning plan.

If you have not studied anything formally in years, the idea of "reskilling" can feel daunting. You may remember school as boring or stressful. You may worry that your memory is not what it was, or that younger people will learn faster. Those worries are normal, and mostly unfounded. Adults bring things to learning that younger people often lack: motivation, context, discipline and years of experience to hang new ideas on.

The bigger risks for adult learners are not about ability. They are about method and money. People waste months on passive videos that do not stick, or spend thousands on a course that promised a job and delivered a certificate nobody asks for. This chapter is designed to protect you from both.

Before you start, have your Plan A from Chapter 9 in mind. Reskilling works best when it is aimed at a specific target role or path. "Learning about AI" is a hobby. "Learning the skills listed in twenty local job postings for a data analyst in healthcare" is a plan.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> The goal of reskilling is not to collect certificates. It is to be able to do work that someone will pay for, and to prove it. Every hour and every dollar you spend should move you toward that proof.

How adults learn fast

Research on learning over many decades points to a handful of methods that work much better than simply reading or watching videos. None of them are complicated. They mostly feel harder in the moment, which is exactly why they work: effortful learning tends to last longer than easy learning.

1. Practise recalling, not just re-reading

Re-reading notes or re-watching a lesson feels productive, but much of it fades quickly. Testing yourself is far more powerful. After a lesson, close the material and try to write down or explain the main points from memory. Use flashcards for facts and terms. Do practice questions before you feel ready. The struggle to remember is what strengthens the memory.

2. Space your practice out

Cramming for eight hours on a Saturday is less effective than one hour a day for eight days. Spreading practice over time, and returning to earlier topics after a gap, helps you remember far more. A simple rule: review new material the next day, then a few days later, then a week later. Many free flashcard apps schedule this for you automatically.

3. Mix related topics together

Once you have the basics, mix different types of problems in one session instead of doing twenty of the same kind in a row. If you are learning spreadsheets, practise a lookup, then a chart, then a pivot table, then a lookup again. Mixing feels slower, but it trains you to recognise which tool fits which problem, which is what real work demands.

4. Learn through real projects

Projects are where knowledge turns into skill. Instead of finishing an entire course before you build anything, start a small, real project early and learn what you need as you go. A project gives your learning a purpose, shows you what you do not know yet, and produces evidence you can show employers (see Chapter 13). Wherever possible, pick projects that solve a real problem for a real person.

5. Teach what you learn

Explaining something to someone else is one of the fastest ways to discover the gaps in your own understanding. Teach a friend, write a short post about what you learned this week, record a two-minute voice note explaining a concept, or answer beginner questions in an online community. Teaching also builds your visibility in a new field.

6. Get feedback quickly

Practice without feedback can lock in mistakes. Look for ways to find out quickly whether you are doing it right: exercises with answers, a mentor who reviews your work, a study group, a community forum, or a supervisor during an apprenticeship. AI tutors can help here too (see below), but human feedback from people in the field is especially valuable.

FEELS PRODUCTIVE, WORKS LESS WELL

- Re-reading and highlighting
- Watching videos at double speed with no practice
- Long cramming sessions
- Finishing the whole course before building anything
- Collecting certificates

FEELS HARDER, WORKS MUCH BETTER

- Testing yourself from memory
- Short, spaced sessions over weeks
- Mixing different types of problems
- Small real projects from week one
- Explaining it to someone else

TIP

You may have heard that people are “visual learners” or “auditory learners” and should only study in their preferred style. Researchers have generally not found good evidence that matching teaching to a supposed learning style improves results. It is better to match the method to the material: diagrams for processes, hands-on practice for physical skills, and self-testing for almost everything.

Using AI as a learning partner

AI assistants can be excellent tutors when used well (Chapter 7 covers the basics). Ask them to explain a concept in simpler terms, give you practice questions, quiz you on what you learned yesterday, or review your project and point out mistakes. Ask them to play the role of a demanding interviewer in your new field. The key is to use AI to make you think harder, not to do the thinking for you. If AI writes your project, you have learned nothing and proved nothing.

Remember that AI can be confidently wrong, especially on technical details, regulations and anything specific to your country. Check important facts against the official course material, a trusted textbook or a qualified person.

Start from the job, then work backward

The most common reskilling mistake is starting with a course that looks interesting, rather than with the skills employers actually want. Flip it around. Start with your target role and work backward.

1. **Collect real job postings.** Save fifteen to twenty postings for your target role, ideally in your area or in remote roles you could realistically win.
2. **List the skills and credentials.** Write down every skill, tool and qualification mentioned. Count how often each appears.
3. **Mark what you already have.** Use your skills inventory from Chapter 8. You may be surprised how many you already meet.
4. **Prioritise the gaps.** Focus first on the gaps that appear most often and those listed as “required” rather than “nice to have”.
5. **Talk to someone in the role.** Ask which skills really matter day to day, and which credential, if any, opened doors for them.

WORKSHEET 10.1 — SKILLS GAP ANALYSIS FOR MY TARGET ROLE

Skill, tool or credential from postings	How many postings mention it	My current level (none / some / strong)	Priority (high / medium / low)

Skill, tool or credential from postings	How many postings mention it	My current level (none / some / strong)	Priority (high / medium / low)

Free and low-cost learning resources

You can learn an enormous amount without spending much money. Before you pay for any course, check the options below. Offers, prices and eligibility rules change often, so always confirm the current details on the provider's official website.

Resource	What it offers	Cost notes
Your public library	Many libraries give members free access to online learning platforms such as LinkedIn Learning, plus language apps, e-books, computers and quiet study space	Usually free with a library card; ask your library what it subscribes to
Coursera and edX	University and company courses across many subjects	Many courses have offered a free "audit" option to view materials without a certificate, though this varies by course and has become more limited on some; financial aid is available for some paid certificates
Khan Academy	Maths, science, economics, personal finance and more, from the basics up	Free

Resource	What it offers	Cost notes
freeCodeCamp	Web development, programming and data courses with projects	Free
MIT OpenCourseWare	Materials from a wide range of MIT courses, including lecture notes and problem sets	Free; no certificate or instructor support
Google Career Certificates	Job-focused programmes in areas such as IT support, data analytics, project management and user experience design	Usually paid by subscription, but financial aid and free access through some employers, libraries and public programmes may be available
Vendor training	Free learning paths from technology companies, such as Microsoft Learn, AWS Skill Builder and Salesforce Trailhead	Much of the learning is free; certification exams usually cost money
Community and technical colleges	Short courses, certificates and qualifications, often with strong links to local employers	Often low cost, with grants and fee waivers for people who are unemployed or on low incomes
Government-funded retraining	Free or subsidised courses, vouchers and training accounts for adults changing careers	Often free for eligible people; see below
Unions, trade bodies and professional associations	Training, mentoring, member discounts and sometimes funded courses	Varies; some offer reduced fees for unemployed members

Government-funded retraining: examples to look for

Many governments fund training for adults, especially people who have lost their jobs or work in declining industries. Names and rules vary widely and change often, but here are some examples of the kinds of programmes that exist:

- **United States:** Local American Job Centers can connect eligible people to training funded under the Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act (WIOA), often through approved providers.
- **United Kingdom:** Free Skills Bootcamps in in-demand areas, and free courses for eligible adults to gain certain qualifications. The National Careers Service can help you find them.
- **Canada:** Provincial and territorial employment programmes fund training, and the federal Canada Training Credit can help eligible workers with course costs.
- **Australia:** Fee-Free TAFE places in priority areas, plus state-based training subsidies.
- **European Union countries:** Many have public schemes. France's personal training account (CPF) and Germany's education vouchers through the federal employment agency are two well-known examples.
- **Singapore:** SkillsFuture credits that citizens can use for approved courses.

Wherever you live, start with your public employment service, your unemployment benefits office, your local college and your library. Ask directly: "What training funding am I eligible for as someone who has lost their job?" If you are receiving unemployment benefits, ask before you start a course whether studying affects your payments. In some places approved training is allowed or even encouraged; in others it can affect your claim.

DO THIS NOW

1. Log in to your library's website (or get a library card) and check which learning platforms it gives you free access to.
2. Search for your country's or region's public employment service and look for "training", "retraining" or "skills funding".
3. Phone or email one local college and ask about short courses and fee support for people who are unemployed.

Credentials that matter, and those that do not

Not all certificates are equal. Some are legally required to do the job. Some are widely respected by employers. Many are simply proof that you clicked through a series of videos. Knowing the difference can save you a lot of time and money.

Type	Examples	How much it usually matters
Legal licences and registrations	Electrician, plumber, nurse, commercial driver, teacher, care worker registration, accountant in regulated roles	Essential: you cannot legally do the job without it
Industry-recognised certifications	Well-known IT, cloud, cybersecurity, project management and accounting certifications that appear frequently in job postings	Often important, especially for career changers without direct experience
Degrees and diplomas	University degrees, college diplomas, vocational qualifications	Essential in some fields, optional in others; check your target postings
Apprenticeship completion	Completed apprenticeships and trade certificates	Highly valued in trades and some technical fields
Reputable course certificates	Certificates from well-known universities or companies	Helpful as a signal of learning, but rarely enough on their own
Generic or unaccredited certificates	“Certified AI Expert” from an unknown provider, short online badges with no assessment	Usually little value to employers; proof of real work matters far more

How to check whether a credential matters

- **Count it in job postings.** If it appears in many of your fifteen to twenty saved postings, it matters. If it appears in none, it probably does not.
- **Ask people in the field.** “If you were hiring, would this certificate make a difference?” is a quick, revealing question.
- **Check accreditation.** For licensed fields, check the official regulator or licensing body in your country, not the course provider’s website.

- **Look for real assessment.** A credential that requires a proctored exam, practical test or supervised hours carries more weight than one you get just for watching videos.

A certificate says you studied. A project says you can do it. Aim for both, but never skip the project.

Apprenticeships: earn while you learn

Apprenticeships combine paid work with structured training. You work for an employer, learn on the job from experienced people, and usually study part-time with a college or training provider. At the end, you have a recognised qualification and real experience. For many people changing careers, especially into trades, care, healthcare and some technical roles, this is the most practical path because it solves the money problem and the experience problem at once.

Apprenticeships are not just for teenagers. In many countries there is no upper age limit, and employers often value the reliability and life experience of adult apprentices. Examples of systems to look into include registered apprenticeships in the United States (search the official government apprenticeship website), apprenticeships in England and the other UK nations, Germany's well-known dual vocational training system, Australian Apprenticeships, and Red Seal trades in Canada.

ADVANTAGES

- You are paid from day one.
- Training costs are often covered by the employer or government.
- You gain experience and a qualification together.
- Strong route to a stable job with the same employer.

THINGS TO WEIGH

- Apprentice pay is often lower than your previous salary at first.
- Some take several years to complete.
- Places can be competitive in popular trades.
- Physical demands in some trades need honest thought.

If you are not ready to commit, look for **pre-apprenticeship** or taster programmes. These short courses introduce you to a trade, teach basic safety and skills, and often connect you directly with employers who are hiring apprentices.

> **A STORY**
>
> *This is an illustrative composite. Siobhan, 39, worked in data entry for an insurance company in Dublin for twelve years before her team was cut. She had always enjoyed fixing things around the house but assumed it was "too late" for a trade. A local college ran a free four-week pre-apprenticeship course in electrical work for adults. She took it, found she loved it, and was introduced to an electrical contractor who was struggling to find reliable apprentices. Her apprentice wage was lower than her old salary, so she and her partner adjusted their budget for a few years. She described it as the first time in a decade that she looked forward to Monday.*

Evaluating paid courses and bootcamps

Some paid courses and bootcamps are excellent. They offer structure, expert teaching, career support and a community, and some people genuinely need that to succeed. But the market for courses is also full of overpriced programmes, misleading marketing and outright scams, and AI anxiety has made this worse. Many sellers know that worried people make fast decisions. Slow down.

Red flags

WALK AWAY, OR AT LEAST INVESTIGATE HARD, IF YOU SEE THESE

- [ ] **Job guarantees.** No honest provider can guarantee you a job. Read the small print: "guarantees" often come with conditions that are nearly impossible to meet.
- [ ] **Pressure tactics.** Countdown timers, "only two places left", discounts that expire today, or a salesperson who calls repeatedly.
- [ ] **Vague or unverifiable outcomes.** Claims such as "94% of graduates hired" with no explanation of how it was measured, who was counted, or what kinds of jobs they got.
- [ ] **Income promises.** "Earn six figures in six months, no experience needed."
- [ ] **Hidden teachers.** You cannot find out who teaches the course or what real experience they have.
- [ ] **No clear refund policy,** or one that ends before you can judge the course.
- [ ] **No accreditation** where your target field requires it (for example, healthcare or trades).
- [ ] **Upsells.** The "course" is mainly a funnel into a more expensive coaching programme.
- [ ] **Reviews only on the provider's own site,** or a suspicious lack of independent reviews.

Income-share agreements: read the fine print

Some bootcamps offer an income-share agreement (ISA) or similar "pay later" deal. Instead of paying upfront, you agree to pay a percentage of your future income for a set period once you earn above a certain amount. This can sound low-risk, but the details matter enormously, and in some countries regulators have taken action against misleading terms.

WATCH OUT

Before signing any income-share or deferred-payment agreement, find out: What percentage of income do I pay, and for how long? What is the minimum income before payments start? Is there a total cap, and how does it compare with the upfront price? Does it count all income, including work outside the field I trained for? What happens if I leave the field, move abroad or stop working? Can the agreement be sold to another company? Is it legally treated as a loan where I live? Ask for the full contract in writing and, if the amount is significant, have someone qualified review it before you sign.

Questions to ask before you pay

Good providers answer these questions clearly and in writing. If a provider becomes vague or pushy when you ask, that tells you something.

SCRIPT: QUESTIONS TO SEND A COURSE PROVIDER

Hello,

I am considering your [course name] and would like a few details in writing before I decide:

1. Of the students who started the course in the past year, how many finished it?
2. Of those who finished, how many were working in a related role within six months, and how did you measure this?
3. What kinds of roles and typical salaries did they get, and in which locations?
4. Who teaches the course, and what is their professional experience?
5. What is the full total cost, including any exam fees, materials or software?
6. What is your refund policy, and until what date can I get my money back?
7. Could you put me in touch with two recent graduates?

Thank you, [Your name]

Then do your own checking. Search for the provider's name plus "reviews", "complaints" or "refund". Look at independent review sites and forums. Find graduates on professional networking sites and ask them politely about their experience. Most people are honest when asked one-to-one.

TIP

Before paying for any bootcamp, try a free course in the same subject for two to four weeks. If you cannot stay motivated through free material, an expensive version will not fix that. If you love it and progress well, you may find you do not need the paid course at all, or you will choose it with much better information.

Your 12-week learning plan

Twelve weeks is long enough to make real, visible progress, and short enough to stay focused. It will not make you an expert, but it can take you from beginner to someone who can show real work and talk confidently about a new field. Use the structure below and adjust it to your target role.

1. **Weeks 1–2: Foundations.** Learn the core ideas and vocabulary of the field. Set up your tools. Join one community of learners or practitioners.
2. **Weeks 3–6: Core skills and small projects.** Work through your highest-priority gaps from Worksheet 10.1. Finish one small project every one to two weeks.
3. **Weeks 7–10: A real portfolio project.** Build one larger project that resembles real work in your target role, ideally for a real person or organisation.
4. **Weeks 11–12: Polish and show.** Write up your project as a case study (Chapter 13), update your CV and profile, and start applying, networking or pitching.

Decide how many hours a week you can truly give (look back at your time constraints in Worksheet 8.6). Five to ten hours a week is realistic for many people who are also job-hunting or working a bridge job. Split them into short sessions on most days rather than one long session, and protect them in your calendar like appointments.

WORKSHEET 10.2 — MY 12-WEEK LEARNING PLAN

Week	Focus / skill	Practice or project	Proof I will have at the end

Week	Focus / skill	Practice or project	Proof I will have at the end
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			
11			
12			

A simple weekly learning routine

- **Start each session with a quick recall test.** Spend five minutes writing what you remember from last time.
- **Learn something new for 20–40 minutes.** Then stop and practise it straight away.
- **End with one small output.** A solved problem, a paragraph of notes in your own words, or a step forward on your project.
- **Once a week, teach or share.** Explain one thing you learned to someone else or in a short post.
- **Once a week, review.** What worked, what did not, and what will you change next week?

WATCH OUT

Expect a dip around weeks three to five, when the novelty fades and the material gets harder. Almost everyone feels it. It is not a sign that you are not cut out for this. Lower your hours for a week if you need to, but keep the habit going, even if it is only 15 minutes a day. Consistency matters more than intensity.

What usually stops you from finishing things you start learning? What will you do differently this time?

Financing your retraining

Retraining can cost little or a lot. The cheapest route is not always the best, but you should always use free and funded options before spending your own savings or taking on debt. Work through these sources roughly in this order.

1. **Free resources first.** Libraries, free courses, vendor training and open courseware, as described above.
2. **Government funding.** Retraining grants, vouchers, training accounts, free bootcamps and fee waivers for people who are unemployed.
3. **Your former employer.** Some employers offer outplacement support or training budgets as part of a redundancy package. If you are still negotiating your exit, it is reasonable to ask (see Chapter 2).
4. **Unions and associations.** Many fund or subsidise training for members.
5. **A new employer.** Apprenticeships and some entry-level roles include paid training. Some employers offer tuition support after you join.

6. **Scholarships, bursaries and financial aid.** Colleges, charities, foundations and online platforms often have funds for career changers, people on low incomes or under-represented groups.
7. **Tax relief.** Some countries offer tax credits or deductions for work-related training. Check with your tax authority or a qualified adviser.
8. **Payment plans.** Interest-free instalment plans from reputable providers can spread the cost.
9. **Loans, carefully.** Government student loans usually have better protections than private loans. Avoid high-interest credit cards and payday loans for training.

Is it worth the cost?

For any course that costs a significant amount, do a quick return-on-investment check. It is not exact, but it forces you to think clearly before you commit.

WORKSHEET 10.3 — IS THIS COURSE WORTH IT?

Question	My answer
Total cost (fees, exams, materials, equipment, travel)	
Time needed (weeks and hours per week)	
Income lost or delayed while studying	
Funding or free alternatives I have checked	
How many target job postings ask for this credential?	
Realistic starting pay in the new role (from postings or people in the field)	
Months to earn back the cost, roughly	
What graduates told me about it	
Refund deadline and terms	
My decision and why	

If you cannot answer most of these questions, you are not ready to pay yet. That is fine. Go back to free options and experiments (Chapter 9) while you gather the information.

KEY IDEA

Debt for training is only a good bet when there is strong evidence the training leads to work that pays enough to repay it. Protect your runway first (Chapter 3). A slower, funded route that keeps you financially stable is usually better than a fast, expensive route that leaves you anxious and in debt.

RESKILLING CHECKLIST

- [ ] I have a specific target role and have saved at least fifteen job postings for it.
- [ ] I have completed my skills gap analysis.
- [ ] I have checked my library, free platforms and government funding options.
- [ ] I know which credentials in my target field actually matter.
- [ ] I have looked into apprenticeships or pre-apprenticeships if relevant.
- [ ] I have checked any paid course against the red flags and asked the key questions in writing.
- [ ] I have filled in my 12-week learning plan and blocked time in my calendar.
- [ ] I have a plan to fund my training without risking my essential runway.

REMEMBER

- Adults learn fast with the right methods: self-testing, spaced practice, mixing topics, real projects, teaching others and quick feedback.
- Start from real job postings and work backward to the skills you need.
- Use free and funded options first: libraries, open courses, vendor training, colleges and government retraining schemes. Check what exists locally.
- Licences and widely recognised certifications matter. Generic certificates rarely do. Proof of real work matters most.
- Apprenticeships let you earn while you learn, at any age.
- Be wary of job guarantees, pressure tactics and income-share fine print. Ask hard questions in writing before you pay.
- A focused 12-week plan with projects beats months of passive watching.

Your next step: Check your library's website today to see which free learning platforms you can access with your card, and start the first lesson.

PART IV

Winning in a Crowded Job Market

When everyone can send a hundred applications a day, volume stops working. This part shows how to be the candidate who gets noticed: targeted searches, real relationships, visible proof, strong interviews, and staying safe from scams.

11 · The Modern Job Search
12 · Networking Without Feeling Fake
13 · Proof Over Promises: Portfolios and Public Work
14 · Interviews, Offers and Job Scams

CHAPTER 11

The Modern Job Search

How hiring really works now that software reads most applications and almost every candidate uses AI, and a calm weekly system that gets you in front of real people without burning you out.

If you have been sending out applications and hearing nothing back, you are not imagining it, and it is probably not because you are unqualified. The job market has changed in a way that makes the old approach (find a posting, click apply, wait) work less and less. This chapter explains what changed, why it is not your fault, and what to do instead.

The good news is that the new approach costs less energy, not more. It means fewer applications, each done with more care, plus steady contact with real people. You will build a short list of target employers, a CV that works for both software and humans, and a weekly routine you can keep up for months if you need to.

Why Spray-and-Pray Stopped Working

For years, a common strategy was volume: apply to as many jobs as possible and hope a few stick. That was never very efficient, but it sometimes worked. In 2026 it mostly does not, and the reason is simple. Everyone else can now do it too.

AI tools let any candidate produce a polished CV and cover letter in seconds. Some tools even apply to hundreds of jobs automatically. So a single online posting can attract a flood of applications, many of them near-identical. Employers have responded by leaning harder on screening software, adding more steps, and relying more on referrals from people they already trust.

The result is a loop. Candidates apply to more jobs because response rates are low. Response rates fall further because everyone applies to more jobs. If you join that loop, you spend your limited energy on the part of the process where

you have the least control and the most competition.

When everyone can apply to a thousand jobs, the advantage goes to the person who is actually known, trusted and specific.

What the volume approach costs you

- **Morale.** Hundreds of silent rejections wear down even the most resilient person. Silence feels like a verdict on your worth, even when it is just a crowded inbox.
- **Quality.** When you apply to fifty jobs a week, you cannot tailor any of them. Generic applications perform worse, which feeds the cycle.
- **Learning.** With so much noise, you cannot tell what is working. Was it the CV? The role? The timing? You never find out.
- **Reputation.** Applying to many roles at the same company, especially roles you are not suited for, can make recruiters there take you less seriously.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> Your goal is not to send applications. Your goal is to have conversations with people who can hire you or refer you. Applications are one way to get there, but rarely the best one. Measure your week by conversations, not clicks.

How AI Screening and Applicant Tracking Systems Work

Most medium and large employers use an Applicant Tracking System, usually called an ATS. It is software that collects applications, stores them, and helps recruiters search and sort them. Many now include AI features that summarise CVs, rank candidates against the job description, or flag “strong matches”.

There are a lot of myths about these systems. It helps to know what is roughly true, so you can stop worrying about the wrong things.

MYTH

- A robot secretly rejects 75% of CVs before a human sees them.
- You must copy the job description word for word.
- Hiding keywords in white text will trick the system.
- A creative, designed CV will stand out to the software.
- If you are rejected, it was the ATS.

REALITY

- Many systems sort and rank rather than auto-reject, though some use knock-out questions (location, right to work, required licence).
- Matching the key terms honestly helps, especially for recruiters who search the database.
- Hidden text is easy to spot, often shows up in AI summaries, and looks dishonest.
- Columns, tables, text boxes and graphics can scramble how the system reads your CV.
- Often a human did see it and chose others, or the role was filled internally or by referral.

Two things matter most. First, the software must be able to *read* your CV cleanly. Second, when a recruiter searches or the system compares you to the job, your CV should clearly contain the skills and terms that genuinely describe your experience. That is it. You do not need tricks.

Knock-out questions

Many applications include yes-or-no questions such as “Do you have the right to work in this country?” or “Do you hold a forklift licence?” or “Are you willing to work weekends?” A “wrong” answer can remove you automatically. Read these carefully. Answer truthfully, but do not undersell yourself: if the question asks about “experience with scheduling software” and you used a scheduling tool every day under a different name, the honest answer is yes.

WATCH OUT

Be wary of tools that promise to auto-apply to hundreds of jobs for you. They tend to produce generic, sometimes inaccurate applications, can submit to roles you would never accept, and some ask for access to your email or accounts. If you use any AI tool in your search, keep yourself in control of what gets sent and where.

The Targeted Search: Fewer, Better Bets

A targeted search starts from the employers, not the postings. Instead of reacting to whatever appears on a job board today, you choose a list of organisations where your skills fit and where you would actually want to work. Then you follow them, learn about them, and find people inside them.

This sounds slower. In practice it is often faster, because one warm introduction can be worth more than fifty cold applications. It also gives you something that mass applying never does: a sense of direction.

Building your target list

Use the path you chose in Chapter 9 and the skills inventory from Chapter 8 as your starting point. Aim for 20 to 40 organisations. That is enough to have options and few enough to know each one reasonably well.

- **Start with the obvious.** Companies in your industry, competitors of your last employer, suppliers and customers you dealt with.
- **Add the adjacent.** Organisations that need your skills even if they are in a different sector. A hospital needs schedulers, a construction firm needs bookkeepers, a school district needs IT support.
- **Look local.** Mid-sized local employers often get far fewer applicants than famous brands and hire through word of mouth. Chapter 18 goes deeper on this.
- **Check who is growing.** Local news, business announcements, new buildings, public funding for infrastructure or energy projects, and companies that are hiring for several roles at once.
- **Include the public and nonprofit sectors.** Government, health systems, universities and charities often have structured hiring with clear criteria,

which can favour experienced candidates.

WORKSHEET 11.1 — TARGET COMPANY LIST

Organisation	Why it fits me	People I know or could reach	Priority (A/B/C)

Mark your top eight to ten as “A”. These get most of your attention: you follow their news, look for contacts, and check their careers page every week. “B” organisations you check every two weeks. “C” organisations you keep an eye on.

> **TIP**
>
> AI assistants are useful for research here. Ask one to list mid-sized employers in your city in a particular sector, or to summarise what a company does and what challenges it faces. Then verify the basics on the company’s own website and recent news, because AI tools can be out of date or simply wrong about smaller organisations.

The Hidden Job Market

Not every job is advertised publicly, and many that are advertised are filled by someone who was already known to the team. Roles get filled through internal moves, referrals, former colleagues, contractors who were converted to staff, and people who simply got in touch at the right moment. This is often called the "hidden job market".

It is not a secret club. It is just how people behave when hiring is risky and time is short: they prefer someone they or a trusted colleague can vouch for. In a market flooded with AI-written applications, that preference has grown stronger.

You get access to it in three main ways:

1. **Be known.** Tell people specifically what you are looking for. Vague requests ("let me know if you hear of anything") get forgotten. Specific ones ("I'm looking for operations coordinator roles at logistics companies in the north of the city") get remembered.
2. **Be early.** Talk to people at your target organisations before roles are posted. When a need appears, you are already in their mind. Informational conversations (Chapter 12) are the main tool here.
3. **Be visible.** Show your work where the right people can see it: a portfolio, a short case study, helpful posts in a professional community (Chapter 13).

A STORY

Illustrative composite. Tomasz, 47, had spent eleven years in customer support for a software firm before most of his team's work was automated. He applied to over a hundred support roles in two months and got two interviews. Then he changed tactics. He made a list of 25 local companies that sold complex equipment to businesses, figured they would need people who could explain technical things calmly, and messaged former colleagues to ask who they knew at each. Three weeks later, a friend of a friend at a medical equipment supplier mentioned they were about to hire a customer onboarding specialist. Tomasz had a conversation with the manager before the job was even posted. He started six weeks later.

A CV That Works for Humans and Machines

Your CV (called a résumé in North America) has two readers now: software that parses and ranks it, and a tired human who will spend perhaps a minute on a first look. The good news is that what helps one usually helps the other. Clear, simple, specific and honest wins both.

Formatting rules that keep the software happy

ATS-FRIENDLY FORMATTING

- [ ] A single column of text. No side-by-side columns, text boxes or tables for layout.
- [ ] Standard section headings: “Summary”, “Experience”, “Skills”, “Education”, “Certifications”.
- [ ] A common font (such as Arial, Calibri or Georgia) at 10–12 point for body text.
- [ ] Contact details in the main body, not in the header or footer, which some systems skip.
- [ ] No photos, logos, icons, skill “bars” or charts (in most countries; follow local norms).
- [ ] Dates in a consistent, simple format, such as “Mar 2021 – Jun 2026”.
- [ ] Save as .docx or a text-based PDF, unless the posting asks for a specific format.
- [ ] A sensible file name: “Firstname-Lastname-CV.pdf”, not “final_v7_REAL.pdf”.
- [ ] Two pages is fine for experienced candidates; one page for early career.

A sample outline

Here is a structure that works in most fields and countries. Adapt the order to your situation. If you are changing careers, for example, a strong “Relevant Skills” or “Selected Projects” section can come before your work history.

Section	What goes in it	Example
Name and contact	Name, city and country (no full address needed), phone, email, one portfolio or profile link.	Amara Okafor · Leeds, UK · 07xxx · amara.okafor@email.com · portfolio link
Headline	The role you are targeting, in the employer's language.	Operations Coordinator | Scheduling, Supplier Management, Process Improvement
Summary	Three or four lines: who you are, what you are good at, one standout result, what you want next.	Operations professional with 9 years in logistics. Cut late deliveries by 30% by redesigning the dispatch schedule. Looking to bring calm, organised coordination to a growing distribution team.
Skills	8–15 skills that genuinely describe you and match the role. Mix tools, methods and domain knowledge.	Route planning · Excel (pivot tables) · Supplier negotiation · Inventory systems · Team scheduling · AI-assisted reporting
Experience	Most recent first. Job title, employer, location, dates. Three to six bullet points per role, each starting with a verb and showing a result.	Reduced stock-outs from weekly to twice a year by setting up reorder alerts across 3 warehouses.
Projects (optional)	Recent courses, portfolio projects, volunteer work. Very useful for career changers and gaps.	Built a shift-planning spreadsheet for a local food bank, saving volunteers 4 hours a week.
Education and certifications	Degrees, diplomas, licences, recent certificates. Leave out graduation years if you prefer.	Google Data Analytics Certificate (2026) · HGV Class C licence

Writing bullet points that prove something

The single biggest upgrade most CVs need is turning duties into results. A duty says what you were supposed to do. A result says what happened because you did it. Use the achievements bank you built in Chapter 8.

A simple formula: **Action verb + what you did + result (with a number if possible)**.

DUTY (WEAK)

- Responsible for customer complaints.
- Handled month-end reports.
- Trained new staff.
- Worked on the company website.

RESULT (STRONG)

- Resolved 40+ escalated complaints a month; kept repeat-complaint rate under 5%.
- Cut month-end reporting from 4 days to 1.5 by building a template and checklist.
- Trained 18 new staff; designed a buddy system that shortened time-to-independence by two weeks.
- Rewrote 30 product pages; enquiries through the site rose noticeably over the next quarter.

Do not have exact numbers? Use honest estimates (“about”, “roughly”, “more than”) or scale words: how many people, how much money, how often, how many locations. You must be able to explain any number in an interview, so never inflate.

Matching keywords honestly

For each application you care about, read the posting and pick out the five to ten most important requirements. Then check: does your CV clearly show each one that is true for you, using words the employer would recognise?

Often the gap is just vocabulary. You might say “handled customer accounts” when they say “account management”. You might say “made the rota” when they say “workforce scheduling”. Translating your real experience into their language is not lying. It is helping them see what is already there. Claiming a skill you do not have is lying, and it tends to collapse in the first interview.

DO THIS NOW

1. Open your current CV and a job posting you like.
2. Highlight the top eight requirements in the posting.
3. For each one, find the line in your CV that proves it. Mark any that are missing or buried.
4. Rewrite your three weakest bullet points using the action + result formula.

Using AI to Tailor Without Sounding Generic or Lying

AI assistants can save you hours on applications. They can also make you sound exactly like everyone else, or quietly add claims that are not true. Here is how to get the benefit without the harm. Chapter 7 covers the basics of prompting and checking AI output; this is the job-search version.

Good uses

- **Finding the gaps.** Paste in the job description and your CV and ask: "Which requirements in this posting are not clearly shown in my CV? Do not rewrite anything yet."
- **Translating your language.** "Here is a bullet point from my CV. Suggest three ways to phrase it using terms common in [target industry], without adding any claims."
- **Drafting from your facts.** Give it your real achievements and ask for a first draft of a summary or cover letter. Then rewrite it in your own voice.
- **Practice and feedback.** "Act as a hiring manager for this role. What would worry you about this CV?"
- **Research.** Summarising a company's recent news or products before you tailor your application (verify the facts yourself).

How to keep it honest and human

- **Feed it facts, not wishes.** Tell it explicitly: "Use only the information I have given you. Do not invent numbers, tools or responsibilities."
- **Check every line.** AI often adds plausible details, such as a software you never used or a percentage you never mentioned. Delete anything you can-

not defend.

- **Cut the clichés.** Watch for phrases like “results-driven professional”, “passionate about leveraging”, “dynamic environment”, “I am thrilled to apply”. Recruiters now read these hundreds of times a day.
- **Add one thing only you could say.** A specific reason you want this company, a detail from a conversation with someone there, a real story. This is what makes an application feel human.
- **Read it aloud.** If it does not sound like something you would say to a person, rewrite it.
- **Mind your privacy.** Remove your phone number, address and anything sensitive before pasting documents into a public AI tool, and check its data settings.

SCRIPT: A TAILORING PROMPT YOU CAN REUSE

I am applying for the role below. I will paste the job description, then my current CV.

Step 1: List the 8 most important requirements in the job description.

Step 2: For each, quote the line in my CV that best shows it, or say “not shown”.

Step 3: For any requirement marked “not shown” that I might actually have, ask me a question to find out. Do not assume.

Rules: Use only facts I provide. Do not invent tools, numbers or responsibilities. Keep my plain, direct style. Avoid buzzwords.

[Job description]

[My CV]

Cover letters in 2026

Many employers no longer read cover letters closely, partly because so many are AI-generated. But a short, specific one can still help, especially for smaller organisations, career changes, or when a posting asks for one. Keep it to three short paragraphs: why this company (something specific), what you would bring (one or two concrete results), and a simple close. Under 250 words is plenty.

A Weekly Job-Search System

Job searching without structure tends to swing between frantic days and frozen ones. A weekly system smooths that out. It also protects you from the trap of spending every waking hour on it, which leads to burnout and, oddly, worse results.

A sustainable full-time search is often around 20 to 30 focused hours a week, not 60. If you are working, caring for family or dealing with health issues, even 5 to 10 hours a week, done consistently, can work. Use the split below as a starting point and adjust it.

Activity	Share of search time	What it includes
Outreach and networking	About 40%	Messages to contacts, informational chats, follow-ups, community events (Chapter 12)
Targeted applications	About 25%	Researching and tailoring 3–8 strong applications a week
Skill-building and proof	About 25%	Courses, practice, portfolio projects, case studies (Chapters 10 and 13)
Admin and review	About 10%	Updating your tracker, planning next week, checking benefits requirements
Rest and recovery	Protected, not optional	At least one full day off; daily movement, sleep, time with people (Chapter 4)

A sample week (about 25 hours)

1. **Monday: plan and research (4 hours).** Review last week's tracker. Choose this week's target roles and people. Check A-list careers pages.
2. **Tuesday: outreach (5 hours).** Send 5–10 personal messages. Follow up on anyone who has not replied in a week. Schedule chats.
3. **Wednesday: applications (5 hours).** Two or three carefully tailored applications. For each, try to find one person at the company to message too.

4. **Thursday: skills and proof (5 hours).** Work on your course or portfolio project. Publish or share one piece of progress if you can.
5. **Friday: conversations and wrap-up (4 hours).** Informational chats, interviews, thank-you notes. Update your tracker and note one thing you learned.
6. **Weekend: rest (at least one full day).** Optional light task: attend one community event or meetup.

> **TIP**
>
> Many unemployment benefit programs require you to log job-search activity, such as a certain number of applications or contacts each week. Rules vary a lot by country and region (for example, state programs in the US, Universal Credit in the UK, Employment Insurance in Canada, or Workforce Australia). Check your local requirements and make sure your tracker records what they need, so one log does both jobs.

Tracking: Your Search Dashboard

A tracker turns a fog of activity into something you can see and improve. It stops opportunities from slipping through the cracks, reminds you when to follow up, and lets you spot patterns. A spreadsheet is fine. So is a notebook.

WORKSHEET 11.2 — JOB-SEARCH TRACKER

Organisation and role	Date and type of contact (applied / message / chat / interview)	Person and next step	Follow-up date and status

Organisation and role	Date and type of contact (applied / message / chat / interview)	Person and next step	Follow-up date and status

The weekly review

Every Friday, spend 20 minutes looking back. Count three numbers: messages sent, conversations had, and applications submitted. Then ask what led to conversations. After four to six weeks, patterns usually appear. Maybe referrals get replies and cold applications do not. Maybe one type of role responds and another never does. Shift your time toward what works.

WORKSHEET 11.3 — WEEKLY REVIEW

Question	This week
Personal messages sent	
Real conversations (calls, chats, meetings)	
Tailored applications submitted	
Interviews or next steps	
Hours on skills or portfolio	
What led to a conversation this week?	
What will I do more of next week?	
What will I stop or do less of?	
Did I take a full day off? How is my energy (1–10)?	

Handling Rejection and Silence

This is the hardest part. You will be rejected, sometimes after several rounds. You will be ghosted, sometimes after an interview that felt great. Much of this has nothing to do with you: budgets get frozen, internal candidates appear, a manager leaves, a role is quietly cancelled. You rarely find out.

That does not make it hurt less. But it can help to separate the event ("I didn't get this job") from the story you tell yourself about it ("nobody will ever hire me"). The event is real. The story is usually not.

Practical ways to cope

- **Keep several things moving.** When you have five live conversations, one rejection stings less. Pipelines protect your mood.
- **Set a follow-up rule and then let go.** Follow up once after a week, once more after another week or two, then mark it closed in your tracker and move on.
- **Ask for feedback, lightly.** After an interview, it is reasonable to ask: "Is there anything I could do to be a stronger candidate for roles like this in future?" Many will not answer. Some will, and it can be gold.
- **Count effort, not just outcomes.** You control messages sent and skills practised. You do not control the hiring budget at a company you have never visited.
- **Limit the checking.** Check email at set times, not every ten minutes.
- **Talk to someone.** A friend, a job club, a peer group from your old workplace. Shame grows in isolation. See Chapter 4 for more support, including when to seek professional help.

SCRIPT: GRACIOUS REPLY TO A REJECTION

Hi [Name],

Thank you for letting me know, and for the time you and the team spent with me. I enjoyed learning about [specific project or challenge] and I'm still very interested in [Company].

If a similar role opens up in future, I'd love to be considered. And if you have a moment to share any feedback that would help me improve, I'd be grateful.

Best wishes,
[Your name]

This reply takes two minutes and leaves a good impression. Second-choice candidates are often contacted when the first choice falls through or when another role opens.

A STORY

Illustrative composite. Priya, 29, a former content writer in Toronto, had three final-round rejections in one month. After the third, she sent a short thank-you reply and asked for feedback. The hiring manager wrote back: the team had loved her, but the person they chose had direct experience with their industry's regulations. Two months later, that same manager referred her to a colleague at a partner firm who needed someone exactly like her. It was not the job she lost. It was better.

When a rejection arrives, what story do you usually tell yourself? What would you say to a friend in the same situation?

When to change your approach

Persistence matters, but so does adjustment. If you have been searching steadily for six to eight weeks with almost no conversations, something in the system probably needs to change. Look at your tracker and ask:

- Am I aiming at roles where I am a realistic fit, or mostly stretch roles? (Revisit Chapter 9.)
- Is my CV clearly showing the top requirements? Ask someone in your target field to look at it for two minutes.
- Am I spending most of my time on applications and too little on people?
- Do I have visible proof of my skills? (Chapter 13.)
- Am I getting interviews but not offers? Then the issue is likely interview practice (Chapter 14).

REMEMBER

- Mass applying fails because everyone can do it now. Fewer, better applications plus real conversations beat volume.
- Applicant tracking systems mostly sort and search. Make your CV simple to read and honestly matched to the role. Skip the tricks.
- Start from a list of 20–40 target organisations, not from job boards.
- Turn duties into results, with numbers where you can defend them.
- Use AI to find gaps and draft from your facts, then check every line and add your own voice.
- Run a weekly system with protected rest, track your activity, and review what leads to conversations.
- Rejection and silence are part of the process, and usually not a verdict on you.

Your next step: Write down ten organisations you would genuinely like to work for in Worksheet 11.1, and next to each, one person you know who might know someone there.

CHAPTER 12

Networking Without Feeling Fake

A practical, honest way to reconnect with people, ask for help, and build relationships that lead to work, with ready-to-use scripts for every situation.

For many people, the word “networking” brings up a picture of name badges, forced small talk and someone pressing a business card into your hand. If that makes you want to hide, you are in good company. But the kind of networking that actually helps people find work looks nothing like that.

Real networking is mostly this: talking to people you already know, being honest about what you are looking for, asking good questions, and helping others when you can. It is slow, human and often quite pleasant. In a job market crowded with AI-generated applications, it has become one of the most reliable ways in. This chapter shows you how to do it in a way that feels like you.

Why Relationships Matter More Now

Chapter 11 explained the problem: when every candidate can generate a polished application in seconds, a CV alone tells an employer very little. What hiring managers lack is not applicants. It is trust. They want to know that a person is real, capable and reliable.

A personal recommendation provides that trust instantly. “I worked with her for three years, she is excellent” cuts through a pile of five hundred applications. Even a lighter connection (“I had coffee with him last week, he seems sharp and knows the sector”) moves you from stranger to someone worth a look.

This is not unfair favouritism. It is people using the best information they have. Your job is to make sure the right people have good information about you.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> Networking is not asking strangers for jobs. It is letting people who could help you know what you are looking for, learning from them, and staying in touch. Most opportunities come from people who are one or two steps away from you, not from the famous person you have never met.

Reframing the discomfort

Much of the awkwardness comes from three beliefs. It is worth looking at each one.

THE BELIEF

- "I'm bothering people."
- "It's using people. It feels transactional."
- "I have nothing to offer right now."
- "People will judge me for being out of work."

A MORE ACCURATE VIEW

- Most people like being asked for advice. A short, specific request is easy to say yes or no to.
- It is only transactional if you disappear afterwards. Staying in touch and helping back makes it a relationship.
- You have attention, curiosity, gratitude, skills and contacts of your own. These all count.
- Job loss from automation is widespread. Many people you talk to have been through it, or fear it.

Mapping Your Warm Network

Your "warm network" is everyone who would recognise your name and probably reply to a message. It is usually much bigger than people think. Most adults know a few hundred people at least loosely, and many of them know people at the organisations on your target list.

Research on job-finding has long suggested that "weak ties", meaning acquaintances rather than close friends, are often especially useful, because they move in different circles and hear about different opportunities. So do not only think about your best friends. Think about the neighbour you chat with, your old manager's manager, the parent you see at school pickup.

Where to look

- **Work:** former colleagues, managers, people you managed, clients, suppliers, contractors, people from other departments.
- **Education:** classmates, teachers, alumni from your school, college, university or training program.
- **Community:** neighbours, faith communities, sports clubs, volunteer groups, parents of your children's friends.

- **Personal:** family, extended family, friends, friends of friends, your partner's network.
- **Services:** your accountant, doctor, hairdresser, mechanic, anyone who meets lots of people professionally.
- **Online:** professional networking sites, past online communities, people who commented on your work.

WORKSHEET 12.1 — WARM NETWORK MAP

Name	How I know them	Warmth (1–3) and what they might know	Contacted? Date and outcome

Use a simple warmth score: **3** means they would happily take your call; **2** means they would remember you and probably reply; **1** means a loose connection. Start your outreach with the 3s and 2s. They will give you confidence, practice and often introductions to people further away.

DO THIS NOW

1. Set a timer for 20 minutes.
2. Write down every name you can think of from your last two jobs. Then your education. Then your community.
3. Do not judge whether they are "useful" yet. Just list.
4. Go back and circle five people who would be glad to hear from you. Those are this week's messages.

Being Clear About What You Want

Before you contact anyone, get clear on what you are asking for. People can only help with a specific request. "Let me know if you hear of anything" puts all the work on them and is easily forgotten.

Write a short, plain description of what you are looking for. This is sometimes called an "elevator pitch", but it does not need to be slick. It just needs to be clear.

SCRIPT: YOUR TWO-SENTENCE INTRODUCTION

I spent [number] years in [field or role], mostly [what you were best at]. I'm now looking for [type of role] at [type of organisation], ideally somewhere [one thing that matters to you, e.g., "that's growing" or "close to home"].

Example: "I spent eight years in payroll for a retail chain, mostly fixing the problems nobody else could untangle. I'm now looking for payroll or finance operations roles at mid-sized healthcare or education employers in the Brisbane area."

Small asks, not big ones

The size of your request matters. A big ask ("Can you get me a job?") is hard to say yes to. A small ask is easy. Good small asks include:

- A 20-minute call to hear about their work or sector.
- Feedback on your CV or your direction.
- The name of one person they think you should talk to.

- Whether they would mind keeping you in mind if they hear of something specific.
- A quick read of a job posting at their company: “Does this team seem like a good fit for someone like me?”

Outreach Scripts

The scripts below are starting points. Change the words so they sound like you. Short is better: most good outreach messages are under 120 words. Always make it easy to say no.

SCRIPT: RECONNECTING WITH A FORMER COLLEAGUE

Hi [Name],

It’s been a while! I hope things are going well at [their company]. I still think about [shared memory or project].

I wanted to let you know that my role at [old company] was cut in the recent changes, and I’m now looking for [type of role]. You always had a good read on the industry, so I’d really value 20 minutes of your perspective on where things are heading and where someone with my background might fit.

Would you be up for a quick call in the next couple of weeks? Totally understand if things are busy.

[Your name]

SCRIPT: ALUMNI OR SHARED-GROUP MESSAGE

Hi [Name],

I noticed we both [studied at X / were part of Y group / trained with Z program]. I saw that you work in [role] at [company], which is exactly the kind of work I’m moving toward after [brief background].

Would you be open to a 20-minute chat about how you got into it and what the work is really like? I’m not asking about specific openings, just trying to learn from people who know the field.

Thanks for considering it,
[Your name]

SCRIPT: COLD MESSAGE TO SOMEONE YOU HAVE NOT MET

Hi [Name],

I read your [post / article / talk] on [topic] and found the point about [specific detail] really useful. It matched what I saw in [your experience].

I'm a [your background] exploring roles in [their field]. If you have 15 minutes sometime in the next few weeks, I'd love to ask you two or three questions about how the work is changing. If not, no problem at all, and thanks for sharing your thinking publicly.

[Your name]

SCRIPT: ASKING FOR AN INTRODUCTION

Hi [Name],

Thank you again for our chat. You mentioned [Person] at [Company] might be good to talk to. Would you be comfortable introducing us? To make it easy, here is a short note you could forward:

"[Your name] has [number] years in [field] and is exploring [type of role]. They'd appreciate 20 minutes of your perspective on [topic]. No pressure at all."

Of course, if it doesn't feel right, I completely understand.

[Your name]

SCRIPT: FOLLOW-UP WHEN YOU HAVE HAD NO REPLY

Hi [Name],

Just bringing this back to the top of your inbox in case it got buried. I know how busy things get. Still happy to work around your schedule if a short chat is possible. If now isn't a good time, no worries at all.

[Your name]

Send one follow-up about a week after your first message. If there is still no reply after a second gentle nudge a week or two later, let it go. Silence usually means busy, not rude.

SCRIPT: THANK-YOU AFTER A CONVERSATION

Hi [Name],

Thank you so much for your time today. Your point about [specific thing they said] really changed how I'm thinking about [topic]. I'm going to [action you will take because of it].

I'll let you know how it goes. And if there's ever anything I can help with, such as [a skill or contact you have], please just ask.

[Your name]

WATCH OUT

It is tempting to have an AI tool write and send dozens of outreach messages for you. Resist that. Mass-produced messages are easy to spot, and people increasingly ignore them. Use AI to help you brainstorm or tighten a draft, but every message should contain at least one specific, true detail that shows you actually know who you are writing to.

Informational Interviews

An informational interview is a short conversation where you learn about someone's work, field or organisation. You are not asking for a job, and you should mean that. You are gathering information, building a relationship, and letting someone get to know you.

They are useful for three reasons. You learn what a job is really like before you commit to it (a good test for the paths in Chapter 9). You learn the language and priorities of the field, which improves your applications. And you become known to someone who may later think of you when a role comes up.

How to run one

1. **Prepare (15 minutes).** Read their professional profile and their company's website. Write down three to five questions. Know your two-sentence introduction.

2. **Open warmly (2 minutes).** Thank them, confirm how much time they have, and give your short introduction.
3. **Ask and listen (12–15 minutes).** Ask your questions. Follow their energy. Listen more than you talk. Take brief notes.
4. **Close well (3 minutes).** Ask who else you should talk to. Ask if there is anything you can help them with. Watch the time and finish on schedule.
5. **Follow up (same day).** Send a thank-you note. Record the conversation in your tracker (Worksheet 11.2).

Questions to choose from

Topic	Questions
Their path	How did you get into this work? What would you do differently if you were starting now?
The real job	What does a typical week look like? What is the hardest part? What do people misunderstand about it?
Change and AI	How has AI changed your team's work in the last year or two? Which skills have become more valuable? Which less?
Hiring	When your team hires, what makes someone stand out? What are the red flags? How do most people get hired there?
Fit	Given my background in [X], where do you think I would be most useful? What gaps would I need to close?
Learning	Which courses, certificates or experiences are actually respected in this field? Which are a waste of money?
The sector	Which organisations are growing? Who is doing interesting work? Are there any communities or events I should know about?
Next steps	Who else would you recommend I talk to? Would you be comfortable introducing us?

TIP

The best question in almost any informational chat is: "Who else should I talk to?" Each conversation can open two or three more. After ten or so conversations in a field, you will often find you are hearing about roles before they are advertised.

A STORY

Illustrative composite. Grace, 56, had worked in a bank's back office in Nairobi for twenty years before her department was automated. She wanted to move into training, but did not know where to start. She asked her nephew's former teacher for a chat, who introduced her to a learning coordinator at a hospital. That coordinator explained that the hospital struggled to train staff on its new digital systems and needed patient, clear explainers. Grace had trained new bank staff for years. Four conversations later, she was invited to run a pilot training session. It became a part-time contract, and then a permanent role.

Communities, Meetups and Professional Associations

Beyond one-to-one conversations, groups are a powerful way to meet many people in your target field. They also give you structure and company during a lonely time. You do not need to join everything. Pick one or two and show up consistently.

Type of community	Examples	Why it helps
Professional associations	Bodies for HR, accounting, project management, nursing, teaching, engineering, trades	Job boards, mentoring, events, credentials. Many offer reduced fees for people who are unemployed; ask.
Local meetups	Small business groups, tech or AI meetups, chamber of commerce events, trade breakfasts	Face-to-face contact with local employers and peers.

Type of community	Examples	Why it helps
Online communities	Industry forums, chat groups, professional networking groups, subject-specific discussion boards	Easy to join, good for learning and visibility. Contribute, do not just lurk.
Alumni networks	School, college, university, bootcamp or apprenticeship alumni groups	Shared identity makes people more willing to help.
Job clubs and support groups	Groups run by public employment services, libraries, charities, faith groups	Accountability, emotional support, shared leads.
Volunteering	Boards of local nonprofits, community events, skilled volunteering	You work alongside people and they see your skills in action.

Public employment services in many countries run free workshops and networking events: for example, American Job Centers in the US, Jobcentre Plus in the UK, Service Canada and provincial employment centres in Canada, and Workforce Australia providers. Local libraries are often an underrated source of free events, too. Check what exists near you.

How to show up at an event without dread

- **Set a tiny goal.** Two real conversations, then you can leave.
- **Arrive early.** It is easier to talk when the room is quiet than to break into groups later.
- **Ask about them.** “What brings you here?” and “What are you working on at the moment?” work almost everywhere.
- **Look for the other person standing alone.** They will probably be relieved.
- **Follow up within 48 hours.** A short message mentioning what you talked about.

Giving First

The fastest way to stop networking from feeling fake is to make it two-way. When you help people, you are no longer just asking. You are part of a community. And people remember those who helped them.

You have more to give than you think, even while out of work:

WAYS TO GIVE, EVEN NOW

- [ ] Share a useful article, tool or job posting with someone who would value it.
- [ ] Introduce two people who should know each other.
- [ ] Write a short, honest recommendation for a former colleague on a professional network.
- [ ] Answer a question in an online community, drawing on your experience.
- [ ] Offer an hour of your skills to a small business or nonprofit.
- [ ] Pass along a role that does not suit you but suits someone you know.
- [ ] Congratulate people on new jobs, promotions or launches. Sincerely.
- [ ] Help a newer job seeker with what you have learned from this book.

You are not only someone who needs help. You are also someone who can give it, and that is often what people remember.

Following Up and Staying in Touch

Most networking value comes not from the first conversation but from staying connected over months. Someone who did not have a role for you in March may have one in July. The people who keep in touch lightly and regularly are the ones who get remembered.

A simple keep-in-touch rhythm

- **After a conversation:** thank-you note the same day.
- **After you act on their advice:** a short update two to four weeks later. (“I took that course you mentioned, and it was exactly right.”)
- **Every two to three months:** a light touch: an article, a congratulation, a quick progress update.
- **When you land a role:** tell everyone who helped and thank them. This closes the loop and keeps the relationship alive for the future.

SCRIPT: PROGRESS UPDATE A FEW WEEKS LATER

Hi [Name],

A quick update since we spoke: I followed your advice and [action, e.g., “reached out to Sam at the regional health board” or “finished the bookkeeping certificate”]. It led to [result, even a small one]. Thank you again for pointing me in that direction.

No need to reply. I just wanted you to know it made a difference.

[Your name]

TIP

Add a “next contact” date to each person in your network map. A recurring calendar reminder once a week (“Send three keep-in-touch notes”) takes ten minutes and keeps your network warm without much effort.

If you are introverted, anxious or out of practice

Networking does not require being outgoing. Written messages, one-to-one calls and small groups suit many quieter people better than large events. Preparation helps: write your questions in advance, and remember that listening well is a rare and valued skill. If social anxiety is getting in the way of your search, it may help to talk to a counsellor or doctor (see Chapter 4). This is common and very treatable.

Who is one person you have been avoiding contacting? What is the smallest, easiest message you could send them this week?

REMEMBER

- In a market flooded with AI-generated applications, trust and personal recommendations matter more than ever.
- Your warm network is bigger than you think. Map it, and start with the people who would be glad to hear from you.
- Be specific about what you want, and make small asks that are easy to say yes to.
- Informational interviews help you learn, test a path and become known. Always ask who else to talk to.
- Join one or two communities and show up consistently.
- Give first and give often. It turns networking into relationships.
- Follow up, keep in touch lightly, and close the loop when you land somewhere.

Your next step: Send one reconnection message today to a former colleague with a warmth score of 3, using the first script in this chapter.

CHAPTER 13

Proof Over Promises: Portfolios and Public Work

How to show what you can do instead of just saying it, in any profession, with templates and project ideas you can finish in two weeks.

Anyone can now write “excellent communicator, detail-oriented, proficient in AI tools” on a CV. Software can write it for them in a second. Because those words cost nothing, they have lost much of their value. What still carries weight is evidence: something real that shows you can do the work.

This chapter is about building that evidence. You do not need to be a designer or a programmer to have a portfolio. A plumber, a care worker, an administrator, a salesperson and a teacher can all show proof of their skill. Often it takes

less time than you fear, and it can make a bigger difference to your search than another hundred applications.

Why Proof Matters More Than Ever

Hiring has always involved a leap of faith. An employer meets you for a few hours and has to guess how you will perform for years. CVs, interviews and references all try to reduce that risk. In 2026, two of those signals have become weaker. CVs are easy to polish with AI, and interview answers can be rehearsed with AI coaching.

Proof of work is harder to fake, especially when you can talk through it in detail. When you show a hiring manager a process you redesigned, a project you built, or a lesson plan that worked, you give them something concrete to evaluate. You also give them something to talk about in the interview, which shifts the conversation from “Tell me about yourself” to “Tell me how you did this.”

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> A portfolio is not a showcase of perfect work. It is a small collection of real examples, each with a short explanation of the problem, what you did and what happened. Three good examples, clearly explained, beat thirty unlabelled ones.

When words are cheap, evidence becomes the currency of trust.

What Counts as Proof in Your Field

Proof looks different in every profession. The question to ask is: “If I were hiring for this role, what would convince me that someone could actually do it?” Here are examples across many fields. Use them to spark ideas, and always respect privacy and confidentiality rules from your past jobs.

Field	Forms of proof
Skilled trades (electrical, plumbing, carpentry, HVAC, mechanics)	Before-and-after photos of jobs, licences and certifications, logbooks of hours, a short video explaining a repair, customer reviews, a list of job types handled
Care work (elder care, disability support, childcare, nursing assistance)	Certificates (first aid, manual handling, safeguarding), written references from families or supervisors (with permission), a reflective account of how you handled a difficult situation, training you have delivered to others
Administration and operations	Anonymised templates, checklists or process maps you created, a before-and-after of a filing or scheduling system, a short write-up of a process you made faster
Sales and customer success	Results summaries (targets met, accounts grown, retention), anonymised examples of proposals or outreach sequences, a short account plan for a target company, testimonials
Teaching and training	Lesson plans, training materials, a short recorded lesson, student or participant feedback (anonymised), a curriculum outline you designed
Finance and bookkeeping	A model or reconciliation template with fake data, a case study of a process improvement, a clear explainer you wrote for non-finance colleagues
Hospitality and retail	Photos of displays or events you organised, customer reviews mentioning you, a training guide for new staff, a cost or waste reduction you achieved
Writing, content and translation	Published samples, before-and-after edits, a niche specialism (for example, medical or legal), examples of editing and fact-checking AI-generated drafts
Tech, data and design	Projects with code or files available, dashboards, case studies of design decisions, contributions to open-source or community projects
Management and leadership	A case study of a team turnaround, a hiring or onboarding process you built, a one-page strategy you wrote (with confidential details removed)

WATCH OUT

Never share confidential information from a former employer: client names, internal figures, private documents or personal data about customers, patients or students. Anonymise everything, recreate examples using made-up data, or describe the work without showing the original. If you signed a confidentiality agreement, check what it covers. When in doubt, leave it out or ask permission.

Proof you may already have

Before you create anything new, look at what you already own. Many people are sitting on proof without realising it.

GATHER WHAT ALREADY EXISTS

- [ ] Thank-you emails or messages from customers, colleagues or managers (screenshot or save them, remove private details).
- [ ] Performance reviews with positive comments.
- [ ] Awards, certificates, licences and course completions.
- [ ] Photos of work you did (where permitted).
- [ ] Templates, guides or tools you created that are not confidential.
- [ ] Results you can describe from your achievements bank (Chapter 8).
- [ ] Articles, posts or talks you have given, even internal ones.
- [ ] Volunteer work, side projects or community roles.

The Case Study: Your Most Powerful Tool

A case study is a short story about a piece of work. It explains the situation, what you did, and what changed. It works in every profession, it can be written in under an hour, and it gives interviewers exactly what they want: evidence of how you think.

A good case study is short, between 300 and 700 words, or a single page. It can include a picture, a chart or a sample. It should be written in plain language that someone outside your field can follow.

WORKSHEET 13.1 — CASE STUDY TEMPLATE

Section	Prompt	Your notes
Title	A short, specific headline. "Cutting patient wait times at a busy clinic front desk."	
Context	Where was this? What kind of organisation, team or client? (Anonymise as needed.)	
Problem	What was wrong, slow, risky or missing? Why did it matter?	
Your role	What were you responsible for? Who else was involved?	
What you did	The key steps, decisions and trade-offs. Include any tools, including AI.	
Obstacles	What went wrong or was hard, and how did you handle it?	
Result	What changed? Use numbers, before and after, or feedback.	
What you learned	What would you do differently? What does this show about how you work?	
Evidence	A photo, template, chart, quote or sample that backs it up.	

A STORY

Illustrative composite. Luis, 41, worked as a warehouse supervisor in Valencia before the site introduced automated picking robots and cut supervisory roles. He felt he had "nothing to show", since his work was all on the floor. A friend helped him write two one-page case studies: one about reducing picking errors by redesigning shelf labels, one about training staff to work safely alongside the new robots. He added photos of the labels (with no company branding) and a short safety checklist he had written. In his next interview, for an operations role at a food distributor, the manager spent most of the time asking about the robot safety training. They had robots arriving next year.

Using AI to help with case studies

AI tools can help you get started if writing is not your strength. Tell it the story out loud or in rough notes, then ask it to organise your notes into the template above. Then edit carefully. Check that every fact is yours and true, cut any exag-

geration, and make sure it sounds like you. Mentioning how you used AI in the work itself (for example, “I used an AI assistant to draft the first version of the training guide, then tested and corrected it with three staff members”) can also show the AI fluency employers look for (Chapter 7).

Two-Week Portfolio Projects by Field

If you do not have enough existing proof, or you are moving into a new field, create some. A small, focused project done well can stand in for experience you do not have yet. It also gives you something fresh to talk about and share.

Good projects are **small** (finishable in about two weeks of part-time effort), **relevant** (they solve a problem your target employers actually have) and **visible** (you can show the result in a page or a short video).

Target field	Two-week project ideas
Operations and admin	Design a clear onboarding checklist and welcome pack for a fictional small business. Map and improve a common process (such as handling a refund) and show before and after. Build a shared scheduling template for a volunteer group.
Customer success and sales	Write an account plan for a real company you would like to sell to, using public information. Create a help-centre article set for a local business’s top five customer questions. Draft and test a follow-up email sequence.
Bookkeeping and finance	Build a monthly budget and cash-flow template for a sole trader, with instructions. Reconcile a sample set of fake transactions and document your method. Write a plain-language guide to a tax deadline in your country.
Teaching and training	Design a one-hour workshop on a skill you know well, with slides and a handout. Record a ten-minute lesson. Create a beginner’s guide to using an AI assistant safely for older adults.
Care and health support	Complete a recognised short course and write a reflection on what you learned. Create a family-friendly guide to local care resources. Volunteer for a few shifts and gather a reference.
Skilled trades	Document a small project from start to finish with photos (a repair, a build, an installation for a friend or relative). Create a simple maintenance checklist for homeowners. Record a short explainer video.

Target field	Two-week project ideas
Marketing and communications	Offer to refresh one page of a local nonprofit's website or social media and measure the response. Write a launch plan for a fictional product. Audit a small business's online presence and give three recommendations.
Data and analysis	Take a public data set (from your government's open data portal, for example) and answer a real question with a simple chart and a one-page summary. Build a dashboard for a club or charity.
Project management	Plan a real community event from start to finish and document the plan, risks and lessons. Create a project template with a timeline and stakeholder map.
AI-adjacent roles	Build a simple AI-assisted workflow for a common task (for example, summarising customer feedback), document how you checked its accuracy, and note its limits. Write an AI use policy for a small business.

A two-week project plan

1. **Days 1–2: choose and scope.** Pick a project linked to a real problem in your target field. Write one sentence: "I will create [thing] so that [user] can [benefit]." Keep it small.
2. **Days 3–8: build.** Do the work in short daily sessions (one to two hours). Save drafts and take screenshots or photos as you go. These become part of the story.
3. **Days 9–10: test.** Show it to one or two people who would use it. Ask what is confusing or missing. Improve it.
4. **Days 11–12: write it up.** Use the case study template. Explain the problem, your process, what you learned and what you would do next.
5. **Days 13–14: share.** Add it to your portfolio, send it to two or three people from your network map, and mention it in relevant applications.

DO THIS NOW

Look at your target company list from Chapter 11. Pick one organisation and write down one problem they probably have that your skills could help with. That problem is a strong candidate for your first two-week project. Bonus: if you finish it, you have a natural reason to contact someone there.

Working for free: when it helps and when it doesn't

Small volunteer projects for nonprofits, community groups or friends' businesses can be a great source of proof and references. But be careful. A short, defined project you choose is fine. Ongoing unpaid work for a profitable company, or a "test task" that looks like real work they will use, is not. Set a clear scope and end date, and agree in advance that you can show the result in your portfolio.

Building a Simple Portfolio

Your portfolio does not need to be fancy. It needs to be easy to find, easy to scan, and easy to share. Choose the simplest format that suits your field.

Format	Best for	Notes
A shared document or PDF (2–8 pages)	Admin, finance, care, trades, sales, management	Easy to email and print. Bring a copy to interviews.
A professional networking profile with featured items	Almost everyone	Add case studies, certificates and links to the "featured" or projects area.
A simple personal website	Writing, design, marketing, teaching, consulting	Free and low-cost website builders work well. A personal domain name is a nice touch but optional.
A photo album or short videos	Trades, hospitality, events, crafts	Keep captions clear: what, where, your role, the result.
A code or file repository	Software, data, technical roles	Include a readable summary at the top of each project.

PORTFOLIO ESSENTIALS

- [ ] A short introduction: who you are, what you do, what you are looking for.
- [ ] Three to six examples, best first.
- [ ] Each example labelled with the problem, your role, and the result.
- [ ] A way to contact you.
- [ ] Nothing confidential, and permissions for anything involving other people.
- [ ] Checked on a phone as well as a computer.
- [ ] A link on your CV and in your email signature.
- [ ] Reviewed and updated every couple of months.

Writing and Teaching in Public

Beyond a portfolio, sharing what you know in public can be a slow but powerful way to build trust. When people see you explaining things clearly and helpfully, they start to think of you as someone who knows the subject. Over time, opportunities can come to you: requests for advice, invitations to talk, and sometimes job offers.

"Public" does not mean going viral. It means being visible to the small group of people who care about your field. Ten thoughtful readers in your industry are worth more than ten thousand random followers.

Ways to share that suit different people

- **Short posts on a professional network.** One lesson from your work, one tool you found useful, one mistake and what you learned.
- **Answers in communities.** Helping people in forums or groups in your field. Often the easiest start.
- **Learning in public.** Sharing your progress as you reskill: "Week 3 of my bookkeeping course. Here's the concept that finally clicked." This also shows commitment and honesty.
- **Teaching locally.** Running a free workshop at a library, community centre or job club. Teaching is one of the strongest signals of expertise (and one of

the human advantages from Chapter 6).

- **Longer articles or a newsletter.** For those who enjoy writing. Even a monthly piece builds up over a year.
- **Short videos or audio.** For those who prefer talking to writing, especially in trades and practical fields.

DO

- Share specific, practical lessons.
- Write in your own voice, even if you use AI to tidy up.
- Credit others and link to good sources.
- Be consistent, even if infrequent.
- Respond kindly to comments.

DON'T

- Post generic AI-written "thought leadership".
- Criticise former employers or colleagues.
- Share confidential details or other people's data.
- Chase engagement with outrage or hype.
- Pretend to expertise you do not have.

TIP

If posting publicly feels uncomfortable, start with "learning notes" that you share with just a few people from your network. Once you have written five, you will have material ready to share more widely, and a lot more confidence.

Staying safe in public

Visibility has risks too. Keep personal details such as your home address, your children's names and your daily routine off public profiles. Be aware that a public "open to work" signal can attract scammers as well as recruiters (Chapter 14 covers how to spot them). You can share professional work while keeping your personal life private.

A STORY

Illustrative composite. Hannah, 34, had been a translator in Leipzig for ten years when demand for her general translation work dropped sharply. She decided to specialise in medical device documentation, where accuracy and regulation matter. Every week, she posted a short note on her professional profile about a tricky term or a common machine-translation error she had spotted in medical texts, and how to fix it. After four months, a quality manager at a device company messaged her. They had been using AI translation and wanted a human expert to review it. It became her largest client.

Talking About Your Proof

Proof only helps if people see it. Here is how to bring it into your search without feeling like you are bragging.

- **In applications:** add one line linking to your most relevant case study. "I recently redesigned a volunteer scheduling system; you can see a short write-up here: [link]."
- **In outreach:** share a project as a natural reason to reach out. "I put together a short analysis of [problem your company faces]. Would you be interested in seeing it?"
- **In interviews:** bring printed copies or have them ready to share on screen. When asked a behavioural question, point to a case study as your example (see STAR stories in Chapter 14).
- **In follow-ups:** after an interview, send a short relevant example. "You mentioned onboarding was a challenge, so I attached a checklist I built for a similar situation."

SCRIPT: SHARING A PROJECT WITH A CONTACT

Hi [Name],

When we spoke last month, you mentioned [problem]. It stuck with me, so I spent some time putting together [short description of what you made]. It's a rough version, but I thought it might be useful, or at least interesting. Here it is: [link or attachment].

I'd genuinely welcome any feedback on what I got wrong or missed. Thanks again for the conversation.

[Your name]

Think of the piece of work you are proudest of from your career. What was the problem, what did you do, and how could you show it to someone today without breaking any confidentiality?

REMEMBER

- When CVs and claims are cheap, real evidence of your work builds trust.
- Every profession has forms of proof: photos, templates, case studies, references, lessons, results.
- Gather what you already have before creating anything new, and never share confidential material.
- A one-page case study (problem, action, result, lesson) works in any field.
- Small two-week projects aimed at real problems can stand in for missing experience.
- Keep your portfolio simple, short and easy to share.
- Writing or teaching in public, consistently and honestly, slowly brings opportunities to you.

Your next step: Fill in Worksheet 13.1 for one piece of work you are proud of. Do not polish it. Just get the facts down.

CHAPTER 14

Interviews, Offers and Job Scams

How to prepare for today's interview formats, answer the hard questions honestly, negotiate a fair offer, and protect yourself from the fake jobs that target people who are searching.

Getting an interview after weeks of searching can bring a rush of relief, quickly followed by nerves. That is normal. An interview is a performance under pressure, and you may be out of practice. The good news is that interviewing is a skill, and like any skill it improves with preparation.

This chapter walks you through the interview formats you are likely to meet in 2026, how to prepare stories that show your strengths, and how to handle difficult questions about AI, gaps, layoffs and age. Then it covers offers and negotiation. Finally, it gives you a detailed guide to job scams, which have become more common and more convincing. Please do not skip that last section. It could save you a great deal of money and distress.

Interview Formats You May Meet

Hiring processes now often include several stages and several formats. Knowing what to expect at each one lowers anxiety and helps you prepare the right way.

Format	What it is	How to prepare
Phone or video screen	A short call, usually with a recruiter, to check basics: interest, experience, salary range, availability.	Have your two-sentence introduction ready (Chapter 12). Know your salary range. Prepare one or two questions about the role.

Format	What it is	How to prepare
Asynchronous (one-way) video	You record answers to on-screen questions, often with a time limit, and no one is on the call.	Practise with a timer. Look at the camera, not the screen. Use good light and a quiet space. Some platforms let you do a practice question; always use it.
AI-led screening interview	An AI voice or chat "interviewer" asks set questions and may summarise or score your answers for a human recruiter.	Treat it like a real interview. Answer clearly and directly, using specific examples. Ask the employer how it is used and whether a human reviews results. Request adjustments if you need them.
Skills test or assessment	A practical test: typing, spreadsheet tasks, writing, coding, situational judgement, a mock customer call.	Ask what format it will be and whether AI tools are allowed. Practise similar tasks. Read instructions twice.
Panel interview	Several interviewers at once, often from different teams.	Learn their roles if you can. Make eye contact with everyone, not just the person who asked. Address different concerns (technical, team fit, business).
Work trial or take-home task	A paid or unpaid trial shift, project or task, from a few hours to a few days.	Clarify scope, time expected, and whether it is paid. A reasonable unpaid task is short (a few hours). Longer trials should usually be paid; local law may require it.
In-person interview	Face-to-face, sometimes with a site tour or meeting the team.	Plan your route and arrive ten minutes early. Bring printed copies of your CV and portfolio examples (Chapter 13).

TIP

If you have a disability, a health condition, or simply find a format difficult (for example, timed one-way video), you can ask for a reasonable adjustment, such as extra time, a live interview instead of a recorded one, or questions in advance. Many countries have laws that protect this right, such as the Americans with Disabilities Act in the US and the Equality Act in the UK. Ask early and in writing.

Questions to ask about AI in the process

It is reasonable to ask how an employer uses automated tools in hiring. Some places, such as New York City and parts of the EU under the AI Act, have introduced rules on automated hiring tools, and others are following. You might ask, politely: "Is any part of the assessment scored automatically? Will a person review my application?" The answer also tells you something about the organisation's culture.

Preparing Your Stories: The STAR Method

Most interviews include behavioural questions: "Tell me about a time when..." Interviewers ask these because past behaviour is a reasonable guide to future behaviour. The best way to answer is with a short, specific story. The STAR method gives that story a shape.

- **Situation:** where and when, in one or two sentences.
- **Task:** what you needed to achieve, or the problem.
- **Action:** what *you* did (say "I", not just "we"). This is the longest part.
- **Result:** what happened, ideally with a number, and what you learned.

A good STAR answer takes about one and a half to two minutes. Prepare six to eight stories that between them cover most common questions. One story can often answer several different questions.

WORKSHEET 14.1 — STAR STORY BANK

Theme	Situation and task	Action (what I did)	Result and lesson
A problem I solved			
A conflict or difficult person			
A mistake or failure			
Leading or influencing others			
Handling change or ambiguity			
Using technology or AI well			

Theme	Situation and task	Action (what I did)	Result and lesson
Going above and beyond for a customer			
Learning something new fast			

DO THIS NOW

1. Pick two rows from Worksheet 14.1 and fill them in using your achievements bank from Chapter 8.
2. Say each story out loud, timing yourself. Aim for under two minutes.
3. Record yourself on your phone once. Listen back for filler words and for whether the "Result" is clear.
4. Optional: ask an AI assistant to play an interviewer and ask follow-up questions on your story. Ignore any suggestions to make the story sound bigger than it was.

Other questions to prepare for

- **"Tell me about yourself."** Not your life story. Try: present (what you do and are good at), past (one or two relevant highlights), future (why this role). About one minute.
- **"Why do you want to work here?"** Be specific. Mention something you learned from research or a conversation with someone there.
- **"What are your weaknesses?"** Name a real but manageable one and what you are doing about it.
- **"Do you have any questions for us?"** Always have two or three. See the list later in this chapter.

Answering "How Do You Use AI?"

In 2026, this question comes up in interviews for almost every kind of job, from admin to nursing to marketing. Employers want to know two things: can you use these tools to work better, and do you have the judgement to use them safely and honestly? A good answer shows both.

Avoid two extremes. “I don’t really use it” can sound out of date. “I use AI for everything” can sound like you lack your own skills or judgement. Aim for the middle: specific uses, a clear method for checking, and awareness of limits.

SCRIPT: A STRONG ANSWER ABOUT AI USE

“I use AI tools as an assistant, not as a replacement for my own judgement. For example, in my last role I used [tool type, e.g., an AI chat assistant] to draft first versions of [task, e.g., customer replies or weekly reports]. That cut my drafting time roughly in half.

I always check the output: I verify any facts or numbers against the source, and I edit for tone, because it can sound generic. I never put confidential customer data into public tools; I follow the company’s policy on that.

Where I find it most valuable is [specific example]. Where I’m careful is [specific limit, e.g., anything legal or medical, where I always go to the original source]. I’d be keen to learn how your team uses these tools.”

If you have limited experience, be honest and show you are learning: “I’ve started using AI tools in the last few months, mainly for [example]. I’m still building my skills, and I’ve found the most important thing is checking its work carefully.” The 30-day plan in Chapter 7 gives you real examples to talk about.

WATCH OUT

Using AI to feed you answers live during an interview, or having an AI tool complete a skills test that is meant to assess you, is usually against the rules and often detectable. If you are caught, you will almost certainly lose the opportunity, and it can follow you. Use AI to prepare, practise and research. Then show up as yourself. If you are unsure whether tools are allowed in a test, ask.

Addressing Gaps, Layoffs and Age Honestly

Many readers worry about questions they feel they cannot answer well. The principle for all of them is the same: be honest, be brief, and steer toward the future. Interviewers mostly want to know that you are ready, reliable and interested in this job.

Being laid off

Layoffs linked to automation and restructuring are extremely common right now, and most interviewers know it. You do not need to apologise or over-explain. State it as a fact and move on.

SCRIPT: EXPLAINING A LAYOFF

"My role was one of [number / many] cut when the company automated much of [area of work]. I'm proud of what I did there, especially [one achievement]. It also gave me the push to [what you have done since, e.g., build my data skills or move toward operations], which is what led me to this role."

Never criticise your former employer, even if you feel badly treated. It makes interviewers wonder what you might say about them.

Employment gaps

Gaps are more common and more accepted than they used to be. Whether your gap is due to job searching, caregiving, illness, study or rest, you can describe it truthfully without sharing private details.

SCRIPT: EXPLAINING A GAP

"I took [time period] to [care for a family member / deal with a health matter that's now resolved / retrain]. During that time I [one or two constructive things: completed a course, volunteered, built a project]. I'm now fully ready to commit to a role, and this one is a strong fit because [reason]."

You do not have to disclose health details. "A personal matter that is now resolved" is a complete answer.

Age

Age discrimination is illegal in many countries (for example, under the Age Discrimination in Employment Act in the US, the Equality Act in the UK, and similar laws across the EU, Canada and Australia), but it still happens, often quietly. You cannot control prejudice, but you can reduce the opportunity for it and answer unspoken concerns.

COMMON UNSPOKEN WORRIES

- "Will they keep up with technology?"
- "Will they expect too much money?"
- "Will they take direction from a younger manager?"
- "Are they planning to retire soon?"

HOW TO ANSWER THEM

- Mention recent tools, courses and AI use naturally in your stories.
- Say you are flexible and focused on the right role, and discuss pay later in the process.
- Share a story about learning from or working well with younger colleagues.
- Express genuine interest in growth and the long term.

Practical steps: you can leave graduation dates off your CV and limit detailed work history to roughly the last 10 to 15 years. Show energy and curiosity. Your experience is an asset: judgement, calm under pressure, and the ability to handle difficult people are exactly the human strengths that AI does not replace (Chapter 6). Chapter 21 has more for workers over 50.

A STORY

Illustrative composite. Robert, 61, from Ohio, had been an insurance claims processor for 25 years before much of his department's work was automated. In his first few interviews, he felt he was being written off. He changed his approach: in every interview he told a short story about how he had helped test the new claims software, spotting errors the system made on unusual cases. He framed his experience as "I know where the automation goes wrong." A regional insurer hired him as a quality reviewer for their automated claims, a role that had not existed two years earlier.

Illegal or uncomfortable questions

In many places it is unlawful for interviewers to ask about age, marital status, pregnancy, religion, or similar personal characteristics. If you are asked, you can choose to answer briefly, redirect ("I can assure you that nothing would stop me committing fully to this role"), or politely decline. If it happens repeatedly or seriously, you can note it and seek advice from an employment rights body in your country.

Your Questions for Them

An interview is two-way. Good questions show interest and help you decide whether you actually want the job.

- What does success look like in this role after six months?
- What is the biggest challenge the team is facing right now?
- How is the team using AI and automation, and how do you expect this role to change?
- Why is this role open? (New role, or did someone leave?)
- How do people learn and grow here?
- What are the next steps in the process, and when should I expect to hear back?

Offers and Negotiation

When an offer arrives, pause. You do not need to accept on the spot, even if you badly need the job. It is normal and professional to say thank you and ask for a day or two to review the details in writing.

SCRIPT: RESPONDING TO A VERBAL OFFER

"Thank you so much, I'm really pleased. I'm very interested in the role. Could you send me the full offer in writing, including salary, benefits and start date? I'd like to review it properly and come back to you by [day]."

Knowing your number

Before any salary conversation, research the typical pay for the role in your area. Sources include salary surveys from recruitment agencies, government labour statistics (such as the US Bureau of Labor Statistics or the UK Office for National Statistics), job postings that list pay (now required in some places), professional associations, and people in your network. Decide three numbers: your ideal, your target, and your walk-away point, below which the job would not work for you financially (use your runway figures from Chapter 3).

Negotiation scripts

Negotiation feels risky when you are anxious about money, but a polite, well-reasoned request rarely causes an offer to be withdrawn. The worst usual outcome is "No, this is our final offer." Keep your tone warm and collaborative.

SCRIPT: WHEN ASKED FOR SALARY EXPECTATIONS EARLY

"I'd like to learn more about the role and responsibilities first. Could you share the budgeted range for this position?"

If pressed: "Based on my research and experience, I'm looking at roughly [range, with your target near the bottom]. I'm flexible depending on the whole package."

SCRIPT: ASKING FOR A HIGHER SALARY

"Thank you for the offer. I'm excited about the role and the team. Based on my research for similar roles in [area] and the experience I bring in [specific relevant skill], I was hoping for something closer to [number]. Is there flexibility there?"

Then stop talking and let them respond.

SCRIPT: WHEN SALARY CANNOT MOVE

"I understand the salary is fixed. Would there be flexibility on [one or two items: a sign-on payment, an earlier pay review at six months, extra leave, remote days, training budget, a later or earlier start date]?"

SCRIPT: ACCEPTING GRACEFULLY

"Thank you for working with me on this. I'm happy to accept the offer of [summarise terms]. Could you send the updated offer in writing? I'm looking forward to starting on [date]."

Do not resign from any other position or turn down other options until you have a written, signed offer and any conditions (such as background checks) are cleared.

Evaluating an offer

Salary is only one part of an offer. Before accepting, check the whole picture. Where contract terms are unclear or unusual, consider asking an employment adviser, union, or lawyer to look at it.

OFFER CHECKLIST

- [ ] Base pay, how often it is paid, and whether overtime is paid.
- [ ] Bonus, commission or variable pay: how it is calculated and how realistic it is.
- [ ] Health coverage, pension or retirement contributions, sick leave and parental leave.
- [ ] Paid holiday or vacation days.
- [ ] Hours, schedule, location, and remote or hybrid arrangements, in writing.
- [ ] Employment type: permanent, fixed-term, contractor, or agency. This affects your rights and taxes.
- [ ] Probation period and notice period.
- [ ] Restrictive clauses: non-compete, non-solicitation, intellectual property terms.
- [ ] Training, development and pay review timing.
- [ ] Commute cost and time, and any equipment you must provide.
- [ ] The manager and team: did they seem fair, organised and respectful?
- [ ] How exposed the role itself is to automation, and whether it builds skills you will need next (Chapter 5).

Job Scams: Protecting Yourself

Job seekers are a major target for fraud. Scammers know that people searching for work are hopeful, sometimes desperate, and used to sharing personal information with strangers. AI has made their job easier: fake recruiters can now write flawless messages, create convincing company websites, and even use fake video or voice in "interviews". Consumer protection agencies in several countries have reported large increases in job-related scams in recent years.

Anyone can be fooled. These schemes are designed by professionals. Being scammed is not a sign of stupidity, and if it happens, you should report it without shame.

> *A real employer will never ask you to pay to get a job, or to move money for them before you start.*

The most common job scams

Scam type	How it works
Fake recruiter	Someone claiming to be a recruiter from a real or plausible company contacts you on a messaging app, by text or on a professional network. They offer a great role with little or no interview, then ask for personal details, bank information or a fee.
Upfront fee request	You are asked to pay for training, a background check, a visa, "certification", a starter kit or software before you can begin. The job never materialises.
Check-cashing or equipment scam	You are "hired" and sent a cheque (check) to buy work equipment from a specific supplier. You deposit it and send money to the supplier. Days later, the cheque bounces, and you owe the bank the full amount.
Task or "job" scams	You are paid small amounts to do simple online tasks (liking videos, rating products, "optimising apps"). Then you are told you must deposit your own money, often in cryptocurrency, to unlock higher earnings or withdraw what you have "earned". The money is gone.

Scam type	How it works
Money mule or “payment processor” roles	You are hired to receive money into your account and forward it. This is often money laundering, which can make you criminally liable and get your bank account closed.
Reshipping scam	You are hired to receive packages at home and post them on. The goods are often bought with stolen cards, and you may never be paid.
Too-good-to-be-true remote job	High pay for little work, no experience needed, flexible hours, immediate start. Often a front for one of the scams above or identity theft.
Deepfake or fake video interviews	An “interview” over chat or video, sometimes with an AI-generated face or voice, or a camera that is “broken”. It feels real enough to lower your guard, and it ends with a request for documents, bank details or payment.
Identity theft through “onboarding”	Before any real offer, you are asked for your passport, government ID number, tax number or bank login, supposedly for payroll. The information is used to open accounts or take out loans in your name.

Red flags

STOP AND CHECK IF YOU SEE ANY OF THESE

- [ ] You are offered a job without a proper interview, or after a chat-only "interview".
- [ ] You are asked to pay anything: fees, training, equipment, or a deposit.
- [ ] You receive a cheque or transfer and are asked to send some of it on.
- [ ] The recruiter uses a personal email address (for example, a free webmail account) rather than a company domain, or a domain that is slightly misspelled.
- [ ] Communication moves quickly to an encrypted messaging app and away from official channels.
- [ ] Pay is unusually high for the work, or the description is vague.
- [ ] There is heavy pressure to act fast: "Only two spots left, decide today."
- [ ] They ask for sensitive personal or bank details before a written, verifiable offer.
- [ ] They ask for cryptocurrency, gift cards or wire transfers.
- [ ] Video is off, faces look oddly smooth or lips do not match the words, or they refuse a live call.
- [ ] You cannot find the job on the company's official careers page.

How to verify an employer or recruiter

1. **Go to the source yourself.** Do not use links or phone numbers from the message. Find the company's official website through a search, and check whether the role is listed on its careers page.
2. **Contact the company independently.** Use the main phone number or email from the official website and ask whether the recruiter works there and whether the role is real.

3. **Check the recruiter.** Look for a professional profile with history, connections and activity. Be wary of brand-new profiles, few connections, or stock-photo faces. Remember that profiles can be faked, so this is only one check.
4. **Check the email domain.** It should match the company's real website exactly. Look carefully for small misspellings or added words.
5. **Search for scam reports.** Search the company name plus "scam" or "fraud", and check your consumer protection agency's scam alerts.
6. **Insist on a live interview.** A real employer will speak to you on a live voice or video call. If you suspect a deepfake, ask the person to do something simple and unscripted, such as turn their head or pick up an object near them, and trust your instincts if something feels off.
7. **Get the offer in writing.** A legitimate offer letter comes from a company email address and includes the employer's legal name, address, role and pay.
8. **Share sensitive details only at the right stage.** Bank and ID details are normally needed only after you have accepted a verified written offer, usually through a secure official onboarding system, not by message or email.

WATCH OUT

Never deposit a cheque from an employer you have not verified and then send money onward, even if your bank shows the funds as "available". Funds can appear available days before a cheque actually clears. When it bounces, you are responsible for the whole amount.

A STORY

Illustrative composite. Aisha, 26, from Manchester, had posted that she was open to remote work. Within a day, a "recruiter" messaged her about a well-paid data entry job for a company with a professional-looking website. After a text-only interview on a messaging app, she was offered the role and told she would receive a cheque to buy a laptop from the "company's approved supplier". Something felt wrong. She found the real company's phone number herself and called. They had never heard of the recruiter, and they had been receiving calls like hers all week. She reported it and warned others in her job-seekers' group.

If you think you have been scammed

Act quickly. The sooner you take steps, the more you can limit the damage.

1. **Stop all contact and payments.** Do not send any more money or information, even if they threaten you or promise a refund.
2. **Call your bank or card provider immediately.** Use the number on the back of your card. Explain what happened. They may be able to stop or reverse a payment, and they can protect your account.
3. **Protect your identity.** If you shared ID documents or ID numbers, contact the relevant agencies and consider a fraud alert or credit freeze with credit bureaus where that is available (for example, in the US, UK and Canada).
4. **Change passwords.** Especially for email and banking, and turn on two-factor authentication.
5. **Keep evidence.** Save messages, emails, phone numbers, website addresses, payment receipts and the names they used.
6. **Report it.** This helps authorities track scammers and may help you recover money or prove you were a victim.
7. **Report the profile or post.** Use the reporting tools on the job board, social network or messaging app where you were contacted.

Where to report

Country or region	Where to report
United States	Federal Trade Commission at reportfraud.ftc.gov; for internet-based crime, the FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center at ic3.gov; identity theft at identitytheft.gov; your state attorney general.
United Kingdom	Action Fraud, the national fraud reporting service for England, Wales and Northern Ireland (check online for its current name and website, as the service has been under review); in Scotland, Police Scotland on 101. Forward scam texts to 7726.
Canada	Canadian Anti-Fraud Centre, and your local police.
Australia	Scamwatch (run by the national consumer regulator) and ReportCyber for cybercrime.
European Union	Your national police and national consumer protection authority; many EU countries have online fraud reporting portals.
Elsewhere	Your local police and national consumer protection or cybercrime agency. Your bank can often tell you the right place.

If the scam has left you in financial difficulty, see Chapter 3 for talking to lenders and hardship programs. If it has shaken your confidence or left you feeling ashamed, please talk to someone you trust (Chapter 4). It is a crime against you, not a failing in you.

Write down your personal scam rule in one sentence, for example: "I never pay, and I never share bank or ID details until I have verified the company myself."

REMEMBER

- Learn the format of each interview stage in advance, and ask for adjustments if you need them.
- Prepare six to eight STAR stories. One good story can answer many questions.
- When asked about AI, give specific uses, explain how you check its work, and show awareness of limits.
- Answer questions about layoffs, gaps and age honestly and briefly, then steer to the future.
- Never accept an offer on the spot. Get it in writing, check the whole package, and negotiate politely.
- A real employer never asks you to pay, send money onward, or hand over bank and ID details before a verified written offer.
- Verify employers through official channels you find yourself, and report scams quickly.

Your next step: Fill in two rows of the STAR story bank (Worksheet 14.1) and practise saying them out loud today.

PART V

Create Your Own Opportunities

Not every next step is a job someone else offers you. Freelancing, small businesses, several income streams and your local community economy are real options — and AI has made many of them cheaper to start than ever.

15 · Freelancing and Consulting
16 · Starting a Small Business with AI as Your Team
17 · The Portfolio Life: Multiple Income Streams
18 · Local Opportunities and the Community Economy

CHAPTER 15

Freelancing and Consulting

How to turn what you already know into a paid service: finding your first three clients, packaging and pricing your work, writing proposals, protecting yourself with contracts, and actually getting paid.

If you have lost a job, you have not lost what you know. The years you spent solving problems for an employer are still inside you: the shortcuts, the judgment calls, the contacts, the sense of what "good" looks like. Freelancing and consulting are simply ways of selling that knowledge directly, one project at a time, instead of through a single employer.

This chapter is not a promise that freelancing will replace your salary next month. For most people it takes several months to build steady work, and some months will be thin. But it is one of the fastest ways to start earning again, it can run alongside a job search, and it often leads to job offers from clients who got to know your work.

You do not need a website, a logo or a registered company to begin. You need a clear offer, a few people who know you, and the nerve to ask. Everything else can come later.

From job title to service offer

The biggest mistake new freelancers make is selling their old job title. “I’m a marketing manager, available for work” makes the client do all the thinking. Clients do not buy titles. They buy a result to a problem they already know they have.

Your task is to translate what you did into a specific outcome, for a specific kind of client, delivered in a specific way. Think of it as a short sentence: *I help [who] get [result] by [how].*

Old job title	Vague offer	Clear service offer
Customer support team lead	“Customer service consulting”	I help small online shops cut their reply times by setting up a help desk, templates and an AI-assisted first response that a human checks.
Accounts payable clerk	“Bookkeeping help”	I help local trades businesses get their invoices, receipts and supplier payments in order every month, so their accountant has clean books at year end.
Junior software developer	“Web development”	I help clinics and salons fix and maintain their booking websites, with a monthly check-up and same-week fixes.
Translator	“Translation services”	I review and correct AI-translated legal and medical documents so they are accurate and safe to use, with a signed quality statement.
HR coordinator	“HR support”	I help companies of 10–50 people write their first employee handbook and onboarding checklist in four weeks.

Notice what the clear offers have in common. They name a type of client, a problem the client can feel, and a deliverable with edges. Several of them also pair AI tools with human checking, which is exactly where many clients now need help: they have the tools but not the judgment or time to use them well (see Chapter 6 on the human advantage).

Three questions to find your offer

1. **What did people come to you for?** Not your official duties, but the things colleagues asked you to fix, explain or check. That is usually your real expertise.
2. **Who pays for that outside a big company?** Small and medium businesses often need the same skills but cannot justify a full-time hire.
3. **What would "done" look like?** If you cannot describe the finished result, the client cannot picture buying it.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> Narrow feels risky but sells better. "I help dental practices fill cancelled appointments" is easier to say yes to than "I do marketing." You can always widen later once you have clients and proof.

Finish this sentence three different ways: "I help [who] get [result] by [how]." Circle the one that feels most believable to someone who knows your past work.

The "first three clients" playbook

Your first clients will almost certainly come from people who already know, like or trust you. Strangers on the internet rarely hire someone with no reviews. Former colleagues, managers, suppliers, customers and friends of friends often will, because they have seen your work or can ask someone who has.

The goal of this playbook is not a big income. It is three paying clients, which gives you real proof, real testimonials and a much clearer sense of what to sell. Use the warm network map you built in Chapter 12.

1. **List 30 people.** Former bosses, colleagues who moved to other companies, vendors you worked with, clients of your old employer (check any non-solicitation clause in your contract first), people from courses, clubs and community groups. Do not judge yet. Just write names.
2. **Mark the likely ones.** Put a star next to anyone who works in or near a business that might have the problem you solve, or who knows lots of people who do.
3. **Send a short, honest note.** Tell them what you now offer and ask for either work or a referral. Use the script below. Aim for ten messages in the first week.
4. **Have real conversations.** When someone replies, offer a 20-minute call. Ask about their problems more than you talk about yourself.
5. **Offer a small first project.** A first project with a clear scope and a modest price lowers the risk for the client. Think of it as a paid trial, not free work.
6. **Deliver brilliantly and ask for a testimonial.** Over-communicate, finish on time, and at the end ask two questions: "Could I quote you?" and "Who else do you know who might need this?"

SCRIPT: TELLING YOUR NETWORK ABOUT YOUR NEW SERVICE

Hi [Name],

I hope things are good at [their company or situation]. Quick update from me: after [old company] restructured, I've started working independently, helping [type of client] with [specific result].

For example, I can [one concrete deliverable], usually in about [time frame].

Two small asks: does that sound like something [their company] could use? And if not, is there anyone you'd suggest I talk to? Even one name would really help.

Thanks either way, and happy to return the favour any time.

[Your name]

TIP

Ask for referrals by describing the person, not just the service. “Do you know any café or restaurant owners who’ve complained about their online reviews?” jogs people’s memory far better than “Do you know anyone who needs marketing help?”

Should you work for free?

Mostly no. Free work tends to attract clients who do not value it, and it does not test whether anyone will pay. A better middle ground: a **small paid pilot** at a reduced “founding client” rate, in exchange for a testimonial and permission to use the work as a case study. Write the normal price on the invoice and show the discount, so the client knows your real rate.

A STORY

Illustrative composite. Mirela, 47, spent fifteen years running payroll for a logistics firm in Romania before her role was absorbed into an automated system. She wrote to 25 people, most of them former suppliers and two ex-managers. Six replied, three took calls, and one, a small transport company, hired her to clean up two years of messy payroll records. That one project led to a referral to the owner’s brother-in-law, who ran a building firm. Four months in, she had three regular clients and was still job hunting, but no longer in a panic.

Packaging your services

A package turns your skills into something a client can understand and buy without a long negotiation. Instead of “I charge by the hour, let’s see how long it takes,” you say “Here are three options, here is what each includes, here is the price.” This makes you easier to hire and protects you from projects that grow forever.

Most freelancers do well with three kinds of offer:

- **An entry offer.** Small, fast, low-risk: an audit, a review, a one-off fix, a half-day workshop. It lets clients try you.
- **A core project.** The main thing you do, with a clear start and finish.

- **An ongoing retainer.** A monthly fee for regular work or support. Retainers are the backbone of a stable freelance income.

WORKSHEET 15.1 — YOUR SERVICE PACKAGE

Question	Entry offer	Core project	Monthly retainer
Name of the offer			
Who it is for			
Problem it solves			
What the client gets (deliverables)			
What is NOT included			
Time frame			
Number of revisions or meetings			
What you need from the client			
Price			
Payment terms			

The "What is NOT included" row matters more than it looks. Most freelance disputes come from different ideas of what the price covered. Writing it down early saves arguments later.

Pricing: how to work out what to charge

Pricing is where most new freelancers undersell themselves. They take their old hourly wage and charge that, forgetting that an employer used to pay for holidays, sick days, equipment, pension contributions, payroll taxes and the hours spent not working on paid tasks. As a freelancer, you pay for all of that yourself.

There are three common methods. Most people start with the first, check it against the third, and move towards the second as they gain confidence.

Method 1: Target income ÷ billable hours

This tells you the minimum hourly rate you need to survive. It is a floor, not a ceiling.

1. **Decide your target take-home income** for a year: what you need to live on, plus savings.
2. **Add business costs:** software, phone, equipment, insurance, accountant, travel, training.
3. **Add tax and social contributions.** This varies a lot by country. Ask a local accountant or tax office for a realistic percentage; many freelancers set aside somewhere between a quarter and a third of income, but your number may differ.
4. **Work out real billable hours.** Take the weeks you will actually work (minus holidays, sickness and quiet periods), then the hours per week you can bill. Remember that marketing, admin, invoicing and learning are unpaid. Many freelancers can only bill 50–70% of their working hours, especially early on.
5. **Divide** the total by your billable hours.

Worked example (illustrative numbers only)	Amount
Target take-home income for the year	40,000
Business costs (software, phone, insurance, accountant, equipment)	+ 5,000
Tax and contributions set-aside (example: 30% of the pre-tax total needed)	≈ + 19,300
Total you need to earn	**≈ 64,300**
Working weeks (52 minus 6 for holidays, sickness, quiet spells)	46
Billable hours per week (of a 40-hour week; the rest is admin and finding work)	22
Billable hours per year (46 × 22)	1,012
Minimum hourly rate (64,300 ÷ 1,012)	**≈ 64 per hour**

The currency does not matter here; the logic does. In this example, someone who earned the equivalent of about 25 per hour as an employee needs to charge more than twice that to end up in a similar position. That shocks many people. It is normal.

WORKSHEET 15.2 — YOUR MINIMUM HOURLY RATE

Item	Your number
A. Target take-home income per year	
B. Yearly business costs	
C. Tax and contributions (ask locally for a realistic rate)	
D. Total needed (A + B + C)	
E. Working weeks per year	
F. Billable hours per week (be honest)	
G. Billable hours per year (E × F)	
H. Minimum hourly rate (D ÷ G)	
I. Day rate floor (H × billable hours in a day)	

Method 2: Value-based pricing

Here you price based on what the result is worth to the client, not on your time. If your work helps a business recover 20,000 a year in missed invoices, a fee of 3,000 is a bargain to them, even if it only takes you 25 hours.

To use it, you must ask good questions before quoting: What is this problem costing you now? What happens if it is not fixed? What would solving it make possible? Then offer a price that is a clear, modest fraction of that value.

Value pricing works best once you have a track record and can point to results. It also rewards you for getting faster, which matters in an era when AI tools may help you finish tasks in half the time. If you charge only by the hour, being efficient cuts your income. If you charge for outcomes, it does not.

Method 3: Day rates and market checks

A day rate is simple for clients to understand and budget, and it stops you being nickel-and-dimed over minutes. Check your Method 1 floor against what others charge:

- Ask two or three freelancers in your field what they charge. Many will tell you if you ask politely.
- Look at published rates on freelance platforms and professional association surveys (many associations publish rate guides for members).
- Ask friendly former colleagues what their companies pay contractors.

If the market rate is far below your floor, that is important information. You may need a different client group (larger businesses usually pay more), a narrower specialism, or a different offer.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Racing to the bottom on price rarely works, especially now that AI tools make basic versions of many services cheap. You cannot win on price against software. Compete on judgment, reliability, accountability and understanding the client's situation. Those are the things clients still pay well for.

How to say your price out loud

State your price plainly, then stop talking. Do not apologise or explain why it is "so much." If a client says it is over budget, do not just drop the price. Reduce the scope instead: "I can do it for that budget if we leave out [part] and do one round of revisions instead of two."

Proposals that win work

A proposal is not a CV. It shows the client that you understood their problem and that you have a clear plan to fix it. Keep it to one or two pages. Send it within 48 hours of your conversation while you are fresh in their mind.

SCRIPT: A SIMPLE PROPOSAL TEMPLATE

Proposal for [Client name] — [Project name] — [Date]

1. What you told me. You're dealing with [problem in their words]. Right now this means [cost or pain: lost time, lost sales, risk]. You'd like [the result they want] by [date].

2. What I propose. I will [main approach in one or two sentences].

3. What you'll get.

- [Deliverable 1]
- [Deliverable 2]
- [Deliverable 3]

4. What's not included. [Items outside scope.] These can be quoted separately if needed.

5. Timeline. Week 1: [stage]. Week 2: [stage]. Final delivery: [date].

6. What I need from you. [Access, information, a named contact, response times.]

7. Investment. Option A: [scope] — [price]. Option B: [larger scope] — [price]. Payment: [e.g. 50% to start, 50% on delivery], due within [14] days of invoice.

8. Why me. [One or two sentences on relevant experience, plus a short result or testimonial.]

9. Next step. If this looks right, reply to confirm and I'll send the agreement and first invoice. I can start on [date]. This proposal is valid until [date].

TIP

Offering two or three options often works better than one price. Clients stop asking "Should I hire this person?" and start asking "Which option do I want?" You can use an AI assistant to tidy the language of a proposal, but write the problem section yourself, in the client's own words. That is the part that proves you listened.

Contracts: protecting yourself

Every paid project needs something in writing, even with friends. Especially with friends. A contract is not a sign of distrust. It is a shared memory of what you agreed, written down before anyone is stressed or disappointed.

For small projects, a clear email that the client replies “Agreed” to can be enough to start. For larger or ongoing work, use a proper agreement. Many professional associations, freelancer unions and small business support services offer free template contracts. For high-value work, it is worth paying a lawyer once to review a template you can then reuse.

CONTRACT ESSENTIALS CHECKLIST

- [ ] Both parties’ names, business details and contact information
- [ ] Description of the work and the specific deliverables
- [ ] What is not included, and how extra work will be quoted
- [ ] Timeline, key dates, and what happens if the client delays
- [ ] Number of revision rounds included
- [ ] Fee, currency, and whether tax (such as VAT or GST) is added
- [ ] Payment schedule (deposit, milestones, final payment) and due dates
- [ ] Late payment terms (interest or fees, where your local law allows)
- [ ] Who owns the work, and when ownership passes (usually on full payment)
- [ ] Your right to show the work in your portfolio, or a confidentiality clause
- [ ] Use of AI tools: whether you may use them, and that you remain responsible for checking output
- [ ] Data protection: how you will handle client or customer personal data
- [ ] Cancellation terms and a “kill fee” for work already done
- [ ] Limit of liability (usually capped at the fee paid)
- [ ] Your independent status (you are not an employee)
- [ ] Signatures and date

WATCH OUT

Some clients try to treat freelancers like employees: fixed hours, their equipment, no other clients, ongoing work with no end date. In many countries this can create legal problems for both sides (often called "misclassification" or "disguised employment"). It can also mean you are missing out on rights you should have. If an arrangement feels like a job, check your local rules or ask a worker advice service.

Invoicing and getting paid

Late payment is one of the biggest stresses in freelance life. You can reduce it a lot with a few habits.

- **Take a deposit.** For new clients, ask for 30–50% up front. A client who will not pay a deposit is giving you useful information.
- **Invoice promptly.** Send invoices the day the milestone is reached. Delay on your side often becomes delay on theirs.
- **Make invoices easy to pay.** Include an invoice number, date, due date, your details, the client's details, what the invoice is for, amount, tax if relevant, and clear payment instructions.
- **Find out the client's process.** Larger companies often need a purchase order number or supplier registration. Ask at the start, not when the invoice is late.
- **Use short terms.** 14 days is common for small businesses. Some countries have laws on maximum payment terms and statutory late-payment interest for business-to-business invoices (for example, the UK and EU both have such rules). Check what applies to you.
- **Keep retainers in advance.** Bill monthly retainers at the start of the month, not the end.

Late payment scripts

Stay polite and factual. Most late payments are disorganisation, not bad faith. Escalate step by step.

SCRIPT: FRIENDLY REMINDER (1–3 DAYS AFTER DUE DATE)

Hi [Name],

Just a quick note that invoice [number] for [amount], for [project], was due on [date]. I've attached it again for convenience. Could you let me know when payment is scheduled?

Thanks very much,
[Your name]

SCRIPT: FIRM FOLLOW-UP (ABOUT 10–14 DAYS LATE)

Hi [Name],

I'm following up on invoice [number] for [amount], which is now [X] days overdue. I haven't yet received payment or a date for it.

Could you confirm by [date, about 3–5 working days away] when this will be paid? If there's a problem with the invoice, or someone else I should contact in accounts, please let me know and I'll sort it out quickly.

As per our agreement, [late fee or interest term] applies to overdue invoices. I'd much rather avoid that, so I appreciate your help.

Best regards,
[Your name]

SCRIPT: FINAL NOTICE (ABOUT 30 DAYS LATE)

Dear [Name],

Invoice [number] for [amount] is now [X] days overdue, despite my reminders on [dates]. I have paused further work on [project] until it is settled.

Please arrange payment in full by [date, 7 days away]. If I do not receive payment or a payment plan by then, I will need to take formal steps to recover the debt, which may include [late payment interest / a formal demand / a small claims process].

I value working with you and hope we can resolve this quickly.

[Your name]

If none of this works, most countries have a small claims court or online money claim service for modest amounts, and some have free mediation services for small businesses. Check your local options before the debt gets old, as there are often time limits.

Platforms versus going direct

Freelance marketplaces connect clients and freelancers, handle payment and sometimes hold money in escrow. They can be a useful way to get first reviews. But many are crowded, and competition on price is fierce, especially for tasks that AI now does reasonably well. Treat them as one channel, not your whole plan.

PLATFORMS: PROS

- Clients are already looking to hire
- Payment protection and dispute processes
- Reviews build credibility quickly
- Good for small, well-defined tasks
- Useful if your network is small or you have moved country

PLATFORMS: CONS

- Fees can take a significant cut of each payment
- Heavy price competition from around the world
- Rules and algorithms can change without warning
- The client relationship belongs partly to the platform
- Scams and unpaid “test tasks” do exist

GOING DIRECT: PROS

- You keep the whole fee
- Stronger, longer relationships and referrals
- You can charge for value, not compete on price
- Repeat work and retainers are more common

GOING DIRECT: CONS

- Slower to start; relies on your network and reputation
- You handle contracts, invoicing and chasing payment
- No built-in payment protection
- You must keep finding new clients yourself

A sensible mix: use your direct network for your main income, use a platform to fill gaps or test a new offer, and always try to move good platform relationships towards repeat work (within the platform's rules, as many forbid taking clients off-platform for a set period).

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Freelance scams are common. Red flags: being asked to pay for "training" or "software" before starting, overpayment by cheque followed by a request to refund the difference, large unpaid "test projects," clients who want to move to a private messaging app immediately, and work that involves receiving and forwarding money or goods. See Chapter 14 for more on recognising scams.

Simple systems that keep you sane

You do not need expensive software. You need a few habits that keep work, money and clients from slipping through the cracks.

- **A client tracker.** A spreadsheet with each lead, last contact, next action and status (talking, proposal sent, won, lost).
- **A separate account for business money.** Even before you register a business, a separate bank account makes taxes and record-keeping far easier (see Chapter 17).
- **A weekly "business hour."** Every Friday: send invoices, chase late payments, update your tracker, contact two people.
- **Reusable templates.** Your proposal, contract, invoice and onboarding email, saved and ready to adapt.
- **AI as an assistant, not a replacement for judgment.** AI tools can draft emails, summarise meeting notes, and tidy proposals. Check everything before it goes to a client, and never paste client confidential information into a tool unless your agreement and the tool's privacy terms allow it (see Chapter 7).

DO THIS NOW

1. Write your one-sentence offer: "I help [who] get [result] by [how]."
2. Fill in Worksheet 15.2 to find your minimum hourly rate.
3. List 30 people from your network and star the ten most likely.
4. Send three outreach messages today using the network script.

You are not selling hours. You are selling a problem that stops being a problem.

When freelancing is and isn't a good fit

Freelancing suits people who can tolerate uneven income, are comfortable asking for work, and have at least a few months of runway or another income source. It is harder if you have no savings and urgent bills, or if you strongly need the structure and social contact of a team.

It does not have to be all or nothing. Many people freelance while job hunting, or keep one or two clients alongside a part-time job (see Chapter 17). If a client offers you a job, that is a success, not a failure. Freelancing is a tool, not an identity you have to defend.

What worries you most about freelancing: finding clients, setting prices, the paperwork, or the uncertainty? What is one small step that would make that worry smaller?

REMEMBER

- Sell a specific result for a specific client, not your old job title.
- Your first three clients will most likely come from people who already know you. Ask directly, and ask for referrals.
- Package your work into clear offers with defined deliverables and limits.
- Price from a real calculation that includes taxes, costs and unpaid time, then move towards value-based pricing.
- Always agree in writing, take deposits from new clients, and chase late payments promptly and politely.
- Use platforms as one channel, but build direct relationships for stable income.

Your next step: Write your one-sentence offer and send it to three people who know your work, asking if they or someone they know could use it.

CHAPTER 16

Starting a Small Business with AI as Your Team

How to find a problem worth solving, test it before you spend your savings, launch on a small budget, and use AI tools as a helpful (supervised) assistant for marketing, admin and bookkeeping.

Starting a business after losing a job can feel either thrilling or terrifying, and often both in the same afternoon. The good news is that it has never been cheaper to start small. Many tasks that once needed a designer, a marketer, a bookkeeper or a receptionist can now be handled, at least in a first version, by you plus a few inexpensive AI tools.

The hard truth is that the basics have not changed. Most new businesses struggle because nobody wants what they sell at a price that covers the costs. AI does not fix that. Talking to customers does. This chapter puts the customer first and the tools second.

A quick word on risk. Do not put your emergency fund, your retirement savings or borrowed money into an untested idea. Start with what you can afford to lose, prove that people will pay, and only then invest more. If you are still building your runway, read Chapter 3 first.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> A business is not an idea. It is a problem that real people are willing to pay to have solved, plus a way of solving it that earns more than it costs. Your first job is to find evidence for all three parts.

Finding problems worth solving

Good business ideas usually come from noticing friction: things people complain about, put off, do badly, or pay too much for. You are well placed to see these. Your old job, your neighbourhood, your hobbies and your family life are all full of problems you understand better than most.

Where to look

- **Your past work.** What did customers or colleagues constantly struggle with? What did your company outsource or do badly?
- **Your local area.** Which services have long waiting lists? What do people drive to the next town for? Which businesses closed and left a gap?
- **Life changes.** People moving home, having babies, caring for ageing parents, retiring, starting businesses or adopting new technology all need help.
- **The AI shift itself.** Many small businesses and older people feel left behind by new tools. Setting up, explaining and checking those tools is a real need.
- **Complaints.** Read local community groups, reviews of existing businesses and forums. Repeated complaints are a map of unmet needs.

Talk to customers before you build anything

The single most useful thing you can do in the first two weeks is talk to 10–15 people who might be your customers. Not friends who will be nice to you, but people who actually have the problem. The goal is to learn, not to pitch.

Ask about their past behaviour, not their future intentions. “Would you buy this?” gets polite yeses that mean nothing. “When did this last happen, and what did you do?” gets the truth.

SCRIPT: A CUSTOMER DISCOVERY CONVERSATION

Opening: "Thanks for making time. I'm exploring whether to start a small service around [problem area], and I want to understand how people actually deal with it. I'm not selling anything today."

Questions:

1. "Tell me about the last time you dealt with [problem]. What happened?"
2. "What did you do to solve it? Who did you use, or did you do it yourself?"
3. "What was most frustrating about that?"
4. "How much time or money did it cost you?"
5. "Have you looked for a better option? What did you find?"
6. "If this problem disappeared, what would that change for you?"

Closing: "This has been really helpful. If I do put something together, could I show it to you? And is there anyone else you think I should talk to?"

TIP

Listen for three signals: the problem happens often, it is painful or expensive, and people are already spending money or time on poor solutions. If you hear all three, you may have something. If people shrug, keep looking.

Validation before spending

Validation means getting evidence that people will pay before you spend serious money. Compliments are not evidence. Signups are weak evidence. Money is strong evidence. Here are four practical ways to test, from cheapest to most involved.

1. **Pre-sales.** Describe your offer clearly and ask people to pay a deposit or book a first slot. If five people pay a small deposit for a service that does not exist yet, that is a powerful signal. Be honest about timing and refund deposits if you do not go ahead.

2. **A simple landing page.** One page that explains what you offer, who it is for, and the price, with a button to book, enquire or join a waiting list. Share it in relevant local groups or with your contacts and count real responses. Many website builders, some with AI-assisted design, let you do this for little or no cost.

3. **A pilot.** Deliver the service to three to five real customers by hand, at a modest "founding customer" price. You will learn what they value, what takes longest, and what you should charge.

4. **A market stall or pop-up.** For physical products or food, a weekend market, a shared kitchen or a shelf in a friendly shop tests demand with real buyers.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Collecting deposits or selling food, childcare, transport or health-related services may need permits, insurance or registrations even at the test stage. Check local rules first. Never take money for something you are not sure you can deliver, and always offer refunds for anything you cancel.

Decide your test in advance

Before you start, write down what result would convince you to continue. For example: "If at least 4 of 30 people I approach pay a deposit within three weeks, I will run a pilot." Deciding in advance stops you from explaining away weak results because you love the idea.

WORKSHEET 16.1 — YOUR VALIDATION TEST

Question	Your answer
The problem I am testing	
Who has it (be specific)	
My offer and price	
Test method (pre-sale, landing page, pilot, stall)	
How many people I will approach, and where	

Question	Your answer
Result that means “go ahead”	
Result that means “change the offer”	
Result that means “stop”	
Most I will spend on this test	
Deadline for the test	

A one-page business plan

You do not need a 40-page plan unless you are applying for a loan or grant. You need one page that forces you to think clearly. Fill this in after your customer conversations, and update it every month.

WORKSHEET 16.2 — ONE-PAGE BUSINESS PLAN

Section	Your answer
Customer: who exactly will buy?	
Problem: what pain do they have, in their words?	
Offer: what do you sell, and what does it include?	
Price: how much, and how often do they pay?	
Alternatives: what do they do now, and why is yours better?	
Reaching customers: how will they hear about you?	
Costs: start-up and monthly running costs	
Break-even: how many sales a month cover your costs?	
Your edge: why you? (skills, contacts, location)	
Risks: what could go wrong, and your plan B	
90-day goals: three measurable targets	

A quick break-even example

Illustrative numbers only. Suppose you start a mobile bike repair service. Monthly costs: van or cargo bike costs, phone, insurance, tool upkeep, booking software and advertising, which add up to 900 a month. Your average job brings in 60, and parts cost you 15 of that, leaving 45 per job.

Break-even = 900 ÷ 45 = 20 jobs a month. That is about five a week before you pay yourself anything. If you want to take home 2,000 a month on top, you need roughly 2,900 ÷ 45 ≈ 65 jobs a month, or about 15 a week. Now you can ask a useful question: is there enough demand nearby for 15 jobs a week, and can you physically do them?

> **A STORY**
>
> *Illustrative composite. Tomás, 34, lost his job as a junior data analyst in Spain. He noticed that the family-run restaurants in his town were paying high delivery-app commissions and had messy, outdated online menus. He spoke to twelve owners. Nine complained about the same things. He offered three of them a "founding" package: a simple ordering page, updated menus and photos, and a monthly check-in, for a small setup fee plus a monthly charge. Two paid in the first week. He used an AI assistant to draft menu descriptions in three languages, but every owner approved the final text, and he hired a local student to take the photos. Within six months he had eleven restaurant clients. It was not a fortune, but it was his.*

Launching on a small budget

A low-capital launch means spending money only where customers will notice. You can look professional without a big outlay.

LOW-COST LAUNCH CHECKLIST

- [ ] A clear name you have checked is not already used by a similar local business or trademark
- [ ] A simple one-page website or a business profile on a major map/search service
- [ ] A professional email address and a dedicated phone number (or a second SIM)
- [ ] A booking or enquiry method that is easy to use on a phone
- [ ] Clear prices, or at least “from” prices, published
- [ ] Basic terms: cancellation, refunds, payment
- [ ] A way to take card or bank payments
- [ ] Three to five photos or examples of your work
- [ ] A short list of the first 50 people or businesses you will tell
- [ ] A way to collect reviews from your first customers

Where to spend if you can: insurance (essential), tools that directly affect quality, and anything that keeps you safe. Where to save: fancy branding, office space, expensive software subscriptions, paid advertising before you know what message works.

AI as your team, with you as the manager

A one-person business wears many hats: marketer, receptionist, bookkeeper, designer, customer service. AI tools can now help with all of these. Think of them as eager junior assistants. They work fast, they never get tired, and they sometimes make confident mistakes. Your job is to give clear instructions and check their work before it reaches a customer.

Role	What AI can help with	What you must still do
Marketing assistant	Drafting social posts, website text, emails and flyers; suggesting headlines; resizing images; translating	Check facts and claims; keep your real voice; make sure images and text do not copy others’ work; follow advertising rules

Role	What AI can help with	What you must still do
Customer service	Drafting replies to common questions; a website chat helper for basic FAQs; summarising messages	Answer anything sensitive or unusual yourself; tell customers when they are talking to an automated system where required; keep personal data safe
Admin assistant	Scheduling, reminders, drafting quotes and terms, organising notes, creating checklists	Review quotes and terms before sending; get legal documents checked for anything important
Bookkeeping helper	Categorising expenses, reading receipts, preparing summaries, spotting unusual items	Check categories; reconcile with your bank; keep original records; use an accountant for tax returns if unsure
Researcher	Summarising competitors, local regulations and supplier options	Verify anything important against official sources; AI can be wrong or out of date
Designer	Logos, menus, simple graphics, product mock-ups	Check for resemblance to existing brands; consider a human designer once you grow

Rules for using AI safely in your business

- **Check before it goes out.** Never let an AI tool send messages, publish posts or make payments without you reviewing them, especially early on.
- **Protect customer data.** Do not paste customers' personal, health or financial details into tools unless you understand how that data is stored and you are allowed to share it. Data protection laws (such as GDPR in Europe and the UK) apply to small businesses too.
- **Do not make claims you cannot prove.** If AI writes "the best in town" or "guaranteed results," remove it. Misleading advertising rules apply whoever wrote the words.
- **Keep a human contact.** Customers should always be able to reach a person. That is part of what makes a small business valuable.
- **Watch the subscriptions.** Small monthly fees add up. Review your tools every quarter and cancel what you do not use.

SCRIPT: AN INSTRUCTION TO AN AI MARKETING ASSISTANT

"You are helping me write marketing for my small business. Business: [name], a [type of business] in [town] serving [customer type]. What makes us different: [2–3 real facts]. Tone: friendly, plain, no hype, no exaggerated claims. Task: write three short social media posts announcing [offer], each under 60 words, each ending with how to book: [booking method]. Do not invent reviews, statistics or awards."

TIP

Create a short "business brief" document with your services, prices, tone, opening hours and common customer questions. Paste it in at the start of each AI task. You will get far more accurate, consistent results, and you only have to write it once.

Legal and tax basics

Rules vary a great deal between countries, regions and types of business. This section gives you a list of things to check, not answers. Most countries have free or low-cost small business advice services: for example, Small Business Development Centers and SCORE mentoring in the US, local Growth Hubs and the government business support pages in the UK, regional chambers of commerce across the EU, Canada's provincial small business centres, and Australia's business.gov.au. Public libraries often run free business information sessions too.

LEGAL AND TAX BASICS TO CHECK LOCALLY

- [ ] Do I need to register as self-employed or as a business, and by when?
- [ ] Which structure suits me (sole trader/sole proprietor, partnership, limited company/LLC, cooperative)? Ask about liability and tax differences.
- [ ] Do I need a business name registration?
- [ ] Do I need a licence or permit for this activity (food, childcare, trades, transport, beauty, alcohol, care)?
- [ ] Does my home insurance, lease or mortgage allow me to run a business from home?
- [ ] Which insurance do I need: public liability, professional indemnity, product liability, vehicle, equipment?
- [ ] When must I register for sales tax (VAT, GST, sales tax), and what is the threshold?
- [ ] How and when do I pay income tax and social contributions? Do I need to make advance payments?
- [ ] What records must I keep, and for how long?
- [ ] Do data protection rules apply to how I collect customer information?
- [ ] Will starting a business affect any unemployment or other benefits I receive? (Report income honestly; some programs have special support for starting a business.)
- [ ] Have I opened a separate bank account for business money?

WATCH OUT

If you are receiving unemployment or other benefits, starting a business or earning any income usually has to be reported. Rules differ widely. Some countries offer start-up allowances or self-employment programs for people on benefits, so ask your benefits office before you start, not after.

Over 30 low-capital business ideas

These are starting points, not recommendations. Each one needs the customer conversations and validation described above. Start-up costs, licensing and demand vary a lot by location. Ideas marked with a licence note often need permits or qualifications.

Local services

1. **Home organising and decluttering** for busy families, downsizers and people moving house.
2. **Garden maintenance and seasonal yard work**, including for older homeowners.
3. **Pet sitting and dog walking**, with insurance and clear safety routines.
4. **Errand and concierge service** for older people, busy professionals or people recovering from illness.
5. **Window, gutter or specialist cleaning** (check safety rules for working at height).
6. **Move management**: planning, packing and setting up a new home.

AI-assisted and digital services

7. **AI setup for small businesses**: choosing tools, setting up booking, email templates and simple automations, then training staff.
8. **Human review of AI output**: checking AI-written translations, documents or product listings in a field you know.
9. **Local business online presence**: map listings, simple websites, menus and review management.
10. **Bookkeeping and admin support** for tradespeople and micro-businesses.
11. **Tech help for older adults**: patient, in-person help with phones, video calls, online banking safety and scam awareness.
12. **Data clean-up** for small organisations with messy spreadsheets, customer lists or records.
13. **Short video and photo content** for local businesses, using your phone and AI-assisted editing.

Care and wellbeing (often needs checks or qualifications)

14. **Companionship visits** for isolated older people (background checks usually needed).
15. **Respite support for family carers**, within the limits of your training and local rules.
16. **Childminding or after-school care** (usually registered and inspected).
17. **Fitness or walking groups** for specific groups such as new parents or over-60s (qualifications and insurance needed).

Trades and hands-on work

18. **Handyperson services** for small jobs that bigger firms will not take (know which jobs legally need a licensed tradesperson).
19. **Furniture assembly and flat-pack installation.**
20. **Painting and decorating.**
21. **Mobile bike repair and servicing.**
22. **Small-scale energy efficiency help**: draught-proofing, insulation advice, helping households apply for efficiency grants (check training and certification).

Food

23. **Meal prep for specific diets or busy households** (food hygiene registration usually required).
24. **Baking for cafés or markets**, often from a registered home kitchen or shared commercial kitchen.
25. **Pop-up dinners or cookery classes** sharing your culture's cuisine.
26. **Packed lunches or catering** for local offices, building sites or events.

Education and teaching

27. **Tutoring** in a school subject, exam preparation or a language.
28. **Workshops for adults** teaching a practical skill you have: budgeting, spreadsheets, using AI safely, cooking, sewing.
29. **Training for employers** in your old area of expertise, such as health and safety, customer service or compliance.

30. **Language and settlement help for newcomers**: practice conversation, help with forms and local systems.

Repair and reuse

31. **Clothing alterations and repairs.**
32. **Phone, laptop and small electronics repair** (training is widely available; be careful with batteries).
33. **Furniture restoration and upcycling.**
34. **Reselling secondhand goods** such as quality clothing, tools or children's equipment, with careful sourcing.
35. **Tool or equipment rental** for neighbours who need something once a year.

DO THIS NOW

1. Pick three ideas from your own experience or the list above.
2. For each, write who would pay and what problem it solves for them.
3. Choose the one where you can most easily reach ten potential customers.
4. Book your first three customer conversations this week.

AI can write your flyer. Only a customer can tell you whether the flyer is worth printing.

Common mistakes and how to avoid them

MISTAKE

- Building the product before talking to customers
- Asking friends if they like the idea
- Spending savings on branding, stock or fit-out first
- Pricing too low to "get started"
- Trying to serve everyone
- Ignoring permits, insurance and tax until later
- Letting AI publish without checking
- Doing it all alone
- Not setting a stop point

BETTER APPROACH

- Have 10–15 problem conversations first
- Ask strangers who have the problem, and ask for money
- Spend only after you have paying customers
- Calculate costs and break-even; price to make a profit
- Pick one customer group and serve them well
- Check rules before you start trading
- Review every message, post and quote yourself
- Find a mentor, peer group or local business network
- Decide in advance what result means "keep going" or "stop"

WATCH OUT

Be very careful with "business in a box" offers, franchise schemes with high upfront fees, multi-level marketing, and courses promising passive income from AI-generated content or stores. If the main way to make money is recruiting others or buying the course, it is not a business opportunity. See Chapter 3 for more on scams.

Knowing when to stop

Stopping a business that is not working is not a failure. It is a sensible decision that protects your money and energy. If you have hit your stop point, write down what you learned, thank the customers who supported you, and move

on. The skills you built (selling, organising, using tools, dealing with customers) are valuable in your next job or venture.

If you could solve one problem for people in your community, what would it be? Who would you talk to first to find out if they would pay for it?

REMEMBER

- Start with a real problem that people already spend time or money on.
- Talk to 10–15 potential customers and ask about past behaviour, not future intentions.
- Validate with pre-sales, a landing page or a pilot before spending serious money, and decide your success test in advance.
- Use AI as a supervised assistant for marketing, admin and bookkeeping, and always check its work.
- Check registration, permits, insurance, tax and benefits rules locally, and open a separate bank account.
- Never risk your emergency fund on an untested idea.

Your next step: Choose one problem you could solve and arrange three customer discovery conversations this week using the script in this chapter.

CHAPTER 17

The Portfolio Life: Multiple Income Streams

How to combine part-time work, freelancing, gig work, teaching and other streams into a steady whole, and how to manage the time, records, taxes and energy that a portfolio life demands.

For a long time, the standard picture of work was one employer, one payslip, one job title. That picture was never true for everyone. Many people, in many countries, have always pieced together a living from several sources. Now, with more roles being reshaped or cut, a growing number of people are choosing, or being pushed into, what is often called a "portfolio career."

A portfolio life means earning from two or more income streams at the same time. It might be a part-time job plus freelance clients. It might be tutoring, weekend market sales and a few shifts a week. It might be a temporary arrange-

ment while you job hunt, or a deliberate long-term choice.

Done well, a portfolio can be more secure than a single job. If one stream dries up, you are not left with nothing. Done badly, it can mean working all the time for unpredictable pay, with no holidays and a tax bill you did not see coming. This chapter is about doing it well.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> A healthy portfolio has a **base** (steady, predictable income that covers essentials), **growth** streams (work that builds skills, reputation or future income) and some **flexible** income you can scale up or down. Aim to cover your essential costs from the base first.

Types of income streams

Not all income is equal. Some is steady but low-paid. Some pays well but arrives unpredictably. Some takes huge effort up front and pays later. Understanding these differences helps you build a mix that actually works.

Stream type	Examples	Strengths	Weaknesses
Part-time employment	Retail, admin, care shifts, a part-time role in your old field	Predictable pay; may include benefits and employment rights; social contact	Fixed hours; pay may be low; less control
Freelance or consulting	Projects and retainers using your professional skills (Chapter 15)	Higher hourly rates; uses your expertise; builds reputation	Uneven income; you handle admin and finding clients
Gig and platform work	Delivery, ride-hailing, task apps, short shifts via staffing apps	Quick to start; flexible; good for filling gaps	Low and variable pay after costs; few protections; can be tiring
Teaching and training	Tutoring, adult education classes, workshops, coaching	Often regular; meaningful; draws on experience	Seasonal (term times); may need qualifications or checks

Stream type	Examples	Strengths	Weaknesses
"Renting" your skills	Being on call for a small business, interim cover, mentoring, assessing or examining	Uses deep expertise; can be well paid	Irregular; depends on contacts
Selling products	Crafts, baked goods, secondhand resale, digital templates	Can scale; creative	Upfront costs; slow to build; marketing effort
Renting assets	A spare room, parking space, tools, equipment	Uses things you already have	Legal, tax and insurance rules; landlord or lease permissions

WATCH OUT

Gig work earnings are often quoted before costs. For delivery or driving, subtract fuel, vehicle wear, insurance, phone data and unpaid waiting time before comparing it with other options. Track a few weeks honestly. Some people find that their real hourly rate is far lower than it first appears.

Teaching and renting your skills: often overlooked

Two of the most useful streams for people with work experience are teaching what you know and "renting out" your expertise in small pieces. Both build on years you have already invested, and both are areas where clients value a real person with a track record.

- **Adult education.** Community colleges, adult learning centres, libraries and further education colleges often hire part-time instructors for evening or weekend courses. Practical subjects (bookkeeping, spreadsheets, workplace safety, languages, digital skills) are frequently in demand. Some roles need a teaching certificate; many short courses do not.
- **Corporate and association training.** Professional bodies and employers pay for half-day or one-day workshops on topics you know well: compliance, customer service, managing teams, using AI tools responsibly in a particular field.

- **Exam marking, assessing and invigilating.** Exam boards and training providers often need seasonal assessors with subject knowledge.
- **Interim and on-call cover.** Small businesses may pay a monthly fee to have an experienced finance, HR or operations person available for a few hours when needed.
- **Mentoring and advisory roles.** Some start-ups, community organisations and small firms pay for an experienced adviser for a few hours a month.

Finding a base stream quickly

If you need steady income soon, look first at sectors that hire part-time staff all year round: health and care settings, schools (administration, support staff, lunchtime and after-school roles), supermarkets and logistics, local government, hospitality, and temporary staffing agencies that place administrative workers. These may not be your long-term goal. That is fine. A base stream is there to keep the lights on while your growth stream develops.

Designing your mix

Start with your numbers, not your wishes. Look back at the runway figures you worked out in Chapter 3. What do you need each month to cover essentials? That number is your base target.

1. **Set your essential monthly number.** Rent or mortgage, food, utilities, transport, insurance, minimum debt payments.
2. **Choose a base stream.** Pick the most reliable income you can get that covers most of that number, even if it is not exciting. A part-time job or a solid retainer client often works.
3. **Add one growth stream.** Something that moves you towards the work you want: freelancing in your field, a new skill, a small business test.
4. **Keep one flexible stream** you can turn up when money is tight and down when you are busy, such as shift work or tutoring.
5. **Limit the number.** Three or four streams is plenty for most people. Every extra stream adds admin, travel, context-switching and mental load.

6 **Review monthly.** Which streams pay best per hour of effort? Which drain you? Which are growing? Drop or reduce the weakest.

WORKSHEET 17.1 — YOUR INCOME STREAM MAP

Stream	Role (base / growth / flexible)	Expected monthly income and hours	Real hourly rate after costs
1.			
2.			
3.			
4.			
Total			
Essential monthly costs			
Gap or surplus			
Stream I would drop first if overloaded			
Stream I most want to grow			

Questions to ask about each stream

- How reliable is it? Could it disappear next month?
- What is my real hourly rate once I count travel, preparation, costs and admin?
- Does it build skills, contacts or reputation for the future?
- How much energy does it take, and does it leave me with any for the rest?
- Does it conflict with any other stream (timing, contracts, exclusivity clauses)?
- Does it affect any benefits I receive?

A STORY

Illustrative composite. Grace, 52, worked for twenty years as a content editor for a publisher in Ireland until most of the department was replaced by an AI-assisted workflow. She now works three days a week as an administrator at a local secondary school (her base, with a pension and holidays), edits reports for two consultancies that need a careful human eye on AI-drafted documents (her growth stream), and tutors two teenagers in English on weekday evenings (flexible). Her income is about the same as before, after a hard first year. She says the biggest change is that she no longer feels one email could take everything away.

Example weekly schedules

These are examples to show what a mix can look like. Your hours, rates and streams will differ. Notice that each one protects time for admin and rest, which is where portfolio lives most often fall apart.

Example A: Part-time job, freelance and tutoring

Day	Morning	Afternoon	Evening
Monday	Part-time job	Part-time job	Free
Tuesday	Freelance client work	Freelance client work	Tutoring (2 hours)
Wednesday	Part-time job	Part-time job	Free
Thursday	Freelance client work	Outreach and proposals	Tutoring (2 hours)
Friday	Part-time job	Admin hour: invoices, records, planning	Free
Weekend	Rest, family, one optional learning block		

Example B: Job search plus bridge income

Day	Morning	Afternoon	Evening
Monday	Job search: targeted applications	Networking calls	Free
Tuesday	Retail or warehouse shift	Retail or warehouse shift	Free
Wednesday	Course or skill-building	Small freelance project	Free
Thursday	Retail or warehouse shift	Retail or warehouse shift	Free
Friday	Job search: follow-ups and interview prep	Admin and weekly review	Free
Saturday	Optional gig shift (only if money is short)		Free
Sunday	Rest		

Example C: Caregiver working around school hours

Day	9:30–14:30	After school	After bedtime
Mon–Thu	Remote freelance or part-time admin work	Family time	One evening a week: an online class to teach or attend
Friday	Admin, invoices, planning; selling products online	Family time	Free
Saturday	Market stall or weekend shift (partner or family covers childcare)		Free
Sunday	Rest		

Managing your time across streams

The hidden cost of a portfolio life is switching. Moving from one type of work to another uses mental energy, and scattered days leave you feeling busy but unproductive.

- **Batch similar work.** Keep a whole day or half-day for each stream where possible, rather than a little of everything every day.
- **Use one calendar.** Put every commitment from every stream in a single calendar, including travel time.
- **Keep one task list**, sorted by stream, and review it each morning.
- **Protect a weekly admin block.** One to two hours to invoice, record income and expenses, reply to emails and plan the next week.
- **Set communication boundaries.** Tell clients when you answer messages. You do not need to reply within minutes.
- **Plan for peaks.** Teaching has term times, retail has holiday rushes, some clients have year-end crunches. Mark these on a yearly calendar so they do not all collide.

> TIP
>
> AI assistants can help with the admin load: drafting routine emails, turning your notes into a weekly plan, or summarising what each client needs. Just keep personal and financial details out of tools you have not checked, and review anything before it is sent.

Keeping records

With several income streams, good records are not optional. They help you pay the right tax, claim allowable expenses, apply for loans or rental housing, prove income for benefits, and see which streams are actually worth it.

RECORD-KEEPING BASICS

- [ ] Open a separate bank account for self-employed and business income and expenses
- [ ] Record every payment received: date, who from, what for, amount
- [ ] Record every business expense: date, supplier, what for, amount, and keep the receipt
- [ ] Photograph paper receipts the day you get them and store them in a dated folder
- [ ] Keep payslips and tax documents from every employer
- [ ] Note mileage or travel for work purposes, if your country allows it as an expense
- [ ] Save copies of invoices you send, numbered in order
- [ ] Update your records weekly, not at the end of the year
- [ ] Back up your records somewhere safe
- [ ] Keep records for as long as your local tax authority requires (often several years)

A simple spreadsheet is enough to start. As you grow, low-cost accounting apps can connect to your bank account, read receipts and prepare summaries. Many now use AI to suggest categories. That is helpful, but check the categories yourself. A mistake there can mean a wrong tax return.

WORKSHEET 17.2 — MONTHLY INCOME AND EXPENSE LOG

Date	Stream / description	Money in	Money out (business expense)

Date	Stream / description	Money in	Money out (business expense)
Monthly totals			
Tax set aside this month			

Setting aside tax

When you have a job, tax is usually taken from your pay before you see it. Self-employed and freelance income generally is not. If you spend it all, you can face a large bill months later, sometimes with penalties. This is one of the most common and painful mistakes people make in their first year of a portfolio life.

The simple "tax pot" method

1. **Open a separate savings account** and call it "Tax." Do not touch it for anything else.
2. **Choose a percentage.** Ask an accountant, tax office or free tax advice service what percentage of your self-employed income to set aside. Many people put away somewhere between 20% and 30%, but your number depends on your country, your total income and your other streams.
3. **Move it immediately.** Every time a client or platform pays you, transfer the percentage into the tax pot the same day.
4. **Check deadlines.** Find out when tax returns are due and whether you must make advance or quarterly payments (common in the US, UK, Canada, Australia and many EU countries).
5. **Top up at year end** if needed. If you set aside too much, the surplus is a pleasant surprise.

Illustrative numbers only: if a freelance client pays you 1,200 and your chosen rate is 25%, move 300 to the tax pot the same day, and treat only 900 as yours to spend.

WATCH OUT

Combining a job with self-employment can push part of your income into a higher tax band, or change how much is withheld from your pay. Some platforms also report your earnings directly to tax authorities. Sales taxes (VAT, GST, sales tax) may apply once you pass a threshold. If you have several streams, a single session with an accountant or a free tax clinic early on can save you money and stress.

Other money habits for uneven income

- **Pay yourself a "salary."** Let all income land in one account, then pay yourself a fixed amount each month into your personal account. This smooths out good and bad months.
- **Build a buffer.** Aim for at least one month of essential costs in your business account, then build towards three.
- **Plan for gaps in protection.** You may not have sick pay, holiday pay or employer pension contributions on all streams. Look at income protection insurance, voluntary pension contributions, and any social insurance you can opt into as a self-employed person. Check what your country offers.
- **Check benefits rules.** If you receive any benefits or tax credits, report all income streams as required.

Avoiding burnout

A portfolio life can quietly turn into working all the time. Each stream feels small, so you say yes to one more shift, one more client, one more evening class. Then you notice you have not had a full day off in six weeks. The fear of losing income again makes this especially likely after a layoff.

WARNING SIGNS

- No full day off in two weeks or more
- Answering messages late at night from habit
- Feeling dread before most work, not just some
- Poor sleep, frequent illness, irritability
- Saying yes to work you know is underpaid out of fear
- Dropping the things that used to restore you

PROTECTIVE HABITS

- Schedule rest first, then fit work around it
- Set a maximum weekly hours limit and track it
- Keep at least one full day a week free
- Plan holidays in advance and save for them
- Review streams monthly and drop the worst
- Stay connected with people outside work

If you notice the warning signs, treat them as information, not weakness. Return to Chapter 4 for support with stress, sleep and mental health, and consider talking to a doctor or counsellor if they persist.

DO THIS NOW

1. Fill in Worksheet 17.1 with your current or planned income streams.
2. Label each one base, growth or flexible.
3. Open a separate "Tax" savings account if you have any self-employed income.
4. Block one weekly admin hour and one full rest day in your calendar.

Several small streams can make a river. But only if you leave yourself time to breathe between them.

When a stream ends or changes

Streams come and go. A client finishes a project, a platform changes its rates, a term ends. This is normal in a portfolio life, and it is the reason for having more than one stream. The trick is to see it coming and replace income before the gap hurts.

- **Watch concentration.** If one client or source provides more than about half your income, you are close to having a single job without the protections. Start building a second source before it becomes a problem.
- **Keep a pipeline.** Spend a little time every week, even when you are busy, contacting past clients, following up leads and keeping your profiles current.
- **Ask about plans.** At least every few months, ask regular clients what is coming up for them. You will often hear about budget cuts, or new projects, before they happen.
- **Leave on good terms.** When a stream ends, thank the people involved and ask for a reference or testimonial. Former clients and employers are your best source of future work.

Explaining your portfolio to others

Some people worry that a portfolio career looks messy on a CV or sounds odd at a family dinner. It does not have to. Tell a clear story that links the pieces.

> **SCRIPT: DESCRIBING YOUR PORTFOLIO WORK**
>
> "I work across a few things that fit together. My base is [part-time role]. I also help [type of client] with [freelance service], and I teach [subject] in the evenings. The common thread is [skill or theme, e.g. 'helping people make sense of complicated information']."

On a CV, you can group portfolio work under one heading such as "Independent consultant and educator, [years]," then list key clients, projects and results. Employers increasingly understand portfolio careers, and the self-management they require is a real strength (see Chapter 11).

If you could design your ideal working week from three or four streams, what would they be? Which one could you start or strengthen this month?

REMEMBER

- Build a portfolio with a reliable base, a growth stream and a flexible stream. Cover essentials from the base first.
- Work out the real hourly rate of each stream after costs and unpaid time.
- Batch similar work, use one calendar, and protect a weekly admin block.
- Keep a separate account and simple weekly records of all income and expenses.
- Set aside a percentage of self-employed income for tax the day you are paid, and check local deadlines.
- Schedule rest first. Several small jobs can easily add up to too much work.

Your next step: Fill in your income stream map (Worksheet 17.1) and decide which stream is your base.

CHAPTER 18

Local Opportunities and the Community Economy

A practical look at the work that happens close to home: skilled trades, care, helping local businesses, cooperatives, public service and nonprofits, plus a clear way to decide whether moving somewhere new makes sense.

Much of the conversation about AI and work happens online, about online jobs. But a large share of the world's work still happens in a particular place, with particular people: fixing a boiler, caring for an elderly neighbour, running a bakery, teaching a class, keeping a town's water clean. This work is harder to automate, and it is often in short supply.

This chapter looks at opportunities in your own community and in the wider "community economy": trades, care, small local businesses, cooperatives, public services and nonprofits. It also helps you think through a bigger question that many people face after a layoff: should you stay where you are, or move?

None of these paths is easy, and none is right for everyone. Some involve physical work, lower starting pay or years of training. But they share something valuable: the work depends on being present, trusted and skilled in the real world.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> Work that requires physical presence, hands-on skill, local knowledge and human trust is among the hardest to automate. It is not immune to change, since tools and methods keep evolving, but the core of the job usually still needs a person on site.

Skilled trades: a realistic look

Electricians, plumbers, heating engineers, carpenters, welders, mechanics and similar trades are in demand in many countries. The energy transition (heat pumps, solar panels, insulation, electric vehicle charging) and ageing infrastructure are adding to that demand. Many trades report that experienced workers are retiring faster than new ones are trained.

AI is touching the trades too: diagnostic tools, quoting software, scheduling apps. But these help the tradesperson; they do not crawl under the floor and fix the pipe.

The honest picture

THE UPSIDE

- Steady demand in many regions
- Good earning potential once qualified, especially self-employed
- Hard to outsource or automate
- Clear, visible results from your work
- Path to running your own business
- Skills that travel between countries (with recognition of qualifications)

THE CHALLENGES

- Physically demanding: lifting, kneeling, ladders, weather
- Risk of injury; safety training is essential
- Training can take 2–4 years for full qualification
- Apprentice or trainee pay is usually lower at first
- Early mornings, travel between sites
- Self-employed income depends on your business skills too

Training routes

- **Apprenticeships.** You earn while you learn, combining work with classroom training. Many countries have adult apprenticeships, and some offer funding or incentives to employers who take on older apprentices. Examples include registered apprenticeships in the US, apprenticeships in the UK, the dual training system in Germany, Austria and Switzerland, and Red Seal trades in Canada.

- **College or vocational courses.** Full-time or part-time courses at community colleges, technical institutes, further education colleges or TAFE in Australia. Some are free or subsidised for unemployed adults.
- **Short courses for specific tasks.** Some roles, such as installing insulation, smart meters or certain renewable systems, may need shorter certified training. Check what is legally required for each task.
- **Trades assistant or labourer roles.** Working as a helper lets you test the work and earn money while you decide. Many tradespeople started this way.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Be careful of private courses promising to make you a fully qualified tradesperson in a few weeks. In most countries, full qualification needs supervised on-the-job experience and assessment. Before you pay, check that the course leads to a recognised qualification with your local licensing body, and ask local employers whether they value it (see Chapter 10 on evaluating courses).

Is a trade right for you? A quick self-check

- Can you work on your feet most of the day, in different weather, and carry or lift regularly?
- Do you enjoy working out why something is broken and fixing it?
- Can your budget handle lower pay for a year or more while you train?
- Are you comfortable taking instructions from someone who may be younger than you?
- Are you willing to follow strict safety rules every time, even when it slows you down?

If most answers are yes, spend a day or two shadowing someone in the trade before you commit. If several are no, look at the many roles around the trades that are less physical: estimating, scheduling, project coordination, building inspection, health and safety, supplier sales, and training.

A STORY

Illustrative composite. Daniel, 41, was a customer support supervisor in Ontario until his team was cut to a handful of people overseeing an AI system. He had always done his own home repairs. He spent two months as a helper for a local electrician to test whether he could handle the physical side, then applied for an apprenticeship. The pay drop was real, and he and his partner rearranged their budget around it. Two years in, he says his knees ache on Fridays, but he no longer lies awake wondering if his job will exist next year.

The care economy

Populations in many countries are ageing, and the need for people to care for older adults, people with disabilities, children and people with health conditions is growing. Care work includes home care aides, residential care workers, nursing assistants, support workers, early childhood educators, and many health roles.

Care is deeply human work. AI can help with scheduling, records and some monitoring, but it cannot bathe someone, notice that they seem different today, or sit with them when they are frightened.

The honest picture

Care work is often **underpaid relative to its importance**, particularly entry-level roles. It can be physically and emotionally demanding, with shift work, weekends and lifting. Burnout is a real risk. At the same time, demand is high, entry is often quick, and there are clear routes to better-paid, qualified roles such as nursing, occupational therapy, physiotherapy assistance, social work and care management.

Entry route	Typical requirements	Where it can lead
Home care or support worker	Short induction training, background check, sometimes a driving licence	Senior care worker, team leader, care coordinator
Healthcare or nursing assistant	Short certificate course (varies by country)	Nursing (degree or diploma), specialist assistant roles

Entry route	Typical requirements	Where it can lead
Early childhood education	Certificate or diploma; background check	Room leader, centre manager, teaching
Disability support	Induction training; background check; sometimes a certificate	Specialist support, case management, advocacy
Mental health peer support	Lived experience plus training	Peer support coordinator, community roles

QUESTIONS TO ASK BEFORE TAKING A CARE ROLE

- [ ] What is the hourly rate, and is travel time between clients paid?
- [ ] Are hours guaranteed, or can they change week to week?
- [ ] What training is provided, and is it paid?
- [ ] What support is there for difficult situations (supervision, debriefing)?
- [ ] Is there a clear progression path and funding for qualifications?
- [ ] What is the policy on lifting and safety equipment?
- [ ] Is the employer registered and inspected by the relevant authority?

TIP

Your previous career can be an advantage in care. People with experience in management, administration, IT or customer service often move quickly into coordinator, scheduling, training or quality roles once they understand the frontline work.

Helping local small businesses adopt technology

Many small businesses (cafés, salons, garages, clinics, trades firms, shops) know they should be using new tools but do not have the time or confidence. They are not looking for an AI expert. They are looking for someone patient and trustworthy who can explain options in plain language, set things up and show staff how to use them.

If you have office, tech, admin or customer service experience, you may already have exactly the skills they need. This can be a freelance service (Chapter 15), a part-time role or a small business (Chapter 16).

What local businesses often need

- Online booking and reminders to reduce no-shows
- Up-to-date map listings, opening hours and simple websites
- Help answering reviews and customer messages
- Setting up AI tools for drafting emails, menus, quotes and social posts, with clear rules for checking them
- Moving from paper records to simple digital systems
- Basic cybersecurity: passwords, backups, recognising scam emails
- Training staff on new tools

SCRIPT: APPROACHING A LOCAL BUSINESS IN PERSON

"Hi, I'm [Name]. I live locally and I help small businesses set up simple tools for things like bookings, reviews and admin. I noticed [specific observation, e.g. 'your hours on the map listing are different from the sign on the door']. I'm not here to sell you anything today, but I'd be happy to leave my details. If you ever want a free 20-minute chat about what might save you time, just let me know."

TIP

Start where you already have a relationship: the businesses you use, the ones friends own, and local business associations or chambers of commerce. A talk at a local business breakfast on "Using AI tools safely in a small business" can bring in several clients at once.

Cooperatives and community enterprises

A cooperative is a business owned and run by its members, who might be its workers, customers or a community. Members share decisions and profits. Cooperatives exist in many sectors: food, housing, cleaning, home care, childcare, renewable energy, retail, tech and more.

Community enterprises and social enterprises are businesses that trade to serve a community or social purpose, such as a community shop, a repair café that charges a small fee, or a local energy project.

Why consider them

- **Shared risk.** Starting with others spreads cost and effort.
- **More control.** Workers have a say in how the business is run.
- **Pooled skills.** One person handles bookkeeping, another sales, another the core service.
- **Community support.** Local people often want to support businesses that keep money and jobs in the area.
- **Platform alternatives.** Some worker-owned groups have formed cooperative alternatives to gig platforms, such as for cleaning, delivery or care, so workers keep more of what customers pay.

The challenges

Group decisions take time. Disagreements can be hard, especially among friends. You still need customers, a sound business model and good governance. Cooperatives work best with clear rules agreed at the start: how decisions are made, how profits are shared, how people join and leave.

1. **Find people with a shared need.** Former colleagues, people in your trade, or neighbours who want the same service.
2. **Get advice.** Most countries have cooperative development bodies or federations that offer free guidance, model rules and training. Search for “cooperative development” plus your country or region.
3. **Test the business first.** Use the validation steps in Chapter 16 before forming a legal structure.
4. **Agree on governance in writing.** Decisions, roles, money, conflict resolution and exit.
5. **Register the right structure.** Rules vary by country; get advice on which legal form fits.

Public sector and nonprofit routes

Governments, local councils, schools, hospitals, universities and nonprofits employ huge numbers of people in almost every country. These jobs are not immune to AI or budget cuts, but they often offer more stability, structured pay, pensions and a strong sense of purpose.

Where to look

- **Local and regional government:** planning, housing, environmental services, social services, libraries, parks, administration, IT.
- **National government:** civil service roles, tax and benefits agencies, regulators.
- **Health and education:** administration, facilities, IT, support staff, teaching assistants, and clinical roles.
- **Infrastructure and utilities:** water, transport, energy networks, often with apprenticeships.
- **Nonprofits and charities:** program delivery, fundraising, volunteer management, finance, communications, advocacy.

What to know about applying

Public sector recruitment is usually formal and slow. Applications often ask you to show evidence against specific criteria or competencies, so read the job description carefully and use concrete examples for each one (the STAR method from Chapter 14 works well). Some countries have special programs to bring career changers into teaching, social work or public service, sometimes with paid training.

Nonprofit pay is often lower than in the private sector, though not always. Many people find the trade-off worthwhile. Volunteering for a few hours a week can be a way to test a sector, build local contacts and gain recent experience (see Chapter 19), but be cautious about unpaid "internships" that are really jobs.

Mapping your local opportunities

Opportunities close to home are often invisible until you look for them on purpose. Spend a week paying attention. Read local news and community noticeboards, notice "help wanted" signs, ask the people you meet what is hard to find

in your area, and check which services have long waiting lists. Then write it down.

WORKSHEET 18.1 — LOCAL OPPORTUNITY MAP

Area	Who is hiring or struggling to find help?	Skills or training needed	Next step and contact
Skilled trades			
Care and health			
Education and childcare			
Local small businesses			
Energy, infrastructure and utilities			
Local government and public services			
Nonprofits and community groups			
Cooperatives or shared ventures			

Good places to gather information include your local public employment service, which often knows which employers are struggling to hire; colleges, which know where their graduates find work; business associations; and libraries, many of which run job clubs and hold local labour market information. Ask each of them the same question: “Which local employers can’t find enough people?”

DO THIS NOW

1. Find your local council or municipal jobs page and your national public service jobs portal. Set up email alerts.
2. Search for one apprenticeship program near you for adults.
3. List five local businesses you use and note one tech problem each seems to have.
4. Look up your country's or region's cooperative development body.

The jobs that keep a town running are still being done by people. Some of those people could be you.

Should you move? Making a relocation decision

Sometimes the work you want is not where you live. Moving to a city, a different region or another country can open doors. It can also be expensive, lonely and disruptive, especially for families. This is a decision that deserves careful thought, not panic.

Three factors to weigh

- **Cost of living.** A higher salary in a big city may vanish into rent. Compare housing, transport, childcare and everyday costs, not just pay.
- **Opportunity.** How many relevant jobs or clients are there? Are they growing? Could you get them from where you are, through remote or hybrid work?
- **Support network.** Family, friends, childcare help, community and healthcare relationships have real value, both emotional and financial. Losing them has a cost that is easy to underestimate.

Before you decide

- **Test before you commit.** Visit, ideally for several days during a normal week. If possible, line up interviews or work while you are there.
- **Secure a job first, if you can.** Moving without work is a much bigger financial risk. Some employers pay relocation costs, so ask.

- **Check practicalities.** Qualification recognition, licences, visas, healthcare registration, schools, and whether your benefits transfer.
- **Consider partial moves.** A temporary contract, weekly commuting, or renting before buying can lower the risk.
- **Talk to people who live there**, ideally in your field, about what it is really like.

WORKSHEET 18.2 — RELOCATION DECISION

Factor	Where I live now	Possible new location	Which is better, and by how much?
Monthly housing cost			
Other monthly living costs (transport, food, childcare)			
Realistic income I could earn			
Number of suitable jobs or clients			
Growth of my field there			
Family and friends nearby			
Childcare or care support			
Healthcare and schools			
One-off moving costs			
How my partner or family feels			
Quality of life (my own score, 1–10)			

Illustrative numbers only: suppose a job in a city pays 600 more per month than anything you can find locally, but rent there is 700 more and you would lose free childcare from your parents worth around 400 a month. On paper the move costs you about 500 a month, before moving costs. The decision might still be right for long-term career reasons, but you would be making it with clear eyes.

WATCH OUT

If you are considering moving to another country for work, be very careful with recruiters who charge fees, hold your passport, or promise visas in exchange for payment. These are signs of exploitation or trafficking. Use official government immigration websites and verified employers (see Chapter 14 on job scams).

What does your local community need that it does not have enough of? Which of those needs could you help with, using skills you already have or could learn?

REMEMBER

- Skilled trades and care work are in demand and hard to automate, but be realistic about pay, physical demands and training time.
- Use apprenticeships, recognised courses and helper roles to test and train. Avoid courses that promise quick qualifications.
- Local small businesses often need patient, trustworthy help adopting technology, and your past experience may fit perfectly.
- Cooperatives and community enterprises let you share risk and control with others, with clear rules agreed at the start.
- Public sector and nonprofit roles can offer stability and purpose; applications are formal, so match evidence to criteria.
- Weigh relocation on cost of living, opportunity and support network, and test before you commit.

Your next step: Walk or scroll through your local area and list five places where work is clearly needed: a business struggling with tech, a care service hiring, a trade with long waits. Pick one to find out more about this week.

PART VI

Meaning, Resilience and the Long Game

You are more than your job title. This final part is about rebuilding identity and purpose, leaning on the people around you, handling particular situations, and building a life that can adapt to whatever comes next.

19 · Finding Meaning Beyond the Job Title
20 · Relationships, Family and Community
21 · Special Situations
22 · Future-Proofing for Life

CHAPTER 19

Finding Meaning Beyond the Job Title

Your job was one place where your life had meaning. It was never the only one. This chapter helps you separate your worth from your work, rebuild a sense of who you are, and find purpose through contribution, craft, connection, creativity and real rest, while you search and long after.

"So, what do you do?" For many people, this is the hardest question after losing a job. It comes up at family dinners, at the school gate, at parties, in small talk with strangers. Before, you had a quick answer. Now you pause, and the pause feels like a confession.

That pause tells you something important. It shows how much of your identity was built around your job title. That's not a flaw. Most of us are raised to answer "Who are you?" with "What do you do for money?"

But when work changes fast, as it is changing now with AI, tying your whole self to one role is risky. Roles can be reorganised, automated or cut in a single meeting. Your character, your care for others, your skills and your curiosity cannot. This chapter is about building a sense of meaning that doesn't disappear when a job does.

None of this replaces the need for income; Chapters 3, 11 and 17 deal with that directly. But meaning is not a luxury you earn after you're employed again. It's part of how you get through.

Separating your worth from your work

Your work is what you do. Your worth is who you are. When those two get fused, losing a job feels like losing your value as a person. Pulling them apart is one of the most useful things you can do for yourself right now.

Here is a simple test. Think of someone you love who is not working: a retired parent, a child, a friend on long-term sick leave, a partner caring for a new baby. Do you think they are worth less as a person? Almost certainly not. You value them for their kindness, their humour, the way they listen, the history you share. Those same things are true about you.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> A job is a deal: you trade time and skill for money. When the deal ends, it says something about the market, the company's costs and the state of technology. It does not measure your value as a human being. Losing a job to automation is a statement about what software can now do cheaply, not a verdict on you.

Notice the "worth stories" you tell yourself

After job loss, many people carry quiet stories in their heads. These stories feel like facts, but they are interpretations. Naming them helps you loosen their grip.

THE WORTH STORY	A TRUER VERSION
• "If I'm not earning, I'm a burden."	• "My income has paused. My contribution to the people around me hasn't."
• "A machine replaced me, so I must not have been good."	• "Certain tasks became cheap to automate. My judgment and experience are still mine."
• "I'm wasting my life every day I'm not working."	• "I'm in a transition. Transitions take time and effort, and that effort counts."
• "I was my job. Without it I'm nobody."	• "I used my strengths in that job. I still have them."

You don't have to fully believe the right-hand column yet. Just notice when the left-hand story shows up, and say the truer version to yourself. Over weeks, this changes how you feel.

What "worth story" has been loudest in your head since your work changed? Write it down, then write a truer, kinder version beside it.

Rebuilding your identity after job loss

Identity is not one thing. It's made of many roles, values and relationships layered together. Think of it like a table. If your whole identity rests on one leg, the job, it falls over when that leg is kicked away. If it rests on many legs, losing one hurts, but the table still stands.

Your identity has more legs than you think

Most people already have many legs; they just stopped noticing them. Common ones include:

- **Relationships:** parent, partner, sibling, friend, neighbour, mentor, grandchild.
- **Values:** honesty, fairness, loyalty, faith, curiosity, generosity.
- **Craft and skill:** the cook, the fixer, the organiser, the one who explains things well.
- **Community:** member of a congregation, club, team, union, cultural group or online community.

1. **List your current legs.** Write down every role, value, skill and relationship that is part of you. Aim for at least 15. Small ones count: "the person who remembers everyone's birthday" is a real part of who you are.
2. **Mark the weak ones.** Which legs have you neglected because work took all your time? An old friendship, a sport, a hobby, a faith practice?
3. **Strengthen one leg this week.** Pick one neglected leg and do one small thing for it. Call the friend. Go to the club once. Pick up the guitar for 20 minutes.
4. **Add one new leg this month.** Try something you've never been: a volunteer, a learner in a new field, a member of a new group. You don't need to commit forever.
5. **Practise a new answer.** Prepare a few honest ways to answer "What do you do?" that aren't just a job title (see the script below).

SCRIPT: ANSWERING "SO, WHAT DO YOU DO?"

If you want to keep it short: "I was a [role] for [number] years. Right now I'm between roles and looking at [field or direction]. Lately I've been spending a lot of time on [project, volunteering or interest]."

If you want to open a door: "I've worked in [field], mostly helping with [the problem you solved]. I'm exploring what's next, especially around [area]. If you know anyone working on that, I'd love to hear about it."

If you'd rather not talk about work: "I'm in a bit of a transition, honestly. The best part of my week right now is [something you enjoy]. What about you, what's keeping you busy?"

A STORY

This is an illustrative composite. Rosa, 52, spent 18 years as a translator in Madrid before most of her agency's work moved to machine translation with light human editing. For months she couldn't say the word "translator" without feeling a lump in her throat. When she listed her identity legs, she was surprised: grandmother, choir member, the friend everyone calls when they need a letter written, a lifelong lover of poetry. She started helping newly arrived families at a local community centre with forms and appointments. She still doesn't know exactly where her career will land. But she says that the question "What do you do?" no longer feels like a trap. "I help people understand each other," she now says. "I just don't always get paid for it yet."

Three sources of purpose: contribution, craft and connection

A job often gives you purpose without you having to think about it. Once it's gone, you have to find purpose on purpose. A useful way to think about this is three sources that most people draw on. You don't need all three at full strength. But if one is empty, you'll probably feel it.

Source	What it feels like	Ways to find it outside a job
Contribution	"Someone is better off because of what I did."	Helping a neighbour, volunteering, caregiving, mentoring, sharing what you know, mutual aid

Source	What it feels like	Ways to find it outside a job
Craft	"I'm getting better at something that's hard."	Learning a skill, building or making things, practising an instrument or sport, a personal project done well
Connection	"I belong somewhere. People notice when I'm not there."	Clubs, classes, faith groups, sports teams, community groups, regular meet-ups with friends

Contribution: being useful to someone

Feeling useless is one of the most painful parts of losing work. The fastest cure is to be useful to someone, today, in a small way. Help an older neighbour set up their phone. Proofread a friend's CV. Cook a meal for a family with a new baby. Answer questions in an online forum about something you know well.

Contribution shifts your attention from "What's wrong with me?" to "What can I offer?" That second question is also the heart of a good job search.

Craft: getting better at something

Craft is the quiet satisfaction of doing something well and improving at it. Many people lost this when their work was broken into small, measured tasks. You can get it back through anything that has skill in it: woodworking, baking bread, coding a small app, writing, sewing, repairing bikes, learning a language, training for a 10K.

Connection: belonging somewhere

Work often supplied most of our daily social contact. When it goes, loneliness can creep in fast, especially for people who live alone or who worked remotely. Connection needs regular, repeated contact with the same people. One big social event won't do it. A weekly walking group will.

> **TIP**
>
> Look for “regulars” activities, things that happen at the same time and place every week: a parkrun or running club, a choir, a community garden, a weekly volunteer shift, a library book group, a pick-up football game, a repair café. Repeated contact with familiar faces is what slowly turns strangers into friends.

Of contribution, craft and connection, which one feels emptiest in your life right now? What is one small thing you could do this week to add a little of it back?

Volunteering strategically

Volunteering is one of the best things you can do in a transition. It gives you contribution, connection and often craft, all at once. It also brings structure to your week and something positive to talk about.

Done thoughtfully, it can also build skills, references and a network that help your search. That isn’t cynical. Organisations get real help, and you get real experience. Both sides win.

What strategic volunteering can give you

- **Fresh, current experience** to put on your CV and talk about in interviews, which also helps explain a gap.
- **New skills** in a field you want to move into, such as event planning, fundraising, social media, bookkeeping, care work, teaching or project coordination.
- **References** from people who have seen you work recently.

- **A network** of board members, staff, donors and fellow volunteers, many of whom have jobs and connections in the wider community.
- **A low-risk test** of a new path before you spend money retraining (see Chapter 9 on small experiments).

Matching volunteering to your goals

If your goal is...	Consider volunteering as...
Moving into healthcare or care work	Hospital or hospice volunteer, befriending older people, disability support charity
Teaching or training	Adult literacy tutor, homework club, digital skills helper at a library
Project or operations roles	Event coordinator, volunteer manager, logistics at a food bank
Marketing or communications	Running social media, newsletters or a website for a small charity
Leadership or board experience	Trustee or board member of a local nonprofit or school

To find roles, try your local volunteer centre or council, community notice-boards, libraries, faith groups and national volunteer matching websites. Many countries have them; for example, VolunteerMatch and Idealist in the US, Do-it in the UK, Volunteer Canada, and Volunteering Australia. Check what exists where you live.

BEFORE YOU SAY YES TO A VOLUNTEER ROLE

- [ ] I know roughly how many hours a week it needs, and it fits around my job search.
- [ ] It gives me at least one of: a skill I want, people I want to meet, or work I care about.
- [ ] There's a named person I report to who could later act as a reference.
- [ ] I understand whether there are costs (travel, background checks) and whether they're reimbursed.
- [ ] I've checked that volunteering won't affect any unemployment benefit I receive (some systems have rules about hours or availability for work).

WATCH OUT

Volunteering is not the same as working for free for a business. Be cautious of "unpaid trial projects," long unpaid "internships" for profit-making companies, or anyone asking you to do real paid work for "exposure." Real volunteering is for charities, community groups, public services or causes, not to replace a paid worker. In many countries it can also break employment law.

When you add volunteering to your CV or LinkedIn profile, treat it like a job: give your role a clear title and list concrete results. "Coordinated 25 volunteers for a weekly food distribution serving around 300 households" is far stronger than "Helped at food bank."

Creativity as a lifeline

You might think creativity is for "creative people." It isn't. Everyone has a creative side, whether it shows up in cooking, fixing things, gardening, telling stories, drawing, arranging a room, making music or solving puzzles.

Creativity gives you a sense of control when much of life feels out of your hands. It absorbs you so worries quiet down for a while. And it reminds you that you can still make things that didn't exist before.

But what about AI?

Some people feel discouraged from creative hobbies because AI can generate pictures, music and writing in seconds. If you've lost creative work to AI, this can hurt in a very personal way. It's worth saying clearly: the value of making something yourself was never only in the finished product. It lives in the process, in what you notice, learn and feel while you make it.

A machine-generated painting doesn't give you the hour of calm you get from painting. A generated song doesn't give you the joy of playing with friends. You are allowed to make things for the experience alone. If you enjoy using AI tools in your creative process, that's fine too.

The value of making something yourself was never only in the finished product. It lives in what making it does to you.

Ways to start, with little or no money

- **Make it tiny.** Fifteen minutes a day of drawing, writing, playing or building is enough. Don't wait for a free afternoon.
- **Use what you have.** A pencil and paper, a phone camera, kitchen ingredients, an old instrument, a library card.
- **Lower the bar.** Aim to make something bad on purpose. It takes the pressure off and usually leads to something good.
- **Join others.** Community art classes, open mic nights, maker spaces and craft circles add connection to creativity. Many libraries and community centres run free or low-cost sessions.

A STORY

This is an illustrative composite. Daniel, 34, in Manchester, had been a junior software developer until his team was cut as coding agents took over much of the routine work. He spent the first month refreshing job boards for ten hours a day and sleeping badly. A friend dragged him to a repair café, where volunteers fix broken lamps, toasters and bikes. Daniel found he loved it: the puzzle of a fault, the satisfaction when something worked again, the thank-yous. He now goes every other Saturday and has started tinkering with electronics at home. It led him to explore apprenticeships in electrical work, a path he'd never considered. Even before that, he says, it gave him something to look forward to.

What did you love making, building or doing as a child or teenager, before anyone paid you for anything? What would a 15-minute version of it look like this week?

Rest without guilt

When you're out of work, rest can feel forbidden. You might feel that every hour not spent applying is a failure, or that you have to "earn" time off by being busy. Many people end up in a strange state: not truly working, not truly resting, just anxious all day in front of a screen.

That pattern burns you out without moving you forward. Rest isn't laziness. It's maintenance: a rested mind writes better applications and makes wiser decisions.

KEY IDEA

A job search is closer to a marathon than a sprint. Plan for a sustainable pace: focused work time, real breaks, and at least one day a week that is fully off. Rest is part of the plan, not a break from it.

Different kinds of rest

Sleep is essential, but it isn't the only kind of rest you need. Different kinds of tiredness need different kinds of rest.

If you feel...	You may need...	Try...
Physically drained, heavy	Physical rest	Sleep, naps, gentle stretching, a slow walk, a bath
Foggy, scattered, can't focus	Mental rest	Short breaks every hour, time away from screens, a walk without your phone
Overwhelmed by news and feeds	Sensory rest	Turning off notifications, quiet time, limiting news to once a day
Emotionally worn out	Emotiona l rest	Talking honestly with someone safe, journaling, a good cry
Lonely or drained by people	Social rest	Time with people who refill you, and less time with those who drain you
Uninspired, flat	Creative rest	Nature, music, art, a new place, something beautiful

How to rest without the guilt

1. **Schedule your job search hours.** Decide your "work hours" for the search, for example 9 a.m. to 1 p.m. on weekdays (see Chapter 11 for a weekly system). When they're done, you're allowed to stop.
2. **Schedule rest too.** Put rest in your calendar like an appointment: a walk at 3 p.m., Sunday fully off. Planned rest feels less like slacking.
3. **Close the loop each day.** At the end of your search hours, write down what you did and the first task for tomorrow. This helps your brain let go.
4. **Notice the guilt, then don't obey it.** When guilt says "You should be applying," answer: "I did my hours. Resting now makes tomorrow's work better."
5. **Choose rest that actually restores you.** Hours of scrolling rarely leave people feeling better. Pick rest that fits the kind of tiredness you feel.

WATCH OUT

There's a difference between rest and withdrawal. If you find yourself sleeping much more than usual, losing interest in everything you used to enjoy, avoiding everyone, or feeling hopeless for more than a couple of weeks, this may be depression rather than tiredness. Please talk to a doctor or mental health professional, and see Chapter 4 for support options and crisis lines.

What does "real rest" look like for you, rest that leaves you feeling better rather than more anxious? What gets in the way of it, and what is one permission you can give yourself this week?

Your meaning map

Now let's bring this together into something practical. A meaning map is a one-page picture of where meaning comes from in your life, how strong each source is right now, and one small action to strengthen it. It's not a test; nobody scores full marks.

Rate each area from 1 (empty) to 5 (full), then write one small action for any area you'd like to strengthen. Skip rows that don't apply.

WORKSHEET 19.1 — YOUR MEANING MAP

Area of life	What gives me meaning here	Strength now (1–5)	One small action in the next 2 weeks
Close relationships (partner, family, friends)			
Contribution (helping others, caregiving, volunteering)			

Area of life	What gives me meaning here	Strength now (1–5)	One small action in the next 2 weeks
Craft and learning (skills I'm building)			
Connection and community (groups I belong to)			
Creativity and play			
Body and health			
Rest and renewal			
Values, faith or a bigger purpose			
Nature and place (where I live, the outdoors)			
Paid work and career direction			

Reading your map

- **Look for your strong areas first.** These are your anchors. Protect them, especially during stressful weeks.
- **Pick no more than two weak areas to work on.** Trying to fix everything at once usually leads to fixing nothing.
- **Notice where areas overlap.** A weekly volunteer shift might boost contribution, connection and career direction at once. A walking group helps body, connection and rest. Look for those multipliers.
- **Revisit it monthly.** Your map will shift as your situation changes. Redo it every month or so, and keep the old versions to see your progress.

DO THIS NOW

1. Set a timer for 20 minutes and fill in the meaning map.
2. Circle your two strongest areas and your two weakest.
3. For each weak area, choose one action small enough to do in under an hour.
4. Put both actions in your calendar for the next seven days.
5. Tell one person what you're planning. Saying it out loud makes it more likely to happen.

More journaling prompts

Writing helps you see feelings that are hard to notice while they swirl in your head. You don't need to write well. Pick one prompt and write without editing.

Think of a moment in your life, at work or outside it, when you felt truly useful and alive. What were you doing? Who was there? What does that moment tell you about what you need now?

Who are three people whose lives are better because you are in them? What do you think each of them would say you give them?

What did your last job give you that you miss most: structure, status, people, purpose, challenge or something else? Where else could you get some of that, starting this month?

> **TIP**
>
> If writing feels hard, speak your answers into a voice memo while you walk. For deeper struggles, a counsellor or trusted friend is the better choice.

Meaning and the job search

None of this is a distraction from the "real work" of finding a job. Volunteering, projects and creative work give you recent stories for interviews (Chapter 14). Every group you join widens your network without "networking" (Chapter 12). And a person with a full life outside the search usually shows up calmer and more grounded.

Finding meaning beyond your job title isn't about pretending work doesn't matter. It does, for money, for structure and for pride. It's about making sure your sense of who you are rests on more than one leg, so that whatever happens with work, you are still standing.

REMEMBER

- Your work is what you do; your worth is who you are. Losing a job says something about the market and technology, not about your value as a person.
- Identity is like a table: the more legs it rests on (relationships, values, skills, community, interests), the steadier you are when one is lost.
- Purpose usually comes from three sources: contribution, craft and connection. Notice which one is emptiest and add a little of it back.
- Strategic volunteering gives you meaning, structure, fresh experience, references and a wider network. Check benefit rules and avoid unpaid work for profit-making businesses.
- Creativity is for everyone. Its value is in the process, whatever AI can produce.
- Rest is part of the plan. Schedule your search hours, schedule real rest, and watch for signs that tiredness has become depression.
- Your meaning map shows where to put your energy. Work on no more than two areas at a time and revisit it monthly.

Your next step: Fill in Worksheet 19.1, your meaning map, today. Then put one small action for your weakest area in your calendar for this week.

CHAPTER 20

Relationships, Family and Community

Losing work doesn't only happen to you. It happens to everyone around you. This chapter gives you words for hard conversations, ways to ask for help without shame, a simple plan for starting a support group, and a page you can hand to the people who love you.

When a job ends, the news rarely stays inside one person. It walks into the kitchen, sits at the dinner table and climbs into bed at night. Partners worry about the mortgage. Children pick up on the tension even when nobody says a word. Friends don't know whether to ask or stay quiet, so many of them say nothing at all.

It's easy to pull away during this time. You may feel embarrassed, tired of explaining, or afraid of being a burden. But the people around you are one of the strongest resources you have, often stronger than any course, tool or job board. The goal of this chapter is to help you keep those connections alive and use them well, without pretending everything is fine.

Talking to Your Partner About Money and Plans

If you share a home or finances with someone, the first big conversation after a job loss is often the hardest. Both of you may be scared. One of you may want to make a plan right now, while the other needs a few days just to feel the shock. Neither approach is wrong. They just need to meet in the middle.

The aim is not to solve everything in one talk. It's to agree that you're on the same team, share the facts, and set a time to make decisions together.

Pick a calm time, away from the children. Bring the numbers if you've done the runway math in Chapter 3. And say at the start whether you need comfort tonight or a plan.

SCRIPT: THE FIRST MONEY CONVERSATION

"I want to talk about where we stand now that my job has ended. I'm scared, and I'm guessing you might be too. I don't want to hide anything from you."

"Here's what I know so far: my last paycheck arrives on [date]. Severance is [amount or 'still unclear']. I've applied for [benefit] and should hear by [date]. Based on our current spending, we have about [number] months before things get really tight."

"I don't want us to make every decision tonight. Can we agree on two things? First, that we'll look at the budget together on [day] and decide what to cut. Second, that if either of us is panicking, we'll say so instead of keeping it in."

"What are you most worried about? I'd rather hear it now than guess."

Keep the conversation going

One talk is not enough. Money stress grows in silence. A short weekly check-in helps. Keep it practical and kind.

1. **Feelings first (5 minutes).** Each person says how they're doing this week, in one or two sentences, without the other fixing it.
2. **Numbers (5 minutes).** What came in, what went out, how many months of runway are left.
3. **Progress (5 minutes).** What the job search, training or side income looked like this week. Celebrate effort, not just results.
4. **One decision (5 minutes).** Agree on one thing: a cost to cut, a bill to call about, a deadline to set. Write it down.

When you disagree about big plans

Sooner or later, a bigger question appears. Should you retrain for a year? Move to a cheaper city? Start a business? Take the first job offered, even if it pays less? These are shared decisions, and they can strain even strong relationships.

Try to separate the *goal* from the *method*. You may both want security and a future you feel good about, but disagree on how to get there. When you name the shared goal out loud, the argument often softens. Then you can talk about

trade-offs, timelines and a "check point" where you'll review the choice together.

WATCH OUT

Hiding money problems from a partner, such as quietly running up a credit card or not mentioning a missed payment, almost always makes things worse when it comes out. If you're tempted to hide something, that's a sign to talk sooner, not later. And if a conversation ever becomes threatening or unsafe, your safety comes first. Domestic abuse hotlines exist in most countries and can help confidentially.

Talking to Children

Children notice more than adults think. They hear tone of voice, closed doors and phone calls. If no one explains what's happening, they fill the gap with their own guesses, which are often scarier than the truth. Some young children even believe that something they did caused the trouble.

You don't need to share every detail. You need to be honest, calm and reassuring, at a level that fits their age. The core message for any child is the same: *this is a grown-up problem, the grown-ups are handling it, and you are safe and loved.*

Young children (roughly 3 to 8)

- **Keep it short and simple.** One or two sentences is often enough.
- **Focus on what stays the same.** Bedtime, school, the dog, their favourite cereal on Saturdays.
- **Reassure them it's not their fault.** Say it directly, even if they haven't asked.
- **Expect repeat questions.** Young children often ask the same thing many times. That's how they process it.

SCRIPT: FOR A YOUNG CHILD

"You know how I go to work every day? My job has ended, so I'll be home more for a while. I'm going to look for a new job. Sometimes I might seem a bit tired or busy thinking, but that's not because of anything you did. We're okay. You'll still go to school, and we'll still have our Friday movie night."

Teenagers

Teens can handle honesty, and they usually spot it when you're not being straight with them. They may also be anxious about their own future, especially if they hear that AI is "taking jobs." This conversation can be a chance to model calm, practical resilience, which is one of the most useful lessons you can give them.

- **Share the real picture, without the weight.** Tell them the facts, but don't make them your main emotional support. That job belongs to other adults.
- **Ask what they've heard.** They may have picked up ideas online about AI and jobs. Listen before correcting.
- **Let them help, if they want to.** Some teens feel better with a role, such as helping plan cheaper meals or teaching you a tool. Never push them to take on paid work to support the family.
- **Talk about their future, too.** Share what you're learning about which skills last (see Chapter 6). It can turn fear into curiosity.

SCRIPT: FOR A TEENAGER

"I want to be straight with you about something. My company cut a lot of jobs, partly because they're using AI for some of the work, and mine was one of them. We have some savings and I'm getting [benefit], so we're not in crisis. But we'll be more careful with money for a while, which means [specific change]."

"I'm figuring out my next step, and honestly it's been stressful. That's my job to deal with, not yours. But I'd like you to know what's going on rather than guess. Is there anything you're worried about, about us or about your own plans?"

TIP

Let your child's school counsellor or a trusted teacher know, briefly, that the family is going through a change. They can watch for signs of stress and offer support. You don't have to share details. "We've had a job loss at home and things are a bit unsettled" is enough.

Signs a child may need more support

Some worry is normal and passes. Watch for changes that last more than a few weeks: trouble sleeping, frequent stomach aches, pulling away from friends, falling grades, anger that seems out of character, or a teen talking about feeling hopeless. If you see these, talk to your family doctor, a school counsellor or a children's mental health service in your area.

Asking For Help and Accepting It

Many people find it much easier to give help than to ask for it. Asking can feel like admitting failure. But think about how you feel when a friend trusts you with a problem. Most people feel honoured, not burdened. Your friends and family likely feel the same way about you.

> *Asking for help is not a sign that you've failed. It's a sign that you're serious about getting through this.*

The secret to asking well is to be **specific**. "Let me know if you need anything" is kind, but it rarely leads anywhere. A clear, small request is far easier for people to say yes to.

Vague	Specific
"Keep an eye out for jobs for me."	"I'm looking for project coordinator roles in healthcare. Do you know anyone at the hospital I could have a 20-minute chat with?"
"Could you look at my CV sometime?"	"Could you spend 15 minutes this week reading my CV and telling me the one thing that's unclear?"
"Things are tough right now."	"Could you pick up the kids on Tuesdays this month so I can go to my training course?"
"I'm feeling down."	"Could we go for a walk on Saturday morning? I could use the company."

SCRIPT: TELLING A FRIEND AND ASKING FOR ONE THING

"Hi [Name], I wanted you to hear it from me: my job at [company] ended last month. I'm okay, but it's been a big adjustment. I'm now looking at [type of role or path]."

"I have one small ask, and it's totally fine to say no. [Specific request, e.g. 'Would you be willing to introduce me to your cousin who works in logistics?']"

"Either way, I'd love to catch up soon. It's been too long."

Accepting help gracefully

When someone offers help, the instinct is often to say "Oh, no, I'm fine." Try saying "Thank you, that would really help" instead. If you truly don't need what's being offered, you can redirect: "That's so kind. What would really help right now is..."

Relationships run on giving *and* receiving over many years. You will have chances to return the kindness, to them or to someone else.

KEY IDEA

Money from family and friends deserves a clear conversation. If someone lends you money, agree in writing (even a simple text) on the amount, whether it's a gift or a loan, and roughly when and how you'll pay it back. Clarity protects the relationship. Unclear money is one of the most common reasons families fall out.

Mutual Aid and Job-Search Support Groups

Mutual aid simply means people in the same situation helping each other. It's not charity, and no one is the expert. A group of five job seekers who meet weekly can share leads, review each other's applications, practise interviews, and, just as important, remind each other that they're not alone.

Job-search groups have existed for decades in churches, libraries, alumni networks and community centres. They work because job searching alone is lonely and easy to put off. A group adds gentle accountability, more eyes on the job market, and a weekly reason to get dressed and show up.

Find one first

Before starting your own, check what already exists near you. Places to look:

- Public employment services and job centres, which often run free job clubs
- Libraries, community centres and religious communities
- Alumni offices, professional associations and trade unions
- Online communities for your industry or former employer

How to start your own

If nothing fits, starting a group is easier than it sounds. You don't need permission, money or experience leading meetings. You need a few people, a time and a simple format.

STARTING A SUPPORT GROUP

- [ ] Find 3 to 4 people to begin with: former colleagues, people from a course, neighbours, or members of an online community
- [ ] Pick a regular time (same day and hour each week) and a length (60 to 90 minutes)
- [ ] Choose a place: a library meeting room, a café, someone's home, or a video call
- [ ] Agree on a small group size (4 to 8 works well, so everyone gets time to speak)
- [ ] Agree on simple ground rules (see below) at the first meeting
- [ ] Rotate a facilitator each week so no one carries the load alone
- [ ] Set up one shared space for leads and notes, such as a group chat or shared document
- [ ] Plan to review the group after 6 to 8 weeks: what's working, what to change

Ground rules that keep a group healthy

- **Confidentiality.** What people share about their money, health or family stays in the room.
- **Everyone gets airtime.** Use a timer if needed. No one dominates.

- **Encourage, don't lecture.** Offer ideas when asked. Ask "Would feedback help?" before giving it.
- **No selling.** The group is not a place to recruit people into paid courses, schemes or "business opportunities."
- **Celebrate leaving.** When someone finds work, they graduate with applause, and are welcome to come back and help.

A weekly meeting format

A clear structure keeps meetings useful and stops them from turning into hour-long complaint sessions. Here is a 75-minute format you can adapt.

1. **Check-in (10 minutes).** Each person shares one word or sentence about how they're feeling this week. No discussion yet, just listening.
2. **Wins and progress (15 minutes).** Each person reports on last week's goals: applications sent, conversations held, skills practised. Small wins count. "I finally updated my LinkedIn" deserves a cheer.
3. **Leads exchange (10 minutes).** Share job openings, contacts, events and resources that might suit someone else in the group. Post them in the shared space too.
4. **Focus session (25 minutes).** One or two members get dedicated help: a mock interview, a CV review, a practice salary negotiation, or problem-solving a stuck point. Rotate who gets this slot each week.
5. **Learning moment (5 minutes, optional).** Someone shares one useful thing they learned, such as an AI tool that saved them time on research or a tip from an informational interview.
6. **Next week's commitments (10 minutes).** Each person states one to three specific, realistic goals for the coming week. Someone writes them down so they can be checked next time.

DO THIS NOW

Send a message to three people who might want to join a weekly job-search group. Keep it short:

"I'm starting a small weekly group for people looking for work, to share leads, practise interviews and keep each other going. Thursdays at 10am, 75 minutes, [location or video link]. Free, no pressure. Want to try one meeting?"

A STORY

Priya, 31, had worked as a translator in Toronto until most of her agency work dried up. She posted in a local community group asking whether anyone else was job hunting and wanted to meet at the library. Five people came the first week, including a laid-off bank teller and a former customer support lead. Within two months, two members had new jobs, one had started an apprenticeship, and Priya had her first freelance client, an introduction from another member's sister. She said the leads mattered, but what mattered most was having somewhere to be on Thursday mornings.

Loneliness: The Hidden Cost of Losing Work

Work gives most people far more than a paycheck. It gives daily contact with others: small talk, shared jokes, lunch, someone who notices if you're having a bad day. When the job goes, that contact often disappears overnight. Even people with loving families can feel deeply lonely after a job loss, because a whole layer of everyday connection is suddenly gone.

Loneliness is not a personal flaw. It is a signal, like hunger, telling you that you need connection. And like hunger, it gets harder to ignore the longer it goes on. Loneliness can also feed low mood, poor sleep and self-doubt, which makes job searching harder. Treating it seriously is part of your job search, not a distraction from it.

Small ways to rebuild daily contact

- **Work around people.** Spend some job-search hours at a library, café or co-working space instead of alone at home.

- **Schedule one social contact a day.** A call, a walk, a coffee, even a voice message to an old friend. Put it in your calendar like an appointment.
- **Join something with a regular rhythm.** A sports club, choir, community garden, volunteer shift or class. Weekly repetition is what turns strangers into friends.
- **Keep in touch with former colleagues.** They are likely going through the same thing and can be both friends and valuable contacts (see Chapter 12).
- **Volunteer.** Helping others is one of the fastest ways to feel useful and connected again (see Chapter 19).
- **Be careful with screens.** Online groups can help, but endless scrolling usually leaves people feeling worse. Aim for real conversations, not just feeds.

Who are three people you've lost touch with since your job ended? What is one small, easy way you could reach out to each of them this week?

WATCH OUT

If loneliness turns into feeling hopeless, worthless, or thinking that others would be better off without you, please reach out for help right away. Contact a doctor, a mental health service, or a crisis line in your country (for example, 988 in the US and Canada, Samaritans on 116 123 in the UK and Ireland, or Lifeline on 13 11 14 in Australia). Chapter 4 has more on getting professional support. You don't have to be in immediate danger to call.

For Friends and Family: How to Support Someone Who Lost Their Job

This section is written for the people around the reader. If you're reading this book because you lost your job, consider sharing these pages with a partner, parent, friend or adult child who wants to help but isn't sure how.

If someone you love has lost their job, you may feel helpless. You can't give them a new job, and you may worry about saying the wrong thing. The good news is that support doesn't require the perfect words. It mostly requires showing up, listening and treating them as the same capable person they were last month.

Remember that job loss often brings grief, shame and fear, even when the person seems calm. Losing work to automation can add an extra sting: a feeling of being replaced or no longer needed. Your steady presence can help push back against that feeling.

DO

- Reach out soon, and keep reaching out after the first week
- Say something simple, like "I'm sorry. That's really hard. How are you doing?"
- Listen more than you talk
- Offer specific help: a meal, a lift, an introduction, a CV read-through
- Invite them to things as you normally would, and pay for the coffee if money is tight
- Ask how they want to be supported, including whether they want job leads
- Notice and name their effort, not just results
- Remind them of their strengths with real examples
- Respect their privacy and let them decide who knows
- Keep checking in after they find work, since the first months can be stressful too

DON'T

- Disappear because you don't know what to say
- Say "Everything happens for a reason" or "At least you get a break now"
- Ask "Any luck yet?" every time you see them
- Blame them, or ask what they did wrong
- Push them to "just learn AI" or "just take anything"
- Forward every job ad you see without asking first
- Compare them to others who "bounced back fast"
- Share their news with others without permission
- Promote a get-rich-quick scheme, paid course or "opportunity"
- Treat them as fragile or as a project to fix

SCRIPT: A MESSAGE TO A FRIEND WHO JUST LOST THEIR JOB

"Hey [Name], I heard about [company]. I'm so sorry. That's a lot to deal with. No need to reply if you're not up for it. I'm around this week if you want to grab a coffee or go for a walk, my treat. And if there's anything specific I can do, like look at your CV or ask around at my work, just say the word."

If you live with them

Partners and family members who share a home face a special challenge. You're offering support while also feeling the money pressure yourself. Both things are real. It's okay to have your own fears, and it's important to find somewhere to share them, such as a friend, counsellor or support group, so that your loved one isn't carrying your worry on top of their own.

Try to avoid becoming their job-search manager. Asking every evening how many applications they sent can feel like surveillance, even when it comes from love. Instead, agree on a regular check-in (like the weekly format earlier in this chapter) and trust them between those times. Keep doing ordinary, enjoyable things together.

When to worry

Sadness, frustration and low energy are normal after a job loss. But watch for signs that someone is struggling more seriously: drinking much more than usual, not getting out of bed for days, cutting off everyone, talking about being a burden, or giving away belongings. If you see these, gently say what you've noticed and encourage them to see a doctor or counsellor. If you think they may be at risk of harming themselves, ask them directly. Asking does not plant the idea. Then contact a crisis line or emergency services in your country.

Being a Support to Others

A few months into this, you'll know things someone newly laid off doesn't: which forms are confusing, which courses were worth it, which recruiters were helpful. Passing that on reminds you that you are still capable, and it builds the kind of network that brings opportunities back. Being two steps ahead of someone is enough.

WORKSHEET 20.1 — YOUR SUPPORT MAP

Type of support	Who could offer it	What I could ask for	When I'll ask
Emotional (listening, comfort)			
Practical (childcare, lifts, meals)			
Job leads and introductions			

Type of support	Who could offer it	What I could ask for	When I'll ask
Feedback (CV, interviews, ideas)			
Fun and distraction			
Someone I can help in return			

REMEMBER

- Talk to your partner early and honestly. Share the numbers, set a regular check-in, and make big decisions together.
- Tell children the truth at their level: it's a grown-up problem, it's not their fault, and they are safe and loved.
- Ask for help in specific, small ways. Accept it with a simple "thank you."
- A weekly job-search group gives you leads, practice, accountability and company. You can start one with three people.
- Loneliness is a real cost of job loss. Build daily human contact on purpose, and reach out for help if you feel hopeless.
- Share the "For Friends and Family" section with the people who want to help you.

Your next step: Fill in one row of Worksheet 20.1 and send one specific request to one person today.

CHAPTER 21

Special Situations

Some readers face extra hurdles on top of the AI shift. This chapter gives focused, practical guidance for six of them, so you can skip to the part that fits your life.

The advice in this book is meant for everyone. But "everyone" is not one person. A 58-year-old operations manager, a 23-year-old graduate, a single parent, someone managing a chronic illness, a worker on a visa, and a translator watching their rates fall all face the same market, with very different pressures.

This chapter does not repeat the core steps from earlier chapters. Instead, it shows how to adapt them to your situation. Read the section that fits you. If more than one fits, read them all. Many people belong to two or three of these groups at once, and the advice stacks.

If You Are Over 50

If you are over 50 and job hunting, you may have already felt it. A recruiter's tone changes when they work out your graduation year. You are told you are "overqualified." Interviews go well and then go quiet. Age bias is real, it is often unspoken, and it is hard to prove.

It is also not the whole story. You bring things that are scarce in an AI-heavy workplace: judgment built over decades, calm in a crisis, a network, and a track record. Machines can draft a report. They cannot tell a nervous client, "I have seen this go wrong before, and here is what we do." Your job is to make that value visible and to remove the easy excuses people use to pass you over.

Defuse the stereotypes before they come up

Most age bias rests on a few lazy assumptions: that older workers are expensive, slow to learn, poor with technology, or about to retire. You cannot argue these away in the abstract. You can quietly disprove them with evidence.

THE UNSPOKEN WORRY

- "They won't pick up new tools."
- "They'll want a senior salary."
- "They won't take direction from a younger manager."
- "They'll leave in two years."
- "They're set in their ways."

YOUR QUIET ANSWER

- Show a recent project where you used AI tools (see Chapter 7).
- Say you are flexible on title and pay for the right fit, if true.
- Mention a time you worked well for or with a younger lead.
- Talk about what you want to build over the next several years.
- Share something you learned in the last six months.

Make your CV look current, not long

You do not need to hide your age, but you do not need to advertise it either. Focus your CV on the last 10 to 15 years. Summarise older roles in one line, or group them under "Earlier career." Drop graduation years if they are not required. Use a modern, simple layout and a professional email address.

Above all, lead with recent results. A line like "Cut invoice errors by a third in 2025 by redesigning the review process with AI-assisted checks" says "current" far louder than any claim about being "tech-savvy."

Leverage experience as a product

Experience is most valuable when it is specific. "30 years in logistics" is a fact. "I know why warehouse rollouts fail and how to stop it" is an offer. Look through your achievements bank (Chapter 8) for problems you have solved more than once. Those are the seeds of consulting work (Chapter 15), advisory roles, training others, or a strong pitch for a full-time role.

Consider bridge roles

A bridge role is work that carries you from your last career to your next phase. It may pay less or carry less status, but it brings income, structure, and contacts. Examples include part-time or contract work in your old field, interim management, training and mentoring, project roles, advisory work for small firms, or roles in growing fields like care, education, and skilled trades (Chapter 18).

> **A STORY**
>
> *Illustrative composite. Margaret, 61, spent 25 years as an office manager for a law firm in Manchester before the firm automated most of its scheduling and billing. After months of silence from online applications, she contacted three former colleagues who had moved to smaller firms. One hired her on a three-day-a-week contract to set up their new AI-assisted intake system and train staff. She now does similar work for two other firms. "I stopped applying for my old job," she says, "and started selling what I knew."*

Know your rights, and choose your battles

Many countries ban age discrimination at work. In the US, federal law protects workers aged 40 and over. The UK's Equality Act 2010 lists age as a protected characteristic, and EU countries, Canada, and Australia have their own protections. If you see clear signs of age-based rejection or a layoff that targeted older staff, keep notes and speak to a local employment advisor, union, or lawyer. Sometimes a claim is worth pursuing. Often the better use of your energy is moving toward employers who value you.

Pension and retirement timing: get advice first

This is where people over 50 can make costly, permanent mistakes under stress. Decisions about when to claim a state pension, whether to draw down private retirement savings early, whether to take a lump sum, or whether to accept an early retirement package can affect your income for decades. Some choices cannot be undone.

WATCH OUT

Do not make pension or retirement-savings decisions in the first weeks after a layoff, and never because a salesperson or website is rushing you. Early withdrawals can bring tax penalties, lost employer benefits, and permanently lower payments. Before you sign anything, speak to a qualified, independent financial advisor, or a free government or nonprofit pension guidance service where you live (the UK, for example, has free government-backed pension guidance; many other countries have similar services). Check whether your severance or package deadline can be extended while you get advice. See Chapter 3 for protecting retirement savings.

OVER-50 ACTION CHECKLIST

- [ ] Trim my CV to the last 10–15 years and lead with recent results
- [ ] Complete one visible AI project I can show or describe (Chapter 7)
- [ ] List three problems I have solved repeatedly and could offer as a service
- [ ] Contact five former colleagues or clients this month
- [ ] Identify two possible bridge roles
- [ ] Book a pension or retirement guidance session before making any withdrawal or claim decision
- [ ] Prepare a calm answer to “Aren’t you overqualified?” (Chapter 14)

If You Are a New Graduate or Early in Your Career

If you are just starting out, you may feel the ladder has had its bottom rungs sawn off. Many of the tasks that once trained junior staff, such as first drafts, basic research, simple code, data cleanup, and routine support tickets, are exactly

what AI now does fastest. Some employers have cut entry-level hiring as a result. You are not imagining this squeeze, and it is not your fault.

But there is another side. You probably learn new tools quickly. You have fewer fixed habits. Your living costs and commitments may be lower, which lets you take smart risks. And employers still need people they can grow. They are simply asking for more proof, earlier.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> The old deal was "hire me and I will learn." The new deal is "here is evidence I can already do useful work, and I will keep learning fast." Your goal is to arrive with proof, not just potential.

Build proof, not just credentials

A degree still opens some doors, but it rarely sets you apart now. What sets you apart is work someone can see. Chapter 13 covers portfolios in depth. For early-career people, the most useful forms of proof are:

- **Real projects for real people.** Help a local business, charity, club, or relative with an actual problem. A small real project beats a large imaginary one.
- **Before-and-after case studies.** "Their booking process took 20 minutes; I set up a form and automated reminders; now it takes 5."
- **Public learning.** Short write-ups of what you built, what broke, and what you would do differently. This shows judgment, not just output.
- **References from anyone who saw you work.** Part-time jobs, volunteering, and group projects all count.

Use AI as leverage, not a crutch

You are competing with people who use AI. You should use it too, but in a way that makes you better, not replaceable. Use it to learn faster, get feedback, and build more. Never hand in AI output you cannot explain.

The test is simple. If someone asks, "Why did you do it this way?" can you answer? If yes, AI made you stronger. If no, it made you fragile. Employers increasingly test for exactly this in interviews (Chapter 14).

Look at apprenticeships and structured entry routes

Apprenticeships are not only for trades anymore. Many countries now offer them in fields like IT, digital marketing, accounting, healthcare, engineering, and project management. You earn while you learn, and you finish with experience and a credential. Examples include degree and higher apprenticeships in the UK, registered apprenticeships in the US, and the long-established dual training systems in Germany, Austria, and Switzerland. Canada and Australia have strong trade and traineeship schemes too.

Also look at graduate schemes, rotational programmes, public-sector entry routes, paid internships, and fellowships. These still exist because organisations know they need a pipeline of talent. Chapter 10 explains how to find and judge them.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Be careful with unpaid "internships" that are really free labour, and with expensive courses that promise a guaranteed job. Fake job offers also target new graduates heavily, especially remote roles that ask you to pay for training or equipment. Chapter 14 shows how to spot recruitment scams.

1. **Pick one target role.** Not five. One clear direction makes everything else easier.
2. **Find one real problem.** Ask people around you what wastes their time.
3. **Solve it, using AI where it helps.** Keep notes on your decisions.
4. **Write a one-page case study.** Problem, what you did, result, what you learned.
5. **Share it with ten people in your target field.** Ask for feedback, not a job.
6. **Repeat monthly.** Three to five projects make a strong early portfolio.

If You Are a Parent or Caregiver

If you care for children, an ageing parent, a partner, or anyone else, your job search competes with the most important job you have. Time comes in fragments. Interviews clash with school runs or medical appointments. Flexibility is not a preference for you. It is a requirement.

That is not a weakness to hide. Caregivers often build strong skills in planning, crisis management, negotiation, and patience. The challenge is fitting a search into a life that is already full, and finding work that fits that life.

Work with the time you actually have

Forget advice that assumes eight free hours a day. Plan in small blocks. A focused 45 minutes can be enough for one tailored application, one networking message, or one learning session. Use AI to save time on drafting, summarising job descriptions, and preparing for interviews, so your limited hours go to the parts that need you.

WORKSHEET 21.1 — YOUR REAL WEEKLY TIME MAP

Day	Protected search time (when)	Care duties that day	Backup if it falls through
Monday			
Tuesday			
Wednesday			
Thursday			
Friday			
Weekend			

Look for flexibility in the right places

Flexible work is easier to find in some places than others. Remote and hybrid roles, part-time and job-share positions, contract and project work, and freelance services (Chapter 15) can all fit around care. Some employers advertise flexibility openly. Others offer it once they want you. In several countries, employees have a legal right to request flexible working, such as in the UK and parts of the EU. Check what applies where you live.

When you research companies, look at how they talk about families, parental leave, and flexible hours. Ask current or former staff in informational chats (Chapter 12). Policies on paper and reality on the ground are not always the same.

Explain gaps without apologising

Career gaps for caregiving are common and increasingly accepted. Keep your explanation short, factual, and forward-looking. You do not owe anyone details about your family.

> **SCRIPT: EXPLAINING A CAREGIVING GAP**
>
> "From [year] to [year], I took time out to care for [a family member / my children]. During that time I kept my skills current by [course, volunteering, freelance project, managing a household budget or medical care]. I'm now ready to return full-time [or: part-time], and I'm particularly interested in this role because [specific reason]."

Use support programmes

Look for local support with childcare costs, carers' allowances, and returner programmes. Many large employers run "returnship" schemes for people coming back after a career break. Some governments help with childcare costs during training or job search. Carers' organisations in many countries offer advice on benefits and rights. Ask your local job centre or employment service what is available.

If You Have a Disability or Chronic Illness

If you live with a disability or chronic illness, job searching can be draining in ways others do not see. Energy can be unpredictable. Interview formats may not suit you. You may face bias, or worry about it, every time you decide whether to disclose. All of this is on top of the pressure everyone else feels.

At the same time, some changes in the AI era can work in your favour. Remote work is far more normal than it was. AI tools can help with reading, writing, note-taking, speech, scheduling, and focus. Used well, they can reduce barriers that once kept people out of certain roles.

Know that rights exist, and that they vary

Many countries have laws that ban disability discrimination at work and require employers to make reasonable adjustments or accommodations. Examples include the Americans with Disabilities Act (US), the Equality Act 2010 (UK), and the Disability Discrimination Act 1992 (Australia). What counts as a disability, what is "reasonable," and how to enforce your rights all differ by country and sometimes by region.

Check with a local disability rights organisation, employment advisor, or legal clinic for the rules where you live. Many offer free advice.

Accommodations you can ask for

Accommodations are changes that let you do the job well. They are often cheap or free. Think about what you need for both the hiring process and the job itself.

Stage	Examples of reasonable adjustments
Applying	Accessible application formats, extra time on online tests, alternative to timed video assessments
Interviewing	Questions in advance, written instead of verbal tasks, breaks, video instead of in-person (or the reverse), a step-free venue, a sign language interpreter or captions
On the job	Flexible hours, remote or hybrid work, rest breaks, adapted equipment or software, a quiet workspace, written instructions, adjusted targets during flare-ups

Decide how and when to disclose

Disclosure is your choice in most places. There is no single right answer. Some people disclose early to get adjustments in the hiring process. Some wait until after an offer. Some never disclose and manage on their own. Think about what you need, how visible your condition is, and how the employer talks about inclusion.

SCRIPT: REQUESTING AN INTERVIEW ADJUSTMENT

Hi [Name],

Thank you for inviting me to interview for [role]. To help me perform at my best, I'd like to request [a short break halfway through / the questions in writing / a video interview instead of in person]. I'm happy to discuss if that's helpful.

Best regards,
[Your name]

Choose roles and setups that protect your health

When you weigh options, include energy and health in the decision, not just pay. A slightly lower salary with remote work, flexible hours, and a supportive manager may be worth more to you than a high-paying role that leaves you exhausted. Use the strengths and energy audit in Chapter 8 to spot work that fits how you function best.

Look for employers with disability networks, accessibility commitments, or recognised inclusion schemes. Some countries also run specific programmes, such as funding for workplace adaptations or support workers. In the UK, for example, Access to Work can help with costs. Ask your local employment service what exists where you live.

WATCH OUT

Before taking a job, check how it would affect any disability benefits or health coverage you rely on. In some systems, earning above a certain level can reduce support or trigger a review. Speak to a benefits advisor first so you are not caught out. Chapter 2 covers health coverage and benefits in general.

If You Are an Immigrant or Visa Holder

If you live and work in a country on a visa, losing your job can be much more than a financial shock. In many systems, your right to stay is tied to your employer. That can start a clock that is measured in weeks, not months. Language

barriers, unfamiliar systems, and a smaller local network can make things harder still.

WATCH OUT

If your visa or immigration status depends on your job, treat this as urgent. Some work visas allow only a short grace period after employment ends before you must find a new sponsor, change status, or leave. The rules differ greatly by country and visa type, and they change. In your first few days, speak to a qualified immigration lawyer or a registered immigration advisor. Do not rely on forums, friends' experiences, or AI chat tools for decisions this important. Ask your former employer's HR team for your exact last day of employment in writing, because that date often matters.

DO THIS NOW

1. Find your visa type and expiry date, and your official last day of employment.
2. Book a consultation with a qualified immigration lawyer or registered advisor this week. Many nonprofits offer free or low-cost help.
3. Ask what your options are: new sponsor, change of visa category, study route, dependant status, or other routes.
4. Gather documents: passport, visa, contract, payslips, termination letter, tax records.
5. Focus your job search on employers able and willing to sponsor, if that is your route.

Get your credentials recognised

Many immigrants hold qualifications that are not fully recognised in their new country. This is common in regulated fields like medicine, nursing, engineering, law, teaching, and accounting. Credential recognition can take time, so start early, even before you need it.

Look for your country's official recognition body or the professional regulator for your field. Ask about bridging programmes, which help internationally trained professionals meet local requirements faster. Canada, Australia, and

several EU countries have well-developed bridging and recognition systems. In the UK, there is an official service for comparing international qualifications. In the US, credential evaluation services and state licensing boards play this role.

Turn your background into an advantage

Your languages, cultural knowledge, and international experience are genuine assets. AI translation is good, but organisations working across borders still need people who understand context, trust, and local business culture. Roles in international trade, customer relationships for global markets, community services, healthcare for diverse populations, and export-focused small businesses can value what you bring.

> **A STORY**
>
> *Illustrative composite. Amara trained as a pharmacist in Nigeria and moved to Australia on a skilled visa, working in a data-entry role that was automated in 2026. With her visa tied to employment, she saw an immigration advisor in her first week, learned her options, and moved quickly. She enrolled in a recognition pathway for her pharmacy credentials while taking a sponsored role as a pharmacy assistant. "The advice in that first week changed everything," she says. "I had been about to panic and make the wrong move."*

If You Work in a Heavily Exposed Field

Some fields are being reshaped faster than others. If you work in customer support, writing and content, translation, coding, administration and data entry, or design and illustration, you may have watched your workload, rates, or team shrink in the last two years. This can feel personal, as if the very thing you were good at has been taken away.

Here is the more useful truth. AI rarely removes a whole field at once. It removes certain tasks, lowers the value of routine output, and raises the value of judgment, quality, relationships, and responsibility. The people who adapt best tend to move toward those higher-value parts, or into nearby roles that use the same skills.

AI rarely erases a whole field. It shrinks the routine middle and widens the edges where judgment lives.

The table below gives a quick view of what is changing in each field, nearby roles that use your existing skills, and how to reposition yourself. Treat it as a starting point for your own research, not a prediction.

Field	What's changing	Adjacent roles	How to reposition
Customer support	AI chat and voice agents handle routine questions; fewer front-line roles; remaining work is complex, emotional, or high-stakes	Customer success, escalations specialist, support operations, AI agent trainer or quality reviewer, account management, client onboarding	Move toward complex cases and retention; learn how support AI is set up and measured; show results like reduced churn or improved satisfaction
Writing & content	Generic content is cheap and plentiful; rates for routine copy have fallen; demand grows for strategy, original reporting, expertise, and editing	Content strategist, editor, brand voice lead, technical writer, communications manager, subject-matter writer, speechwriter	Specialise in a domain (health, finance, tech); sell outcomes, not word counts; offer editing and AI-workflow setup; build bylined expert work
Translation	Machine translation handles much general text; work shifts to post-editing; high-stakes, creative, and certified work still needs humans	Localisation specialist, transcreation, certified or legal translation, interpreting, language quality lead, cultural consultant	Focus on regulated, legal, medical, or creative work; get certified where it matters; offer quality review of machine output; consider interpreting
Coding	Coding agents write much routine code; fewer junior roles; more value in design, review, security, testing, and understanding the business	Software architect, QA and test engineer, security, DevOps or platform engineer, solutions engineer, AI integration developer, technical product manager	Show you can direct and review AI-written code; learn system design and security; build domain knowledge; demonstrate shipped, maintained projects

Field	What's changing	Adjacent roles	How to reposition
Admin & data entry	Forms, invoices, scheduling, and data processing are heavily automated; remaining roles are coordination, exceptions, and people-facing	Operations coordinator, executive assistant, project coordinator, process or automation specialist, compliance assistant, office manager	Learn the automation tools your sector uses; position yourself as the person who sets up and checks them; develop project and people skills
Design & illustration	Image generators handle stock and simple visuals; demand for low-budget work has dropped; brand, taste, and strategy matter more	Brand designer, art director, UX and product designer, creative director, design systems lead, illustrator for premium or physical media	Sell concept, direction, and brand thinking; build a distinct style; work in UX, where research and user testing matter; use AI to speed up exploration

Three repositioning moves that work in any exposed field

Whatever your field, the same three moves keep coming up. You can use one or combine them.

1. **Move up the value chain.** Shift from producing the routine output to setting direction, checking quality, and owning results. A writer becomes an editor or strategist. A support agent becomes an escalation or success specialist.
2. **Specialise in a domain.** Generic skills compete with AI. Skills combined with deep knowledge of an industry, such as healthcare, law, finance, or manufacturing, compete with very few people (Chapter 6).
3. **Become the person who runs the tools.** Every team adopting AI needs people who understand both the work and the tools. You already know what good output looks like. That makes you well placed to set up, train, and review AI systems in your field.

A STORY

Illustrative composite. Lucía, 38, was a freelance Spanish–English translator in Madrid whose general work dried up as clients switched to machine translation. She took a course in legal translation, earned a recognised certification, and now focuses on contracts and court documents where accuracy has legal weight. She also reviews machine-translated material for two agencies. Her client list is shorter, but her rates are higher than before.

Which parts of your current or past work needed your judgment, relationships, or responsibility, rather than just your output? Which adjacent role from the table could use those parts most?

REMEMBER

- Over 50: counter age bias with recent proof, sell your experience as solutions, consider bridge roles, and get qualified advice before any pension or retirement decision.
- Early career: the entry level is squeezed, so arrive with proof. Real projects, apprenticeships, and smart AI use beat credentials alone.
- Parents and caregivers: plan in small time blocks, look for flexible work, and explain gaps briefly and confidently.
- Disability or chronic illness: you can ask for adjustments; rights vary by country; remote work and AI tools can lower barriers.
- Visa holders: treat job loss as urgent and see a qualified immigration professional within days; start credential recognition early.
- Exposed fields: move up the value chain, specialise in a domain, or become the person who runs the tools.

Your next step: Identify the single most time-sensitive issue in your situation, such as a visa date, a pension deadline, or a benefits rule, and book one conversation with a qualified advisor about it this week.

CHAPTER 22

Future-Proofing for Life

This chapter gives you simple habits and worksheets for learning, money, planning and staying informed, so the next change finds you ready instead of surprised.

Nobody can promise you a job that will never change. That promise was never real, even before AI. What you can build is a life that bends without breaking: steady habits that keep your skills fresh, a financial cushion that buys you time, and a plan you made on a calm day for the hard days that may come.

This chapter is not about predicting the future. Nobody can do that well, including the people who build AI. It is about building systems small enough to keep going for years. A system you actually use beats a perfect plan you abandon in February.

KEY IDEA

You cannot control which jobs AI changes. You can control how early you notice, how much runway you have, and how ready your next move is. Those three things are most of what "future-proof" really means.

Build a Personal Learning System

Most adults learn in bursts. A layoff happens, we panic, we take three courses, we land a job, and then we stop learning for five years. The problem is that the world does not stop. A learning system replaces bursts with a small, steady habit that runs in the background of your life.

You already have the tools for this from earlier chapters. Chapter 7 covered building AI fluency, and Chapter 10 covered how adults learn fast. A personal learning system simply makes those things permanent.

The four parts of a learning system

1. **A small, fixed time slot.** Choose a time you can protect almost every week. Two hours a week, split into four 30-minute sessions, is enough to stay current in most fields. Put it in your calendar like a meeting.
2. **A learning backlog.** Keep one list (a note on your phone is fine) of things you want to learn. When something catches your interest, add it. When your slot comes, you pick from the list instead of wondering what to do.
3. **A "use it" rule.** Within a week of learning something, use it on a real task, even a tiny one. Learning that is never used fades fast. Learning you apply becomes a skill you can prove.
4. **A visible record.** Keep a simple learning log: date, what you learned, where you used it. This becomes material for your CV, interviews and portfolio (see Chapter 13). It also shows you, on bad days, how far you have come.

Balance three kinds of learning

A healthy learning diet mixes three types. Too much of one leaves you exposed.

Type	What it is	Example	Rough share of your time
Deepen	Getting better at your core skill	A nurse learning a new care protocol; an accountant learning a tax change	About half
Tools	Staying fluent with AI and the software of your field	Trying a new AI feature on a real work task each month	About a quarter
Explore	Something adjacent that could open a new door	A designer learning basic data analysis; a teacher learning facilitation for adults	About a quarter

The "explore" slice is your insurance. It is how people build the combined skills described in Chapter 6, and it often becomes the bridge to their next role.

> **TIP**
>
> Learn with someone. A friend, a former colleague or an online study group makes it far more likely you will keep going. Even a monthly message saying "Here is what I learned this month, what about you?" adds gentle accountability.

WORKSHEET 22.1 — MY LEARNING SYSTEM

Question	My answer
My weekly learning time slot(s)	
Where my learning backlog lives	
One "deepen" topic for the next 3 months	
One "tools" topic for the next 3 months	
One "explore" topic for the next 3 months	
Where I will keep my learning log	
My learning buddy or group	
Free or low-cost sources I will use	

The Quarterly and Annual Career Review

Companies review their plans every quarter. Your career deserves the same attention. A career review is a short, honest meeting with yourself. It catches problems while they are small and keeps your options visible.

Do a short version every three months (about 30 minutes) and a longer version once a year (about two hours). Many people tie the annual review to a fixed date, like a birthday or the start of the year, so it does not slip.

The quarterly check-in

Keep it light. Answer these questions quickly, in writing, and file the page somewhere you can find it next time.

WORKSHEET 22.2 — QUARTERLY CAREER CHECK-IN

Question	This quarter
What did I accomplish that I am proud of? (Add to your achievements bank from Chapter 8.)	
Which of my tasks are now done by AI or software, fully or partly?	
What new task did I take on that AI cannot easily do?	
What did I learn, and did I use it?	
Who did I reconnect with in my network?	
How is my emergency fund compared to last quarter?	
Any early-warning signs at work? (See the list later in this chapter.)	
One thing I will do differently next quarter	

The annual review

Once a year, step back further. Read your four quarterly check-ins first and look for patterns, not single bad weeks.

WORKSHEET 22.3 — ANNUAL CAREER REVIEW

Area	Where I am now	Where I want to be in a year
My role and how it has changed this year		
My strongest skills (top three)		
Skills I need to build		
Income and income sources		
Emergency fund (months covered)		
Network: people I could call for help		
Proof of my work (portfolio, case studies, references)		
Energy and wellbeing		
Values: does my work still fit them?		
My CV: last updated on		

DO THIS NOW

Open your calendar and create four recurring reminders, one per quarter, titled “Career check-in (30 min).” Add one more yearly reminder titled “Annual career review (2 hours).” Scheduling it now is the step most people skip.

Financial Resilience: Your Emergency Fund and Beyond

Time is the most valuable thing you can have when work changes. Money buys time. It lets you turn down a bad offer, take a course, or spend three months finding the right role instead of grabbing the first one. Chapter 3 covered money triage during a crisis. This section is about building strength once things are stable again.

The emergency fund

An emergency fund is money set aside only for real emergencies, like job loss or an urgent repair. A common guideline is to aim for three to six months of essential expenses. If your field is very exposed to automation, or you are the only earner in your household, you may want more. If that number feels impossible right now, that is normal. Start smaller.

1. **Starter cushion.** Aim first for one month of essential costs, or even a small fixed amount. This alone stops many small shocks turning into debt.
2. **Automate it.** Set up an automatic transfer on payday, even a small one, into a separate savings account. Money you never see in your main account is easier not to spend.
3. **Keep it reachable but separate.** Use an account you can access within a few days, but not one linked to your debit card. Look for one that pays some interest and is protected by your country's deposit-protection scheme.
4. **Refill after use.** Using the fund is not failure. That is what it is for. Once things settle, rebuild it.

Other layers of resilience

An emergency fund is the first layer. Others can matter just as much.

FINANCIAL RESILIENCE CHECKLIST

- [ ] I know my monthly essential expenses (from my runway worksheet in Chapter 3).
- [ ] I have a separate emergency savings account with automatic deposits.
- [ ] I am paying down high-interest debt, starting with the most expensive.
- [ ] I have at least one small second income stream, or I know what it could be (see Chapter 17).
- [ ] I understand what my employer benefits cover and what I would lose if I left.
- [ ] I know what public support I could claim if I lost my job (unemployment benefits, health coverage) and roughly how to apply.
- [ ] I have looked at income protection or similar insurance, if it exists and is affordable where I live.
- [ ] My important documents (contracts, payslips, tax records) are saved somewhere I can reach even if I lose access to work systems.

WATCH OUT

When money feels uncertain, "get rich with AI" schemes, high-risk trading apps and miracle side-hustle courses look very tempting. Your emergency fund is not for speculation. If something promises fast, guaranteed returns, treat it as a red flag (Chapter 3 covers common scams). For decisions about investing, pensions or retirement accounts, talk to a qualified, independent financial adviser or a free public money-guidance service in your country.

Scenario Planning: "If X Happens, I Will Y"

When something bad happens, our thinking narrows. Stress makes it hard to plan. That is why the best time to decide what you will do in a crisis is now, while you are calm. Scenario planning simply means writing down a few likely "what ifs" and your first moves for each.

A STORY

Mei, 41, worked in translation in Singapore. She noticed her agency sending fewer full projects and more "post-editing" jobs, where she corrected machine translations at a lower rate. Instead of waiting, she wrote three scenarios on one page. For "my main client cuts my work in half," her plan was: contact two former clients, raise her rate for specialist legal work, and start a short course in localisation project management. Six months later, the cut came. She was upset, but not frozen. She had already sent the first emails by the end of that week. (Illustrative composite.)

How to write your scenarios

- **Pick three to five scenarios.** Include at least one bad one, one medium one and one good one. Planning for good surprises (a promotion, a new opportunity) matters too.
- **Name your trigger clearly.** "Things get worse" is too vague. "My hours are cut" or "My team is told to use an AI tool for half our tasks" is clear.
- **List your first three actions.** Keep them small and specific enough to do in the first week.
- **Note who you would call.** A mentor, a former manager, a union rep, a friend.
- **Review once a year.** Update it during your annual career review.

WORKSHEET 22.4 — MY "IF X HAPPENS, I WILL Y" PLAN

If this happens...	My first three actions	Who I will contact	Money I can use
I lose my job with little notice			
My hours or pay are cut			
Much of my role is handed to AI tools			
My whole industry shrinks quickly			
My health or a family member's health stops me working for a while			
I am offered a new role or opportunity			
My own scenario:			

A plan made on a calm day is a gift to the person you will be on a hard one.

Early-Warning Signs Your Role Is Being Automated

Jobs rarely vanish overnight. Usually there are signs months ahead. Many people notice them but explain them away, because noticing feels frightening. Learning to read these signals is one of the most useful skills you can have. It gives you time to act while you still have a salary, a network inside the company and the confidence that comes with being employed.

No single sign means you will lose your job. Several together, over a few months, deserve attention.

WARNING SIGNS TO WATCH FOR

- [ ] Your team is asked to document your processes in detail, “for training” or “for the new system.”
- [ ] You are asked to review, correct or approve AI output instead of producing the work yourself.
- [ ] Leaving colleagues are not replaced, and the work is spread across fewer people “with help from tools.”
- [ ] Leaders talk about “efficiency,” “doing more with less” or a target percentage of work to automate.
- [ ] Budgets for training, travel or contractors in your area are cut, while AI or software budgets grow.
- [ ] Your work is measured more on volume and speed than on judgment or relationships.
- [ ] New job postings in your company are for roles that manage or build automation, not roles like yours.
- [ ] Similar roles at competitor companies are being cut or merged.

What to do while you are still employed

If you see several signs, do not panic and do not quit on impulse. Use the time you have. Being employed is a strong position from which to search, learn and negotiate.

1. **Move toward the work AI is not doing.** Volunteer for tasks that involve judgment, clients, training others or handling exceptions. Offer to help roll out the new tools. People who understand both the old process and the new system are often the last to go and the first to be rehired.
2. **Collect your proof now.** Update your achievements bank, CV and portfolio while you still have access to the details. Save copies of your own performance reviews and non-confidential examples of your work, following your employer's rules on data.
3. **Warm up your network.** Reach out to former colleagues and contacts before you need anything (see Chapter 12). It is much easier to say "just catching up" while employed.
4. **Boost your emergency fund.** Even a few extra months of savings can change your choices later.
5. **Learn your rights.** Read your contract and employee handbook. Find out how redundancy, severance or notice periods work in your country, and whether there is a union or staff association. Check with a local employment adviser or legal service if anything is unclear.
6. **Ask direct, calm questions.** You are allowed to ask your manager how your role is expected to change.
7. **Start a quiet search.** Begin informational conversations and track interesting roles. You do not have to leave, but you will know your options.

SCRIPT: ASKING YOUR MANAGER ABOUT YOUR ROLE'S FUTURE

Hi [Manager's name], I've noticed we're bringing in [tool or process] for some of the work my team does. I'm keen to stay useful as things change. Could we talk about how you see my role developing over the next year?

I'd especially like to know which parts of my work you see as most valuable going forward, and whether there are new responsibilities or training I could take on. I'm happy to help with the rollout if that would be useful.

Would [day/time] work for a 20-minute chat?

An Information Diet: Stay Informed Without Doom-Scrolling

News about AI is everywhere, and much of it is designed to grab attention. Headlines swing between "AI will take every job" and "AI is overhyped." Reading all of it does not make you better prepared. It mostly makes you anxious and tired. You need a small amount of good information, taken at set times.

DOOM-SCROLLING

- Checking news and social media many times a day
- Reading mostly headlines and hot takes
- Following people who profit from fear or hype
- Scrolling late at night in bed
- Feeling worse, but no clearer about what to do

A HEALTHY INFORMATION DIET

- One or two set times a week to catch up
- A few trusted, in-depth sources
- News about your own field and region
- Phone off or in another room at night
- Ending each session with one question: "Does this change anything I should do?"

Building your information diet

- **Pick two or three core sources.** Choose ones that explain rather than shout: a trade publication for your industry, a professional body's newsletter, and

one general news source you trust. Reports from established public or international organisations, such as national labour statistics offices or the World Economic Forum's *Future of Jobs* reports, can help you see bigger trends.

- **Follow your field, not just "AI."** What matters most is how AI affects your work and your local job market. People working in your field, not only AI commentators, often give the most useful view.
- **Set a time box.** For example, 30 minutes on Sunday morning. Outside that, turn off news notifications.
- **Check before you believe.** Dramatic claims about jobs should name a source. If a post cites "a study" without a link or name, treat it with caution. Look for the original report.

> **DO THIS NOW**
>
> Look at your phone's screen-time settings. Find the two apps where you read most news or social media. Set a daily limit, or move them off your home screen. Then write down your two or three core sources and your weekly catch-up time. If the news is affecting your sleep or mood, Chapter 4 has more on looking after your mind.

Your Civic Voice

Many of the forces shaping work are bigger than any one person. Decisions about retraining funds, unemployment support, worker protections and how AI is used in hiring are made by governments, employers and institutions. You have a right to a say in them. Using your voice is not about any political party. It is about making sure the people who make decisions hear from those who live with the results.

Contacting your elected representatives

Most countries have elected representatives at local, regional and national level. They usually have staff who read and log messages from residents. A short, personal, polite message from a real constituent carries real weight, especially when it describes local experience.

SCRIPT: WRITING TO YOUR REPRESENTATIVE

Dear [Title and name],

I am a resident of [town or district] and I work (or worked) as a [your role] in [industry]. I am writing about how AI and automation are affecting jobs in our area.

In my experience, [one or two sentences about what you have seen: for example, roles not being replaced, difficulty finding affordable retraining, or long waits for benefits].

I would like to know what you are doing, or plan to do, on [one specific issue: access to retraining, support for displaced workers, transparency in automated hiring]. I would also welcome information about any local programmes I could share with others in my situation.

Thank you for your time. I look forward to your reply.

[Your name]
[Your address or postcode, if required to confirm you are a constituent]

Unions, staff associations and professional bodies

Collective groups give individual workers a stronger voice. A union or staff association may be able to negotiate how new technology is introduced, what training is offered and how job changes are handled. Professional bodies and trade associations often set standards for your field, publish guidance on AI use, and speak to government on behalf of members.

- Find out whether there is a union or staff association for your workplace or sector, and what membership involves.
- Join your field's professional body, if there is one. Many offer reduced rates for people who are unemployed or students.

Supporting retraining and safety-net policy

Whatever your politics, you can help make sure support for workers in transition is well designed and easy to use. Practical ways to do that include:

- **Responding to public consultations.** Governments often ask for public comment on plans for skills, benefits and technology rules. Your firsthand experience is exactly what they ask for.

- **Giving feedback on services you use.** If a retraining programme or benefits process helped you or failed you, tell the agency running it. Specific feedback improves services for the next person.
- **Joining local forums.** Town hall meetings, local workforce or skills boards and community groups often welcome residents' views.
- **Voting and helping others register.** Check candidates' positions on work, skills and support for workers, using a range of sources, and decide for yourself.

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> You do not need to become an activist. One letter a year, one consultation response, or one meeting of your professional body is real participation. Small, steady civic action from many ordinary people is how institutions learn what is happening on the ground.

What is one issue about work and AI that matters to you, and one small way you could make your voice heard on it this year?

Putting It All Together: Your Future-Proofing Rhythm

Everything in this chapter fits into a simple rhythm. You do not need to remember it all. You need a calendar and a little consistency.

How often	What to do	Time needed
Every week	Learning slot; information catch-up; automatic savings transfer	About 2–3 hours

How often	What to do	Time needed
Every month	Reach out to one person in your network; check your warning signs	About 30 minutes
Every quarter	Career check-in (Worksheet 22.2); update your achievements bank	About 30–60 minutes
Every year	Annual review (Worksheet 22.3); update scenarios (Worksheet 22.4) and CV; one civic action	Half a day

A Closing Note: Hope You Can Act On

If you have read this far, you have been through a lot. Maybe you lost a job you loved. Maybe you are watching your field change and wondering where you fit. It is fair to feel tired, angry or scared. These changes are real, and they are not your fault.

But here is what is also true. People have lived through huge shifts in work before, and many found new paths that suited them better than the old ones. Today's major forecasts, like the World Economic Forum's *Future of Jobs Report 2025*, expect large numbers of jobs to be created as well as lost this decade. The transition is uneven and often unfair. It is not the end of work.

Hope that waits for good news is fragile. Hope that comes from action is sturdy. Every learning session, every saved payment, every message to an old colleague, every plan written on a calm day is a small proof that you are not powerless. You are building the kind of life that can adapt.

The things that make you valuable, your judgment, your care, your relationships, your ability to learn and to show up for people, do not expire. Keep tending them. Keep going, one small step at a time. And when you are back on your feet, reach back and help someone else find theirs.

You do not have to predict the future. You only have to keep preparing for it, a little at a time.

REMEMBER

- A small, steady learning habit with a “use it” rule beats occasional bursts of courses.
- Short quarterly check-ins and a yearly review catch problems early and keep your options visible.
- An emergency fund buys time. Start small, automate it, and refill it after use.
- Write “if X happens, I will Y” plans while you are calm, so a crisis finds you ready.
- Learn the warning signs of automation and act while you are still employed: move toward judgment work, collect proof, warm your network.
- Keep a deliberate information diet: a few trusted sources at set times, not endless scrolling.
- Your civic voice matters. Contact representatives, join professional bodies or unions, and give feedback on retraining and support programmes, whatever your politics.

Your next step: Put five reminders in your calendar today: four quarterly career check-ins and one annual review. Then set up a small automatic transfer to your emergency savings, even if it is only a token amount to start.

APPENDIX A

The 90-Day Comeback Plan

The whole book turned into twelve weeks of clear, doable actions, in three phases: stabilise, explore and build, then launch and land.

Big goals are easier to reach when they are broken into small weekly steps. This plan takes the advice from every part of the book and puts it in order, so that each week you know what to focus on and what can wait. You do not have to follow it perfectly. Think of it as a trail map, not a timetable.

If you are still employed and preparing early, you can stretch the plan over six months instead. If you find work in week five, wonderful: skip to the section at the end called "When You Land."

> **KEY IDEA**
>
> Each phase has a different job. **Phase 1** protects you. **Phase 2** points you in a direction and builds proof. **Phase 3** puts you in front of the right people, consistently, until something lands. Skipping Phase 1 to rush into applications is the most common mistake.

How to Use This Plan

1. **Pick a start date.** Write it at the top of this page. Day 1 is that date, not the day you lost your job.
2. **Plan each week on Sunday or Monday.** Read that week's goals and checklist, then put the tasks into your calendar.
3. **Do the weekly review on Friday.** Use Worksheet A.1 at the end of this appendix. It takes about 20 minutes.

4. **Protect your energy.** Aim for steady effort, about four to six focused hours a day on weekdays, not twelve-hour panics. The daily template (Worksheet A.2) helps.
5. **Adjust without guilt.** If a week goes badly, repeat it. If life gets in the way, pause. The plan serves you, not the other way round.

Phase 1: Stabilise (Days 1–30)

The goal of the first month is to make your situation safe and predictable. By day 30 you should know your runway, have benefits and health cover sorted, have a daily rhythm, and feel at least a little steadier. Chapters 1 to 4 support this phase.

Week 1 (Days 1–7): Protect yourself

Goal: Get the urgent paperwork, money and support in place. Nothing permanent is decided this week.

WEEK 1 CHECKLIST

- [ ] Read the Quick Start at the front of the book.
- [ ] Get your termination letter and final pay details in writing.
- [ ] Save personal copies of payslips, contracts and reviews you are allowed to keep.
- [ ] Apply for unemployment benefits or your local equivalent.
- [ ] Find out when any work-linked health cover ends and note your options.
- [ ] Ask for time to review any severance agreement; do not sign under pressure.
- [ ] Tell at least one person you trust what has happened.
- [ ] Set a regular wake-up time and keep it.

Week 2 (Days 8–14): Know your numbers

Goal: Calculate your runway and cut costs so it lasts as long as possible. See Chapter 3.

WEEK 2 CHECKLIST

- [ ] Complete the runway calculator (Appendix B, Worksheet B.1).
- [ ] Sort spending into essential and flexible; pause the flexible items.
- [ ] Contact any lender or landlord where a payment may be difficult.
- [ ] Check whether you qualify for hardship programs, utility support or local aid.
- [ ] Decide, with advice if needed, whether to sign any severance offer.
- [ ] Make a short list of possible bridge income (temporary, part-time, or a few hours of freelance work).
- [ ] Agree with your household how money decisions will be made for the next three months.

WATCH OUT

Week 2 is when many people feel pressure to "do something big," like enrolling in an expensive course or withdrawing retirement savings. Wait until Phase 2, when you know your direction. Chapter 10 shows you how to evaluate training before paying for it.

Week 3 (Days 15–21): Steady your mind and body

Goal: Build routines that keep you well enough to do the hard work ahead. See Chapter 4.

WEEK 3 CHECKLIST

- [ ] Set up your daily schedule using Worksheet A.2.
- [ ] Move your body for at least 20 minutes on five days this week.
- [ ] Set a daily limit for job sites, social media and news.
- [ ] Write down what you miss about your old job and what you do not.
- [ ] Have an honest conversation with your partner, family or housemates about how you are doing.
- [ ] Find one support option: a friend, a peer group, a counsellor or a helpline (see Appendix C).
- [ ] Do one thing purely for enjoyment.

Week 4 (Days 22–30): Understand the landscape

Goal: Replace fear with facts. Learn how AI is changing work and start using AI tools yourself. See Chapters 1, 5 and 7.

WEEK 4 CHECKLIST

- [ ] Read Chapter 1 and Chapter 5.
- [ ] List the main tasks of your last job and mark which ones AI now handles, assists with, or cannot do.
- [ ] Start the 30-day AI fluency plan in Chapter 7 (about 20–30 minutes a day).
- [ ] Set up a simple tracking system for the search ahead (Appendix B, Worksheet B.3).
- [ ] Ask two or three people to be references.
- [ ] Do your first full weekly review (Worksheet A.1).

PHASE 1 CHECKPOINT: BY DAY 30, CAN YOU SAY YES?

- [ ] I know my runway in months.
- [ ] Benefits and health cover are applied for or sorted.
- [ ] I have a daily routine I mostly keep.
- [ ] At least one person knows how I am really doing.
- [ ] I understand, in plain terms, how AI affects my field.

If you answered no to one or two, that is fine. Carry them into Week 5. If you answered no to most of them, repeat Week 3 or Week 4 before moving on.

Stabilising is not wasted time. It is the foundation every later step stands on.

Phase 2: Explore and Build (Days 31–60)

The goal of the second month is to choose a direction and start building evidence that you can do it. By day 60 you should have one or two target paths, a clear story about your strengths, an updated CV and profile, a first piece of proof, and a growing list of conversations. Chapters 6, 8, 9, 10, 12 and 13 support this phase.

Week 5 (Days 31–37): Take stock of yourself

Goal: Build a full picture of what you can do, what energises you, and what you need. See Chapters 6 and 8.

WEEK 5 CHECKLIST

- [ ] Complete the transferable skills audit in Chapter 8.
- [ ] Write at least ten achievements in your achievements bank, with numbers where you can.
- [ ] Do the energy audit: which tasks gave you energy and which drained you?
- [ ] Write down your non-negotiables: income floor, location, hours, caring duties, health needs.
- [ ] Fill in the skills snapshot (Appendix B, Worksheet B.2).
- [ ] Ask two people who know your work what they think you are best at.

Week 6 (Days 38–44): Compare your paths

Goal: Narrow the options to one or two paths worth testing. See Chapter 9.

WEEK 6 CHECKLIST

- [ ] Read the six paths in Chapter 9 and list two or three that could fit you.
- [ ] Score each one using the decision matrix in Chapter 9.
- [ ] Check each path's AI exposure using the method in Chapter 5.
- [ ] Book two informational chats with people already doing work on your shortlist (see Chapter 12).
- [ ] Design one small, cheap experiment for your top path.
- [ ] Choose a primary path and a backup path. Write them down.

A STORY

Daniel, 51, had been a payroll administrator in Manchester for nineteen years. In Week 6 his shortlist was bookkeeping for small businesses, a public-sector finance role, and training as an electrician. Two informational chats changed everything: a local accountant told him she was turning clients away. His experiment was offering a month of help to a friend's café. By Day 60 he had two paying clients and a clear primary path.

Week 7 (Days 45–51): Rebuild your materials

Goal: Make your CV, profile and introduction match your chosen path. See Chapters 11 and 12.

WEEK 7 CHECKLIST

- [ ] Rewrite your CV or résumé for your primary path, using your achievements bank.
- [ ] Check it is readable by both humans and screening software (Chapter 11).
- [ ] Update your online profile, including a new summary (Appendix B, Script 5).
- [ ] Write your one-minute introduction (Appendix B, Worksheet B.5) and say it out loud until it feels natural.
- [ ] Map your warm network: list at least 30 people you know (Chapter 12).
- [ ] Send five warm outreach messages (Appendix B, Script 1).

Week 8 (Days 52–60): Build proof and fill gaps

Goal: Create at least one piece of visible proof and start a focused learning plan. See Chapters 10 and 13.

WEEK 8 CHECKLIST

- [ ] Identify the one or two skill gaps that matter most for your path.
- [ ] Choose free or low-cost learning to close them (Appendix C lists options).
- [ ] Create one work sample, case study or small project that shows what you can do.
- [ ] Share it with at least two people and ask for feedback.
- [ ] Hold at least two informational interviews.
- [ ] Send thank-you notes within a day of each conversation (Appendix B, Script 4).
- [ ] Do your monthly check-in (Appendix B, Worksheet B.6).

PHASE 2 CHECKPOINT: BY DAY 60, CAN YOU SAY YES?

- [ ] I have a primary path and a backup path.
- [ ] My CV, profile and introduction match that path.
- [ ] I have at least one piece of proof I can show people.
- [ ] I have had at least four real conversations with people in my target field.
- [ ] I know which skills I am learning and how.

TIP

Check your runway again at the end of Phase 2. If it has become shorter than three months, add a bridge income task to every week of Phase 3. Part-time, temporary or freelance work is not a step backwards. It buys you time to land well.

Phase 3: Launch and Land (Days 61–90)

The goal of the third month is steady, focused action. You will run a weekly search system, keep conversations flowing, prepare well for interviews, and, if you are on a self-employment path, win your first clients. By day 90 you should have a working system and real momentum, even if you have not yet signed an offer. Chapters 11 to 18 support this phase.

Week 9 (Days 61–67): Switch on your search system

Goal: Move from preparation to a regular weekly rhythm of targeted action. See Chapter 11.

WEEK 9 CHECKLIST

- [ ] Make a target list of 20–30 organisations or potential clients that fit your path.
- [ ] Set weekly targets, for example: 5 tailored applications, 10 outreach messages, 2 conversations.
- [ ] Apply to your first targeted roles, each one tailored, not mass-sent.
- [ ] If freelancing, send your offer to past contacts (Appendix B, Script 6).
- [ ] Join one professional community, online or local.
- [ ] Log everything in your job-search tracker.

Week 10 (Days 68–74): Prepare for interviews

Goal: Be ready to perform well when opportunities come. See Chapter 14.

WEEK 10 CHECKLIST

- [ ] Write five STAR stories from your achievements bank.
- [ ] Prepare a calm, honest answer about why you are looking and about AI in your field.
- [ ] Practise a mock interview with a friend, or with an AI assistant as a practice partner.
- [ ] Research typical pay for your target roles so you can negotiate later.
- [ ] Keep hitting your weekly outreach and application targets.
- [ ] Follow up on messages from Week 9 that have not been answered (Appendix B, Script 2).

Week 11 (Days 75–81): Widen and deepen

Goal: Strengthen what is working and fix what is not. See Chapters 12, 13 and 18.

WEEK 11 CHECKLIST

- [ ] Review your tracker: which actions led to replies, conversations or interviews?
- [ ] Do more of what worked; change one thing about what did not.
- [ ] Look at local opportunities you may have missed (Chapter 18).
- [ ] Share a second piece of proof or public work.
- [ ] Help someone else in your network: an introduction, a referral or advice.
- [ ] Stay alert to scams: check any unusual offer against the warning signs in Chapter 14.

Week 12 (Days 82–90): Land, or reset with clarity

Goal: Handle offers well, or take stock and plan the next 90 days. See Chapters 14 and 22.

WEEK 12 CHECKLIST

- [ ] If you have an offer, review it carefully and negotiate respectfully (Appendix B, Script 7).
- [ ] If you are declining an offer, do it kindly and keep the door open (Appendix B, Script 8).
- [ ] Thank everyone who helped you, whatever the outcome so far.
- [ ] Do a full 90-day review: what has changed since Day 1?
- [ ] Recalculate your runway and decide what the next 90 days need.
- [ ] Do your monthly check-in and celebrate what you have done.

PHASE 3 CHECKPOINT: BY DAY 90, CAN YOU SAY YES?

- [ ] I run a weekly search system and track the results.
- [ ] I am having regular conversations with people in my target field.
- [ ] I can tell my story and my strengths clearly in an interview.
- [ ] I know what is working and what I will change.
- [ ] I have a plan for the next 90 days, whether or not I have landed.

If Day 90 Arrives and You Have Not Landed

This happens to many capable people, especially in a crowded market. It does not mean you failed or that the plan failed. Hiring often moves slowly, and the conversations you started in Phase 3 may turn into offers in the months ahead.

Use your Day 90 review to make honest adjustments. Is your target path realistic in your area? Is your runway long enough, or do you need more bridge income? Are you spending most of your time on the actions that produce replies? Then start a new 90-day cycle, beginning at Phase 2 or Phase 3, with what you have learned.

DO THIS NOW

If you are past Day 90 without an offer, do these three things this week:

1. Ask two trusted people to review your CV and one-minute introduction and tell you honestly what is unclear.
2. Look at your tracker and find the one activity with the best reply rate. Double it.
3. Book one thing for yourself that has nothing to do with work.

When You Land

When you accept an offer or win steady clients, take a breath and celebrate. Then protect what you have built. Keep your achievements bank going. Rebuild your runway as soon as you can. Stay in touch with the people who helped you.

And set a date, perhaps six months from now, for a short career review using Chapter 22. The next change will be easier because of what you learned in this one.

Worksheet A.1: The Weekly Review

Do this every Friday, or at the end of your working week. Copy it into a notebook or print it from Appendix B. It should take about 20 minutes.

WORKSHEET A.1 — WEEKLY REVIEW (WEEK ___ , DAYS ___ TO ___)

Question	Your answer
This week's main goal was...	
Checklist items done / total	
Applications sent / outreach messages sent	
Conversations or interviews held	
Replies or results received	
What went well?	
What got in the way?	
Energy this week (1–10)	
Runway remaining (months)	
One thing I will change next week	
Next week's top three tasks	
One thing I am proud of	

Worksheet A.2: Daily Schedule Template

A job search with no structure tends to swallow the whole day and still feel unproductive. This template gives your day a shape. Adjust the times to fit your life, caring duties and energy. Mornings are often best for focused work like writing applications; afternoons suit conversations and learning.

WORKSHEET A.2 — DAILY SCHEDULE (DATE: _____)

Time	Block	What I will do
Wake-up	Start the day: get up, wash, eat	
30 min	Move: walk, stretch, exercise	
15 min	Plan: choose today's top three tasks	
90 min	Focus block 1: applications, CV, proof work	
15 min	Break: away from screens	
60 min	Connect: outreach, follow-ups, calls	
60 min	Lunch and rest	
60 min	Learn: course, practice, AI fluency	
60 min	Focus block 2 or bridge income work	
15 min	Close: update tracker, note tomorrow's first task	
Evening	Off: people, hobbies, rest. No job sites.	

TIP

Have a clear "closing time" each day. When the close block is done, you are off duty. Knowing that the search has an end each day makes it much easier to start it again the next morning.

What would make the next 90 days feel like a success to you, even if not everything goes to plan?

REMEMBER

- Phase 1 protects you, Phase 2 points you, Phase 3 launches you.
- Plan each week at the start and review it at the end.
- Steady, focused effort beats long, anxious days.
- If Day 90 comes without an offer, adjust and begin a new cycle. Nothing is wasted.

Your next step: Write your Day 1 date at the top of this appendix and put Week 1's checklist into your calendar.

APPENDIX B

The Toolkit: Worksheets and Scripts

The worksheets and message scripts you will use again and again, collected in one place so you can copy, print and reuse them.

This appendix is your workbench. Everything here also appears, with more explanation, somewhere in the main chapters. Here it is stripped down to the essentials so you can photocopy a page, print it, or copy it into a notebook whenever you need a fresh one.

Make several copies of the trackers. Date every sheet. Over a few weeks, the pile of filled-in pages becomes a record of how much you have actually done, which is worth having on the days when it feels like nothing is moving.

> **TIP**
>
> For the scripts, replace every [bracket] and then read the message out loud before sending. If it does not sound like something you would say, change it. A short, genuine message beats a long, polished one.

Worksheet B.1: One-Page Runway Calculator

Your runway is how many months you can cover your essential costs. Fill in the left side with what you have and the right side with what you need each month. Chapter 3 explains each line in detail.

WORKSHEET B.1 — RUNWAY CALCULATOR (DATE: _____)

Money available	Amount	Essential monthly costs	Amount
Cash in bank accounts		Rent / mortgage	
Final pay and holiday pay		Utilities and phone	

Money available	Amount	Essential monthly costs	Amount
Severance / redundancy pay (after tax)		Food and household basics	
Accessible savings (not retirement)		Health costs and insurance	
Expected benefits (total over period)		Transport	
Partner or household income share		Minimum debt payments	
Bridge income expected		Childcare / caring costs	
Other		Other essentials	
A. Total available		**B. Total monthly essentials**	
Runway in months = A ÷ B			

Recalculate every month. If your runway is under three months, focus on cutting costs, applying for every support you are eligible for, and finding bridge income before anything else.

Worksheet B.2: Skills Snapshot

A one-page summary of what you bring. Use it before rewriting your CV, before interviews, and when choosing a path. Chapter 8 has the full inventory.

WORKSHEET B.2 — SKILLS SNAPSHOT

Category	My skills	Proof (example or result)
Technical or job-specific skills		
Tools and software (including AI tools)		
People skills (helping, persuading, calming)		
Organising and managing		
Problem-solving and judgment		

Category	My skills	Proof (example or result)
Teaching, explaining, writing		
Physical or hands-on skills		
Industry knowledge I have		
Skills that give me energy		
Skills I want to build next		

Worksheet B.3: Weekly Job-Search Tracker

Use one sheet per week. Track every application and lead. Chapter 11 explains how to read your results and adjust.

WORKSHEET B.3 — JOB-SEARCH TRACKER (WEEK OF _____)

Organisation and role	Date and how applied	Contact person	Status and next step
This week's totals: applications ___ replies ___ interviews ___			

Worksheet B.4: Networking Tracker

Relationships are built through follow-up. Use this sheet to make sure nobody falls through the cracks. Chapter 12 covers warm network mapping.

WORKSHEET B.4 — NETWORKING TRACKER

Name and how I know them	Date contacted	What we discussed	Follow-up and date

KEY IDEA

A good rule for networking: every conversation should end with a next step, and every next step should go on this tracker with a date. Most opportunities come from the second or third contact, not the first.

Worksheet B.5: One-Minute Introduction Builder

You will be asked “So, what do you do?” or “Tell me about yourself” many times. A clear, short answer makes people more likely to help you. Fill in each part, then join them into four or five sentences.

WORKSHEET B.5 — ONE-MINUTE INTRODUCTION

Part	Prompt	My words

Part	Prompt	My words
1. Who I am	Your name and the kind of work you do or have done.	
2. My strength	What you are known for or best at, in plain words.	
3. Proof	One short example or result, with a number if possible.	
4. What I am looking for	The type of role, client or project you want next.	
5. The ask	A small, specific way the listener could help.	

EXAMPLE: ONE-MINUTE INTRODUCTION

"I'm [Name]. For the last [number] years I've worked in [field], mostly [main work]. I'm known for [strength], for example [short result]. Now I'm looking for [type of role or work], especially where [what matters to you]. If you know anyone at [type of organisation], I'd really appreciate an introduction."

The Essential Message Scripts

These eight scripts cover the messages you will send most often. Keep them short. Personalise the first line every time.

SCRIPT 1: WARM OUTREACH TO SOMEONE YOU KNOW

Hi [Name],

I hope you're well. I wanted to let you know that my role at [Company] ended recently, and I'm now exploring [type of work or field].

You've always had a good view of [industry or topic], so I'd value 20 minutes of your perspective. Would you be open to a quick call or coffee in the next couple of weeks?

No pressure at all if things are busy. Thanks either way.

[Your name]

SCRIPT 2: POLITE FOLLOW-UP

Hi [Name],

I'm just following up on my message from [day or date] about [topic, role or call]. I know inboxes get busy.

I'm still very interested in [opportunity or conversation]. If now isn't a good time, could you point me to someone else I should speak with?

Thank you,
[Your name]

SCRIPT 3: ASKING FOR A REFERENCE

Hi [Name],

I'm applying for roles in [field], and I'd be grateful if you would act as a reference for me. You saw my work on [project or responsibility] closely, especially [specific achievement].

If you're happy to, I'll send you my updated CV and a short note on the roles I'm going for, so you know what to highlight. I'll always let you know before anyone is likely to contact you.

And if it's not a good time, I completely understand.

Many thanks,
[Your name]

SCRIPT 4: THANK-YOU AFTER A CONVERSATION OR INTERVIEW

Hi [Name],

Thank you for taking the time to speak with me today. I especially appreciated what you said about [specific point], and I'm going to [action you will take because of it].

[For interviews: Our conversation made me even more interested in the role, particularly [aspect]. I'm confident my experience in [relevant skill] would help with [challenge they mentioned].]

I'll keep you posted on how things go.

Best wishes,
[Your name]

SCRIPT 5: PROFILE "ABOUT" SUMMARY (FOR LINKEDIN OR SIMILAR)

I help [type of people or organisations] [achieve what result] by [how you do it].

Over [number] years in [field or fields], I've [two or three concrete achievements, with numbers if possible]. I'm known for [strength, e.g. calm problem-solving, clear communication, turning messy processes into simple ones].

I use modern tools, including AI, to [specific example of how you work faster or better], while bringing the judgment and relationships that technology can't replace.

I'm currently looking for [type of role or project] in [area or remote]. Feel free to get in touch at [email or contact method].

SCRIPT 6: FREELANCE OFFER TO PAST CONTACTS

Hi [Name],

I wanted to share some news: I'm now working independently, helping [type of client] with [specific service].

For example, I can [concrete deliverable 1] or [concrete deliverable 2], usually within [timeframe]. Given our work together on [shared project], I thought this might be useful for you or someone you know.

If it sounds relevant, I'd be happy to have a short call to see whether I can help. And if you know anyone who might need this, an introduction would mean a lot.

Thanks,
[Your name]

SCRIPT 7: NEGOTIATING AN OFFER

Hi [Name],

Thank you so much for the offer for the [Role] position. I'm genuinely excited about the team and about [specific aspect of the work].

Before I accept, I'd like to discuss the salary. Based on my research into similar roles in [location or sector], and the experience I bring in [key strength], I was hoping for something closer to [figure or range].

If there's limited flexibility on base pay, I'd also be glad to talk about [other options: start date, training budget, flexible working, review in six months].

I'm keen to make this work. When would be a good time to talk?

Best regards,
[Your name]

SCRIPT 8: DECLINING POLITELY AND KEEPING THE DOOR OPEN

Hi [Name],

Thank you for the offer and for the time you and the team spent with me. After careful thought, I've decided to decline, as I've accepted a role that is a closer fit for [reason, kept brief and positive].

I really enjoyed learning about [something specific], and I'd be glad to stay in touch. I hope our paths cross again.

With thanks,
[Your name]

WATCH OUT

It is fine to use an AI assistant to help draft these messages, but always read the result carefully. Remove anything generic, invented, or not quite true, and make sure the details about the other person are correct. People can usually tell when a message was not written with them in mind.

Worksheet B.6: Monthly Check-In

Once a month, step back from the weekly detail and look at the bigger picture. This works well on the last Friday of the month, alongside your weekly review.

WORKSHEET B.6 — MONTHLY CHECK-IN (MONTH: _____)

Area	Where I am now	What I will do next month
Money: runway in months		
Health: sleep, movement, mood		
Relationships and support		
Direction: is my path still right?		
Skills and learning		
Proof and portfolio		
Search or client results		

Area	Where I am now	What I will do next month
Biggest win this month		
Biggest lesson this month		
Something I will do just for me		

Looking at this month as a whole, what are you doing better now than when you started?

REMEMBER

- Copy or print fresh sheets as often as you need them, and date each one.
- Recalculate your runway monthly.
- Every conversation gets a follow-up and a date on your tracker.
- Personalise every script and read it aloud before sending.

Your next step: Print or copy Worksheet B.1 and Worksheet B.3 today, so they are ready for this week.

APPENDIX C

Resource Directory

Where to find help: crisis support, employment services and benefits, free learning, AI education, small business support, scam reporting and debt advice, organised by category and country.

You do not have to work everything out on your own. Governments, charities, universities and community organisations offer a great deal of free help, but it can be hard to know where to start. This directory gathers some of the most widely used and trusted options in one place.

It is not a complete list. Services vary by country, region and city, and many excellent local organisations are not listed here. Use this directory as a starting point, then ask your local library, job centre or community centre what else is available near you.

WATCH OUT

Resources change. Phone numbers, website addresses, program names and eligibility rules are updated regularly. Before relying on anything here, confirm it on the organisation's official website or by phone. Be careful with search results: scam sites sometimes copy the look of official services. Type addresses directly when you can, and look for official government domains (such as .gov, .gov.uk, .gc.ca, .gov.au or europa.eu).

TIP

Public services should never ask you to pay a fee to apply for unemployment benefits or to access a government job board. If a website charges you to "help" with an application that is free on the official site, close it.

1. Crisis and Mental Health Support

If you are in immediate danger, call your local emergency number (for example 911 in the US and Canada, 999 in the UK, 112 across the EU, 000 in Australia). The services below offer free, confidential support from trained people.

Country	Service	How to reach it
United States	988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline	Call or text 988; 988lifeline.org
United States	SAMHSA National Helpline (mental health and substance use)	1-800-662-4357; samhsa.gov
United States	NAMI (National Alliance on Mental Illness): information and support groups	nami.org
Canada	9-8-8 Suicide Crisis Helpline	Call or text 988; 988.ca
Canada	Canadian Mental Health Association: local services	cmha.ca
UK and Ireland	Samaritans	Call 116 123; samaritans.org
UK	Shout (text support)	Text SHOUT to 85258
UK	Mind: mental health information and local services	mind.org.uk
UK	NHS 111 (urgent health advice in England)	Call 111; nhs.uk
Australia	Lifeline	Call 13 11 14; lifeline.org.au
Australia	Beyond Blue	Call 1300 22 4636; beyondblue.org.au
New Zealand	Need to Talk? (free call or text)	1737
Many countries	Find A Helpline: directory of free helplines worldwide	findahelpline.com

In many EU countries, 116 123 is the number for emotional support helplines. Check whether it operates where you live. For ongoing support, your doctor or local health service can refer you to counselling, and many employers' former Employee Assistance Programs continue for a short time after a job ends; ask your former HR team.

2. Employment Services and Benefits

Public employment services help with job listings, career advice, training funds and, in many countries, unemployment benefits. Apply for benefits as soon as possible: in many systems, the clock starts on the day you apply.

United States

Resource	What it offers	Where to find it
CareerOneStop (sponsored by the US Department of Labor)	Job search, career exploration, training finder, salary information, and a tool to find your state's unemployment office	careeron-estop.org
State unemployment insurance offices	Unemployment benefit applications; each state runs its own program	Find yours through ca-reeronestop.org or dol.gov
American Job Centers	Free in-person help with job search, training and career counselling	Find locations through careeron-estop.org
US Department of Labor	Information on workers' rights, unem-ployment, COBRA health coverage and more	dol.gov
HealthCare.gov	Health insurance marketplace; losing job-based coverage usually allows a special enrollment period	healthcare.gov
211	Free referrals to local help with food, housing, utilities and more	Dial 211; 211.org
USA.gov	Guide to federal and state benefits and services	usa.gov

United Kingdom

Resource	What it offers	Where to find it
National Careers Service (England)	Free careers advice, skills assessment and CV help, online and by phone	nationalcareers.service.gov.uk
Jobcentre Plus	Benefits such as Universal Credit and New Style Jobseeker's Allowance, plus job search support	gov.uk
Find a job (government job board)	Official job listings	gov.uk/find-a-job
Citizens Advice	Free, independent advice on benefits, employment, debt and housing	citizensadvice.org.uk
Acas	Free, impartial advice on employment rights, redundancy and disputes	acas.org.uk
Turn2us	Benefits calculator and grants search for people facing financial hardship	turn2us.org.uk

Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland have their own careers services (for example, Skills Development Scotland and Careers Wales). Check which applies to you.

European Union

Resource	What it offers	Where to find it
EURES (European Employment Services)	Job listings and advice on working in other EU and EEA countries	eures.europa.eu
Europass	Free tools to create a CV and record skills and qualifications in a format recognised across Europe	europass.europa.eu
Your Europe	Information on rights to work, unemployment benefits and social security when moving between EU countries	europa.eu/youreurope

Resource	What it offers	Where to find it
Germany: Bundesagentur für Arbeit	National public employment service and unemployment benefits	arbeitsagentur.de
France: France Travail (formerly Pôle emploi)	National public employment service and unemployment benefits	francetravail.fr
Spain: SEPE	National public employment service and unemployment benefits	sepe.es
Netherlands: UWV	Unemployment benefits and job search support	uwv.nl
Sweden: Arbetsförmedlingen	National public employment service	arbetsformedlingen.se
Estonia: Töötukassa	Unemployment insurance, career counselling and training support	tootukassa.ee
Ireland: Intreo	Jobseeker payments and employment services	gov.ie

Every EU country has a national public employment service. If yours is not listed, search for “public employment service” plus your country name, or start from the EURES website.

Canada, Australia and New Zealand

Resource	What it offers	Where to find it
Canada: Job Bank	Official job listings, career planning and labour market information	jobbank.gc.ca
Canada: Employment Insurance (EI)	Temporary income support after job loss	canada.ca
Canada: 211	Referrals to local community and social services	Dial 211; 211.ca
Australia: Workforce Australia	Government employment services and job listings	workforceaustralia.gov.au

Resource	What it offers	Where to find it
Australia: Services Australia (Centrelink)	Income support payments, including for job seekers	servicesaustralia.gov.au
Australia: Your Career	Career exploration and planning tools	yourcareer.gov.au
Australia: Fair Work Ombudsman	Information on workplace rights, notice and redundancy pay	fairwork.gov.au
New Zealand: Work and Income	Financial support and employment services	workandincome.govt.nz

DO THIS NOW

Find your own country's three essential links and write them here or in your Job Change notebook:

1. Where to apply for unemployment or jobseeker support.
2. The official public job board or employment service.
3. A free, independent advice service for employment rights and money.

3. Free and Low-Cost Learning

You can learn a great deal without paying much, or anything at all. Many platforms below offer free access to course materials, with an optional fee for a certificate. Some, such as Coursera, offer financial aid for those who qualify. Chapter 10 explains which credentials are worth paying for.

Resource	What it offers	Where to find it
Khan Academy	Free lessons in maths, science, economics, computing and more	khanacademy.org
Coursera	University and industry courses; many can be audited free; financial aid available	coursera.org
edX	University courses from around the world; many with free audit options	edx.org

Resource	What it offers	Where to find it
freeCodeCamp	Free, self-paced coding and data courses with certifications	freecodecamp.org
MIT OpenCourseWare	Free materials from thousands of MIT courses	ocw.mit.edu
Harvard CS50	Free introductory computer science courses	cs50.harvard.edu
Google Career Certificates	Job-focused certificates in areas such as IT support, data analytics and project management (usually paid, often with financial aid or free access through partners)	grow.google
OpenLearn (The Open University)	Hundreds of free short courses	open.edu/openlearn
FutureLearn	Short online courses from universities and organisations	futurelearn.com
Microsoft Learn	Free training on Microsoft tools, cloud and AI	learn.microsoft.com
GCFGlobal	Free basic computer, internet and office software skills	gcfglobal.org
Your public library	Free computers, internet, workshops, and digital services such as e-books, audiobooks and sometimes online course platforms	Ask at your local branch or check its website

Many universities also publish full lectures for free on their official YouTube channels. Search for the university's name plus the topic, and check that the channel is the official one.

4. Learning About AI

You do not need to be technical to become confident with AI. These resources range from complete beginner to more advanced. Chapter 7 includes a 30-day AI fluency plan.

Resource	What it offers	Where to find it
Elements of AI (University of Helsinki and MinnaLearn)	Free, beginner-friendly online course on what AI is and how it works; no maths or coding needed; available in many languages	elementsofai.com
Ethics of AI (University of Helsinki)	Free course on the ethical questions raised by AI	ethics-of-ai.mooc.fi
Official learning pages of AI companies	Several major AI developers, including Anthropic, OpenAI, Google and Microsoft, publish free guides and courses on using their tools well	Look for "learn," "academy" or "courses" on each company's official website
DeepLearning.AI	Short courses on using and building with AI, many free	deeplearning.ai
Hugging Face Learn	Free, more technical courses on AI models and tools	huggingface.co/learn
fast.ai	Free practical deep learning course for people with some coding experience	course.fast.ai

WATCH OUT

The best introductory AI learning is free. Be very cautious about expensive "AI mastery" programs, especially those that promise guaranteed income or use countdown timers to rush you. See Chapters 3 and 10.

5. Small Business and Self-Employment Support

If you are thinking about freelancing or starting a business (Chapters 15 and 16), these organisations offer free advice, mentoring, and sometimes funding.

Resource	What it offers	Where to find it
US: Small Business Administration (SBA)	Guides on planning, launching and funding a business; local Small Business Development Centers	sba.gov

Resource	What it offers	Where to find it
US: SCORE	Free mentoring from experienced business people, plus workshops	score.org
UK: GOV.UK business support	Guidance on setting up, registering and running a business, plus the Business Support Helpline	gov.uk
UK: Start Up Loans (British Business Bank)	Government-backed personal loans and mentoring for new businesses	startuploans.co.uk
EU: Enterprise Europe Network	Support for small businesses, including advice on growing internationally	een.ec.europa.eu
Canada: BDC (Business Development Bank of Canada)	Advice, guides and financing for entrepreneurs	bdc.ca
Canada: Futurpreneur	Financing and mentoring for young entrepreneurs	futurpreneur.ca
Australia: business.gov.au	Government information, grants and support for businesses	business.gov.au
Local chambers of commerce	Networking, local business events and sometimes mentoring	Search for your town or region's chamber

6. Reporting Scams and Fraud

Job scams and "get rich quick" schemes target people who are looking for work. If you see one, or have been caught by one, report it. It helps protect others, and it may help you recover money. If you have shared bank details, contact your bank immediately.

Country	Where to report	Where to find it
United States	Federal Trade Commission (FTC)	reportfraud.ftc.gov
United States	FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3)	ic3.gov
United States	Identity theft reporting and recovery plans	identitytheft.gov

Country	Where to report	Where to find it
UK (England, Wales and Northern Ireland)	Action Fraud, the national fraud reporting centre (in Scotland, report to Police Scotland on 101)	actionfraud.police.uk
UK	Forward scam text messages free of charge	Text to 7726
Canada	Canadian Anti-Fraud Centre	antifraudcentre-centreantifraude.ca
Australia	Scamwatch	scamwatch.gov.au
Australia	ReportCyber (cybercrime)	cyber.gov.au
EU countries	Your national police or consumer protection authority	Check your government's official website

7. Debt and Money Advice

Free, non-profit debt advice can help you deal with lenders, set up affordable repayment plans, and avoid costly mistakes. Avoid companies that charge large upfront fees to "fix" your debt or credit. Chapter 3 explains how to talk to lenders.

Country	Service	Where to find it
UK	StepChange Debt Charity: free debt advice and solutions	stepchange.org
UK	MoneyHelper: free, government-backed money and pensions guidance	moneyhelper.org.uk
UK	National Debtline: free debt advice by phone and online	nationaldebtline.org
United States	NFCC (National Foundation for Credit Counseling): non-profit credit counselling	nfcc.org
United States	Consumer Financial Protection Bureau: guides and complaints about financial companies	consumerfinance.gov

Country	Service	Where to find it
Canada	Credit Counselling Canada: directory of non-profit credit counsellors	creditcounsellingcanada.ca
Australia	National Debt Helpline: free financial counselling	Call 1800 007 007; ndh.org.au
Australia	Moneysmart (ASIC): free money guidance and calculators	moneysmart.gov.au
Ireland	MABS (Money Advice and Budgeting Service)	mabs.ie

KEY IDEA

Before you withdraw retirement savings or take on new debt to survive a job loss, speak to a free, non-profit adviser. A single conversation can reveal options you did not know existed, such as payment holidays, hardship programs or benefits you qualify for.

8. Other Places to Ask

Some of the most useful help is local and informal. Do not overlook these:

- **Trade unions and professional associations.** Many offer members legal advice, career support, retraining funds and networking.
- **Public libraries.** Often run CV workshops, digital skills sessions and job clubs, and staff know local services well.
- **Community and faith organisations.** Food banks, job clubs, mentoring and emergency funds.
- **Colleges and adult education centres.** Ask about free or subsidised courses for people who are unemployed.
- **Your former employer.** Ask HR about outplacement services, retraining support or extended employee assistance.

Write down the local resources you discover that are not in this directory: name, contact details, and what they offer.

REMEMBER

- Most of the help you need is free: start with public and non-profit services.
- Apply for benefits early and confirm details on official websites.
- Never pay to access a government service.
- Report scams, and contact your bank at once if you have shared financial details.
- Resources change. Always verify before you rely on them.

Your next step: Find and bookmark the official unemployment or jobseeker service for where you live, and one free advice service.

APPENDIX D

Glossary

Plain-English explanations of the terms you will meet in this book, in job adverts, and in conversations about AI and work.

New words can make a changing world feel even more confusing. Many of the terms below sound technical, but the ideas behind them are simple. If you come across a word in a job advert or an article that is not here, ask an AI assistant or a librarian to explain it in plain language, and check the answer against a trusted source.

Achievements bank
A running list of things you have done well at work, ideally with numbers or results. You draw on it for your CV, cover letters and interviews. See Chapter 8.

Adjacent pivot
A career move into a role close to your current one, where much of your experience still applies, such as moving from customer support to customer success. See Chapter 9.

AI (artificial intelligence)
Computer systems that perform tasks which usually need human thinking, such as understanding language, recognising images, making predictions or writing text.

AI agent
An AI system that can take a series of actions on its own to complete a goal, such as searching the web, filling in forms, writing and running code, or sending messages, rather than only answering one question at a time.

AI exposure
How much of a job's tasks could be done, or changed, by AI. High exposure does not always mean a job will disappear; it may instead change shape. See Chapter 5.

AI fluency

Being comfortable and capable with AI tools: knowing what they are good and bad at, how to ask for what you need, and how to check the results. See Chapter 7.

Algorithm

A set of step-by-step rules a computer follows to solve a problem or make a decision.

Apprenticeship

A way of learning a skilled job by working and training at the same time, usually while being paid. Common in trades, care and increasingly in technical and office roles.

ATS (applicant tracking system)

Software employers use to collect, sort and filter job applications. Many ATS tools scan CVs for keywords and some now use AI to rank candidates. See Chapter 11.

Augmentation

When technology helps a person do their job better or faster, rather than replacing them. A nurse using AI to draft notes, so they have more time with patients, is an example.

Automation

When technology takes over a task that a person used to do. Automation usually affects specific tasks first, and whole jobs only when most of their tasks can be automated.

Bootcamp

A short, intensive training course, often in coding, data or design. Quality varies widely, so check outcomes carefully before paying. See Chapter 10.

Bridge income

Temporary or part-time earnings that help cover costs while you look for your next main role or build a new path.

Case study

A short written account of a problem you worked on, what you did, and what happened as a result. Useful as proof of your skills. See Chapter 13.

Chatbot / chat assistant
An AI tool you talk to by typing or speaking, which answers questions, drafts text, and helps with tasks.

COBRA
A US law that lets many people keep their employer's health insurance for a limited time after leaving a job, usually at full cost. Other countries have different systems.

Cooperative (co-op)
A business owned and run by its members, such as its workers or customers, who share decisions and profits. See Chapter 18.

Credential
Formal proof of a skill or qualification, such as a degree, licence, certificate or badge.

Deepfake
Fake audio, video or images created with AI to look or sound like a real person. Sometimes used in scams, including fake job interviews.

Displacement
When workers lose jobs or tasks because of changes such as new technology, restructuring or moving work elsewhere.

Freelancing
Working for yourself and selling your services to several clients, usually project by project, rather than being employed by one organisation. See Chapter 15.

Generative AI
AI that creates new content, such as text, images, audio, video or code, based on patterns it learned from large amounts of existing material.

Gig work
Short-term, task-based work, often found through apps or platforms, such as deliveries, driving, or small online tasks. Flexible, but usually without employee benefits.

Hallucination
When an AI tool states something false or made up as if it were true, such as an invented fact, quote or source. Always check important AI output.

Hidden job market
Jobs that are filled through referrals, networks or direct approaches without being widely advertised. See Chapters 11 and 12.

Informational interview
A short, relaxed conversation with someone in a job or field you are curious about, to learn from their experience. It is not a job interview, and you do not ask for a job. See Chapter 12.

Large language model (LLM)
The type of AI behind most chat assistants. It is trained on huge amounts of text and predicts likely words to produce answers, summaries and drafts.

Machine learning
A way of building AI where computers learn patterns from examples and data, rather than being given every rule by a programmer.

Mutual aid
People in a community helping each other directly, by sharing food, skills, childcare, transport or information, rather than relying only on official services. See Chapter 20.

Negotiation
A respectful conversation to agree on terms, such as pay, start date or working hours, that work for both you and the employer or client. See Chapter 14.

Notice period
The time between being told your job is ending and your last day, or pay in place of that time. Minimum notice is often set by law or by your contract.

Outplacement
Career support, such as coaching or CV help, that some employers pay for when they let people go. Always ask whether it is offered.

Portfolio
A collection of examples of your work that shows what you can do. Not only for designers: anyone can build one. See Chapter 13.

Portfolio career
A working life made up of several income streams at once, such as part-time work, freelancing and teaching, instead of one full-time job. See Chapter 17.

Prompt

The instruction or question you give an AI tool. Clear prompts with context, examples and a stated goal usually get better results. See Chapter 7.

Redundancy / layoff

Losing your job because the employer no longer needs the role, rather than because of your performance. “Redundancy” is common in the UK, Ireland and Australia; “layoff” in North America.

Reference

A person who can speak to a new employer about your work and character, usually a former manager or colleague.

Reskilling

Learning new skills so you can move into a different type of job.

Runway

How many months you can cover your essential costs with the money you have and expect to receive. See Chapter 3.

Safety net

Public support that helps people through hard times, such as unemployment benefits, health coverage and income support.

Settlement agreement

A legal agreement in which you usually accept money or other terms in exchange for giving up the right to make certain claims against your employer. Get advice before signing.

Severance (severance pay)

Money an employer pays when your job ends, sometimes required by law and sometimes offered in exchange for signing an agreement. Read any agreement carefully before signing. See Chapter 2.

Skill stacking

Combining several skills that are useful together, so that the combination is rarer and more valuable than any one skill alone. See Chapter 6.

Skills-based hiring

Hiring that focuses on what you can show you are able to do, through tests, projects or portfolios, rather than mainly on degrees or job titles.

Soft skills

A common, if slightly misleading, name for people skills such as communication, teamwork, empathy and judgment. They are often the hardest to replace.

STAR method

A way of answering interview questions with a short story: the Situation, the Task, the Action you took, and the Result. See Chapter 14.

T-shaped skills

Having deep skill in one area (the upright of the T) plus a broad, working understanding of related areas (the crossbar). See Chapter 6.

Task vs job

A job is a bundle of many tasks. AI usually changes or takes over particular tasks, which reshapes jobs rather than simply removing them. See Chapter 1.

Transferable skills

Skills you can carry from one job, field or industry to another, such as organising, explaining, solving problems or managing people. See Chapter 8.

Unemployment benefits

Payments from the government, or from an insurance system, to people who have lost their job. Names and rules vary by country, for example Jobseeker's Allowance or Universal Credit in the UK and Employment Insurance in Canada.

Upskilling

Learning new or deeper skills to do your current type of work better, or to keep up as it changes.

Value proposition

A short, clear statement of the problem you solve and for whom. Useful for freelancers, small businesses and job seekers alike.

Verification

Checking that information, especially AI-generated information, is accurate by comparing it with reliable sources. See Chapter 7.

Warm network

People who already know you, such as former colleagues, friends, neighbours, classmates and clients. Usually the best place to start networking. See Chapter 12.

Work sample

A real or realistic example of work you have done, shared to show your skills. See Chapter 13.

> **TIP**
>
> When you meet unfamiliar jargon in a job advert, write it down and look it up. Then use the plain-English version in your notes, and the advert's exact wording in your CV, so both people and screening software recognise it.

A CLOSING LETTER

To You, on the Hard Days

A few words to come back to when the plan feels heavy and the progress feels slow.

If you are reading this on a hard day, I am glad you opened the book again. That alone says something about you. It says you are still looking for a way forward, even when part of you would rather pull the covers over your head. Hold on to that part. It is stronger than it feels right now.

I will not pretend this is easy. Losing work, or watching it change under your feet, is one of the most unsettling things a person can go through. It touches money, identity, routine, pride and relationships all at once. If you have felt angry, ashamed, frightened or simply exhausted, none of that means you are doing it wrong. It means you are a person who cared about your work and your life, and something important has been taken or shaken.

I also will not pretend that it is fair. Some of the changes happening in work right now are fast, and the people making decisions do not always think about the people those decisions land on. You did not choose this. You did not cause it. And you are far from the only one going through it.

A slow week is not a failed week. It is a week you kept going.

But here is what I believe, and what this whole book has tried to show: you are not obsolete. The things that make you valuable were never only the tasks on your job description. They are your judgment, your care, your ability to understand what another person needs, to stay with a problem, to learn something new when you have to, to be trusted. Machines can do more every year. They cannot be you, with your history, your relationships and your particular way of seeing things.

On the hard days, the goal is small. You do not need to rebuild your career before dinner. You only need to do one useful thing. Send one message. Fill in one line of a worksheet. Go for one walk. Eat one proper meal. Call one person who makes you feel more like yourself. Small things, done on hard days, add up to more than you can see at the time.

Be gentle with the version of you who is struggling. Talk to yourself the way you would talk to a friend in the same position. You would not tell a friend they were worthless because a company restructured. You would remind them of what they have done, what they are good at, and that this is a chapter, not the whole story. You deserve the same kindness.

Let people help you. It is tempting to hide until things are fixed, so that you can show up again with good news. Please do not wait for that. The people who care about you would rather walk beside you now than hear about it later. And many of the opportunities in this book, from referrals to new clients to a kind word at the right moment, arrive through other people. Reaching out is not weakness. It is how humans have always got through hard times.

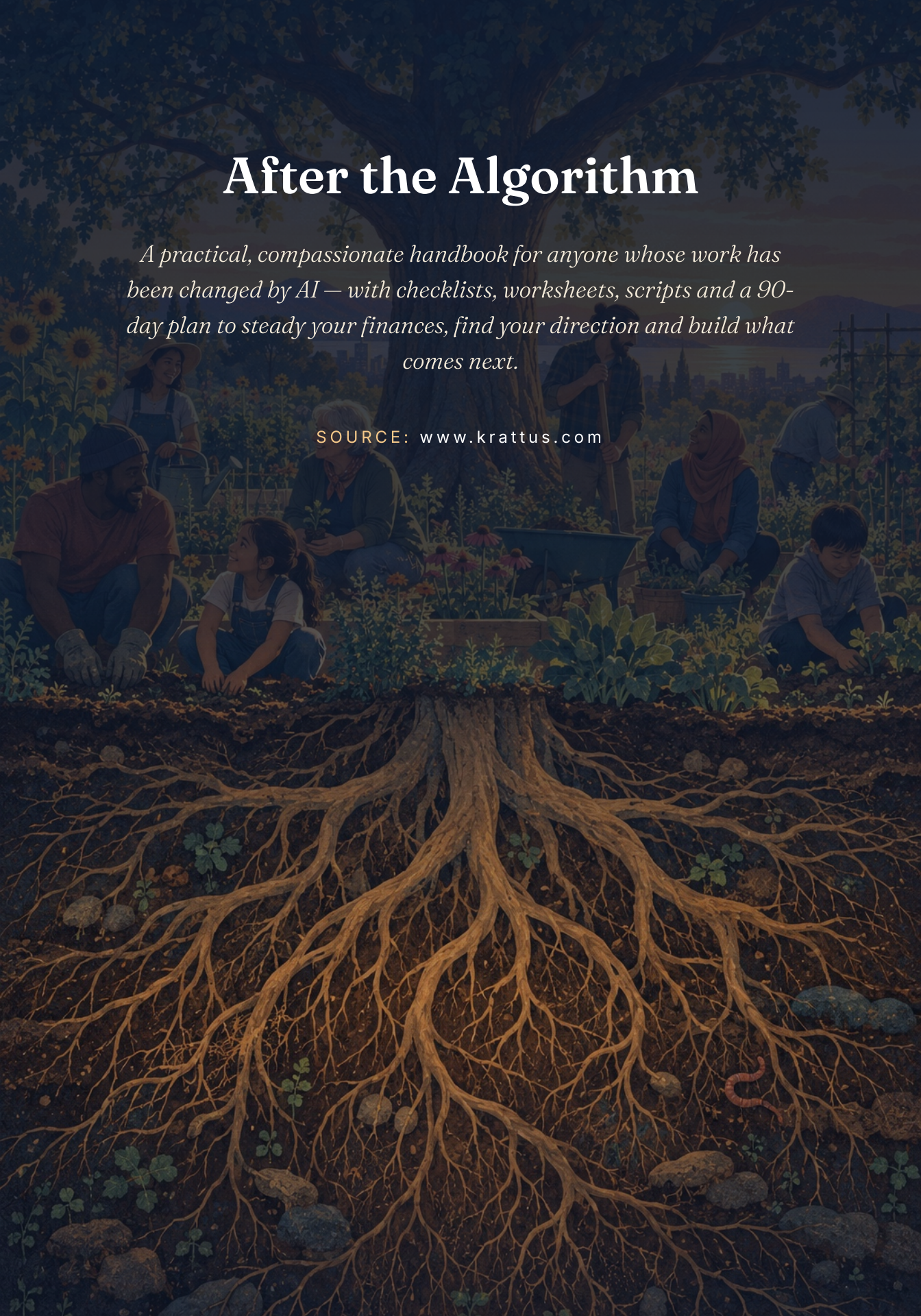
If the hard days become very dark, if you start to feel that there is no point, please reach out today to someone you trust, your doctor, or one of the crisis lines in Appendix C. You matter far more than any job, and help is there.

And when the better days come, as they so often do, take a moment to notice them. Notice the reply that finally arrived, the interview that went well, the client who said yes, the evening you forgot to worry. Write it down. Then, when you are able, turn around and offer a hand to the next person starting the road you have just walked. What you learn now will be worth a great deal to someone else.

The world of work will keep changing. That is the honest truth. But you can change too, at your own pace, in your own way, with the people who matter to you. You have already done hard things to get this far. You can do the next one.

Close the book for now if you need to. Rest. Come back tomorrow. The plan will still be here, and so will you.

— With you on the road ahead



After the Algorithm

A practical, compassionate handbook for anyone whose work has been changed by AI — with checklists, worksheets, scripts and a 90-day plan to steady your finances, find your direction and build what comes next.

SOURCE: www.krattus.com